All I've Ever Needed

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/39297696.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Enemies to Friends to Lovers, Enemies to Lovers, Enemies to Friends, Drama & Romance, Catra & Glimmer Friendship (She-Ra), Catra & Scorpia Friendship (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra) Redemption, Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Adora/Catra Fluff (She-Ra), Adora/Catra in Love (She-Ra), Adora/Catra Angst (She-Ra), adora catra, Alternate Ending, Slow Burn

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by catastrophe86

Summary

Catra is at her lowest point having been publicly excommunicated from the Horde. Adora is at her lowest point having destroyed She-Ra's sword to save the universe. Tempers are high and the risk of loss is low. They run into each other in the whispering woods and finally have the conversation they've needed to have all along. Feelings are hashed out. Feelings are hurt.. but then maybe they'll find some common ground to stand on.

Previously "Untitled Catradora"

Alternate ending - This is my take on season 5 starting from the end of season 4. A couple changes to start off with - Catra doesn't get teleported up to Horde Prime's ship, neither does Glimmer. After their fight, Glimmer teleports back with Bow to the city to assess the damage of the latest battle while Catra escapes to the whispering woods.

Notes

AN - this is my first fic on Ao3 and my first writing in years, so I apologize if I'm a little rusty. I marked the story Mature for language only. I curse like a sailor, so it naturally came out in my writing. This is not a smut fic - I've tried my hand at smut before, and it's just not my specialty. There will be some heated moments between the two though.

I don't own the characters. This story is based off the creation of Nate Stevenson.

With Friends Like These

The fright zone is in shambles.

Everyone saw the beam of light that took away their leader, and many of the wounded soldiers returning from their epic defeat at Bright Moon were around long enough to see that it was *Catra* and Hordak destroying the city just before that.

They're onto her.

They know she's been cut out of the Horde and in the most visible and humiliating way possible. And many who arrived too late think *she* had something to do with Hordak's disappearance. No one knows what to think of the ships breaking into their atmosphere, but that coupled with their recent crippling defeat is putting everyone on edge and they're looking for someone to blame… Catra just happens to be the only authority figure left. So with that, the former force commander escapes. She doesn't know where she's going or what she's going to do, but she can't stay in the Fright Zone any longer.

So she's gone - running through the Whispering Woods, leaping from tree branch to tree branch. She can't seem to process what's happened… She was so close to her goal only to trip at the finish line. Everyone she's ever cared about has left her alone to die, but she kept on fighting no matter what. And now? No matter how hard she tries, she can never win. Never. *And it's all that fucking princess' fault*.

The cat girl growls and hunches down, pushing herself faster and faster.

Adora.

She wants to scream; she wants to yell. *This is all her fault. She had to go and thwart my master plan and turn my closest ally*

against me. Though, try as she might, Catra can't quite seem to find the malice she's looking for. Her thoughts keep spinning around and around but never quite landing on her last conversation with Double Trouble.

"They didn't need you… left you.." it's Adora's face and Adora's voice, but it's only a illusion.

Catra halts on a branch as a yell tears itself from her throat. She scrubs the back of her hand across her eyes, because she won't cry; she refuses. Yes, Adora left her, but that was her decision. She wasn't good enough for the blonde. Never was. Catra grits her teeth and digs her claws into the bark beneath her. *No… I won't cry over her. Never again.*

Taking a breath and steeling her resolve, she continues through the forest, moving quietly through the trees with no destination in mind. She just needs to get away. It was then that she heard it - a twig snapping in the distance. The cat girl investigates, first sniffing and then creeping closer to get a better look… That's when she finds her.

Adora

Narrowing her eyes, Catra alters course and heads straight for the princess, being careful not to draw attention to herself. She lands on a tree not far off from the princess and listens. Not only does Adora appear to be alone, but she's limping… *Hmmm, she looks like she's in worse shape than me*. That's when Catra notices the most important detail.

She doesn't have her sword.

If there were ever a more perfect time to attack She-Ra, Catra's never seen it. Digging her claws into the branch beneath her feet, she prepares to lunge.

Enough is enough.

The bush catches on her signature jacket, and she pulls her arm free with a grunt. Her eyes are tired; her legs are tired. Ever since the whole ordeal ended, Adora had never felt more weak. She wasn't She-Ra anymore… She-ra is dead. Now she's nothing more than a common foot soldier.

Her boot gets hooked on a covered root and she stumbles forward. Thanks to her years of training, she's learned how to fall with the least amount of damage… but that doesn't help when your foot is stuck to the ground. The warrior yells then, jerking her foot away from the foliage, rolling and then jumping back to her feet. Once stable, she swings around and starts kicking at the nearby tree with little relief. When her attack on the tree only ends with a sore foot she stops, lifts her head up and yells again… This time putting all of her frustrations to the forest, hoping that someone out there will just swallow her up and put her out of her misery.

No one answers though.

She feels tears stinging at the corner of her eyes, but she brushes them away angrily before trudging forward through the woods once again. She doesn't even know why she's heading back to Bright Moon. Is there anything left for her there? She can't be their hero anymore. She can't be their *anything* anymore. Even the title of friend seems to be on the fence these days. When the blonde thinks of Glimmer and Bow, all she senses is distance now... and tension. Things were so *tense* between them these days. With Adora and Glimmer constantly fighting over trusting Shadow Weaver, and Bow, the poor thing, constantly being caught in the middle. And then there were the other princesses… They obviously sided with Glimmer and went with Shadow Weaver's plan, despite her warning… Was it even worth it to return?

With each thought and each step, her heart sinks lower and lower. Her energy seems to have disappeared with her strength, and she can't help but wonder where her place is in the world now?

Do I belong anywhere?

"Hey *Adora*."

Oh, fuck no.

Her voice echoes between the trees, causing Adora to look one way while Catra tackles her from the other - Adora grunts and flips them, tossing the cat girl away from her. Seeing her old friend-slash-nemesis again makes her heart squeeze and her stomach drop. "I don't have time for this," she grumbles before returning to her feet.

"Of course you don't." Catra rolls her eyes with her signature smirk as she pulls herself gracefully off the ground, "It's been a while… Haven't you *missed* me?"

"You've lost, Catra. Give it up," the Rebel's voice is full of hostility, "The Horde has no place here anymore."

"That's where you're wrong," Catra's smirk deepens as she crosses her arms over her chest, "You looked up in the sky lately?"

"Adooora!" Glimmer and Bow's voices calling in the distance distracts the two girls. They're looking for her, but definitely not close enough to find her.

"I need to go," Adora grumbles and turns to stalk off.

"Just leave 'em. I mean, that *is* what you do, isn't it?" The feline feels her smile growing when she sees the blonde's shoulders tense up as she turns back around, "Leave your best friends behind?"

"***You don't know what you're talking about***," Adora's voice is *laced* with venom. So much so that Catra loses her smile a tad.

Wow, she thought, *Guess the idiot's been through the ringer one too many times*. While she's surprised by the anger she finds

there, that doesn't change anything… this argument has been a long time coming.

Adora stands there, hunched forward while her chest rises and falls rapidly with her ragged breathing. She's not sure why the accusation struck at her harder than any punch or scratch, but she's lost too much today and can't handle this woman who makes her feel too many emotions.

"What's the matter, A-*dora*? Don't like being confronted with the truth?"

Adora scoffs and turns to stalk off in the direction she heard her friends again.

"Here your friends are, trying *desperately* to find you, not knowing that *any day now*.. you'll leave them in the dust as well."

"That is *not* what happened!" Adora rounds back to face her.

"Should we tell them?" The cat woman's amusement is back. *Man, she's so easy*. "Should we let them know they're just your side-kicks? Replaceable… *Dispensable*." Catra laughs coldly, "I mean, it's not like you ever really gave a damn about *me*."

"I *loved* you!"

…Catra's smile fades completely.

The exclamation is followed by a dead silence.

The minute she yelled it Adora clenched her fists and turned her face away, trying not to curse her own stupidity. Her jaw and eyes also clamped shut as a few tears managed to squeeze out. The only sound that can be heard is the two girls' heavy breathing in the tense air between them… so tense it feels electric - like some force field is connecting them, pulling them together, though

they're so far apart. For once the woods seem to be silent - all the trees and animals quietly awaiting their next move.

Adora turns to leave again, only for Catra to pounce.

"What did you say?!" Catra is startled and alarmed so she shoves the taller girl. *There's no way she means what I think she means*. When Adora rounds back, she blocks a punch the brunette throws at her and then delivers a kick that the girl's catlike reflexes easily evades.

"Just forget it." she tries to leave again, only to this time have Catra tackle her and pin her to the ground.

"*No!* I wanna hear it," Catra is angry, ears pointed back and tail flicking wildly as she pins Adora's arms to her sides and closes a hand on her throat. *"Lie to me again!"*

"It *wasn't* a lie," Adora growls out. "I *loved* you," when her voice breaks and more tears slip out, it gives the feline pause. Catra watches the broken woman beneath her for a second, not finding malice or falseness in her words or actions. But it's not enough.

"Oh *really?"* Catra's tone is sarcastic, cold and cutting; her gaze unwavering. *This is some cruel, sick joke*. She purposefully moves both hands to the ground on either side of the girl while sliding down her body to press their chests together sensuously. "So, you *love* this do you?"

The cat girl's voice takes on a gravelly quality, almost purring, that makes the blonde squirm. Adora's cheeks burn bright red as she tries to wriggle out of her grasp. *"Catra."*

"And how about *this?*"

Before either of them can think about it too long, Catra drops down and plants one on Adora. Their lips collide and both of them stop, not daring to breathe. It's there, it's happening. She didn't plan to do this… but they were so close, and her mouth was *right there*. What did she have to lose? So many times she's dreamt of

what her old friend would taste like, but nothing could've prepared her for the reality. Her lips were soft… so soft. Softer than Adora ever was. The cat girl takes another taste. *Mmmmm*. And she tastes like fruit. O*f course she tastes sweet…. Been hanging around those damn princesses too long*.

Adora responds minimally at first, barely capturing the cat girl's lips with her own, but Catra picks up the pace, kissing her faster and deepening their connection with every turn. *Better than I could have imagined*. The smaller girl is elated, her thoughts racing - It wasn't lost on her that her captured target was responding to each move she made in kind. Whenever Catra takes a breath, so does Adora… whenever she moves back to capture her lips again, Adora is right there with her. It's wonderful. She hardly knows what to do with herself. When she slips her tongue into her mouth, the blonde moans audibly beneath her, loud enough for the reverberations to echo back into her own chest… and Catra feels her heart soar. Everything is there. *She really does care about me*. The thought humbles her. It's hers - Everything the brunette ever wanted.

But the next thing she knows, she's tossed to the side.

She's not sure what happened - one second she was lip locked with the girl she's wanted her whole life and the next she's rolled over in the dirt as Adora towers over her, breathing in angrily.

"Fuck you," Adora growls before stomping off into the woods.

Shit.

"Adora *wait-*" She scrambles up to give chase but the princess has already disappeared in the tree line. Catra, determined, was always faster though and she catches up to her quickly. When she gets close enough, she reaches for the girl's arm… only to be tossed aside… *again*.

"I cannot *believe* you," Adora spits out, "Have you *ever* cared about anyone other than yourself?!"

“Adora, I-”

“You *abandoned* me!” the statement slices through her, silencing her as her ears fold down. She sits there, quietly, looking up at the enraged woman. “Yes, I left the Fright Zone, that was my choice, but I *asked* you to come with me, *multiple* times, because I *needed* you!” Adora is furious but her tirade is accompanied by tears streaking down her face. “Everything I thought I knew about myself turned out to be a lie; I turned out to be the *very enemy* I thought I was fighting. And I *needed* my friend there with me because my entire world had just been turned *upside down*. But when I opened myself up to you, you turned your back on me and *you left!”* The feline is speechless, staring at her with her mouth agape.

The blonde’s chin trembles as she looks at her old friend resentfully. The last part is barely choked out: “Just when I needed you the most.”

“Adora…” Catra’s voice is barely above a whisper. She has nothing to say to that, so she just sits there and watches her oldest friend crumble in front of her.

“I hate you,” the blonde’s voice is quiet, but she hears it all the same - Catra winces like she’s been slapped and her ears fold down again just as her shoulders droop. She doesn’t want to believe it, but one thing is for certain - she can’t sit by and let it be true. As soon as Adora turns her back, she tackles her again and quickly gets the upper hand. Adora tries throwing punches but Catra easily grabs her wrists and pins her down. It’s no wonder Adora can’t swing to save her life as she’s openly crying, tears completely clouding her vision.

“Hey,” Catra’s voice is gentle now as she uses one hand to hold her wrists and the other to wipe her tears. She feels tears of her own welling up now and her voice tightens with emotion. “Adora… I’m- I’m *sorry*,” She makes sure to look her in the eyes for this, “I’m so sorry.” Adora cries harder as Catra leans down to kiss her again, this time softly on her cheek, thoughtfully trying to kiss

away her sadness. She tastes the salt of her tears but that only pushes her forward - she kisses her again and again, each time more lovingly than before while slowly moving down and connecting with her salt stained lips once more.

And then her back connects with a tree and a yelp is torn from her throat.

"Go fuck yourself," Adora tries to sound angry before jumping up and stalking off to join up with her friends.

Catra rubs the back of her head and watches her leave. This can't be the end.

…*It can't be*.

Adora marches through the forest like a warrior on a mission. She doesn't know what the hell that was - she has no room left in her mind or her heart to even process what the hell happened back there. And considering everything that transpired before that, she's going to have more than one fire to put out today, so the last thing on her mind should be whatever the fuck is going on with her arch nemesis… No matter how much her mind wanted to linger on that kiss…

"Adooora!"

There they are. She was definitely getting closer. Instead of taking a minute to pull herself together, she takes off at a sprint in the direction she heard them, hoping to leave whatever those lingering emotions are behind her. It doesn't take her long to make it to the clearing where her friends had just stopped to check Bow's tracker pad.

"Adora!" Bow looks up at Glimmer's exclamation and they both come flying towards her. Adora stands resolute and lets her friends grip onto her as if their lives depended on it. She still

hasn't figured out how she's going to handle what happens next. Noticing that Adora kept her arms glued to her sides even under the shower of affection, they reluctantly let her go and take a step back.

"Adora, are you okay?" After taking a moment to look her over, Bow can clearly see that their friend is worse for wear.

"As well as I can be considering," her eyes glance pointedly at Glimmer who takes another half step back and swallows nervously.

Bow looks exasperated by the exchange, but it was to be expected. He himself doesn't know how to feel about Glimmer's recent actions. They'd been arguing ever since they set out to find Adora. But they have too much ground to cover. "What happened? I saw all the princesses get super powered up for a minute, but then.. They started screaming in pain…" he stops here to look at Glimmer for confirmation but she doesn't look up from the spot she's found on the ground that seems so fascinating. "But then it all stopped, and everyone seemed back to normal." He waits for her to respond, but she seems lost in thought as well. "Adora?" he prompts again.

She doesn't know how to say it - she thought about how to break the news to them, but never figured out how she was actually going to get the words out. Instead of saying anything, she removes the satchel strapped to her chest, opens the top and drops it on the ground. Glimmer's and Bow's gazes both snap in the direction of what sounds like glass shattering, but… Bow kneels down and lifts up the satchel from the bottom, allowing She-ra's sword, or what's left of it, to fall out onto the ground in pieces. Glimmer gasps and he can only stare in shock.

"Adora?" Glimmer's voice wavers, like she's on the brink of tears. Bow interrupts her and stands back up to face their friend, "What does this mean?" His voice is as grave as his expression.

Adora's eyes are glossed over, unseeing, staring at some point far behind them as she shrugs her shoulders. "She-Ra's gone. We'll have to find a way to survive without her."

The three friends stare in different directions, all trying to process where to go from here. Glimmer kneels down, instantly reaching to pick up the shards and trying to piece them back together. When she sees for herself that it's hopeless, she drops them and turns her face to look up at Adora. With tears staining her cheeks, she pleads, "Adora, this is all my fault… But there has to be a way to fix this?"

"Why don't you go ask your new BFF Shadow Weaver?" Adora asks her with a hardened expression.

"Wait, *hold on*… *You* did this?"

The three best friends jump to attention and look back at the tree line to see the woman just now stepping out of the shadows.

"Catra??!" Glimmer scrubs her cheeks quickly and takes a step towards the intruder, but Adora instinctively steps between them leaving the sparkly princess and Bow both staring at her agape. "Why are you *protecting* her? You *know* what she is - What she's *done*."

"Yeah…" Adora's voice, like her eyes, are dull. All the fight has gone out of her, "And you and her seem to have a lot in common these days." Glimmer looks like she's been slapped as she falls a step back. Bow steps up in her defense, "Now hang on a second-"

"What?" Adora's gaze snaps to their male friend then, "Are you honestly going to try and defend her after what happened today?"

"We don't *know* what happened today, because you won't tell us-"

"Glimmer activated the weapon," they all turn to look at Catra in surprise. She rolls her eyes, crosses her arms and continues, "Double Trouble was all too proud of the wool you pulled over my eyes. They couldn't help but tell me all about it. So, let me

guess…" Here the cat girl steps around Adora and slowly walks towards the purple haired Queen. Taking a single glance back at the blonde, she turns back to the subject at hand, "Yooou trusted Shadow Weaver, which obviously was mistake number one." At this Glimmer clamps her eyes shut and turns her face away, trying to hide her own inner disgust, "And then you went and activated the ginormous weapon Entrapta was always talking about… Synced up all the princesses to their stones, sang kumbaya or whatever, and then *boom*." Catra steals a glance at Bow before stopping right in front of the Queen, "Giant, super-powered princesses." Here she stops and waits for Glimmer to meet her eyeline again, "Only I'm *guessing* Shadow Weaver left out one tiny, but important detail, hmm?" The shorter of the two glares at the former, daring her to say anything else.

"The Heart of Etheria is the weapon," Adora picks up where the cat girl left off, "The princesses were used to power it." She wanders off to the side looking pensive and kicking a rock absentmindedly, "And then She-Ra… was meant to be the trigger."

Everyone watches the despondent girl like a hawk as she turns to face Glimmer.

"The weapon was meant to be used against my will," a single tear escapes and falls down her cheek, "I had no power over it." Stopping for a second to brush the tear away, she continues, "So the choice was… Let the universe be *destroyed*," here she laughs humorlessly like she actually had a choice, "Or kill She-Ra." Everyone in the group takes a second to glance back at the broken sword that's still on the ground behind them, "I'm guessing you can tell which one I went with."

"Adora, I'm so-"

"Wow," Catra interrupts the princess with a small chuckle while crossing her arms. She looks at Glimmer with a smirk and eyes that can cut like daggers, "With friends like *you*, Sparkles… Adora doesn't even need enemies like me."

"You *piece* of *sh*-" Bow jumps in and grabs Glimmer's arm, pulling her away before she can launch a series of sparkle blasts at the cat woman's face… leaving the smug feline laughing silently to herself. All the while Adora steps to the side of the clearing, wanting a breather from the quarreling enemies.

"Guys, that's enough," Bow exclaims, pushing himself between the two girls. "Adora, let's go. We need to get back to Bright Moon and assess the damage. And *Catra*…" here he turns to glare at the intruder once more, "Go *home*, you don't belong here - You're lucky I'm letting you just walk away."

Catra suddenly loses her smile. "Yeah, about that," she scratches thoughtfully at her lower lip while turning to glance at Adora.. The sullen warrior only recently turned back to face them but hasn't moved forward to rejoin the group. "You feel like swearing in a new initiate?? Or whatever it is you princesses do."

Adora breathes out some semblance of a laugh and shakes her head, not believing what she's hearing. Bow stares in utter bewilderment and Glimmer sputters back to life, "Wha- *Are you*.. How.. Are you *fucking* kidding me? After *everything* you've done?!"

"Catra, you can't *possibly* be serious," the blonde sounds exasperated as she meets her eyes again and the brunette shares a secret smile with the girl. "Oh, I'm *very* serious." Though Adora doesn't think she means anything with her tone, her mind flashes back to the *moment* they shared before and it causes her cheeks to heat up.

Catra, seeing the blush, smirks to herself before she turns back to Bow. "Come *on*," she rolls her eyes again, "I've *seen* you guys fight." Here she stops to glance at each of them, "You could *seriously* use the help, especially with what's covering up the sky right now."

"You said that before," Adora narrows her eyes at the cat girl. "What are you talking about?"

“Umm… Adora?” Bow questions hesitantly, “Have you not seen what’s going on out there?”

Adora furrows her brows and examines the worry on each of their faces, “You mean something’s happened *besides* the battle at Bright Moon?” They all stare at her and slowly nod their heads.

Holy fuck, what now?

The trio plus the former Horde commander walk together in silence as they breach the tree line and Adora has her first clear view of the sky since everything went down. Trepidation sends shivers down her spine and a growing pit of dread fills her stomach like a brick as she watches dozens upon dozens of alien Horde ships breaking into their atmosphere and heading straight for their villages.

The princesses are still recovering from their recent battle and the encounter with the Heart of Etheria, the trio of friends are breaking apart at the seams, her ex-friend (ex-enemy?) is now trying a new angle to possibly plot against her, and She-Ra is gone…

“What the *hell* are we supposed to do now?”

You Need Me

Chapter Notes

Rating M for language

I don't want to promise to put up a new chapter every few days because shit happens - Right now for instance, I'm still recovering from a nasty migraine, but I really wanted to get this chapter up. It was supposed to go up last night, but alas I couldn't look at screens without hurting.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Previously

The trio plus the former Horde commander walk together in silence as they breach the tree line and Adora has her first clear view of the sky since everything went down.

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The princesses are still recovering from their recent battle and the encounter with the Heart of Etheria, the trio of friends are breaking apart at the seams, her ex-friend (ex-enemy?) is now trying a new angle to possibly plot against her, and She-Ra is gone…

"What the hell are we supposed to do now?"

Chapter 2

The trio plus Catra stare on at the scene before them in a slight state of shock, not quite sure what to do or even if they're capable of fighting off such an extremely powerful force.

"We need to get back," Bow reiterates, though now he sounds much less sure of himself.

"Alright," Glimmer doesn't seem to be overly enthused about it either, "Let's go." She moves in between her two best friends, grabs their shoulders and prepares to lift them off back to Bright Moon.

The intruder watches with a furrowed brow as the trio reposition themselves curiously. At the last second she realizes what's happening and reflexively leaps forward to grab ahold of Adora's sleeve. They whoosh through the air and when the world stops spinning, the four find themselves standing on the ground level of Bright Moon's extravagant entrance, right where the troops have sat themselves to recover from the battle. Catra, not having experienced teleporting in a while, immediately bends at the waist and starts making retching noises.

The trio turn around to see what the commotion is and collectively express annoyance at the girl's impromptu tag along.

"Catra, you can't be here," Adora finally has the energy to express her emotions again, and in this instance the emotion is irritation.

"Yeah, no one is going to want you here, and I for one am not going to stop the guards when they come after you," Bow agrees.

"I'll take it one step further and say I'll even specifically send the guards after you if you even *think* of stepping foot in my castle," it goes without saying that Glimmer is definitely the least impressed of the friends as she stands there, brow furrowed with her hands on her hips. Catra will get inside Bright Moon over her dead body.

The former force commander pulls herself together after her stomach settles. Once she straightens back up, she prepares herself to meet the rude welcome head on. The three friends all

stare or glare at her in varying degrees of hostility. She knew this was going to be a hard sale, but what did she have to lose? *Not to mention…* her eyes shift involuntarily to her old friend. She isn't ready to let go of Adora just yet, not after what happened. She needs to get back on the blonde's good side.

"Guys, nothing has changed between the Whispering Woods and here," Catra starts, pointedly glancing up to the sky while mirroring the Queen's stance, "You're not equipped to handle an invasion of this magnitude. *I*, however, rose through the ranks of the Horde faster than anyone, because this is what I'm good at." Here she smiles at them smugly while crossing her arms over her chest, "How many villages have you lost to me? How much ground? I was the one in charge at the battle of Salineas, and that was a HUGE victory for us." Here she pauses for dramatic effect before continuing, "No one here understands better how the Horde works from the inside; you *need* me."

Adora matches her stance and raises an eyebrow at her, clearly not impressed, "Seriously, Catra? You're trying to sell us on this by bragging about how much you've taken from us over the years?"

The feline grimaces slightly and her ears drop a little with her bravado. *Okay, maybe not the right route to take with these three.*

"She may not be entirely wrong though," Bow states factually after a moment, and Glimmer and Adora both snap their heads in his direction. Seeing their incredulous expressions, he quickly back tracks, "Look, I'm not saying we forget about everything she's done, because you're right - She *has* taken enough from us and done a lot, a *lot* of really bad stuff." He meets both their gazes earnestly, "But can we really afford to turn down any extra help we can get when we're faced with a threat like *this?"* He gestures to the ships flying through the sky.

Adora shakes her head and looks off in the distance when Glimmer speaks up, "Bow, how on Etheria are we supposed to *trust* her? I don't care how experienced she is - it won't matter if she's only here to sabotage us like Double Trouble was!"

Bow takes a moment to examine the situation they're in again - it's definitely a double edged sword, but he comes to the same conclusion. Looking back at their shorter friend, he appears glum as he says, "I think that's a risk we're just going to have to take."

"Adora?" Glimmer turns to the stoic girl, praying she'll talk some sense into him.

But she is busy studying the former commander. After a few uncomfortable seconds of sizing her up, she takes a step forward. "Why do you want to help us now?" she asks, full of suspicion.

Catra's eyebrows raise at the question, not quite sure how to answer, "Why what now?"

"Why now… Catra," Adora's rigid stance and tone says she's not in the mood for games - The brunette either needs to pass this test or turn around and find her own way. "Why do you want to join us *now* when you've had plenty of opportunities to join us in the past?" she pauses to reiterate, "Why would you want to help us now after everything?"

The unwanted feline takes a moment to examine each of their faces while she tries to formulate a response - she knows she needs to get this right. She does her best not to give away her nerves by swallowing them down discreetly and keeping a blank expression on her face with her ears drawn back slightly. Unfortunately she's not able to control her tail flicking uneasily behind her, and she *knows* Adora has long since learned how to read her through her behavioral tics.

But how exactly is she supposed to tell them that she doesn't give a damn about this war? She was kicked off the side she chose to fight for and couldn't care less if the rebellion manages to overthrow them… or if they get destroyed in the process. The cat girl always finds her own way, so the outcome of the war doesn't really affect her at all. Honestly the only thing keeping her planted here is 5'9, blonde, and currently staring her down like she's trying to burn holes into her head.

“I have my reasons,” is the response she goes with as she gives them a half hearted shrug.

“Not good enough,” Adora shoots back, her eyes narrowing on the girl.

The former commander takes a breath then and decides to go with the best excuse she can think of, “I was kicked out of the Horde, okay?” Here both Adora and Arrow Boy raise their eyebrows in surprise. “Lets just say Hordak was less than impressed with how I’ve been running things lately and decided to get physical with me. Obviously he was no match for me, but then the ships arrived and teleported him off the planet.” She watches them with a disinterested expression for a moment, before throwing in for good measure, “You can ask Sparkles - she was there. She saw the whole thing.”

The two other friends turn to Glimmer with inquisitive looks and she sighs before confirming, “Yeah, I suppose that happened. I mean, I can’t imagine the Horde keeping her around after the beating she took from Hordak.”

Bow turns back to Catra who’s still mid-eyeroll and prompts her, “So, what? You want to join the rebellion to get back at the Horde? Like Shadow Weaver?”

The cat woman grimaces harder at the name but answers the question, “Yeah, sure.”

The other two friends miss Adora’s face softening at the realization that Catra would be reunited with a woman who’s terrorized her for years. *She wouldn’t willingly sign back up to be around that unless her motivation was sincere… right?*

“What do you think, Adora?” Bow asks quietly, “You think we can trust her?”

“Absolutely not.” Catra’s ears drop after hearing the blonde’s answer. “But… we need her,” here she turns to look at the other

two, “I say we watch her like a hawk, but otherwise? We let her stay.”

“You can*not* be serious,” Glimmer makes her disapproval known.

Ignoring Glimmer, Bow concurs with Adora, “Agreed.”

“Guys, *what!?”* the Queen exclaims, her voice raising a few decibels in disbelief, “Are you *really* forgetting everything she’s done to us?”

“No one is forgetting anything, Glimmer," Bow turns his focus on the Queen, "We know we can’t trust her. But if we hope to stand a chance against the horde, we *have* to have someone who understands their battle strategies.” He turns back to study the former commander, “I say we use her.”

”*love*beingtalkedaboutlikeI’mnothere,” Catra mutters under her breath.

“Okay,” Glimmer pauses to pinch at the bridge of her nose for a second, “You’re just forgetting one very important thing.” The princess pushes her shoulders back and tries her best to put back on her air of authority, “This is *my* kingdom. And I can’t in good conscience let someone who’s so intimately *familiar* with the Horde just walk around like it’s nothing!”

“Didn’t seem to have that problem with Shadow Weaver,” Adora responds without missing a beat. Glimmer winces at her friend's words and loses some of her confidence. “Glimmer, we’re *doing* this. And frankly, this place won’t *be* your kingdom much longer if we don’t do something to stop the Horde’s takeover.”

The purple Queen groans and face palms, realizing she’s losing this fight, “And exactly how do you plan to get the other princesses on board with this?”

“We’ll talk to them,” Bow shrugs, “I’m sure we can get them to listen to reason.”

The two friends wait. No matter what excuse Glimmer tries to come up with next, she knows they'll find a way to shoot her down every time. And she's not exactly in a position to argue after everything that's happened.

"*Fine*, but I still say this is a horrible decision."

With that, Adora turns to her old nemesis with only minor trepidation for what they're about to do. "You ready to be sworn in, initiate?" she asks sarcastically which leads the feline to give her old friend a soft grin. "Lead the way," she tells the taller girl.

Adora looks back to Bow, hoping to squash the butterflies in her stomach. "And speaking of new initiates to the Rebellion," she takes a second to glance pointedly at Glimmer, hoping he'll take the hint.

"Oh?" the arrow boy pauses curiously to look back and forth between the two friends when his eyes widen, "*Oh*."

"*Yeah*," the tall soldier gives him a small smile and takes a step back from the group, ignoring Glimmer's curious glances, "I'll uh, let you handle that, if that's okay?" Bow gives her a small smile and a nod which Adora takes as a dismissal. She glances back to the cat woman and tries to mentally prepare herself for having someone who gets under her skin and messes with her emotions a little too well back into her life. Adora motions with her head towards the entrance of the castle, "Let's go."

Catra is a little confused about them splitting off, but she doesn't need to be told twice and quickly catches up to the fair skinned warrior. It's a generous walk across the bridge so she takes a second to admire the city. She's never actually been this close to the castle before, and honestly, every time she's been here in the past it was to attack the kingdom so she really didn't take a bunch of time to admire the architecture. Although now the scenery was a little overshadowed by the invasion happening all over the planet. So, instead she takes a second to admire the woman walking just a step ahead of her.

The former princess undoubtedly seems tense - shoulders back, fists clenched as she marches them to the entrance of the castle. Catra smiles to herself and maybe lets her eyes linger on her blonde counterpart a little too long. She no longer seems to be limping which is good, but the feline couldn't help but to take the opportunity to check out the rest of her form as well. *She always did look good in red… Fuck*, Catra chastises herself, *Focus*.

Taking a breath she skips a step to walk alongside her new comrade and attempts to break the tension. "So uhh…. What was *that* about?"

Adora doesn't break her stride when she glances over to Catra. She's not entirely certain what she's inquiring about, but, looking back at Glimmer and Bow deep in conversation, she can guess. She sighs, but continues towards the entrance where the guards are starting to open the doors for them as they approach.

The feline also sighs when her question is met with silence. "Come on, Adora," she rolls her eyes back over to her companion, "If this is going to work, you're gonna have to talk to me."

Taking a breath, the taller girl decides there's no harm in telling her. Staring straight ahead she responds, "We found King Micah *alive* on Beast Island."

"Seriously?" Catra's eyes widen and she glances back to see Glimmer falling into Bow's arms, grasping him in an embrace. But then the second part of that statement hits her and she feels her stomach drop. "Wait," she faces forward again with worried eyes, "What were you… doing on…"

Her question eventually trails off as Adora slows and then stops before the entrance to turn and look at her. The lithe rebel soldier rests her hands on her hips and raises a singular eyebrow, because she knows the brunette already has the answer to that question.

Catra swallows thickly as her ears tuck down.

When she doesn't say anything else, Adora decides to confirm her suspicions, "We were there to save Entrapta." Her tone is crystal clear if not a little accusatory.. So Catra can surmise that the warrior most likely knows *exactly* how Entrapta ended up there.

"Right," the feline nods her head absentmindedly and shifts her gaze to the entrance just over the blonde's shoulder. Up to this point her nerves had been mostly minimal, but suddenly she feels her stomach tying in knots. "So, umm," she returns her eyes to Adora's waiting gaze, "I'm guessing Scorpia is in there, too?" Because how else would the Rebellion have known where to find the short scientist?

"Yeeeep," Adora makes it clear from her flippancy that she holds absolutely no sympathy for the former Horde soldier. *She made this bed - now she needs to lie in it.* "This is a part of joining us, Catra," she gestures to the door behind her, "If you want to work with us that means facing all the people you've hurt over the years."

Catra gulps again and lets her eyes drift up to the structure that seems a lot more intimidating now than when they first started across the bridge..

When she doesn't respond, the taller girl prompts her, "You think you can handle that? Because it's not too late to turn around and go back." The cat girl drops her eyes to meet Adora's again, "So, what's it gonna be?"

Catra senses the challenge behind her words and she's never been one to back down from a challenge… especially not when it comes to her lifelong rival/friend. So, she nods slightly and attempts to put her brave face back on. "Let's do this," she says, but suddenly sounds a lot less sure about this decision. Nevertheless Adora steps aside and gestures for the former commander to go in first.

You got this, Catra tries to encourage herself. *You can do this.*

The two women enter the castle, ignoring the curious glances from the nearby guards, and go to face whatever may await them.

“Dad?” the voice is timid and on the brink of tears.

The former castaway turns from his conversation with his sister and immediately recognizes his little girl. Or maybe not so little anymore.. “Glimmer?” his eyes are wide and he appears as shocked as she is. It doesn’t take too long for the pair to run into each other’s arms.

“W-w-what happened?” Glimmer tries to ask when she pulls back, but she’s having a hard time speaking through her tears, “H-how are you alive?”

King Micah smiles down at his baby girl and can’t help but plant a tender kiss on the broken girl’s forehead. “That’s a long story, baby.” He steps back then, holding her hands out in his, “Look at you!” Tears are streaming down his own face now. “You’re all grown up!”

The two grasp each other again and hold each other through the tears. Neither of them seem to want to let go.

“Dad?” Glimmer sniffles and picks her head up to look at him. “M-mom…. She-” the princess squeezes her eyes shut and tries to summon the courage, “She’s not… S-she didn’t-” King Micah takes a gentle hold of Glimmer’s chin and pushes her face back up so she’ll meet his eyes.

“I know, baby girl,” another tear escapes, as he gives her a forced smile, “I know.”

The princess sniffs and returns to the hug. Everyone else clears the room so the two broken hearts can take comfort in each other.

The two former friends seek seclusion in one of the many grand rooms of Bright Moon's castle and lay in wait. Adora had stopped to share a few private words with Bow and then she ushered the former force captain away into a deserted room. *But what are we waiting for?* Catra's not exactly sure what they're doing in there, but she drifts off to the side and walks along the wall of glass separating them from a 500 ft. drop.

The duo sat mostly in silence up till now. Catra had tried to initiate conversation a couple of times only to be shut down by the stoic warrior. *So I guess I'll just be bored then. For a Rebellion I figured this place would be more lively.* The feline focuses out the window and sees the woods from their perspective for the first time.

"Wow," she says, mostly to herself.

The fright zone didn't have a building nearly this tall. Catra would know - She spent a good amount of her childhood climbing and investigating every inch of her old home. Here in Bright Moon, though, they have nearly a birds eye view of the Whispering Woods from here.

"It's nice, isn't it?"

The brunette tenses and jerks her head around to find Adora standing off to her side a short distance away. When did she get so quiet? Catra swallows and turns back to the view. "Yeah," is all she states since the taller girl didn't seem to be up for much conversation. But they stand there, in silence. It's not much, but the cat girl will take it as a good sign.

Watching a large bird fly over the tops of the trees causes Catra to smile - then she chuckles, "Do you- do you remember when you got stuck in the drain pipes trying to climb on top of the barracks that time?" She turns back to watch the rebel soldier who keeps her gaze focused out the window and doesn't seem as amused.

"I was only up there because you ran away from our field training," Adora states with much less fondness.

"I know, I know," but the former captain keeps chuckling, "I was just thinking about how, before I was able to come get you out, that gull found you…" Here she folds her arms over her stomach trying to contain her laughter, "... and started to build a nest in your hair."

Adora turns to face her full on, and Catra can see from her expression that she's not entertained. The feline's laughter quickly dies off as studies her stance - arms crossed, face expressionless. *At least she's not mad*, the shorter of the two thinks… But somehow the entire lack of emotion for the old story of the two of them seems far worse.

"Catra, I don't know why you're here - I know the excuse you gave, but I'm not certain it's entirely true," Adora holds her gaze and tries to express with her eyes how serious she is, "What I *can* tell you is the reason you'll be allowed to stay… Because you *offered* to help." She searches her old enemy's face, probably for the dozenth time that day, and looks for any signs of dishonesty. When she doesn't find any, she continues, "But that's it. Whatever ideas you may have about us reconciling should be the absolute farthest thing from your mind." The cat woman drops her gaze and clenches her fist behind her, outside of Adora's view. "We're not friends, Catra," the warrior finishes and waits for the former Horde soldier to respond.

"Yeah, I get that," Catra turns her face back to the view and tries to control her desire to dig her claws into her palm to squelch her sadness. She knows Adora isn't thrilled about her being here, but

she can’t give up that easily. She’ll keep trying to win back her heart, but until then, the last thing she wants to do is cry in front of her old friend.

The door opens behind them, drawing both of their attention. It’s Bow. He stops when he enters and glances at the two of them before speaking to Adora, “They’re all together. You ready?”

The blonde takes a moment to meet the shorter girl’s gaze, a question in her eyes. Catra gives her a small, tight smile - *I mean, it's now or never, right?*

So, Adora turns back to Bow:

“We’re ready.”

Chapter End Notes

Let me know what you think :)

Welcome to the Rebellion

Chapter Notes

> This chapter is a bit shorter, and there's not much Catradora so I apologize for that. It's just necessary for the plot.

Previously

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"We're ready."

Chapter 3

As Bow, Adora, and their unlikely companion approach the war room doors, they hear the sounds of unease pouring out into the hallway. Everyone's either arguing, yelling, or crying out in distress. The trio pause just outside, and at least two of them are questioning whether this is a good idea or not. Catra especially thinks this is an epically bad time to introduce her to the group.

"Ummm.." she starts, unsure of how to voice her concerns as she stares wide eyed at the doors. *I'm pretty sure I just heard someone break a vase against a wall,* she thinks as she turns her worried gaze to the taller girl. Adora looks back at her and Catra feels somewhat relieved to see the brief flash of concern there

before she hardens her expression and tells them, “Let's get this over with.”

The trio enter the room and none of the rest of the group even pause in their panic to take note of them. King Micah appears to be throwing spells at Shadow Weaver. Glimmer and her Aunt Castaspella seem to be simultaneously yelling at the quarreling adults and each other. Mermista is arguing with Seahawk, and Frosta is arguing with Netossa while her wife tries to get her attention. The only three that seem to be keeping out of the chaos are the ones loitering at the side, watching everything with wide, worried expressions - Scorpia, Entrapta and Emily.

“Hey, guys!.... GUYS!” Perfuma’s voice rings out over the room and one by one all of the groups quieten down and turn to see why the flower girl is staring aghast at the door where the new additions stand. Everyone stands there in stunned silence for a minute while they try to comprehend what they’re seeing - why their sworn enemy, the one who had beaten them time and time again, the one who had taken so much from them over the years, is now standing next to the two most trusted members of their inner council.

The three who are being scrutinized don’t see the pool of water slowly creeping into the room from outside until it’s launched in a narrow, speed bullet-train right at them. Bow stands there frozen, not understanding why they’re suddenly being attacked. But Adora, seeing how the water blast is being frozen as it crosses the room, knows *exactly* who the target is and that this ice train hurdling in their direction is meant to *hurt* . Without thinking, three of them move simultaneously in a cadence no one is able to process until after it’s over.

Firstly, Adora steps in between Catra and the ice train, pulling up her arm to call on She-Ra’s shield to protect them, only realizing too late that’s no longer an option. And then, as she feels two hands pulling at her hips and turning her away, she sees the giant armor-shelled red woman step in front of both of them, hold out her giant claw and send red lightning shooting out to destroy the

ice/water blast all the way back to the source. Everyone stands there frozen, having watched it all play out in a matter of seconds but not reacting in time to shield themselves. Fortunately no one was hurt.

"Whoa," Catra breathes out and Adora finally looks to the side to see that it was her arch nemesis who grabbed her, tucked her into her side and tried to shield her away from the blast. The taller of the two feels her heart flutter for a second, relishing in the feel of the arms wrapped around her, until she sees the look of awe and wonder on the girl's face as she stares ahead at their savior.

Wonderful , Adora's heart sinks, *Scorpia gets her powers the same day I lose mine* . The blonde places her hand flat on the cat woman's stomach and pushes her off, trying desperately to school her features so no one sees her trying to squelch the jealousy burning through her chest.

Scorpia, still acting as a barrier between the princesses and the former Horde captain, raises one of her claws to rub bashfully at the back of her neck, "Oh gee, sorry about that." She chuckles nervously before continuing, "But before we jump to any conclusions, I am *sure* that Catra has an *excellent* reason for being here." Always the positive one.

"She's right," Bow agrees as he goes to stand beside her.

Without missing a beat, the chaotic yelling and arguing slowly but surely raises to full volume once again.

"What are you *thinking?!* "

"This can't be real."

"Why is she *here?* "

"Did the *Horde* send her?!"

"Are you *insane?!* "

Bow holds up a hand to quiet down the masses once more. "Look, I know it seems unlikely, but believe it or not, Catra is fighting for the rebellion now."

Dead silence.

"We *can't trust her!* "

"She can't be here!"

"Do you *honestly* believe that?!"

" ARE YOU *INSANE?!"*

"Guys," Bow sounds exasperated this time. He rubs his hand down his face, trying to lower his stress level before trying again, " *Guys!* " All of the voices slowly die down again. "Look, I know this is confusing, okay? But in case you haven't noticed, we have bigger problems right now." He moves to the center of the room for two reasons: one - to make sure everyone can hear him but also two - he wants to draw their attention away from their worst enemy standing just behind him.

"Horde Prime's army has already breached our planet's atmosphere, and the ships are landing everywhere they can. There are more and more ships arriving every hour. We're already getting reports from neighboring villages of the weaponry he's armed with," here he stops to glance around the group, "It's not good, guys. We are severely outnumbered, but not only that… Horde Prime's army mostly consists of robots and clones.. Clones like Hordak. Even if we manage to take out a good portion of them, he'll probably just build more. This man essentially has an unlimited amount of resources at his disposal." Everyone in the group looks more and more worried as he goes on.

"And that's not all," the group turns then to find Adora stepping up

to speak. Steeling her resolve, she holds her head high while she breaks the news, "She-Ra is gone."

There are a few murmurs around the room, everyone getting more and more upset.

"Wait, what?"

"Adora, what are you talking about?"

"What happened to She-Ra?"

Adora clenches her jaw to bite back her emotions before answering their questions, "In order to stop Light Hope from activating the Heart of Etheria and destroying the universe most likely along with all of you…" here she glances around at all the princesses. "I had to destroy She-Ra's sword." Bow takes the opportunity to grab the satchel Adora brought back to the city and empties it on the war room table. Everyone sees for themselves what's left of She-Ra, and if they weren't panicked before, they definitely are now.

Perfuma, with tears in her eyes, turns back to the former princess, "What- does this mean that She-Ra is just… gone?"

Everyone waits with bated breath for Adora to answer, but she can't. All she can do is look down and nod her head.

Glimmer who's standing off to the side with her father can't help but feel her heart squeeze in anguish at the sight of her broken best friend. *I did this.*

"Yes," Bow picks up where Adora left off, "She-Ra is gone which means we're that much more unprepared for this fight we're about to face."

Adora slinks off to the background while everyone focuses back on Bow. Everyone, that is, except for Catra. The feline watches the despondent soldier drop her shoulders, fold her arms and

almost withdraw into herself. *She's really broken up about this, isn't she?* The former commander found herself selfishly pleased when she found out She-Ra was gone - She thought maybe that would make rekindling her friendship with Adora that much easier, but… Her brow furrows as she reads more into her old friend's sullen expression. *It looks like she's lost a part of herself…*

"... and that's why we need Catra," Bow's voice finally filters back into her consciousness. *What, huh?*

Catra turns her gaze back to the crowd and sees them all staring at her. She flashes them a small, forced grin while Glimmer rolls her eyes.

"Catra has been practically leading Etheria's Horde for some time now. She's probably our best bet for organizing a defense against Horde Prime. So we ask that you all put our history with her aside, and focus on the problem at hand."

"Just for the record," Glimmer pipes up from the side, "I did not agree with this decision." Here she shoots daggers with her eyes at the former Horde soldier.

"Then why did you let her in?" Mermista groans in her dry tone.

Here the Queen gestures to Bow who suddenly looks uncomfortable. "It was actually mine and Adora's decision," the man answers.

"Well, *that* makes it okay," Mermista drones on sarcastically.

"I don't know if you've thought this out, Bow," Perfuma interjects nervously, "I mean, obviously we respect both you and Adora, but.." Here she looks around at the apprehensive faces in the room, "Well, Catra has been known to deceive people, hasn't she?" There's a murmur of agreement echoing throughout the group.

Bow looks back to Adora for help, but the former princess is

leaning against the back wall, disengaged from the conversation.

"Then I ask you to trust *us* ," Bow meets their disagreements with earnesty, "We'll watch Catra, make sure she's not up to anything nefarious. But in the meantime she can help us get an advantage over Horde Prime."

"But what if she leads us astray, Bow?" Glimmer can't help but to interject again, "What if we follow her advice, and end up worse off because she wants to get back on the Horde's good side?"

Bow is faltering. Adora seems to be barely hanging on by a thread. Best chance for the cat girl is to speak up for herself… right?

"Is that something you do often, *your majesty* ?" Catra steps out from behind Scorpia's shadow, and while she addressed the Queen formerly, it was definitely said sarcastically. "Follow the advice of someone *you know* you shouldn't trust?" She's being fairly blatant about what she's referring to, causing all the princesses to look over at Glimmer whose face is burning red with anger.

" *Catra* ," Bow hisses at her quietly, " *Not. Helping* ."

"Look, all I can do is offer my opinion, okay? I'm not *going* anywhere - I'm not going to *doooo* anything." Here she rolls her eyes before continuing, "I won't go around any tech, so you'll know I'm not feeding information to anyone. None of you even *have* to talk to me, so you don't have to worry about me manipulating anyone into doing what I want," she narrows her eyes resentfully at Shadow Weaver. "I can tell you what I think you should do regarding the Horde, and then you can decide for yourselves if it's a good decision or not."

Here she shrugs - she honestly couldn't give a damn about their opinion of her, but she leaves that part out.

"You all have your own voices, you all have your own opinions," she takes a moment to glance angrily at Glimmer. She doesn't say it out loud, but obviously she's implying they don't need to simply follow whatever their Queen says since her judgment is compromised. "I'm sure between the lot of you, you can decide for yourselves if I'm being dishonest or not."

The group looks around at each other then. If she's telling the truth, they really have nothing to worry about, but even if she's not… They can keep her in check. Keep her honest.

"We're giving Catra a chance," everyone's eyes shoot around to Adora who's rejoined the group at last. "At the first sign of trouble, she's out. Like Bow said, we have bigger problems to worry about." The group nod along or begrudgingly accept the circumstances. Glimmer stands off to the side, fuming, with her arms crossed.

"Right," Bow starts, "So let's get to it."

As most of the group pairs off, ready to receive their instructions, Catra turns around with a pleased grin on her face. *Crisis averted* . However she loses her smile when a long shadow casts over her. She looks up into the worried face of Scorpia. *Oh fuck* .

The red giant gives her a small smile while simultaneously glancing nervously around the room. "He-Hey, Catra."

"Hey," she responds, but words elude her.

They both gulp and shift anxiously on their feet. "So, you're with the rebellion now?" Scorpia asks, somewhat confused seeing as how the brunette has spent all her life shitting on princesses.

"Uh, yeah- yeah," Catra glances around, looking for a rescue, but at least manages to get out, "Thanks.. by the way. You know, for earlier." She tries to rub away the color she feels creeping up her neck.

"Oh, um, yeah," Scorpia gives her a genuine, if not a somewhat embarrassed, grin but loses it quickly when someone calls for her across the room.

"Scorpia!" someone exclaims worriedly. The two look around to spot Perfuma eyeing the former force captain suspiciously.

"I uh- I should go," the red woman laughs nervously before excusing herself.

Catra follows her with her eyes. Scorpia lumbers back over to where Perfuma is standing with Entrapta and Emily. When she's close, the flower girl starts whispering frantically out of Catra's range of hearing, but she clearly looks distressed. After a moment Scorpia turns back to glance at Catra over her shoulder confirming that Perfuma was absolutely trying to warn her away from the former Horde commander.

The cat woman watches on, trying not to show her sadness, when Scorpia turns her back on her. She looks to Entrapta then, who, she thinks, is looking back at her but can't tell with her mad scientist helmet pulled down. Catra raises her eyebrows and the genius turns away, tapping away on a pad similar to Arrow Boys.

Steadying herself, she walks away with her head held up while trying to ignore her stomach slowly trying to kill her. She knows somewhere logically that what's twisting her up inside is guilt, but she doesn't know how to handle that. She never had to apologize for anything when she was leading the Horde, but now…

Before exiting the room she takes one more glance back and wonders if there'll be a day when they want to call her friend again.

Restless Nights

Chapter Notes

This chapter is more Catradora centered. Hope you enjoy :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Previously
The cat woman watches on, trying not to show her sadness, when Scorpia turns her back on her. She looks to Entrapta then, who, she thinks, is looking back at her but can't tell with her mad scientist helmet pulled down. Catra raises her eyebrows and the genius turns away, tapping away on a pad similar to Arrow Boys.

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Chapter 4

Later that night, after everything is said and done, part of the group splits off to get some much needed rest while the others are ready to defend the castle if need be. Adora, of course, made the short list and was sent to bed. Everyone was looking at her differently - some with pity, whilst others didn't seem to know how to talk to her anymore. That on top of everything else that transpired in the last 24 hours made it a very restless night for the broken warrior.

She tossed and she turned for the first several hours. Whenever she'd start to fall asleep some other worry or nuance she hadn't processed would pop up and she was right back to where she started… It was all too much. Her mind just kept spinning around and around. And the few moments she was able to doze, her dreams would only take her back to the same image, over and over again - A bright, glowing figure out in space that seemed to be calling to her.

Adora kicks the covers off and sits up, leaving her in just her tank top and shorts. She scrubs her face with her hands and wonders if she should just give up on sleep and go join the patrol group. It's pointless for her to continue to lay here and only worry.

Maybe she just needed a minute to process everything, but with more important matters at hand she couldn't afford to think of anything else outside of defending themselves against the Horde's invasion. They need a plan. Anytime she tries to focus on it though, she feels more lost than ever before… And the vicious cycle of worry starts all over again.

The soldier groans loudly and tries smacking her cheek, hoping that'll drive the maddening thoughts out of her head, but her mind and her heart are in conflict so of course it won't be that easy.

Smack

The princesses need to mend their relationship with the genius they accidentally left behind and made to feel like she'd been abandoned.

Smack

Bow's still carrying the weight of the best friend squad as they slowly but surely fall apart.

Smack

The rebellion, while coming out of their last battle victorious, is strained and burnt out.

Smack

Glimmer and her ridiculous idea that Shadow Weaver can somehow be trusted.

Smack

Her best friend's betrayal.

Smack

… That kiss

"Uuuggghhhh," Adora flops back on her bed and tries her best to push the thought out of her mind. Of all the things to worry about, that's the one thing she can't even begin to process and also the one thing that should be furthest from her mind. But it's always there… just under the surface… replaying in her head over and over again in the background waiting to be pulled to the front when her thoughts finally still for a moment.

Adora opens her eyes to stare blankly at the ceiling. She takes a slow breath to steady her pounding heart and then relaxes her mind.

Let's just get this over with.

She still feels the weight of the shorter girl laying on top of her, pressing them together. Her husky voice resonates deep inside Adora, making her squirm. And then their chests sliding together before Catra steals a kiss… *Fuck.*

Adora slams her eyes shut and turns on her side, curling up into the fetal position before all the fight leaves her. She stares ahead blankly again and this time feels the weight of sadness pulling her further into the mattress.

It took her way too long to figure it out.

The cat girl had always been such a steady fixture in her life that it wasn't until she lost her that things became abundantly clear for the Horde deserter.

When Catra turned her back on her after learning she was a Princess at the battle of Thaymor, she was hurt. The first time she slept alone in Bright Moon without the feline's comfortable weight resting on her feet, she hurt more. Every time Adora had to watch Bow and Glimmer share secret smiles or inside jokes like life-long friends do, her heart struggled to keep on beating and her lungs ran short of air. And after Catra left her on a ledge, literally dangling and holding on for dear life after *blaming* her for not knowing something the feline never told her… Her heart shattered.

"I wonder what my life could have been like… had I gotten rid of you sooner…"

Adora clamps her eyes shut at the memory and feels a few tears leak out onto her pillow. But then she relaxes and lets the tears flow freely. *This needs to happen,* she tells herself as she flops back over on her back to stare at the ceiling again, letting the tears fall where they may.

Her heart was broken - The thought was clear to her after that. It didn't help fix things after they became enemies, but after obsessing over it for months after, it was quite clear to the blonde that she'd been in love with her best friend for quite some time. Which is why it made sense how much she was hurting after the girl left her to die. Nothing's been the same since. Every time the two faced off with each other from then on, their interactions were only filled with anger and retribution. For Adora her anger was a shield, a means to try to protect herself after the girl hurt her so badly - it barely worked most days. But now she couldn't help but wonder… was Catra's anger just a cover up, too?

It's probably best not to go down that road , Adora halted the

thought in its tracks, but… it would make sense after the way she kissed her..

Maybe not the first kiss when she was clearly trying to humiliate the soldier and make her uncomfortable, but the second kiss was more… hungry… and passionate. *And that last kiss* … Adora could still feel how tenderly Catra's lips pressed against her own while the brunette tried to calm her tears.

That kiss… Well, that one Adora didn't understand at all. But it made her heart leap up into her throat and butterflies swim around in her stomach all the same.

It's infuriating.

How is it after all this time the Horde commander still has such an effect on her? Even after walking through the whole scene again, Adora didn't find peace. If anything, she only had more questions after allowing herself to think about the mind boggling experience she had with her former friend earlier that day.

She pulls her pillow out from under her head and holds it on her face.

That'll have to be a problem for another day.

"Opening a portal right now will be disastrous," the scientist exclaims after escaping the commander's grip. "It's going to collapse and take us all with it! Adora was right!"

Unknowingly the pink haired princess said exactly *the wrong thing at that moment.*

"'Adora was right,'" Catra forces out between clenched teeth; her whole tense frame suddenly shaking with her maniacal laughter.

All she can think about are the princess's friends - along with their former mentor, Shadow Weaver - somewhere in the Fright Zone looking for the girl… Looking to rescue her - HER. *It's always* her! "Adora *gets* everything *she wants!"*

Here the Horde commander stops to breathe, taking in a few calming breaths which do little to lessen the ache in her chest and the hate in her heart. "But not this time. This time I *am going to win. I don't* care *what it takes; we are opening that portal…* now!"

"No!" Entrapta exclaims, "I won't. I need to tell Hordak - he'll understan-"

Her words are cut off by the electric current passing through her body. After writhing in shock for a moment, the scientist drops unconscious on the floor. Catra stands over her, panting… shock baton in her hand…

Catra wakes up with a start - her heart racing, sweat dripping down her temple - and she flees. She kicks the blankets away, runs desperately to the other side of the room and slinks down against the wall. It takes a second for her eyes to adjust to see what's in the room and almost a full minute before her heart starts to slow. *I'm in Bright Moon,* she thinks while still sucking down air. Waking up in a room she doesn't recognize with the nightmares she's been having? It clearly isn't a good combination.

After calming down, she slides down the wall to sit and then rubs at her forehead, glad to be free of her Horde mask. Unfortunately that does nothing to ease her subconscious mind. *The nightmares are getting worse*, she thinks. It probably has something to do with being in such close proximity to the girl she betrayed, but Catra is smart enough to know better. Smart enough to know better, but probably not brave enough to do anything about it…

She sighs softly and stares off at the far wall.

The longer she sits the more she thinks this isn't going to work. Not only is this room five times as large as anything she ever had in the Fright Zone, but it's also dark… and quiet. There was no steady hum of machinery, no flickering lights… *How do they sleep like this?* The former captain shivers as the sweat starts to dry on her bare arms and legs while she tries to decide what to do next.

Something's gotta change. She doesn't know what needs to happen, but she can't sleep here. And she's gonna need some sleep if she's to help the rebellion fight against the Horde.

Not bothering to cover herself, deciding the bra and shorts cover up enough, she opens the door to her room only to stop dead in her tracks. The two guards that were apparently posted at her door straighten up and turn to face her.

"What's going on?" she asks, only somewhat hostile.

"Orders from the Queen," the guard responds gruffly, "You are to be supervised at all times and kept in your room."

"*If* you try to leave, we've been told to use whatever means necessary to detain you and lock you away," the other guard speaks up.

"Return to your room," the prior barks the order at her.

Catra rolls her eyes and slams the door. *Of course,* the feline seethes, *fucking Sparkles throwing her weight around, making sure I remember who's in charge.* She reaches up and pulls at her hair trying to keep her cool while she figures out what to do. There's no way she's staying trapped in this room all night. Taking a deep breath, she opens her eyes and immediately gets an idea. She leaps over to the windows in a couple bounds, straightens up and presses her hands against the glass. *There's definitely a seal here,* she thinks as she feels a slight breeze blowing through. Inspecting the glass further, she spots where

the window starts and pushes it open. The cat girl steps out onto the ledge then, being sure to keep one hand on the seal while she looks down.

She gulps.

They definitely didn't think the window would be a problem for escape for one very good reason. Focusing her eyes ahead and trying not to think of the drop, Catra uses her agility to balance carefully on the side of the building as she walks around, trying to find another opening to crawl into.

She only hoped it wouldn't be too windy tonight.

Somehow trying to suffocate herself with the pillow seemed to work. Before long the exhausted warrior started to feel herself drifting off to sleep. That is until…

Tap tap tap

Adora shoots up to a sitting position, letting the pillow flop to her lap while she squints at the door. The room is dark, as is the hallway, but from what she can tell, there's no one standing on the other side of the door…

Tap tap tap

The warrior flinches, realizing instantly it was the sound of someone tapping *glass* and not the wood of her door. Shooting her gaze over she immediately finds the source. *What the fu-*

"Catra?!" Adora jumps up and runs to the window before dragging it open. "What the *hell* are you doing?"

"Oof." Catra can't even get a word out before the blonde grabs her

and drags her inside. The cat girl ends up losing her balance in the transition and falls against her... Fortunately the taller girl doesn't seem to have trouble carrying both their weights. Taking a breath to try to calm her pounding heart, Catra turns to look at the drop again. "Yikes."

"*Yikes*, indeed," Adora sounds worried and that sends a warm, pleasant tingle down the cat girl's spine to the tip of her tail… which was already flicking back and forth at the feeling of being in those toned arms. "What the fuck were you thinking?"

Catra rolls her eyes and slides her hands down the taller girl's broad shoulders as she regains her footing, but stops about halfway through. She takes a step back but keeps her hands on the girl, holding her at an arm's distance as she looks her over. *She, umm…* Catra feels her mouth go dry and her face flush when she examines her in her sleep clothes, *Wow* . The rebel soldier definitely filled out, and not just her curves. With her muscled arms and legs on display, Catra feels her eyebrows slowly creeping up while her tail swishes wildly behind her. *Fuck, I can't stop looking at her,* she wants to smack herself, *Get your shit together!*

"*Catra*," Adora calls her name loudly to get her attention and the brunette finally snaps out of it.

She grimaces, her cheeks darkening even further, "Wha- Huh?"

The warrior rolls her eyes but feels somewhat flattered by the girl's inability to stop staring at her. She will admit she had to try desperately to keep her eyes on the cat woman's face otherwise she would end up in a similar position with how little the feline is wearing. Adora glances down for a second and blushes. *But back to the matter at hand..*

The taller girl crosses her arms over her chest and furrows her brow. "*Why* are you slinking around *outside* in the middle of the night on a ledge that's not even made to be walked on?" she

shakes her head in disapproval, "You could've been killed. Do you *know* how far that drop is?"

Catra rolls her eyes as she turns to close the girl's window again, "I had to get out of my room. Her Royal pain in my ass decided to post guards at my door." After the window's secured, she starts to walk towards the exit but slows to a stop and looks back at her. "How do you- how do you sleep here?"

The taller of the two tries to shake the remaining fog from her head - *Did she just say Glimmer is keeping her prisoner in her own room?* Not that anyone should really be surprised. But outside of that she noticed the softer tone the cat woman used for her question and the soldier felt a little warmth blossoming in her chest. *Man, I'd give anything to be able to see in the dark like she can.* Unfortunately Adora only has a few lights shining in through the window to guide her.

"Still afraid of the dark then, are you?" She tried *really* hard to keep the amusement out of her voice.

"I am *not!* "

A very unladylike snort escapes the soldier before she can slap a hand over her mouth.

"You know what? *Uggh*, forget it." The brunette starts huffing over to leave the room before Adora stops her.

"Catra, wait," she shakes her head to try to rid herself of her amusement before taking a step forward towards the girl. She can see she's turned back around and is standing in the dark with her arms crossed over her chest and her softly glowing, heterochromatic eyes narrowed at her in irritation. "It is difficult," Adora tells her. "It took some getting used to for me, too."

There's a beat of silence before the cat girl responds again, "It's just so *quiet*." It was also said quietly, so that the soldier barely

heard it, but she knew what the girl was talking about.

"Yeah, it is," the rebel finds herself wanting to smile again, forgetting how soft the feline can be and finding that she's missed it terribly. But she swallows down her feelings and grinds her teeth. She can't let herself go down this road again. She can't let the woman who seems to have a personal pathway to her heart worm her way back in.

"I suppose you wouldn't..." Here the once fearsome Horde commander clears her throat and looks away nervously, "You wouldn't let me sleep in here… would you?"

"Catra…" Adora shakes her head.

"I *know*, I know," Catra feels her ears drop as she stares at the ground and hugs herself tighter, "We're not friends."

The two stand there in awkward silence trying desperately to break away but neither of them are willing to take the first step. The taller of the two sighs and turns to head back towards her bed. The brunette looks after her longingly but turns to excuse herself from her space.

"Here," Adora says, and Catra stops in her tracks. She looks over her shoulder back towards the bed but doesn't dare get her hopes up. The warrior turns around then walks back towards her with a pillow and a blanket.

Catra feels her heart rate pick up and her eyes burn slightly, but she swallows down the emotion and thanks the girl quietly.

Adora gestures with her head towards the couch. "You can sleep over there," she tells the tired feline. Catra nods and turns to go make up a pallet on the couch. As she's settling in under the blanket she hears Adora's voice drift over to her from the direction of her bed, "This doesn't change anything."

The former captain feels her heart sink and turns her back to the girl when tears start burning the corners of her eyes again. "I know," she whispers just loud enough for her former friend to hear.

She listens for a while as Adora sits down on her bed and fusses with her pillows, but then she grows quiet again. Catra could swear she can feel the blonde's eyes burning holes into her back for several minutes before she finally lays back and settles in for bed.

Is this ever gonna get easier? She wonders. She knew that she was fighting an uphill battle with this one, but she can't lose her again… She won't.

With that, the cat girl lets her eyes drift close and she finds slumber easily.

Knock Knock

"Adora? Are you up?" Bow's voice drifts through the cracks of her door.

The soldier's eyes shoot open and she instantly jerks upright in bed. *Oh shit.* Recalling her memories from last night, her head snaps over to the couch only to find it empty.

"Adora?"

"Uhh- one minute!" She hops up to throw some clothes on when she notices the blanket she yanks off of her is actually the blanket she'd given the cat girl last night. She feels her face flush and quickly moves to dress herself up. Just in the knick of time since Bow decides one minute is up and pushes the door open.

"Are you decent?" He asks and the blonde notices he walked in with his eyes covered.

"Yes, I'm decent," she says as she tosses her blankets and pillows back on the bed. "What's the plan?"

He peaks through his fingers first before deciding it's safe and removes his hand, "Glimmer is calling us in groups to give us our assignments. We're up."

Adora narrows her eyes at the information but follows behind her friend to the war room. Once the duo walk in they see another group walking out.

"Adora, Bow…Just in time," Glimmer says as they join the other few circled around the war table. The Queen quickly explains that she's sending them to Greenfield to help evacuate the village before the Horde troops arrive there later today.

As the rest of their group suits up and prepares to head out, Adora can't help but look around questioningly. "Where's Catra?" she asks. "Bow and I are responsible for her - she should be in our group," the soldier tells Glimmer, "Where are you sending her?"

Glimmer barely glances at Adora while moving some maps around, "She's staying here."

"To… defend the castle?" she asks incredulously. "If she's here, why isn't she helping with war preparations? I mean, that is why we let her stay isn't it?"

"Your answer is in your question, Adora," The Queen's tone is sharp and it's clear she doesn't appreciate her friend arguing with her. "She's here to help with *war* preparations. We are not planning any attacks yet. For now we're only focusing on saving lives and bringing them back here to safety. Catra doesn't need to be around to gather any unnecessary information." At that the warrior rolls her eyes before Glimmer continues, "When we're

ready to start fighting, then the horde scum will join us."

"What? So, she'll actually get to leave her prison cell?" The taller of the two asks with irritation in her voice. It's enough to catch the attention of the others in the room. Glimmer's eyes snap to hers, and she drops the maps back on the table.

"It's not a prison cell," she argues.

"If she's not allowed to leave her room? Kind of the same thing," Adora responds sarcastically.

"Guys," Bow interjects, stopping their argument.

Glimmer closes her eyes and takes a breath before starting again in a calmer tone, "I don't understand why you're sticking up for her after how much she's hurt you - *betrayed* you."

Adora rolls her eyes and walks over to get her staff, "You don't have to understand it."

"I do when it involves my best friend," tears spring up to her eyes, "Catra gets to you, Adora, I've *seen* it. You can't afford to let her get in your head again."

The rebel soldier pauses by the war table on her way out. She meets the Queen's gaze, "So I'm guessing we're going to lock Shadow Weaver back up for the same reason, right?" Then she turns and leaves.

The tears fall and Glimmer is quick to wipe them away. Bow lingers but doesn't seem sympathetic towards the girl.

"What am I doing wrong?"

"You stopped trusting us," Bow responds gravely, hurt flashing across his expression.

Glimmer reels and immediately tries to defend herself, “It’s not a matter of trust-”

“Isn’t it?” her oldest friend interrupts, “We’re trying to do what we think is best, all the while you’d rather listen to Shadow Weaver than us… When have we ever led you astray?”

Here the Queen looks away… *Never. You’ve never led me astray.*

“So, how about this?” Bow continues, his expression hardening again. He gathers up his bow and arrows as he prepares to leave, “We’ll listen to you and follow your every command the minute you start listening to us again.”

Glimmer clamps her jaw shut and watches with wide, wet eyes as her best friends leave her to her thoughts.

Chapter End Notes

What'd ya think? :D

The World Needs Adora

Chapter Notes

> This is a lengthy chapter - I do apologize for that. It covers the span of a week, so there's a lot of ground to cover. I do have a nice Catradora moment at the end though XD hope that makes it worth it.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Previously

"What am I doing wrong?" Glimmer sounds hopeless.

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Chapter 5

The road to Greenfield was long and bumpy. They were traveling by horseback and by wagons. Obviously having Glimmer teleport back and forth to rescue all the villagers in danger would've been faster, but they can't expect her to do that all day every day without repercussions. So Glimmer is in charge of evacuating villages that are further out from Bright Moon while the warriors traveling by land have time to get to the nearer villages.

Outside of Bright Moon, other kingdoms like Salineas and the Kingdom of Snow are sending out troops of their own to help who they can. So far the Horde seems to be avoiding the larger kingdoms, probably testing out the waters… seeing what kind of weapons they have in their arsenal. But the rebellion specifically avoided direct conflict with the Horde in an attempt to play their cards close to the vest.

It'll be a long road, but they think this is the best route to take for now.

Adora and Bow sit in the back of one of the wagons as Greenfield comes into view… they're getting close. The blonde stays en garde and ready to fight, searching the nearby trees for any signs of danger. They were told from the rebellion scouts that the nearby Horde battalion are approaching from the southwest, so by the time they arrive there in a matter of hours, the evacuated villagers will be well on their way to Bright Moon heading in the opposite direction. Regardless, the former princess keeps a close eye… *You can never be too careful.*

Bow had been watching her on and off for the entire ride. He knows Adora isn't really one for talking about feelings, so the few conversations they've had about the tension between her and Glimmer were short and somewhat scattered. She'd been waiting for him to broach the subject the entire ride as he switched his attention from what's on his trackerpad to watching Adora. When

he looks away again without actually saying anything, the silent soldier finally pushes the conversation.

"I can see you want to say something, Bow," she says, her tone wary, as she keeps her eyes on the treeline, "Just say it."

Bow studies her for a moment, contemplating if it's worth it to say anything before bringing his eyes back down to the trackerpad now laying in his lap, "I was just wondering…"

When his voice trails off, she looks over in his direction.

Her friend stalls a moment before looking up and meeting her eyes, "How did you know Glimmer posted guards outside Catra's room when she obviously made that decision after we went to bed, and then I came and got you first thing this morning?"

Adora clenches her jaw and turns her eyes back to the tree line. His tone isn't accusatory, more curious than anything, but she's not sure how she should answer that.

Bow scrubs the back of his neck and then sets his tracker aside, "Look, Adora," when she meets his eyes again, he continues, "I trust you, okay? Let me just say that - I trust you…" The rebel soldier waits with bated breath for the other shoe to fall. "But Glimmer wasn't wrong," he pauses to let his words sink in, "Catra *does* have a knack for getting inside your head, and I just need to make sure you're being careful, okay? Don't forget who she is."

The tall girl nods and stares off into space for a moment before responding, "I haven't forgotten who she is, I promise." She meets his eyes earnestly, "I know not to trust her and I won't. I know too well what she's capable of and I won't allow myself to fall for it. Just… trust me, okay? I can handle it."

Bow studies her for a minute longer before nodding and giving her a small smile. He goes back to his trackerpad, and Adora spends the rest of the ride in silence, watching out for enemies.

The rescue of Greenfield is a success, as are all their other rescues throughout the next week. There were a few hiccups - The Horde definitely caught up with them in a few instances, but so far the groups sent to escort the villagers were able to fight off the bots chasing after them with little effort. Besides that, everything seemed to be going okay for them…

In all honesty, the biggest threat to them so far had been Adora herself.

"I got it!"

Before Mermista can even water whip the drones advancing on her, the wild blonde appears from nowhere and smashes both of them with only a little difficulty. "Adora!" the blue princess calls after her in warning.

"Oops," the tired warrior suddenly noticed the bots advancing from the treeline, "I'm on it!"

"Adora, no! We need to run," Bow calls to her from across the clearing, but she ignores him.

She knocks the head off one bot only for another to knock her from behind, sending her into a tree. The fallen soldier tries to stand only to realize a pain in her side that knocks the breath out of her for a second. She watches with a mild panic as three bots start advancing on her, but before they get too close, vines creep up behind them, wrap around and then crush the mechanical menaces.

The exhausted fighter sighs in relief as Perfuma runs to help her up, "Adora, you can't keep doing this." Her tone is chastising, "You're not… you-know-who anymore."

Adora feels a short stab to her heart but pushes on, "You help Bow get the villagers out of here." She turns to the other bots appearing out of the treeline, "I'll take care of these clowns."

“Adora,” Perfuma sighs in exasperation but goes to help Bow.

It doesn’t take long before the broken soldier ends up in a similar situation as before - knocked down on the ground with five bots approaching her from all sides. “Oh shit,” Adora says, glancing around her. How is she going to get out of this now?

Before she can devise a plan, the five bots are spontaneously electrocuted and fall to the ground around her. Bow comes bounding up then, stashing his bow away. “Adora!” he yells in worry.

“I’m okay,” she struggles to push herself up, “I’m okay.”

“No, you’re not,” he argues, “You’re not sleeping, you’re barely eating.” She looks away while she dusts herself off. “Adora,” her friend sighs, “You’re not… She-Ra anymore- You’re vulnerable. You can’t keep pushing yourself like you’re not.”

Adora grits her teeth and nods shortly before turning to follow the rest of the group back.

And that’s how it goes all week - Adora runs in head first, trying to protect everyone when it’s just not an option for her anymore. She’s just.. normal… weak.

The thought hurts her every time, but she can’t stop trying. This is the role she’s always had in the rebellion - how is she supposed to just step back and let the princesses handle everything?

Things weren’t much better back in Bright Moon. Every one regarded her either with sympathy or irritation.. They either felt sorry for her or mad at her for constantly landing herself in trouble at every turn. The princesses started doing other missions on the side, mostly intelligence gathering, that the blonde was specifically left out of. Adora had never felt so useless before.

The only good thing she’d managed to do all week was finally convince Glimmer to let Catra out of her room.

"You don't have to let her out of the castle… Just let her leave her room!"

"Uuugggh, fine," the Queen gave in, probably only to shut her irritating friend up.

Though the former Horde commander was free now, that didn't necessarily mean the two frenemies saw each other. Adora usually left first thing in the morning and sometimes wouldn't return to the castle until late in the evening. Despite their distance, the cat girl still returned to the broken warrior's room every night. Sometimes she wouldn't show up till after Adora was asleep or sometimes Adora would enter the room to find Catra already lightly snoring on the couch. The only thing that stayed steady was every night the blonde would leave a folded blanket and a pillow on the couch, and every morning she would find that blanket covering herself, as she had the tendency to kick her blankets off in her sleep.

They were ships passing in the night. Sharing a room, but not actually interacting with each other. The couple of times Catra entered the room to find Adora still awake, she went about her routine quietly… Knowing that the rebel soldier didn't have the energy to deal with her old nemesis.

The one time words were exchanged between the two was late one night when Adora woke up with a start - sweating through her clothes and breathing heavily- after she found the glowing woman in space haunting her dreams again. She shot up in bed only to have two hands grasp her shoulders.

"Whoa, hold on," the rebel blinked into focus to see worried teal and yellow eyes inspecting her closely, "It was just a bad dream."

Adora looked around her darkened room while her heart rate and breathing returned back to normal. She glanced back at the cat woman sat in front of her on the bed. "It's okay," the feline's voice was a low rumble, "You're safe."

The exhausted soldier nodded before turning and falling back to sleep.

And that was it. Adora's days were too long - definitely too long to try and fit someone she had so many mixed feelings for back into her life.

On this day in particular, she actually got to see the castle during the daylight hours. The rebellion was planning their next steps. There were still villages on the outskirts of the kingdom that they were keeping an eye on but they weren't in immediate danger. So the point of focus next would be taking down the Horde.

Adora wanders down the hallways looking for the others when she hears raised voices coming from the war room. The warrior, curious about what's going on, trots to the room and enters to stand behind the princesses who were facing King Micah and Shadow Weaver.

Basically the entire core group of the rebellion was in there… Even Bow and Catra were seated off to the side. *Why did no one tell me we were having a war room meeting?* The worn soldier frowns and crosses her arms, trying not to read too much into the oversight.

"Why would we mess with the Heart of Etheria?" Glimmer yells at Shadow Weaver. "It was a mistake before and it's a mistake now." *At least she's admitting it was a mistake now,* the blonde rolls her eyes.

"We do not have the resources to face off with Horde Prime," Shadow Weaver's voice rings out over the room, "If we do not act now all of Etheria will be lost."

"Why would we listen to you?" Frosta bites out, "We don't even like you."

"Not to mention," Mermista's dry tone pipes in next, "The last time

we messed with the Heart of Etheria, it nearly killed us all, and plus… there is no Heart since Adora *lost* She-Ra."

Adora grimaces and feels what little energy she has drain from her body. With no one even noticing she was there it's fairly easy for her to drag herself back out.

The worn out soldier walks back down the hallway she came from at half-speed. She doesn't know what to do anymore. She's not a princess, but after being She-Ra for years it's hard to break that cycle of thinking she's invincible…

The only thing she really offers to the group these days is someone else they need to rescue.

Shaking her head and clenching her fists, Adora storms off.

The first few days living in Bright Moon were definitely some of the most boring days of her life. Who knew there was very little to do to keep yourself entertained while trapped in a bedroom?

By the fourth day, her highness, Princess Sparkly Pants, deemed her fit to move around the castle at least. The move was confusing for her - did she get out for good behavior? She didn't know, but she definitely wasn't going to argue.

Catra already had the castle mapped out within the first day. Seeing as how she wasn't allowed in the super secret meetings yet, she had a lot of time to explore. The top few floors were reserved for the officers of the rebellion, a couple of the middle floors were reserved for feeding people and healing people, and the lower levels were jam-packed full of villagers that'd been rescued from the Horde. A large majority of them went to villages that were still safe, but the rest came here. So the castle was quite large and bustling with people all times of day.

Fortunately none of them spoke to her which is how she preferred it. She'd seen Scorpia and Entrapta every so often, but whenever she saw them she immediately turned and went another direction. The cat girl wasn't ready to face them yet and she didn't think they really wanted to talk to her anyways.

So while the relative freedom was nice, it too got quite boring after a while.

In the meantime she had gotten absolutely nowhere with Adora. Her former friend was at least nice enough to continue to let her sleep in her room every night. But the few times they actually were both awake at the same time, the soldier looked like she'd taken a beating… Either that or she was just ready to pass out at any minute. But Catra was in no hurry. She'd take as long as she'd have to, and, seeing how Adora still seemed very skittish around her, it was going to take a while. The brunette decided that giving her some space, even when they were in the same room together, was the best option.

As she makes her way through one of the few vacant corridors, she reaches out with her free hand to start dragging her claws along the wall, leaving scratch marks in her wake. She was just deciding if she should go do some training or have an early dinner and then bed when she hears a voice call her name with some irritation.

" *Cat* ra."

The cat girl leaps around to face the newcomer which turns out to be the Wonder Boy himself.

"Uhh… hey."

Bow walks towards her with purpose, giving a side glance to the scratches on the wall.

"Those were here when I got here," she states, not even trying to sound believable, to which Bow rolls his eyes.

"I don't care. We're due to be in the war room - let's go." With that he turns and marches back the way he came, expecting Catra to follow.

The shorter girl rolls her eyes and follows reluctantly. *This meeting better be more entertaining than the rest of Bright Moon.* Though she supposes she's a little grateful to be included now.

As they sat down, the rest of the rebels started filtering in. The brunette spotted Shadow Weaver already standing at the front of the room when she entered and tried her best not to hiss at her. Though they'd been apart for some time now, Catra still felt uneasy whenever her former mentor was sucking the light out of the room - she's not sure if that's something she'll ever get over. Soon the princesses along with the few humans they rely on were all gathered around the war table to discuss options. The team made it clear they didn't really want her input, nor did they want Shadow Weavers - *Why are we even here?* - so the cat girl kept her mouth shut.

It wasn't too far into the meeting that Catra notices Adora isn't there. *Hmmm* . As far as the feline knew, there were no missions currently going on, and if there were… *the girl definitely wouldn't be out there by herself, so where is she?*

After a few more moments of questioning why the rebellion even invited her in here - and listening to these idiots throw out every stupid plan they can think of - she spots movement out of the corner of her eye. Glancing over she sees that Adora has finally arrived, squished in the back behind the other princesses. *Now where have you been?*

"And plus," Mermista continues, "there is no Heart since Adora *lost* She-Ra."

The blonde grimaces then, and Catra frowns at the blue princess. *Way to be sensitive* , she thinks. When the solemn warrior turns to leave, the cat girl watches her go. She knows it's a stupid idea,

and she tries really hard to convince herself of that, but without much thought she gets up to follow. The arrow boy, however, grasps her forearm before she makes it too far.

"Where do you think you're going?" he whispers.

"Bathroom," she lies as she slips out of his grasp and carries on in the direction she thinks Adora went.

After checking the few rooms she thought she'd find the lost girl, she finally decides to check the training room that's usually abandoned. *It's no wonder these rebels are shit at fighting* . However, Adora wasn't, and sure enough, as soon as Catra reaches the top step to look down at the training rings, she spots her…

The willowy blonde is down close to the end, swinging her staff at a training dummy. Only she's not really using skill or practicing moves - by the look of it, she's trying to kill the thing. Catra watches on as she approaches the girl quietly. Once she's close she can hear Adora's ragged breathing as her swings get more and more sloppy until she stops completely. The feline is very aware that the girl's shaking shoulders aren't entirely because of the workout.

"He'll never sass *you* again," the woman decides to announce her presence. Adora's shoulders instantly tense up and Catra can see her quickly trying to wipe her tears away.

"What are you doing here?" The warrior's voice is raspy and still thick with emotion.

Catra thinks for a moment and decides she needs to hear the honest answer. "I came to check on you," she says softly.

"I'm fine." Adora doesn't miss a beat as she moves over to rest on one of the nearby benches, finally facing towards the cat woman though she refuses to meet her eyes.

Taking a step forward, the former commander debates whether or not she should call the girl out for the blatant lie. She decides to wait.

When met with silence, Adora finally glances over at her and sighs. She swallows hard before turning her gaze back towards the dummy. "I don't really have a place here anymore, do I?" She asks quietly, "I'm just a liability."

"I find that hard to believe," Catra answers earnestly.

Adora lets out a breath of a laugh, still refusing to look at her, "You haven't seen me out there."

"I mean, you may be out of practice," the feline shrugs while walking towards her, "But I sincerely doubt anyone considers you a liability."

The soldier rolls her eyes and turns her face away, trying to keep her tears from falling.

"Hey."

Catra's voice is soft as she moves forward, squatting to sit on her haunches right in front of the former princess.

Adora avoids her gaze as long as she can, but when her ex-best friend doesn't move away, the blonde glances back at her… trying to hold her intense stare but finding she's not strong enough for even that.

The former commander studies her face carefully before telling her another truth, "You were a badass long before you ever picked up that sword." Adora lets out a faint snort of a laugh. "I'm serious," Catra smiles along with her. "If you want my opinion, that sword honestly didn't do you any favors."

The seated woman rolls her eyes though she's starting to feel better, "Whatever."

“Okay,” the cat woman’s infamous attitude is back, “How many times did I beat you in a fist fight back in the Horde?”

“Never,” Adora responds with a catty grin.

Catra laughs, “Yeah, that's about right.” Her eyes shine up at her blonde counterpart, glad she’s at least gotten a smile out of her. “And how many fist fights did I *lose* after you became She-Ra?”

Squinting her eyes, the rebel soldier tries to count but slowly the smile dims into a confused expression… *That’s not right, is it?*

Catra answers for her, “Only two, dummy. And technically speaking, one was Double Trouble pretending to be me so that hardly counts, and the other you were super juiced on some red rock.”

Holy shit . “That doesn’t make any sense,” the broken warrior mutters to herself.

“Which part?” Catra tilts her head and smirks up at her adorably. “The part where She-Ra was a worse fighter than you???”

Adora shakes her head while meeting the cat girl’s eyes again only to find a grin waiting for her.

The brunette shrugs while she stands back up, “She-Ra was a large, lumbering oaf. You were more agile and skilled… I don’t see the confusion here.” The warrior is still shaking her head in confusion when Catra holds out her hands, “Here.”

Adora glances at the hands offered, up to Catra’s face, and then back to her hands before hesitantly reaching out to grasp them. The shorter girl takes the opportunity to pull her to her feet and relishes in the closeness of her old friend. Adora meets her eyes looking somewhat vulnerable again, so Catra tries to ease her fears…

“The world needs Adora now… not She-Ra.”

As soon as the words reach the rebel's ears, tears instantly spring to her eyes and start to run over. Catra watches it happen but doesn’t hesitate to reach up with one hand and brush the tears away gingerly.

Adora feels her heart melt at the feline’s words and can’t look away from her heterochromatic eyes regarding her so tenderly. She’s not sure how she can take this but definitely knows she shouldn’t. The only thing she can do is close her eyes and turn her face into Catra’s palm while she tries to control her breathing. The cat woman is patient, holding onto her cheek while caressing it gently with her thumb. Her heart stutters again when she thinks she feels her old nemesis move closer but she can’t be sure until she feels it - when Catra pushes their heads together and starts nuzzling her softly.

A breath of a laugh escapes her and she opens her eyes again to witness the softest side of Catra. A side that only Adora has ever gotten to see - the thought makes her a mess all over again. Her heart swells and starts thundering in her chest as she tries to remember the last time she’s experienced this…

It happened often when they were kids - not in front of people, of course - but usually when the two were hidden away from everyone, in some darkened corner of the loud city, and having a moment between themselves… The cat girl would lean forward and nuzzle her friend, showing her affection in a way she couldn’t talk about. The instances became few and far between as they got older, happening less and less with every year to the point that Adora can’t even pin down the last time it happened.

The cat woman starts rumbling then, letting a very audible purr resonate in her chest as she nuzzles the taller girl again. Adora grins and reaches up to comb her fingers through the feline’s hair before another solitary tear escapes.

Standing so close to her, Catra sees the tear cascading down her cheek. She watches it fall for a moment and, without thinking twice, tilts her head up to catch the tear with her lips…. A tear that ended up landing on the corner of Adora's mouth. The two freeze, not daring to move, and the former Horde commander wonders if she made a mistake. But when the timid woman doesn't shrink or move away, she takes a chance by sucking gently at the corner of her mouth in the world's smallest kiss… and then she feels the rush of cold air.

One second she was there, pliant under Catra's hands and mouth.. and the next?

The cat woman's stomach drops as she turns and watches Adora trot back to the entrance of the training room, not even pausing for a second to look back. When she's out of sight, Catra sighs and smacks her forehead with her palm, feeling the disappointment wash over her.

Stupid stupid stupid.

Why does this keep happening? Why does she keep *letting* this happen? How does this woman know how to make her melt every time?

"Adora."

The woman marching down the corridor stops in her tracks after slamming her eyes shut. She can't do this - she can't let herself hope.

"Adora?"

After getting her composure and shoving her feelings away she turns to the other thorn in her side. "Did you need something, your majesty?"

Glimmer winces and slows her step, but continues forward until she's in front of her friend. "We're sending some of the princesses out to do some reconnaissance on the spires that are loitering near one of our villages…" here she pauses, looking a little guilty as she glances down for a moment, "We decided it's probably best for you to stay here for the time being-"

"No longer needed, am I?" Though she's mostly over it, she can't help the anger that seeps through.

The Queen looks saddened for a moment, "No, of course you're needed, Ador-"

"Then why am I being left out?? Out of the missions, out of the meetings," her voice raises in volume, drawing the attention of some nearby guards. "I know She-Ra's gone, but that won't sto-"

"Adora," Glimmer interrupts sternly, "Come with me." She grabs her friend's hand, escorts her to an empty room and closes the door behind them. The tired warrior walks forward and leans against the edge of the table, waiting for whatever's coming.

"Adora," the princess starts when she turns around - it's then that Adora sees the tears glistening in her friend's eyes. "You're not being included in missions and meetings because we need you to rest. There are bags under your eyes, your clothes aren't fitting you anymore… You're running yourself into the ground."

The taller of the two crosses her arms and clenches her jaw. Loathe as she is to admit it, she's not doing well.

"I stopped listening to you," this was said quieter, but it drew the lone soldier's attention anyway. The tears are now making their way down the Queen's face as she continues, "I know I messed up. I never should've listened to Shadow Weaver… I definitely shouldn't have listened to her over you. And now the pain that you're in -" her lips tremble as she takes a shaky breath, "It's my fault."

Adora's stance loosens and she feels her guard dropping as she looks on at her broken friend.

"I'm so sorry, Adora," the purple princess continues, "I did this to you. And there's nothing I can do to change it, or I would. You can stay mad at me; you can hate me and I won't blame you… I deserve it. But I will *never* stop being your friend," here the Queen's expression turns from sad to determined. "I will never stop caring about you - I will never stop trying to protect you… even if that means protecting you from your own stubborn self."

Her friend lifts her chin then, meeting the blonde's gaze head on as if daring her to contradict her. She won't back down from this. Adora shakes her head and lets out a breath of amusement as a small, tired grin finds its way to her face. Glimmer stares on, looking hopeful for the first time in this exchange, as the soldier approaches her slowly and gently pulls the girl into a hug. The princess feels tears leave her eyes again as she grips onto the warrior for dear life.

"Okay," Adora says softly, stroking her friend's hair, "Okay."

The hug lasts until the girls run out of tears - They reconcile, hopefully this time for good.

The Horde takes more ground every day. More and more troops are being spotted all over the planet. So, the best friend squad is going to need to rely on each other if they ever hope to survive this war.

Chapter End Notes

Any thoughts?

What are you planning?

Chapter Notes

AN: I had to go back and look to see what chapter we're on now lol I'm currently writing chapter 12, so chapter 6 feels like forever ago.

Hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Previously

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Chapter 6

After their confusing encounter in the training room, Adora hadn't seen or heard from her childhood friend. The first night came and went with no late night visitors as did the second.. and also the third. Though she counted it as a blessing, she couldn't help but feel curious if not a little despondent at the feline's sudden disappearance. She knew she had to be around somewhere, but she didn't make it a point to go looking for her.

The warrior kept her word to Glimmer, though, and rested as much as she could - as much as the glowing space lady would allow - and overall just took it easy. I mean, she did still train when things were a little too quiet around the castle, but there was only so much laying around she could do. Regardless she's glad she listened to her friend, because she definitely needed the break.

While she wasn't allowed in their meetings, she did still hear words floating around about what was going on out there. So far from their intel they couldn't find a weak spot for Horde Prime. With an army this large, their best bet was to take the fight straight to their leader since they were horribly out-numbered. Horde Prime, however, turned out to be as enigmatic as the rest of his entourage. It is a firm belief that he hasn't even laid a foot on Etheria yet… simply commanding his troops from space.. Which made their jobs a little more difficult. Glimmer still had some ideas for what they would try next, and Adora was grateful to hear she'd actually be able to sit in on this meeting and contribute… She just had to survive her boredom until tonight.

While walking to the dining hall she passed a few of the princesses and couldn't help but feel a little guilty for her three-day vacation. Each one of them looked more haggard than the last. They've hardly even seen battle yet, and their biggest team players already look worse for wear. Seeing them just strengthens Adora's resolve to get back into fighting condition as soon as possible. *I'll be back out there fighting alongside them in no time* , she assures herself while turning into the dining hall in search of food.

But she stops dead in her tracks just inside the door.

Adora feels her heart rate pick up for a second, but she schools her features and tries to act nonchalant before she walks up behind the unsuspecting Horde commander. Catra has her back turned to Adora, so she watches for a second while her tail swishes back and forth as the cat woman tries to decide what she wants to eat. Adora mentally kicks the memory from the other day out of her head - she can't look at the woman if all she can think about is how it felt to have her old friend's lips so close to her own. *Get a grip* , she scolds herself and forcibly removes her eyes from the girl's tail.

The blonde sighs softly to herself as she arrives at the food table. Without looking at her, she reaches out to pick out a muffin and places it on the brunette's waiting plate. They didn't have sweet food in the Horde - it's one addiction she's had since coming to Bright Moon and figures the cat girl will enjoy it as well.

Catra looks up in surprise at the unwelcome intrusion, but feels her eyes go wide when she sees who it is. Adora finally looks at her and offers her a small grin in lieu of a greeting.

"Uhh… hi?" the former commander grimaces at herself. *'Uhh.. hi?' What the hell is wrong with you?*

"Hey," Adora responds in kind. She looks down for a second as she reaches to grab her own plate to start decorating when she finds herself blurting, "You haven't come by." *Fuck, seriously? Why did you bring that up? You shouldn't care if she showed up or not.*

"Yeah, umm.." Catra moves forward, picking out some other delicious smelling, savory meats to go with her roll thing while she formulates a response. "I figured you'd want some space after.." *Shut up, shut up, shut up.* She looks over to see the healthier looking warrior offering her a grateful smile before they both go about sorting their plates quietly.

The blonde knows she shouldn't, she *fucking* knows it, but her mouth has a mind of its own. "Well, my orders from the Queen are to get some rest…" her shorter companion turns to look at her questioningly while she continues, "And it's hard for me to sleep when…" She clears her throat uncomfortably, wondering what the hell she's doing.

Catra feels one of her eyebrows slowly creeping up the more she talks. She can't help but feel a bit smug when she prompts her, "When???"

Adora licks her suddenly dry lips and rolls her eyes before turning to fully face the girl, "Just- come back, okay? We don't have to like each other; we don't have to trust each other." She's not even really sure who she's trying to convince now as she turns to look for an empty table, "I just… sleep better when someone else is in there is all."

The cat woman has to perk her ears up to catch the end of Adora's mumbled rambling as she admires the pretty pink that's coloring the blonde's cheeks. She does her best not to gloat. Things between the two are still very delicate right now, and she already fucked up by pushing her too fast last time. She didn't need to screw this up by teasing the poor girl.

"Okay," she states simply, still admiring the girl's profile with a small grin.

Adora's head snaps over to look at her, "O-okay?" she asks, trying to keep the hopefulness out of her voice.

Catra's smile deepens, stretching all the way to her eyes. "Okay," she says again as she turns to leave the beautiful woman behind her.

Adora feels a tiny brush against her as she watches the cat woman walk away. She glances down and notices it was her tail, sliding down the length of her arm as she moved to find a table.

Adora feels her blush deepen and is grateful no one else is watching her.

No one else that she notices anyway.

Glimmer stands at the side of the room, narrowed eyes focused on the former Horde commander as she leaves her best friend's side.

We're gonna have words , the Queen mentally projects to Catra as she turns to leave.

We're gonna have words and one way or the other, you *are going to listen* .

Catra was exploring the castle again for the millionth time since she arrived. People for the most part - with the exception of a gorgeous, blonde warrior - still avoided her like the plague, but now at least they'd walk down the hall she's in without turning and fleeing in the other direction. On that afternoon in particular she had to force herself not to think about her very interesting encounter with Adora that morning lest everyone walking past see the goofy grin on her face while her tail swishes wildly behind her.

Maybe things are turning around? … Maybe? She knew not to get her hopes up. One wrong step would send the girl running again. But Catra can't help but let herself hope for something more. She hasn't made any leeway with anyone else yet, but let's face it… Adora is at the forefront of her mind most days.

When she reaches the end of the hallway she figures it's about the time she needs to start heading towards the war room. *Maybe Adora will be there?* With a grin and a hop in her step she turns… and then immediately freezes - her grin falling somewhere

on the ground in front of her as she faces off with the purple haired pain in the ass herself.

"*Catra*," her name is pushed out in disdain. The Queen stands there with her shoulders back and her chin up, trying to seem as intimidating as she can be to the former Horde soldier..

The feline eyes her with her arms crossed and an eyebrow raised at her. She doesn't know whether she should laugh or bite her lip because this is Adora's friend.

"Your royal sparkly pants," Catra responds, the corner of her mouth slowly creeping up despite her trying to keep a straight face.

Glimmer sneers at her and makes her way forward. The cat girl stands her ground as the rebellion leader marches up to her, only stopping when she's a couple feet away. She is definitely trying to use her height as an advantage here, but Catra has been fighting people twice her size for a long time now. She doesn't need a few more inches to scratch someone's eyes out.

"We need to have a talk," the woman tries to sound intimidating and ominous, probably hoping to get a rise out of the brunette.

But Catra, calm as ever, gestures for her to continue.

Glimmer stares her down before continuing. "I don't know exactly what your game is here," she purposefully keeps her voice low to make her sound more threatening, "But I'm watching you. Whatever you're trying to do won't work. Adora may be trusting enough to give you a second chance, but I won't." Here she clenches her fists and leans forward into the cat woman's space. She narrows her eyes at her before concluding with, "You are going to stay away from my friends - Is that understood?"

Catra handled it pretty well up till then, but the sparkly princess with literal stars in her eyes… *threatening* her? She couldn't resist - she threw her head back and laughed until her stomach hurt.

The Queen did not appear amused and just stood there and watched as the former commander doubled over, clutching her stomach.

"Are you finished?" Glimmer grumbles out between clenched teeth.

The cat woman holds a finger up while she gets the last of the chuckles out of her system and wipes at the corner of her eyes. "Wow, that was good," Catra shakes her head before meeting her eyes again, "Now, it's my turn." Glimmer watches her cautiously as the former Horde soldier steps right up to her face and glares at her menacingly. " *First* of all - Adora can decide for *herself* who she wants to spend time with," she maybe says it with a bit of a growl, but she's been feeling very protective of the girl lately. "Second of all - I don't answer to you. You do not get to dictate what I do in my spare time. I may be helping the rebellion fight the Horde, but that does *not* mean, in any way, that I'm one of *your* loyal subjects, *princess* ."

The brunette watches on, waiting for the Queen to lose her temper, to fight back, to cry - really anything at this point - but does not expect the response she actually gets.

Glimmer's face slowly lightens - a smile (albeit a *malicious* one) curls up on her face - like she's just been handed Horde Prime's head on a plate.

"Very well," is all she says before turning and making her way back down the corridor.

Catra stands there frozen and staring after her - her ears dropping along with her stomach.

Why do I get the feeling I just walked into a trap?

When the group finally gathered in the war room, it was evident that the princesses looked relieved Adora's back. The outcast revelled in the smile that played on her old friend's features. *At least she's happy* , Catra thought, trying to ignore the unsettled feeling still swimming in her stomach. Once the last of the rebel council arrived, it was time to get started. *No turning back now, I guess.*

"Alright, everyone, settle down," Bow calls out across the room. Most of the room uses any available seats they can find, but with the size of the group, a few of them have to remain standing.

Once the chatter quiets, Glimmer steps up next to her friend and continues on with the meeting, "Okay, everyone. As some of you have heard, we've run into some trouble around Erelandia. Not one, but two Horde spires have landed in close proximity to the city which is cause for concern."

"She's right," Bow picks it up from there, "Erelandia isn't like the villages we've evacuated before - this city is significantly larger and will be difficult to get everyone out safely… Especially if the Horde is planning on targeting them which it seems they are. Drones have already been spotted overhead and appear to be gathering intel before the attack. But we've had an idea - we'll take out two birds with one stone."

Everyone takes a second to glance around - some low murmurs of confusion can be heard before Glimmer explains, "These two spires on opposite ends of the city present a unique opportunity for us… But if we're going to pull this off, we need *all* of you."

"Absolutely," Bow concurs before moving up to the war table to explain. "We'll position group A here - your primary job will be to take the fight to the Horde. If they're coordinating with other battalions like we believe they are, the troops coming from the second spire," here he pauses to circle and draw an imaginary line back to the first group, "will reroute. Instead of going for the city, they'll target group A which is why this group will mostly be

composed of princesses - We'll need as much fire power as we can get."

"Yes, and while we have the princesses distracting the Horde troops here," Glimmer steps up and points to group A's position, "group B, which is composed of everyone else, will be at the eastern entrance to the city, helping to evacuate everyone as fast as we can."

King Micah joins in the explanation, "Group B is going to have their hands full, because as they mentioned before this will be a very difficult city to evacuate - Not only do they have a larger population, but we're looking at multiple levels, shops, side streets, fenced in properties… And there's always the risk that some of the clones and bots will still target the city while the rest take on the princesses. Group B is going to need to break up into sections itself just to make sure we hit all the houses and protect the people in the process."

Bow nods along before continuing, "This will be the biggest extraction we've done, but that coupled with all the princesses fighting the Horde will give us a rare opportunity… to sneak around and investigate the abandoned second spire."

The room becomes unsettled again, everyone questioning quietly what that could mean when Queen Glimmer starts explaining again, "Entrapta has been working really hard to find a way to hack into Horde Prime's system. We know he has to have a signal to command his troops from space, and Entrapta believes she can find it. So while Group A and Group B focus on distracting the Horde battalions and evacuating the villagers, Group C will escort Entrapta to the abandoned spire so she can get close enough to take a peek at their system."

"Once she's able to hack into Horde Prime's system, we should then be able to see what he's planning or at the very least, listen in on their communications," Bow concludes.

The group looks around at each other. This seems doable; this is a good plan. There's some excited chatter amongst the masses. If they could pull this off it could be a big step forward for the rebellion.

"You haven't told us who's going to be in Group C yet?" Swift Wind asks curiously which is followed by more affirming murmurs.

"Well, we haven't deci-"

" *Actually* ," the Queen is quick to cut her friend off, "It was decided just before the meeting who we can spare for Group C."

There's some confused glances and questions in everyone's eyes, including from Bow, as they await to hear who is going to be a part of this crucial group.

"Seeing as how the bulk of our troops will be going to the first two groups, we have a limited space for people to assist with Group C. So for those who are to accompany Entrapta and help her *get* to the spire…" Here Glimmer makes a big show of unfolding a piece of paper to read from. Bow narrows his eyes at her suspiciously because he's *fairly* certain there are no names on that paper, but listens as she continues:

"Scorpia, Perfuma… and *Catra* ."

There's a huge disturbance amongst the crowd then. Some are arguing, some are suspicious, and others just watch on in surprise. Catra herself feels all of the color drain from her face as her stomach bottoms out. Her eyes scan the crowd for the giant red woman - she finds her across the room and she looks just as uncomfortable with this plan as she does.

"Um, Glimmer?" Perfuma speaks up with a nervous giggle, "I think there's been some mistake here."

“Yeah, isn’t the Horde scum still restricted to the castle?” Netossa adds on.

There’s several who agree with the princesses, but Glimmer waves off their arguments. “As we’ve already said, it’s all hands on deck if we want to make this work.” She takes a second to pause and look over to meet the disturbed cat woman’s eyes, “This is your chance to prove to us what side you’re really on.”

As everyone slowly turns to look at the former Horde commander, Catra keeps her eyes locked on the sparkly bitch, trying without hope to figure out exactly what the hell she’s thinking. When all eyes are off of the Queen and focused on her, Glimmer takes a moment to wink at her… And the cat woman feels her blood boil.

This can’t happen, she thinks and looks around the room for anyone who might help her. The rest of the crowd, however, resign to the Queen’s decision and disperse to start collecting in their groups - there's no time to waste. The only person Catra can find that looks a little worried for her is her blonde counterpart, standing across the way - Adora’s eyebrows are scrunched together, but she offers her a small, encouraging smile.. It does little to bring her any comfort.

What the fuck am I supposed to do now?

When the room clears, Glimmer takes a moment to gloat to herself. *We’ll see if she feels like giving me attitude again* , she thinks, trying to keep the delighted giggle from escaping.

“What are you doing?”

“AHH!” The Queen yells and jumps around only to find Bow standing there with his arms crossed, inspecting her suspiciously. “Bow!” She exclaims, “I thought everyone had left already.”

“Thought I’d hang back,” he’s using the same exasperated tone that seems to be directed at her more and more these days. “Now answer my question - What are you doing?”

“Oh, I was just,” she turns around briefly to move some of the maps around on the table, “you know - straightening up.” Here she turns back to him with a false grin which he doesn’t buy for a second.

“You know what I mean, Glimmer,” he looks at her sternly, “We had no plans to let Catra join the battle today - you threw that in there as your own personal vendetta.”

The purple haired girl rolls her eyes and shakes her head, “I don’t know why you and Adora are defending her.”

“I’m *defending* her because we agreed to give her a chance,” the man argues, “Signing her up to fight with all the people she’s hurt when she’s barely even gotten her feet wet isn’t giving her a chance.” The two have a standoff, staring at each other, willing the other to fold before Bow continues, “Look.. I know you and Adora just had a talk. And while I’m happy the two of you seem to be sorting things out, that kinship is still treading on thin ice, and she’s not the only one you’ve hurt with your actions. I mean, did you even stop to consider Scorpia or Entrapta’s feelings in this?” Glimmer’s face softens, losing some of her bravado as she watches her oldest friend tear into her. “If you keep pushing like this, if you keep going down this road, you’ll end up in the same position Catra’s in - surrounded by all your old friends who want nothing to do with you while you try to redeem yourself… Is that really what you want?”

When Glimmer doesn’t respond, the archer turns and marches hotly out of the room, leaving the princess to her thoughts.

One step forward, two steps back, she sighs and follows shortly after him.

After all, they have a battle to win.

Chapter End Notes

Any thoughts or comments? :D

The Battle of Erelandia

Chapter Notes

> The battle of Erelandia... should be interesting. There is next to no Catradora in this chapter though - I do apologize.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Previously

"You know what I mean, Glimmer," he looks at her sternly, "We had no plans to let Catra join the battle today - you threw that in there as your own personal vendetta."

The purple haired girl rolls her eyes and shakes her head, "I don't know why you and Adora are defending her."

"I'm defending her because we agreed to give her a chance," the man argues, "Signing her up to fight with all the people she's hurt when she's barely even gotten her feet wet isn't giving her a chance." The two have a standoff, staring at each other, willing the other to fold before Bow continues, "Look.. I know you and Adora just had a talk. And while I'm happy the two of you seem to be sorting things out, that kinship is still treading on thin ice, and she's not the only one you've hurt with your actions. I mean, did you even stop to consider Scorpia or Entrapta's feelings in this?" Glimmer's face softens, losing some of her bravado as she watches her oldest friend tear into her. "If you keep pushing like this, if you keep going down this road, you'll end up in the same position Catra's in - surrounded by all your old friends who want nothing to do with you while you try to redeem yourself… Is that really what you want?"

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After all, they have a battle to win.

Chapter 7

As the Rebel Etherians start closing in on Erelandia, they begin to split off into their groups. According to their scouts, this battle is happening *now* and they don't have a minute to waste. The second spire battalion is already approaching the other side of the city so they need to act fast.

Group A lash out and attack the first spire battalion as soon as they're within range - they don't even get close to the city. And as soon as the princesses start to wipe the floor with them, the second battalion, as predicted, stop in their advance to the city and turn to join the fight against the princesses.

Meanwhile, Group B has infiltrated the city and is using a grid system to remove everyone as quickly and efficiently as possible while Group C… Well, Group C have traveled mostly in awkward silence all the way to their position for obvious reasons.

Catra follows behind her teammates a good distance away. They don't trust her and they have no reason to. Scorpia has thrown her a couple pitying looks, but then Perfuma grabs her arm and she turns away again. And Entrapta? Well, Entrapta hasn't raised her helmet or looked away from her trackerpad since they set off on this journey.

She wonders if any of them plan to throw her off a cliff before they return.

But Catra sighs and carries on. She said she would fight for the rebellion, and so she will… even if this isn't how she imagined it going. They can hear the sounds of battle behind them which is pushing them forward, but it's quite clear no one is happy about this grouping.

As they get closer to their destination, suddenly Perfuma and Scorpia grab Entrapta and quickly duck down behind some brush. Catra's ears flatten and she looks around - *What's got them spooked?*

"Catra!" Perfuma whisper-yells at her while Scorpia tries to signal her over with her claw. Confused, the feline leaps over to them in a couple bounds, being sure to stay under cover. *"What's going onmf-"* the cat girl is cut off by Perfuma's hand. When she releases her, she points just beyond the brush in the direction of the second spire - their destination. Catra looks over and immediately spots the problem. *For fuck's sake…*

So, some of the intel they received was false. Either that or the Queen was very wrong about what they would find there. There aren't *many*, but this spire was definitely meant to be abandoned, and there's at least a few dozen bots and drones circling around, supervising the area. "Well, *that's* inconvenient," Catra grumbles quietly.

"What do we do?" Scorpia almost looks comical with her broad frame and tail tucked behind her trying her best to hide behind the brush.

Perfuma starts nervously "M-maybe they just haven't left yet?"

"No," Catra answers. She sits steadily on her haunches as she peers over the leaves to observe the bots and their movement patterns as they cross paths and circle back, "They were definitely left behind to guard the spire."

"We should just head back then… right?" Scorpia asks unsurely.

"What?!" the other three girls immediately shush Entrapta after she exclaims. The purple haired scientist takes the hint and lowers her voice, though she raises her helmet for the others to hear her better. "No, we're *so* close!" She whisper-yells, "Once I hack my way into Horde Prime's system, the possibilities are endless! We can maybe even get his bots to work for *us!* "

Perfuma sighs and glances at the Horde forces one more time before nodding, "Okay, let's go."

Catra watches, confused, as the other three start making their way out of the trees, heading for the spire. "Wait, what?" The cat girl leaps after them and stops them just before leaving the tree line, "That's it, you just- go in there without a plan?"

"We *have* a plan and it hasn't changed," Perfuma explains, exasperated, "We need to get Entrapta to the spire."

"*Yes*, but there was an unforeseen variable added to the situation so *obviously* we need to come up with a *new* plan," Catra matches her tone with snarkiness.

"Maybe we should go back to the city and come back with a few more troops?" Scorpia suggests.

Perfuma crosses her arms and looks at Catra accusingly, "Or *maybe* you just want us to give up entirely."

The cat woman actually considers it because with this lot, it won't be easy…

"Now's your chance to prove to us whose side you're really on."

Glimmer's words echo through her head and she curses the princess silently. "No, we're already here," Catra grumbles, inspecting the guards they'll have to face. "Might as well give it a shot."

Perfuma rolls her eyes and gestures to the crevices where pipes were laid out leading all the way up to the Spire, "I figure we can conceal ourselves and sneak up to the Spire where no one could see us. We'll have to be careful of the drones scanning the area, but it's definitely doable."

"No, that won't work," the feline shuts the idea down immediately.

Here the flower girl huffs and crosses her arms again, "Your negativity isn't appreciated or wanted here, Catra."

"Look," the cat woman nods behind the two and they turn around just in time for Scorpia to reach out and grab the purple haired girl before she wanders right out of the woods in plain sight. "Even *if* we were able to avoid the bots and go undetected, we can't do that *and* keep track of Entrapta."

"Oooo, so close," the scientist says, still trying to move forward even though the red-shelled woman is holding her back. She's completely engrossed in her trackerpad and unintentionally proving the former Horde captain's point.

"So what do *you* suggest?" Perfuma and Scorpia both wait for an answer.

"We use Group A's plan," here the cat woman shrugs as she looks out at the spire once more, "and we hope it works for us, too."

The princesses turn to each other confused, so Catra explains, "We use a distraction… Two of us will engage the bots and drones on one side while someone escorts Entrapta on the other."

Perfuma looks pleasantly surprised by the idea and Scorpia nods along with a grin.

"We can do this," Catra tries to instill confidence in her teammates. "We're outnumbered-" she pauses to count, "by a lot, but we don't need to beat them, just distract them."

“Okay, so- who is supposed to be the distraction?” the red woman asks.

“Well, the two princesses will be able to do the most damage against the bots,” Perfuma offers.

Catra immediately grimaces knowing that option would leave her alone with Entrapta, and she’s not quite ready to face that yet. “No uh- we’ll need a princess on both teams in case this plan doesn’t work and the bots go after Entrapta instead.”

The two princesses look at each other quietly, and the cat woman feels irked that they’ve already built some secret communication in the short time the armor-shelled woman’s been with them. But then again, she can’t really blame Scorpia for finding better friends, can she? The thought causes Catra’s ears to lower and the guilt that’s been eating away at her to make a sudden reappearance.

Perfuma’s not happy about the idea of them splitting up, but she’d rather be paired up with the former Horde commander than leave her alone with her impressionable friend. “Okay,” she says somewhat sullenly before meeting the cat woman’s eyes, “You and I will be the distraction while Scorpia escorts Entrapta to the spire.”

Catra nods in affirmation and gulps before walking over to the engrossed scientist. “Entrapta?” she calls hesitantly.

The purple haired girl looks confused at first but then meets her former friend’s eyes with a little apprehension.

“How close do you need to get?” Catra asks, “You know, to get into the system?”

“Hmm,” Entrapta looks back down at her trackerpad and punches a few buttons, “It’s hard to say. I need to follow their uplink that connects the spire to the mothership out in space but, depending on the sophistication of their tech, which seems *immeasurable*,

their uplink could have a broad bandwidth to encompass more ground or-" The scientist stops, remembering who she's talking to. She then holds the trackerpad up to Catra's face and starts speaking more slowly, "I need to connect *thiiiis* to Horde Prime's *spiiire* via it's *signal* - I won't *know* until I get *cloooser* how strong the spire's *signal* isss."

Catra nods, "Okay." She turns to Scorpia then. "Just plan on taking her all the way to the foot of the spire if need be, and Perfuma and I-" she glances at the flower girl for a moment, "We'll keep them busy as long as we need to. Whenever she's finished doing… whatever she's doing, I don't know… Send an electric current down one of those pipes or maybe up the spire? We should be able to see the signal from where we are, and we'll hightail it out of there."

The team agree on their plan of action and decide to send Perfuma and Catra to the far end of the spire to start engaging the drones. Once the bots are drawn away from their area by the fight, that's when Scorpia and Entrapta make their move.

Perfuma and Catra are both hesitant to rely on each other during this fight but decide for the time being they'll just have to trust each other. They fight mostly back to back. The feline focuses primarily on the drones flying overhead as she can leap into the air and knock them out of the sky - sometimes grabbing one to throw at another or one of the bots below - while Perfuma uses her power to crush the bots that come close to them.

The former commander watches the flower girl out of the corner of her eye when she can - she's always been impressed with Perfuma's power. She's strong enough to sometimes take out whole tanks, but even from far away Catra can see that she's sometimes reserved in her fighting technique. Even now, she's lashing out at one bot at a time when the feline knows the peaceful blonde could easily wipe out the whole group of them that's approaching.

At one point as Catra's taking a breath - because they've been going at this long enough for the girl to work up a sweat - she spots a bot out of the corner of her eye. Not a fully functional bot, but one that Perfuma believed she'd obliterated earlier with her vines. Its' legs weren't functional but it appeared the torso still had some life as the bot sat up and aimed its arm cannon-blaster right for the flower girl's back.

"Watch out!" Catra calls to her and leaps from her recently downed drone straight to the offending bot to swipe its head clean off. The action stops the cannon blast in its tracks and the feline leaps again to one of the other bots approaching the blonde, completely missing the look of awe and appreciation Perfuma throws her way.

The two of them continue their brutal attack on the bots for what feels like forever. They're both keeping an eye out for their signal to leave, but it seems to be taking longer than they thought. As the girls start dragging on, Perfuma finally starts getting nasty - using her vines to drag several bots back into the ground or sometimes she will swing one bot around to take out all the bots in the immediate vicinity while Catra ducks out of the way. But after a few minutes of that, the duo are left back to back, both breathing heavily as they look around to take on the next enemy… only there isn't any. Inspecting the ground littered with mechanical parts around them, it's pretty clear the two soldiers took out *all* the guard bots by themselves.

"Whoo!" Perfuma shouts in celebration and turns around to high-five her unlikely comrade.

Catra meets her high-five and shares a tired grin with her, "Now *that's* how it's done, princess. Way to show 'em."

The blonde blushes lightly at the praise and turns to look around, "I wonder what's taking them so long?"

"I'm not sure-" Catra freezes when her ears pick up the familiar sound of Scorpia's lightning strikes, but there's no lightning going

up the spire. *Oh no…* "They're in trouble!" The former commander immediately takes off in the direction she heard them, but pretty soon she's picked up by something wrapped around her waist and she looks around to see Perfuma's determined expression as she uses her waves of vines to carry them quickly towards the spire.

Once the wave passes the spire, Catra jumps off as Perfuma continues forward to assist Scorpia with the bots that are teleporting - *Teleporting?!* - right in front of her eyes. "What the actual *fuck?"* The cat woman curses but doesn't have long to linger. She immediately spots several bots heading straight for Entrapta who's elbow deep in a panel she removed from the spire. Catra launches herself at the first bot, ripping off his head before yelling, "Entrapta? We need to go, *now!"* She takes on the next two bots without much interference but then gets a nasty shock from a drone she didn't see coming.

The cat woman tumbles down into the crevice next to the spire and by the time she blinks and shakes off the attack, more bots are surrounding her - two with their cannon blasters already charging up while pointed directly at her. *Guess this is it*, she thinks and squeezes her eyes shut while she waits for the blasts that never come.

The sound of circuits frying causes the former commander to peek her eyes open, and then they widen completely as all four bots are electrocuted and fall over in front of her. She suspects she has Scorpia to thank for the save, but then she hears Entrapta's maniacal laughter.

"Hahahaha!" The purple haired princess drops down right next to Catra, "It worked!" She exclaims as she puts her new and improved shock baton back away in her hair. One of the purple tendrils then slides over to pull the cat woman back to her feet while Entrapta runs off to join the other two, leaving the baffled horde commander staring after her. She laughs and shakes her head incredulously before running to catch up.

All of the rebel troops limp back to Bright Moon after the battle. To say that the Rebellion won would be a lie. Did they survive? Yes, but only barely. None of the groups were expecting dozens of horde clones and bots to suddenly start teleporting out of thin air right into the thick of it. They were all caught off guard. The princesses in Group A barely made it out with their lives. The rescue teams of Group B got split up and many of the villagers were injured as bots teleported in and started destroying the city before they'd finished evacuating.

When it was all said and done, the group with the highest success rate turned out to be the most unlikely - Group C.

Glimmer stood there with her arms crossed, silently fuming as Scorpia, Entrapta, and Perfuma recounted their tales, all boosting up Catra as the heroine of the story.

"You should've seen it - she was like 'whack-WHACK'-"

"But she stopped us before we went and got ourselves killed-"

"I got *all* the information I could from their servers, and *what a whirlwind!* There's *so* much data to analyze!"

Catra stood there with a satisfied smirk on her face, knowing the Queen must be furious that her plot didn't pan out like she'd hoped. But the feline didn't care about her opinion so much. Without being too suspicious, she glances around the room casually to find Adora's eyes locked on her - a pleasantly surprised, albeit tired, grin playing on her lips - and Catra feels her cheeks flood with color.

"Yeah, Catra really stepped up and showed us what she's capable of today," the cat woman looks over to find the flower girl smiling at her graciously, and the color spreads to her neck.

"Alright, alright," the former commander rolls her eyes, "I'm sure *her highness* has other meetings to go to."

The chatty trio turn and continue to blab all the way out of the war room with Catra falling in silently behind them. Once they're out in the corridor and have some semblance of privacy, the cat girl figures it's now or never.

"H-hey, Scorpia? ...Entrapta?"

The trio fall silent and slowly turn back to look at the feline who appears anxious out of nowhere. Perfuma, who seems to have some other secret power of reading people, gives Catra an encouraging smile and continues on her way, leaving the three former Horde soldiers to talk amongst themselves.

Once she's gone, the brunette gulps and decides Scorpia will be the easiest one to start with. She looks up into the giant red woman's curious gaze and starts talking, "So, I'm not uhh- good at this." Catra glances down and shuffles her feet awkwardly before meeting her eyeline again, "I just wanted to say… You were right." She pauses for a second to let those words sink in, "I was a bad friend. You were always there for me and I- I took advantage of that… I'm sorry."

Catra clears her throat gruffly and looks down to shake her head, hoping to scare off the tears she felt burning her eyes. When her eyes are under control again, she turns to the short scientist, "And Entrapta…" The feline swallows thickly, "What I did was wrong - there's no excuse for it. I should've listened to you." Here she shakes her head, feeling the disappointment gnawing away at her. "I was an asshole and I put my vendetta before my friends. You deserved better…" she glances back at Scorpia, "You both did." When she turns back to look at Entrapta, the tears are back-stinging at the corner of her eyes. "Thank you, and I'm sorry."

The scientist's face lights up before she steps forward. A long tendril of purple hair pops up and pets the fearsome commander on the head. "I forgive you."

"Oof," before she knows what's happening, both Entrapta and herself are scooped up into the giant, armor-shelled woman's

arms as the air is choked out of them.

"You know I'm a hugger," Scorpia tells her with a smile. Catra lets out a breath of a laugh and relaxes into the embrace.

Maybe things will be alright after all.

Chapter End Notes

Any thoughts? :D

The Many Colors of Catra

Chapter Notes

PLEASE READ: TRIGGER WARNING

It's not huge because I can't bring myself to write on very serious topics, but I do describe in some detail a character having a panic attack later on in this chapter:

****
****
****
****
I will bracket it like this in case you want to skip over it.
You won't miss much, I promise.
****
****
****
****

There are some good Catradora moments in this one, so enjoy :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Previously

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Chapter 8

Catra, Entrapta, Perfuma and Scorpia end up having dinner together that night. They talk about old times, laugh and drink. When Entrapta gets distracted and goes to start decoding her work and then Perfuma calls it an early night, it leaves just the two old friends to catch up.

"W-wait," Scorpia busts out, somewhat amused and somewhat shocked, "Hordak *destroyed* the Fright Zone?"

"Well, it was still standing when I left," the former Horde commander chuckles and takes another sip of her drink, "But a good chunk of it around the sanctum and the labs is completely demolished. I think part of it was you and Sparkles, but most of it was *definitely* Hordak." She shakes her head in amusement, "He almost got me a couple of times, but I was faster. Made it out with just a few scrapes and bruises."

"*That* is insane," Scorpia laughs along with her, "Oh man, I wish I could've seen it."

The two friends go silent and think about the implications of Hordak's meltdown. “Do you think-” the cat woman starts and almost stops because she realizes it sounds crazy, “Do you think there’s really something between Hordak and the science whiz?”

“I don’t know, honestly,” Scorpia chuckles, so grateful to have someone to gossip with, because she herself wondered about it from time to time, “They definitely spent a *lot* of time together, though.”

“Right?” Catra laughs and they both take another sip. She’s missed this. *It’s nice to have someone I can actually talk to in here*, she thinks. The former Horde commander eyeballs the red woman then, “And speaking of secret romances - what’s going on with you and *Perfuma*, huh?”

Scorpia’s face turns as red as her uniform and she looks down, embarrassed. “Oh, uh- you know,” she chuckles bashfully, “She’s been a *really* good friend to me- like… the *nicest* person I’ve ever met. Even when she had no reason to like me, and the rest of the rebellion just wanted to lock me up, she was always *so* kind.”

The cat woman watches her friend, amused. *I don’t think she realizes how revealing her babbling is,* she thinks. “So, just a friend, huh?” she asks with a catty grin.

“A- *ha!* ” Scorpia tries to laugh to hide her unease, but quickly falters, “I mean, sure? I mean, no. I mean-” The red woman stops and shakes her head, “She’s nice- like really nice- and *so* pretty.” Here she looks back up to her friend’s gaze, worriedly, “Do you think she likes me?”

Catra has to bite her lip to keep from laughing, and shakes her head in amusement, “*Yes* , I think she likes you, dummy.” She watches the red woman’s face light up and can practically see the hearts in her eyes. *Oooo, she’s got it bad* . “Question is, what are you gonna do about it?”

The two continue to gab back at each other, not noticing Adora walking in on the far side of the dining hall. The warrior witnesses the friends making each other laugh back and forth and tries to ignore the stabbing pain in her chest. Some of the other rebels notice her and try to talk her into sitting down and having dinner with them, but she chooses to leave, having suddenly lost her appetite.

Scorpia and Catra end up talking for hours, well into the morning before they decide to call it a night. The cat woman feels good, like she might actually be able to make it work here. They had a great, but very close, victory, she flirted with Adora, she reunited with her friends… She chuckles devilishly as she thinks about her drunken midnight shenanigans that'll most likely come back to bite her in the ass, but overall… She feels good; it was a good day. Tonight's the first night the former commander enters her bedroom and thinks she may actually be comfortable enough to sleep in there. But then she thinks about the blonde soldier, and a grin spreads across her face as she runs over to the window.

She takes the ledge at a snail's pace seeing as how she's a little intoxicated. And she knows this really isn't even worth the risk seeing as how Adora has surely been asleep for hours by now. *But I just wanna be close to her,* Catra thinks stupidly as she goes to crawl in the other girl's window. She's normally very sly and stealthy, but on this night she tumbles through and lands with a loud thud.

Well shit, that didn't go as I planned it.

A light comes on quickly and then she hears the thumping of boots heading her way.

"My hero!" she chuckles as Adora hooks her hands under her arms and pulls her to her feet.

The warrior takes one look at her and rolls her eyes, "You're drunk."

"Yes," Catra goes to nod - her head goes down but then she forgets to bring it back up again. "Whoops."

Adora sighs and scoops the woman up in her arms bridal style, trying to ignore how it feels being so close when the girl's arms naturally wrap around her neck, before walking over to sit her on the couch.

"What're you still doing up?" the feline asks, feeling a little more lucid after her terrifying crawl to the blonde's room.

The annoyed one sighs and sits down next to her on the couch before glancing over, "Couldn't sleep. I just tried taking a walk around the castle, but that didn't really help either."

"Oh," the cat woman is genuinely sad to hear the news, "You should've come to dinner with Scorpia and me. We've been talking each other's ears off for hours."

"Yeah, I noticed," the soldier grumbles and Catra notices for the first time how closed off the girl is. Even now she's looking straight ahead, arms crossed, eyebrows furrowed…

Is she- is she jealous???

That thought definitely wakes her up. Catra's eyes widen a bit and she turns to inspect the sullen soldier more closely.

"I'm surprised Perfuma doesn't mind you hanging out with her so much…" the warrior continues when the feline doesn't say anything. And while the statement was said with *less* hostility, it definitely seemed like her old friend was fishing for something.

Holy shit… she's totally jealous.

Catra has to try her best, which isn't very good given the state she's in, to keep from jumping up and doing a celebratory dance. *Wow… wow wow wow*. She can't help the little chuckle that

escapes, but it at least gets the soldier to finally meet her eyes again.

"I'm pretty sure Perfuma knows that Scorpia and I are just friends…" she states with a lower register that seems more intimate. She takes a moment to prop her arm on the back of the couch to rest her head in her hand all the while looking at her old friend probably more tenderly than she means to. In case it needs to be said, she includes, "We've only ever been friends."

Adora swallows gently and tries not to look like she cares too much at the statement. "Oh…" she nods dumbly and turns her gaze down to her lap where her fingers are twisting together anxiously, "That's uh- that's good then."

Catra's grin broadens as she studies the girl's nervous antics and can't help but throwing in, "Besides… I've always been more into blondes."

The rebel's face flushes and she quickly jumps up, suddenly feeling too vulnerable around the former commander. When she turns back to face her a moment later she's managed to reign in her emotions at least a little better. "Are you, uh- are you okay to sleep in that?" The soldier gestures to the petite woman's red Horde outfit. Not that she's, um- hoping she'll take it off.. Just wants to make sure the girl is comfortable enough to sleep.

The former Horde captain grunts as she stands up and stretches out her limbs, "Yeah, I should be fine."

The warrior swallows gently and tries her best not to stare at the woman's curves on display. *Why, why, whyyy are her uniforms always form fitting?* "Um, I noticed you got rid of the mask," she says, hoping to distract herself.

When Catra lowers her arms back down she turns to face the taller girl, "I did. And yooou-" the feline reaches out to tap Adora's chest, right over her heart, "Got rid of your force captain's badge."

Rolling her eyes, she tosses the lithe brunette a small smile, "Got rid of that years ago." She takes a second to look down at herself and sighs wistfully as she tugs at the hem of her red jacket, "I was never able to give up the outfit though."

The former commander steps closer to her then and makes a grand show of inspecting her - eyes gazing over every inch of the taller woman. Adora feels her face flush from the attention and wonders if this is entering into dangerous territory. Before she can decide, she freezes as a long finger reaches out to trace the line of her belt. "It does suit you, doesn't it?" The feline's voice is a soft purr, causing the blonde's blush to deepen and spread to her neck when the girl hooks her finger into her belt and tugs her half a step closer.

"Umm…" the heterochromatic eyes flash up to her and she forgets how to speak for a moment. Definitely, *definitely* dangerous… Adora reaches up to pull the clawed hand away and does her best to reign in whatever instinct that's telling her to kiss the girl. "I'll uh- I'll leave you to it," she sputters out and quickly escapes to the other side of the room to get ready for bed.

Catra rolls her eyes but smiles after the girl fondly. *We'll get there someday*, she thinks as she moves back over to the couch to flop down. After doing a few more stretches to get comfortable after the long battle, she cuddles up and listens for the blonde woman to return.

It takes a few minutes - long enough that the brunette starts to doze off - but eventually she does hear the taller girl return, this time in her sleep clothes and bare feet. Adora walks over to turn off the lamp and gets settled in bed. Catra waits for her to get comfortable before calling out to her.

"Goodnight, Adora," she says softly.

She hears a rustle of movement and then a moment of silence before the girl calls back, "G'night, Catra."

The cat girl turns over and feels a smile pulling at her lips as she drifts off to sleep.

...

Adora wakes with the sun the following morning. Even though she barely slept, the few hours she *did* sleep seemed to have been enough. She stretches leisurely under her covers when she notices she's actually covered. Immediately freezing mid-stretch, she quickly inspects the blanket and she notices it's the one she left for her visitor late last night. *Surely not?* She glances over to the couch and the cat woman has already vacated her room. *Damn, she's more of a morning person than I am.* She didn't remember that about the former force captain, but then again they have been apart for several years now.

The soldier stretches again, trying to work out the kinks from yesterday's battle. She lays there for a moment longer trying to decide if she wants breakfast or more sleep when a shrill scream echoes down the hallway.

Adora doesn't miss a beat - She quickly throws off the blanket and runs full speed at her door before tearing it open. Once she steps out into the hallway she doesn't have to wait long before she sees what the commotion is about.

Queen Glimmer, still only dressed in her nightgown, comes speeding down the hallway with bare feet and tears streaming down her face.

"A rat! A *RAT!!!* " her wail bounces off the walls as she runs passed the blonde and continues down the hallway, "There's a fucking dead *rat* in my bed!!"

The warrior's heartbeat is still racing from the scare, but she's glad Glimmer doesn't witness her facepalming. She stands like that for a moment before dragging her hand down to cover her mouth while she shakes her head in horrified disbelief.

I wonder who could've done that, she thinks sarcastically before going back to her room to dress for the day.

An emergency meeting is called later that evening. Entrapta is attempting to decode all the data she collected from Horde Prime's spire and it's looking less and less likely that she'll be able to get too much from the sophisticated encryption. But there's more worrying news…

"We've just received reports from our allies in the Kingdom of Snows that the Horde appear to be preparing for a massive strike against their kingdom." Queen Glimmer starts while everyone's still piling in the room. "Up till now the Horde hasn't targeted any one specific kingdom, but so far five spires have been spotted in strategic locations around Princess Frosta's land."

"This is very daunting news seeing as how Princess Frosta's guard are mostly out in the rural areas protecting the villagers there," King Micah throws in.

"Exactly," Glimmer continues, "This is going to be another situation where we need as many fighters as possible. I know we're all still recovering from yesterday, but if we bring the same energy we brought to the Horde then, combined with Frosta's excellent defenses, we should be able to at least scare them off."

"So, that means we need everyone to get a good rest tonight, because we leave early tomorrow morning." Bow concludes, "Frosta's guards are already returning with the villagers they were defending and should arrive back to the castle by the time we get there. We should arrive rested and ready to fight as they'll need time to rest. Does that sound doable?"

There are a few confirming murmurs - none of them sound too

eager, rather exhausted, but ready to fight another day as they start to break up again.

"Whoa whoa whoa, hang on," everyone turns around, a little surprised to be hearing from a certain Horde commander for the first time in one of these meetings. Catra steps up closer to the center of the room to address the people leading the meeting, "That makes it sound like you intend *everyone* , like *all* of the princesses and guards and soldiers, to leave *here* and go *there,* for a battle that'll most likely last a few days if not a few *weeks* … Am I hearing that right?" Catra is attempting to hide her incredulousness but isn't very successful.

"Perhaps you need to clean out your ears, *commander*," the Queen bites out spitefully. Though she can't prove it, she's fairly certain she has the horde scum to thank for her rude awakening early this morning. "The Kingdom of Snows is currently surrounded by, not two, but *five* spires… We were barely able to handle the two we faced yesterday. *Of course* I mean all of us."

"Don't you think that's a little shortsighted?" The cat woman continues and then glances around the room for back-up. "How many villagers are here? How many people are we going to be leaving defenseless if we all go to assist the Kingdom of Snows? What if they *want* us all to leave to go there while they take our stronghold out from under us?"

"Why… is that something *you* would do?" The familiar tone of disappointment and disdain seeps through the room and makes Catra tense up instinctively as Shadow Weaver floats forward to join in the discussion. "Oh wait," the dark woman continues sarcastically, "You already did that at the Seagate." The feline's brow furrows as she clenches her fists. "Tell me… how many innocents did *you* sacrifice while taking Salineas out from under us?"

Catra lets out a low warning growl and takes a step towards the bitch before a hand closes firmly on her arm. Still tense, she glances over to see who it is… and is surprised to find Adora there

- *Adora* stepped up and is currently holding her back. The cat woman instantly loses her anger and prepares to watch her old friend be disappointed in her once again, only the warrior isn't looking at her. She still has a sure grip on her arm, but she's glaring ahead at Shadow Weaver who wisely decides to shut up.

"There aren't any spires here, Catra," Glimmer continues with her arms crossed, "There also aren't any drones. Bright Moon is safe for the time being, but the Kingdom of Snows requires all the help they can get."

Bow stayed mostly quiet up to then, but he's been scratching his head, mulling over the good point Catra made. *Is she really trying to help us?* After her work at the battle of Erelandia yesterday, and now this? Bow's starting to think keeping her around was a good idea. "She makes a good point, Glimmer," he says, to play the Devil's advocate.

The Queen drops her face in her hand, clearly irritated about her plans being derailed once again, but hearing Bow's opinion makes the room start to question what's best.

While Shadow Weaver was mostly speaking to remind everyone why they *shouldn't* listen to the former commander, it has the opposite effect. Perhaps they *should* listen to her… Seeing as how that's definitely something the Horde would be capable of. And why else did they let Catra into these meetings if not to tell them exactly what tricks they should be prepared for?

"*Ugh* , fine," Glimmer resigns, "If it'll make everyone feel better, we can leave a small, and I mean *small* , troop here to defend the castle on the off-chance something might happen." She finishes with a dramatic eye roll before throwing a glare at her former enemy, letting her know she doesn't appreciate the interruption. "But the rest of us are heading to the Kingdom of Snows at day break, so be ready."

The group disperses then and Catra hangs back to see who's going where. The two, and the only two princesses, that are to

stay behind are Perfuma and Scorpia, seeing as how their powers won't be as effective in the snow. There are a few other human rebels to stay at Bright Moon - Catra, of course, made the short list of those who were to stay behind and "defend" the castle, as Glimmer snarkily put it. That just left Bow and Adora…

Seeing as how the two of them are solely responsible for keeping tabs on the former Horde commander, they play rock, scroll, dagger for who would stick around to watch her. Catra rolls her eyes at the two and moves to go stand outside on the balcony while the crowds clear out. Things are starting to wind down, and the majority of the Rebellion are settling down to sleep before they travel to the snow kingdom in the morning.

Catra's not sure if she'll enjoy the peace and quiet for the next few days or pull her hair out from boredom. As she contemplates leaving more surprises for her royal sparkliness while she's away, the balcony suddenly becomes very dark and very cold…

The feline feels her muscles tense and a familiar tingle of fear travels down her spine before she turns around to face her former mentor.

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The tall, shadowy conjurer lurks in front of her, staring her down. "You would do well in the future to mind your place, *Catra*," she says her name with the same contempt she's used her entire life. "This isn't the Horde. There is no place for your *foolishness* here."

The feline schools her features and meets her criticism with false confidence, "Foolishness?" Catra flashes a grin that quickly turns

into a scowl, "That foolishness got the Horde farther than *you* ever did."

"You- insolent- *child!* " Shadow Weaver narrows her eyes and lurches forward, trapping the cat girl against the balcony's ledge. Despite her bravado, the feline shrinks away from the shadow woman all the while trying to hide her fear behind a mask of hatred. She feels her muscles tense even further, and her chest tightens as her heart races.

"You *failed* leading the Horde, just like you'll fail at whatever you try here."

Catra clamps her jaw and digs her claws into the railing behind her as she tries to control her breathing.

"You *never* would have made it as far as you did without *Adora* and I showing you the way."

The trembling commander hisses in warning and tries to focus as her vision starts to darken… her heart thudding so loudly she can feel the pulses in her neck. She *needs* to get away.

"Look at you. You're the same *helpless* little child you've always been, trying *desperately* to get our approval because that's all you're good for."

She's gone too far. Catra arches her back and prepares to strike when a flash of blonde hair and a yell throws her off track.

"HEY!"

Adora's there suddenly, pulling the tall, dark woman away as she steps between them. Catra freezes, her body still trembling as she stares blankly at Adora's back. "*YOU* don't get to talk to her!"

Somewhere in the back of her mind, she hears her old friend coming to her defense and shouting at their former mother figure, but she's fading. Her muscles are shutting down, her mind is

shutting down… She needs to get away. Before she can think twice about it, she flees - off the balcony, out of the room and down the corridor. She doesn't stop running until she's safe.

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Adora had heard the commotion outside and when she got close enough to see what was happening, she saw red. She's not sure how she got here, but she suddenly finds herself in front of Shadow Weaver, yelling in her face while blocking her from Catra.

"Adora…"

"Save it!" the warrior yells again. "You're about as welcome here as she is. As far as *I'm* concerned, you can go right back to your prison cell. *You* are not needed here." She takes a breath before going again, "Catra at least has brought something to the table. What have you done?"

Shadow Weaver starts to speak, but she cuts her off.

"That's right, *nothing!* " Adora clenches her fists, trying to restrain the urge to hit the woman, "If anything, we're worse off *because* of you!"

Her former mentor narrows her eyes and backs away. But the blonde isn't done.

"You stay away from her - *got it?"* She barks out before turning to grab the cat girl's arm… only to find she's not there. Adora looks around frantically but only finds Bow looking at her with concern in his eyes. He indicates to the open doorway, letting her know

which way she went before she takes off in search of the girl

The soldier sprints down the hallway, letting her feet guide her up and up. Every time she's been in this situation in the past, the panicked feline has always chosen somewhere high up or some dark, desolate corner in some storage area no one would ever find them. There's only one place like it in Bright Moon, so that's where she goes.

She slows to a stop when she gets to the entrance… The highest, outside garden they have. It's not a popular spot though, one, because there's no outside lighting so at night it's quite eerie, but also two, because of the waterfall directly behind it - if you stand too close you get splashed, but even just standing in the general vicinity makes it hard to have conversation seeing as it's so loud. It's not quite fully night time yet, so Adora's able to spot her in the dusky twilight. But even if she didn't see her, she could probably hear her cries even over the waterfall.

Adora walks to the side of the bench Catra is crouched behind. She knows there's no way she can alert the girl to her presence with how loud it is over here, so she moves to the side of her and tries calling her name when she's close..

"Catra?"

The feline reacts predictably and swings with her claws out. The warrior deflects the blow by grabbing onto the offending arm and side stepping the scratch. Without missing a beat, she then pulls the arm around her middle, effectively pulling the cat girl into her so she can wrap her arms around her still trembling frame. Catra fights her with receding intensity until all the fight has gone out of her. Adora just stands there and holds her until she finally accepts the embrace and cries into her neck. She also grips onto the blonde by digging her claws into the back of her jacket, but Adora stands solid… Gently stroking her hair and whispering into her ear.

"It's okay… You're okay. You're safe…"

She tries distracting her every so often by stroking over her ear instead of just her hair. Adora knows it's a sensitive spot for the girl, so sometimes brushing against it will draw away her attention from whatever's bothering her. It seems to have the desired effect as the broken woman's tears slowly dry up and her wails slowly die out.

When it's all over, Catra is weakened. All the fight has gone out of her and all that's left is the two of them. They relish in the warmth of their embrace and try to draw it out as long as they can. It's been a while since they've held each other like this, and it's hard to let go of since neither of them know when they'll get the chance to again.

Catra doesn't know what to say. She wants to thank her old friend, to apologize, to spill her heart out… But she only has the strength to lift up her head and nuzzle her softly in appreciation.

Adora smiles and runs her fingers through her hair - holding her close for as long as she can… and as long as Catra needs.

Chapter End Notes

Just to explain why I included this - I have read several theories about Catra being emotionally and verbally (maybe even psychologically) abused by Shadow Weaver as a child, and I agree it's very likely. One of the big points she complains to Adora about early in the series is in regards to her treatment when she was younger at the hands of Shadow Weaver... I think it left a lasting impression. So in this chapter when she started letting her guard down and her tormentor cornered her, it triggered a panic attack. There will be more Shadow Weaver/Catradora drama later on, too.

When You Least Expect It

Chapter Notes

> Working on Chapter 15 now so I had to remind myself what happens here -lol- it's a good chapter with a couple nice moments between the two ladies. Hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Previously

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Chapter 9

Adora let Catra sleep with her that night. After consoling her in the garden, she escorts her back to her room to rest. She doesn't care if anyone sees her leading the former Horde commander into her room late at night - there's no way she's letting her sleep alone.

She sits with her for a while on the couch, the cat girl's head resting on her lap while she plays with her hair. The brunette eventually falls asleep like that and Adora's not far behind her. When she wakes the next morning, she's alone.

By the time she actually gets around to getting up to get an update, most of the troops have already left. Glimmer has been teleporting them in large groups until they're all almost over to the snow kingdom. Bow is one of the few waiting to be taken over. Before he leaves though, he shows Adora where he's left his spare tracker pad. In case they need something, for any reason, Adora should be able to contact him and they'll be back over in no time.

The tired blonde nods along quietly. She doesn't think there will be any need to contact them. The next few days will mostly be her babysitting the few left behind with the villagers. They do use the tracker pad to keep in touch though. After the first day goes by and then the second, the troops in the Kingdom of Snows are still waiting for some kind of ambush. They've spotted troops forming near a couple of the spires, but that's it… They haven't moved. It's almost as if they're waiting for something. So far they're just laying in wait for whatever happens next.

Things in Bright Moon aren't much more exciting. She's seen Scorpia and Perfuma gardening and giggling to themselves every so often and the sight makes her smile. It also makes her wish to see the broken feline, which she knows she shouldn't wish for…

Catra disappeared that morning after her encounter with Shadow Weaver, and the warrior has barely seen her since. She understands though - the commander, out of everyone in their former unit, hated showing weakness the most. And growing up in the Horde, basically everything could be viewed as weakness. Adora was the only person she felt safe enough to cry around, but even then the brunette would be cold and distant towards the girl for days afterwards… Like she was trying to reaffirm how tough she is. The warrior had long since learned how to spot the signs and no longer took offense to it.

She expected the girl to disappear after that night. It’s just- being here alone in the quiet castle left her feeling more lonely than usual… and Catra always provided interesting, if not sometimes dangerous, company. But Adora knew better than to push the girl. If she needs space, she’ll give her space.

The rebel shakes her head, trying to stop thinking of her old friend. But it is a little scary how quick she was to jump in and defend the lithe cat woman again after all these years. Between Adora, Catra, and Shadow Weaver… There's just a lot of bad blood there caused by deep wounds that never quite healed properly.

Shadow Weaver had been a mentor to both of them but also seemed to try her hardest to tear them apart. Despite looking for their pseudo mother's approval, though, all they really had was each other… So no matter how hard she tried, Adora would never stop being Catra's friend…

She just wished she could say the same was true for the other girl.

And therein lies the problem.

Regardless of how much she's missed the feline and how much she wants them to go back to the way things used to be… Catra was all too willing to cut their ties so long as she could be in power.

Adora shakes her head and resumes her path down the abandoned hallway. As loathe as she is to admit it - that's why she needs to distance herself from her old rival/friend.

Because how does she really know things will be any different this time?

Catra keeps her eyes covered, thinking maybe that'll make everything okay again. She doesn't know how this happened, and she doesn't know how to fix it. The scared brunette has been here for hours, crying into her hands, but no one's been by to find her. No one's looking for her, no one cares. She starts to cry harder.

"Catra?"

The voice is faint and in the distance, but the cat girl's overgrown ears pick it up. She gasps and her head shoots over to face the open doorway.

"Adora!" she cries out, "I'm here!"

It takes another minute before little five-year-old Adora comes skidding into the locker room. She glances around, looking behind lockers but finds no sign of her small friend.

"Catra?" she calls again, starting to get worried.

She hears a tiny sniffle and then a quiet, "Up here."

Adora throws her head back and finally sees a tail waving to her from on top of the lockers.

Oh boy *… she thinks.*

As she watches, two large ears followed by the kitten's watery, mismatched eyes poke out to look down at her. She looks absolutely hopeless.

"I'm stuck," she cries as more tears run down.

"Okay," Adora takes a quick look around, "Okay." She sees some crates as well as a supply closet that may be useful. "Just hang on. I'll get you down, okay?" the blonde girl calls back up to Catra, who nods her head solemnly.

And then Adora gets to work.

It takes pushing with her entire weight to get the bench to move but she does it. Then she runs back over to grab a crate - her arms are too small and she can only manage one at a time, but she's got it. Then she finds a small step ladder in the supply closet that she drags out and rests against the crates on top of the bench against the wall next to the lockers. She is red-faced, tired and sore, but she's done it.

Adora takes the steps slowly up to the top which still doesn't quite reach where the feline is, but it's close. Once at the top she looks up to see Catra's forlorn eyes staring out at her, worried about what's to come next.

"Do you trust me?" the taller girl asks her friend.

Without missing a beat, the cat girl nods her head.

"I need you to come down a little bit, and then I can help you onto the ladder."

The tiny brunette peeks over the edge and suddenly looks very nervous with her ears pulled down.

"Catra," Adora says to get her attention, "I won't let you fall, okay?"

Little Catra nods and turns around, slowly easing her legs off the side of the lockers. Adora grabs ahold of her and slowly lowers her down until she's standing on the ladder.

Once they're safely back on the ground together, the taller girl holds Catra while she cries and tells her about the ugly rat that tried to eat her. Adora nods along and listens quietly, softly petting the cat girl's ears until she's purring again.

When she's feeling safe again, the two friends hold hands while they rush to dinner before they're too late.

The memory came back to her in a dream. It just so happened to

be the night she fell asleep on Adora's lap while the blonde soothed her with soft words and gentle pets. When she woke up to find her hero passed out on the couch - head fallen back while she snored - she couldn't stop the grin that came to her face, but also the guilt she thought she'd gotten rid of.

So she left.

She'd spent the last couple days hiding around the castle, avoiding her lifelong friend like the plague, while she contemplated wrongs passed. The fact of the matter is, whether or not she recalled the memory prior to the other night, it didn't matter… Her childhood was full of memories just like that. Adora saving her from rats, Adora standing up to Octavia for her, Adora trying to talk Shadow Weaver into letting her go…

She used that as an excuse for her hatred towards the girl… Even going so far as telling her that the princess made her weak. Always coming to her aid, always fighting her battles… Catra never learned to stand up for herself. It wasn't until Adora was gone that she had to face her own problems. And she used that like ammunition…

Adora abandoned her, leaving her weakened and fighting for herself, for the first time in her life, against her greatest tormentor.

But…

She always could've left, couldn't she?

The warrior had tried repeatedly to get her friend to come along with her, but Catra denied her every time. So there she was, blaming Adora for all of her problems, when the blonde never wanted to leave her behind… She chose it for herself.

Catra had left more than a few sets of scratch marks all over Bright Moon in those introspective days. Apparently her anger issues were still cause for concern. Every time she thought back to the other night, she flashed back to feelings of being helpless

while in the Horde, feelings of anger for Adora leaving her there… feelings of hatred for the princesses after stealing her best friend from her…

She just had to remind herself to breathe.

Because no matter what her former self believed about her old friend… the fact of the matter is, whenever she needed help, Adora was there. Not because she wanted to be the hero, but because she cared about the feline. And the only reason she was left behind, defenseless, is because *she chose* to stay there.

So she shifted between hating everything, to being eaten up by guilt. Needless to say, she wouldn't make very good company.

She did hang out with Scorpia every so often, and sometimes Perfuma was there as well. But always in a spot she figured she'd have little chance of running into the tall warrior. On this afternoon in particular, she and Scorpia decided to play a board game in the dining hall, well after lunch but also too early for dinner.

"Man," Scorpia laughs heartily, "I am cleaning you out."

Catra looks back down at the board, and she's right - she's not doing so good.

"What happened?" The red woman still has a grin brightening her face, "You used to always kill me at this game."

The cat girl chuckles ruefully, "Guess my hearts just not in it today."

Scorpia loses her smile and inspects her friend carefully. Something is definitely up, but she knows better than to ask. She chooses to talk about Perfuma instead, which always brings a smile to her friend's face.

"So how's that going?" Catra is still chuckling after she told her the story of falling in the pond after the flower girl touched her

claw.

“Eh-I don’t know,” the taller woman says with a blush coloring her cheeks, “I think I keep making a fool of myself.”

“I’m sure she just sees that as part of your charm,” Catra reassures her with a small grin.

“Heh, you think so?” She tries not to sound too hopeful, but she’s really drowning, sometimes literally, when it comes to the other princess.

“Yeah, I do,” Catra offers up a rare, earnest smile, “You two make sense.”

Here Scorpia blushes again, but thanks her friend for the reassurance. It’s a nice, peaceful moment between the two before she sees a blush flood the brunette’s face and she instantly folds up, looking like she wants to disappear.

Scorpia, having never seen the fearsome commander do that before, glances around the room to see what could’ve elicited such a reaction. All she sees is Adora though. The blonde had just walked in, grabbed a piece of fruit and walked right back out again, not even sparing them a glance. The red woman gives it a beat before turning to look at the smaller girl again, who’s now looking down at the board, embarrassed, still with a red tint to her cheeks.

“What was that about?” The friendly giant tries to make light of the situation by flashing her a smile, but she *is* concerned. “I thought you and Adora were getting chummy with each other again?” She used to despise the other girl - always fearing that she was a better friend to Catra than her - but having spent time with her lately, even she has to admit that Adora is pretty great. She’s made it a point not to talk about the rebel soldier with the feline though - not sure if she still harbored that undying hatred for the girl.

"We were, we-we are," Catra stammers out without looking at her, choosing instead to move her piece across the board. Scorpia only gets more concerned about that. *Since when does she ever get unsure of herself?* The former commander sighs and finishes with, "It's complicated."

"Yeah, I don't doubt that," Scorpia comments, amused, before glancing back at the open doorway. "You two always seem to be dancing around each other."

The heterochromatic eyes look up finally to study her friend before curiosity gets the best of her. "What do you mean?"

"Well, I mean-" now it's Scorpia's turn to sound unsure of herself, "You two were best friends all of your lives, right?" At the feline's nod, she continues, "But then you two went right into hating each other like you were never friends to begin with. And now that you're on the same side again… I don't know." Here she lets out an uncomfortable laugh, "It's like you don't know what you want to be to each other."

Very astute, Catra thinks as she sighs and moves her piece again, not even trying to win anymore. "Yeah, that sounds about right."

Scorpia frowns at the girl's despondent tone and can't keep it in anymore, "Catra, are you okay?"

The former commander meets her eyes, suddenly shifting to cover up her sadness, and offers up a small smile, "I'm fine. You're about to lose though."

The red woman guffaws before resetting the game after her latest victory. "I doubt that," she says good naturedly, and decides to leave the topic alone for now - though she does intend to keep a closer eye on her friend in the future.

They play a couple more rounds before Perfuma shows up and whisks Scorpia away, but not before giving Catra's shoulder a loving squeeze. *I'll never understand that girl*, she thinks with a fond grin as she watches them leave together. The feline stays

seated there for long after, lost in her own thoughts. She knows she can't hide from Adora forever, but maybe just long enough until the rest of the group comes back? That way there's plenty of distraction, and the former commander's breakdown on the balcony will be long forgotten?

Catra sighs and feels herself deflate. It's been a while since she's let her guard down to the point she feels embarrassed it even happened. But she knows Adora - her old friend would never try to make her feel uncomfortable about it and never mention it to anyone else… That's just the way she is. Always looking out for everyone. She shakes her head and stands up. If she's going to keep hiding, the dining hall isn't a very good place to do it.

She's very lost in thought as her feet move on their own accord, taking her anywhere but here… But that ends up being not very far.

"Oof," the grunt escapes her as soon as she walks out of the dining hall and collides with a solid frame.

"Ouch- Oh… sorry," the cat woman hears. She instantly feels the color flood her cheeks again because she doesn't have to look up to know who it is.

Adora releases the girl from where she grabbed her to keep her steady and takes a step back to examine her. *She looks like she wants to bolt,* the blonde thinks. Though it really should be her who bolts. The lines have been blurring between them too much lately, and she needs to keep those boundaries clear…

But why can't I move? The warrior thinks hopelessly.

Catra finally peeks her eyes open and faces her old friend head on. "Hi," she breathes out in a whoosh, finally releasing the breath she'd been holding in.

"Hi," Adora responds, her eyes strangely guarded - Catra doesn't know what to think of that. And when the rebel gives her a small, tight smile and then moves to carry on her way like nothing

happened, the cat girl can't help but watch her walk away, perplexed.

"Adora, wait-" the words are out before she can stop herself. When the taller girl stops and then only half turns to regard her hesitantly, Catra decides she needs to do something.

She trots back up to her but keeps her distance so as to not crowd the girl. When she stops in front of her, she blurts out again, "I didn't get a chance to.. thank you.. for the other night.." The cat woman clears her throat and anxiously glances around before meeting inquisitive blue eyes again.

"Thank you for standing up for me," she watches the soldier carefully. "And um, y'know, looking after me," she finishes with a breath of a laugh, hoping to relieve some of this tension.

Had she not been watching so closely, she might've missed Adora's expression opening back up just a tad to flash her a more genuine grin.

But then the warrior turns away, hoping to hide the grimace that shortly follows. Catra's vision is too sharp for her to miss it though.

"Hey," the lithe brunette reaches out, halting the girl with a gentle touch to her shoulder. When Adora turns back but can barely meet her gaze, she questions, "What's wrong?"

Her blonde counterpart sighs, and hesitantly meets her eyeline again - it's then that Catra notices the sheen of unshed tears lingering there. "It's just that, um-" Adora starts, but looks like she's having a difficult time getting the words out. "When we were trapped in that First Ones temple, like forever ago," it's Catra's turn to grimace and wonder where this is going, "You said something to me… something that uh, kinda stuck."

"Adora," the brunette starts, hoping to end this line of thinking in its tracks. That was forever ago - she said a lot of awful things

she didn't mean when she was hurting. But the sad girl holds up her hand to stop her.

“You were right,” Adora looks at her earnestly, and the tears in her eyes grow heavier, “I did enjoy being Shadow Weaver’s favorite. I didn’t realize how much that hurt you at the time, because I thought you didn’t care, but…” The sad girl closes her eyes and shakes her head, “I still should’ve done better.” Watery, blue eyes look up to hers again, “I should’ve protected you better."

Catra clamps her jaw shut hoping to keep her own tears at bay.

“She never gave you enough credit, Catra,” her old friend continues, “The way she treated you… if she would’ve taken just a second to see you the way I saw you?” Here she shakes her head again, but tells her earnestly, “You were a better leader than I ever could’ve been.”

The feline lets out a watery laugh then as a couple tears spill over, “I’m not sure about that.” She swipes the tears away quickly and then looks up at her with admiration, “You always had a way of getting everyone to follow you… Probably to the ends of Etheria and back."

The warrior grins along with her, but Catra's known the girl long enough to tell she's still bothered.

"Adora," she reaches forward to connect her hands with her own. "You've been protecting me… *all* of my life," she pauses to let that sink in, "You've been a *great* friend. Shadow Weaver, she just-" Catra wants to wretch just from saying her name. "She played mind games with both of us, y'know? She was constantly pitting us against each other. I honestly couldn't say I'd have been much better had the situation been reversed."

The soldier inspects her closely and swallows down her emotions. While so much of the fiery cat girl is the same, there are still glaringly obvious differences. *She's grown so much* , Adora thinks. *We both have* . The taller of the two tries to keep her heart in

check, but she can't help but give her old friend a small, watery smile which she returns. *Could this.. maybe be real? Is she really trying to change?*

It's a nice, intimate moment between the two… which is why Adora is confused when she watches the cat woman's ears fall as the color drains from her face.

"..Catra?"

CRASH

Their world trembles under their feet for a moment, leading Adora to instinctively grab the brunette and pull her into her chest. When the ground settles, she peeks her eyes open to see they're still standing… The only evidence that anything had happened is the dust that's falling over them after being shaken loose from the ceiling.

Adora has no idea what the hell just happened, but when her adrenaline kicks into fight mode, she finally hears it and pulls away to look at Catra's disturbed expression. It only takes a second for them to recognize the sound of Horde tanks just outside and the fact that they are very, very screwed at this moment. Catra shakes out of her shock first and pushes Adora towards the stairs.

"Go. Call for help. I'll go check on the villagers," the cat girl says while backing away before turning and sprinting in the opposite direction- just as she turns to go, there's another hit-

CRASH

This time the impact causes the lights overhead to flicker, and Adora kicks her ass into gear. She sprints towards the stairs, leaping up several at a time trying to move as fast as she can. The trackerpad that was left behind is in her room, another two levels up, so she's got to move. On her sprint up the stairs, she passes by a very panicked Perfuma and Scorpia.

"You need to get outside, now," she barks at them, "We're being attacked."

The duo both nod and start tearing down the stairs while Adora continues to climb. It feels like forever before she finally has the trackerpad in her hands and then she scrambles to turn it on.

The call rings twice before Bow picks up. The man seems to be in the middle of laughing at something when he sees the warrior's panicked expression.

"Ador-"

"You need to get back here, *now* - *all* of you," she yells to be heard over another collision, "The Horde is here. We're under attack." With that she throws the tracker on the bed and rushes over to grab her staff. Running out into the hallway, she pauses, panicked when another strike hits the castle. She wants to be outside, she wants to help, but as a common foot soldier she can't do much against whole tanks. The warrior takes a breath to calm herself… even though she can't offer help outside, there's still work that needs to be done here.

With that, she sprints back the way she came, thundering down the stairs to go assist Catra with moving the villagers.

Going down the stairs seems to fly faster than going up. On each level she ends up jumping the last several steps before turning down the next stairway. It's not until she passes the dining hall that things start to get tricky. There's a crowd of villagers panicking, running up the stairs and straight through the mountain access gate on that level, where they have a built-in shelter for just such an event. *Clever girl*, Adora smiles, thinking about the lithe brunette. *She probably found that on her first day here.*

Nevertheless, that doesn't stop her. She needs to get downstairs to help. So, as quickly as she can, she pushes through the sea of villagers, fighting against the tide, to get to where she needs to

be. It's not until she gets to the lowest levels of the castle that she really starts to see the damage. Those tanks are powerful, but they don't have much range on them. While the structure seems to be holding, the bottom two levels are full of debris and chaos. It's also on those levels that Adora finally starts to see a break in the crowd. By the time she reaches the lowest level, there are only a handful of villagers, some with a few scrapes and bruises, fleeing the scene. When she gets down to the bottom floor, she sees why.

The front doors have been completely blown off… the rest of the room is in shambles. There's so much dust and falling pieces from the ceiling that's slowly breaking apart, it takes her a second to spot Catra. She's there, in the center of the room, caked in dust like the rest of the victims, while she assists an old lady back to her feet and points her in the direction of the stairs. It looks like everyone's out… everyone's clear and heading on their way to the emergency shelter.

Everyone, that is, except for Catra.

Like the rest of the last several agonizing moments, everything seems to happen in slow motion. Adora sees it happening, but by the time she processes it, she's already too late.

The ceiling, right above the cat woman's head, starts to cave in.

"Catra!" she yells and is immediately on the move.

The feline looks up just as the first few bricks start to fall - they hit her, knock her down while others start to land on top of her. Adora slides in right as the two largest pieces start to come down. Using her staff as leverage, she pushes up and holds the two breaking slats of ceiling in place before they can crush the two girls. The blonde grits her teeth and holds the ceiling up on her shoulders as best as she can. Looking down, she can see Catra knocked out, laying just at her feet. She pleads with the girl to wake up. The sounds of a heavy battle take place outside, and

the warrior can surmise that their backup has finally arrived - Only no one's going to be looking for them here… are they?

Her foot slips and the ceiling caves in a little further. Tears start to fall from her eyes as she looks on at her wounded friend… blood dripping from her temple.

"Catra, please," she gasps out, "You gotta get up." She feels her cheeks getting wet as she cries for the girl. The ceiling is just too heavy. More and more pieces are falling around her and it's only an amount of time before her strength finally gives out…

But it can't…

Adora clamps her jaw shut - she feels the fury fill her as she furrows her brow and watches the helpless girl at her feet.

"No," she growls, and steadies her hands against the rock, "I am *not* .. losing her… *again!"*

And with that last shout, the warrior thrusts upwards with all her might - some newfound strength suddenly seeping through her veins as a bright light flashes throughout the room. Adora steadies herself against the bricks, and slowly relaxes her grip before looking up.

Her hands are there… larger than they were before, encased with golden gauntlets. That's when she notices the two pieces of ceiling that were seconds away from caving in on them are shoved back upwards, somehow stuck back in place. *What the…*

"She-Ra?!" someone gasps off to the side. Looking back over to the stairs she sees both Glimmer and Bow looking at her, dumbfounded.

She doesn't know what just happened, how this is possible, but she's definitely familiar with this feeling… Slipping right back into her 8 foot frame like she never left. But there's no time to waste.

She-Ra bends down to gingerly lift the broken cat girl up into her arms and carries her over to pass off to Bow.

“Take care of her for me, please,” she tells them and then reaches out her hand to conjure a sword out of thin air.

Her friends both watch her, astonished, with their mouths hanging open.

She smirks at them, “It’s time for me to teach Horde Prime a lesson.”

Chapter End Notes

Any thoughts? :D

The Aftermath Pt. I

Chapter Notes

> Just a heads up - this one is shorter than most. If I remember correctly, when I went to write this chapter, it ended up being very long. So, I broke it into two separate chapters. This is the first part and next chapter is the second part :) enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Previously

"She-Ra?!" someone gasps off to the side. Looking back over to the stairs she sees both Glimmer and Bow looking at her, dumbfounded.

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Chapter 10

She-Ra made quick work of the most recent battle of Bright Moon.

The princesses were struggling to keep up with all of the clones and bots teleporting in, as well as the tanks, but with a few swipes of her sword, the tanks were gone leaving them to focus on the individual enemies. It was a resounding success.

When it was all over, the princesses flooded over to She-Ra, embracing her in a hug. Adora enjoyed the attention for a second, but then all the questions started coming… Questions she didn't know how to answer, but even if she did, her mind was a bit preoccupied with the injured feline somewhere upstairs. So, as soon as she was able, she broke free from the crowd and ran back to the castle.

Bright Moon's castle was still standing. Fortunately its fortified structure built into the mountain directly behind it kept it from succumbing to the damages. The framework was still very much intact, but the bottom few levels, where they'd been housing the villagers, were completely destroyed. All the windows, rooms, and furniture were obliterated, and in some cases, the ceilings and the floors were one shake away from crumbling.

Queen Glimmer scurried to rectify the situation. Once the battle was over, she devised a plan to have the rebels escort the villagers to neighboring communities. Horde Prime seems to be targeting their kingdoms now, so they should be safe in the farming villages scattered across the kingdom. But if Horde Prime sees a giant mass of people moving from the kingdom, he may target them next; they won't take that chance. So, those who are still standing are breaking up into smaller groups, to escort the villagers all over the area.

The purple haired Queen stands in one of her torpedoed rooms where the dust is still settling and can't help but seethe at the sight. It's going to take them weeks, if not months, to repair the damages… if they can even afford to think about that in the middle of a war. Glimmer grips onto the arms folded across her chest in order to maintain the rage bubbling beneath.

"Glimmer?" a hesitant voice calls from the stairway. Bow eases into the room to stand behind her, "You shouldn't be in here; it's dangerous. The floor could collapse at any minute."

"Oh, I'm well aware," she can hear the anger slipping out into her words.

Bow can, too. "What's going on?" He asks hesitantly, not sure if he wants to hear the answer.

The Queen turns around to face him with measured steps. "I think this is Catra's 'first sign of trouble'," she says, quoting Adora, "which means she's got to go."

"Glimmer… *what?* " Bow's exasperation knows no limits, apparently, "Catra specifically *warned* us that this could happen."

"And that's awfully convenient, isn't it?" Glimmer spits out. "*Think about it*, Bow. She *knows* we won't fall for the same tricks twice. She *knows* we're going to be watching her like a hawk. What else could she do to gain our trust but to very *accurately* predict a battle *no one* saw coming so she comes out of it looking like a hero?"

"Come *on*, Glimmer," the man scrubs his face with his hand in frustration, "I think you're just reaching now." Though that would be the perfect plan, wouldn't it?

"Please, Bow," she insists, "I want you to tell me it doesn't seem a *little bit* suspicious that Catra knew *exactly* what was going to happen today."

It was exactly how she predicted it… When the battle was over, he received reports from the Kingdom of Snows that Horde Prime's army teleported out of there… If the timeline is right, it seems like they teleported out of *there*, to come directly *here* … Horde Prime set them up. Bow sighs and shakes his head. He won't lie, it is a little suspicious, but he knows where his faith lies. "Glimmer…" He

starts, probably never more disappointed in her than he is in this moment, "You've got to stop this."

The purple princess hears it in his tone and feels her heart break just a little bit more, "Bow, if you just-"

"*No* , Glimmer," he stands his ground, "I've had *enough* of this. You keep looking for all these imaginary enemies around you to blame for your mistakes, when *you* are the one pushing your friends away… Not Catra, not Shadow Weaver, not Light Hope, not me or Adora, but *you*." The saddened girl doesn't think she's ever seen her friend this mad before, but he continues. "Is it a little suspicious? Yes. But do I trust my friend's judgment? *Absolutely*. Because that's what friends *do*, Glimmer." His voice cracks and he swallows down the emotion creeping up on him but can't keep the tears from filling his eyes. "When did you stop being our friend?"

He turns and marches away, leaving Glimmer alone to her thoughts.

She shakes her head with tears streaming down her face, her heart hurting more with every beat.

I'm losing him.

Adora was still stopped a few times on her way back into the castle. Everyone was curious; everyone was excited, but in all honesty… she had no idea what to tell them. She didn't know how She-Ra came back, or why, she just.. did. One minute she believed her to be dead and the next it was like she never left. Adora couldn't really process anything, though, not until she got to the healing room.

When the warrior finally makes it there, she marches right in and starts checking the many occupied beds for the injured feline - it

doesn't take long to spot her. She's the only one who's trying desperately to get *out* of the bed while the healer tries to convince her to lay back down.

"I *told* you, I'm *fine,*" Catra is very close to hissing at the obnoxious woman before a voice interrupts her.

"I got this one."

With that one statement, the annoying excuse for a human finally leaves her alone and walks away to reveal the blonde soldier, smiling gently down at her. The feline huffs and falls back into the bed knowing this one won't be much better.

"I see you're taking it easy," Adora says with amusement in her voice. She quickly sits down on the edge of the bed, blocking the brunette in before she thinks of trying to escape again.

Heterochromatic eyes roll and glance back at the healer who just left her side, "I'm *fine.* I *told* her I'm fine, but she wouldn't listen." The rebel chuckles and moves her hand to grasp onto the cat girl's wrist delicately, drawing her attention back over to her. Catra loses some of her bluster then and settles back down.

"You have a bandage wrapped around your head to keep whatever brains you have left from falling out," Adora jokes, triggering another eye roll from the girl, "I think that's the opposite of fine."

The cat woman tries to appear annoyed but can't help her mouth twitching up into a grin to match the soldier's. "I don't think it's that bad," she tells her.

"Still," Adora insists while reaching up to tuck a stay piece of the cloth back in place, careful not to snag the girl's messy locks in the process, "Let's not tempt fate, shall we?"

Catra watches as the warrior continues to futz around with her bandage and finally reaches up to halt the process. She brings the offending hand back down to rest on the bed with her own

but doesn't let it go right away. "I think my brains are happy right where they are," she offers the worried woman another grin.

Adora chuckles and shakes her head before looking down to inspect their hands which are still entwined but hidden from view of the rest of the room. Catra takes the opportunity to study the girl before bringing up the giant, super powered elephant in the room.

"Sooo… *She* -Ra," she mentions quietly, and the soldier's eyes immediately shoot up to her own.

"How do you know about that?" Adora can't keep the surprise from her voice.

"Oh, come on," Catra chuckles, "She-Ra comes back from the dead and you think that's *not* what everyone's going to be talking about?"

It's the soldier's turn to roll her eyes, then she drops her gaze back to their hands where her fingers are itching to explore the ones she's holding. They haven't done this in a while… held hands just for the sake of holding hands. She doesn't know what to do with herself.

When it's clear the rebel doesn't intend to speak anymore on the subject, Catra shakes her hand to get her attention. "Come on. I want all the details."

Adora glances over her shoulder to see if anyone is eavesdropping before turning back to meet the mismatched eyes studying her. "There's not really much to say. She was just… there. It came out of nowhere," she shrugs and looks down at her hand again, "It was like- she never really left? Like she was there, all along, waiting to get out."

"But- how did you do it without the sword?" Catra asks curiously.

"I have no idea," The tired warrior shakes her head and looks off in space, "One minute we were about to be crushed by a falling

ceiling and the next… There she was, saving the day. I just have no idea how to do it again."

"I'm sure you'll figure it out," the cat woman tells her and then narrows her eyes suspiciously, still stuck on the first part, "And *I* was about to be crushed by a falling ceiling - what do you mean *'we'*?"

The other woman's cheeks blossom with color and she looks down again, "I may have, um- jumped in there with you at the last second. But then She-Ra showed up and kinda fixed the ceiling before we were crushed to death."

Catra raises her eyebrow at the girl as she digests that information, "Sooo… She-Ra came back just to save *me* then?" She asks, cheekily.

Adora laughs loudly and shakes her head, "I guess, maybe. I don't know." When her laughter subsides, she studies her brunette counterpart again and can't help but let the adoration shine through. She jostles the cat girl's hand, still entwined with her own and tells her softly, "What you did today was really brave."

The feline watches her intently, meeting her starry-eyed gaze with one of her own before she starts running her thumb along the side of the blonde's finger, "Right back at ya."

The soldier feels her blush burn brighter and looks down to watch Catra's fingers gently caressing her own. She feels the electricity from her touch shoot up her arm, through her shoulder, and go straight for her heart. Blue eyes drag back up to meet the girl's dilated pupils that seem to reflect her own yearning back at her. Her chest feels so full in the moment that she's struggling to breathe.

Catra isn't faring much better. Sliding the length of her fingers against the smoothness of her old friend's makes her heart flutter and sinking into those deep blue eyes makes her feel lightheaded.

Fuck, I wanna kiss her. Her heart squeezes painfully when she remembers she can't, but she doesn't think she's ever wanted anything more.

"Adora," a voice booms from the doorway.

The two girls instantly tense up and pull their hands away, like they were caught sneaking morsels from the kitchen when they were kids. When the blonde turns, she sees Bow waiting on her, and he doesn't look too happy. The light feeling of walking on air suddenly comes crashing down, and she has to return to the real world. She passes the cat woman a sheepish look and starts to get up.

"Hey," the feline halts her movements with a gentle touch on her arm. When blue eyes turn back to her, she takes a shot, "Maybe when I'm better you and I can start sparring again? We don't want you getting rusty now that She-Ra's back." Catra knows it's a flimsy excuse, but she's hoping Adora will take her up on it anyway.

The soldier's smile reaches up to her eyes and she gives her a slight nod before turning to face the music. She finds Bow still watching her at the entrance to the med bay and centers herself. *Time to get serious*, she thinks as she follows him out into the hallway.

She doesn't know what's gotten Bow so upset, but whatever it is can't be good.

The man seems tense and angry about something which is very unlike him, but Adora follows him down the corridor until he maneuvers the two of them into a room out of earshot of the others. She's not sure she's going to like this conversation.

When Bow turns back to face her, he's lost some of the intensity she saw on his face before and now just appears to be more tired than his years. Adora is still worried though - she has no idea

where this is going and wisely decides to let him lead the conversation.

"Do you trust her?" He finally asks.

"Wh-what… Who?" She has a fairly good idea *who* he means, but she tries to play dumb.

"You *know* who," Bow furrows his brows at her, "You and Catra have been getting close again recently, and I *need* you to tell me that you trust her."

"I was just checking in on her. Where is this coming from, Bow?" she asks him, confused, "I thought we already talked about this."

"We did, but a lot can happen in a week." Whatever seems to be bothering him has him riled up again, so he takes a second to breathe before starting again more calmly.

"I trust you, Adora, you *know* I do," he meets her eyes to make sure she's hearing him, "But I've *seen* you two." The soldier opens her mouth to defend herself, but he cuts her off. "You weren't disappointed when you lost our wager and had to stay behind to watch her. You *yelled* at Shadow Weaver, like, louder than I've ever heard you yell before, for upsetting her. I watched you *chase after her* when she ran out of there crying." Here he pauses, debating if he should even bring it up, but he might as well put it all out there, "And later I saw you taking her back to your room in the dead of night when everyone was asleep." Adora's face burns bright red and she suddenly finds the floor very interesting.

Bow pauses for a second to let all of that seep in before continuing. "Look Adora, you don't have to explain anything to me," he tells her steadily. "In all honesty, I'm not even sure I *can* process whatever it is going on between you two just yet, but that doesn't matter," Bow pauses until she looks up to meet his eyes again, "I need you to tell me - honestly - is it possible that Catra had something to do with the attack today?"

"*What?!* No-"

"-Adora, I just need you to think about it-"

"-I *am* thinking about it," she cuts him off emphatically, "Bow, I was with her when the attack started- I *saw* her face." Adora watches him for a moment, her expression full of concern, "She was *just* as surprised as I was."

The man sighs and nods his head, having gotten the answer he predicted, though it doesn't make the situation any better. "Okay."

After a moment of silence, the warrior can't help but ask, incredulously, "Bow, does *Glimmer* think she had something to do with this?"

The archer, dejected, walks over and slumps down in one of the chairs nearby. He's tired… he's so tired of this. "Yeah," he answers, not even trying to defend their other friend.

The blonde closes her eyes and shakes her head. *Of course, she does*, she thinks. It's going to be a long road before those two ever like each other. Adora walks over and sits next to Bow quietly - both of them slouched forward, feeling the weight of the decision they made to bring the former Horde commander into the Rebellion sitting on their shoulders. She knows the Queen has no reason to trust or like Catra, but she can't help but try to defend the cat woman to the man who's been basically carrying the emotional weight of the Best Friend Squad for way too long now.

"If this was all a part of her master plan," she starts, staring off into space, "Then why was her first instinct to go and protect the villagers? Where she got injured for caring."

"I know," Bow drops his face into his hands to rub at his brow, trying to relieve some of the stress he's been under lately. "I know, Adora. I just don't know what to do with Glimmer anymore," his crestfallen tone causes the soldier to worry for him.

Her and Glimmer seem to be on better footing these days, but Bow is still having a hard time forgiving her. Of course, it doesn't help when the purple princess makes more problems for them than she solves.

Adora is truly worried about the future of the Best Friend Squad - she watches the archer's shoulders slump even further as his sadness seems to weigh on him more than ever. She reaches out and wraps an arm around her friend and rests her head on his shoulder, hoping to lend him her strength to get through this.

Chapter End Notes

What did ya think? Do y'all like the title? :)

The Aftermath Pt. II

Chapter Notes

Part 2. This chapter is also on the shorter side, but it is necessary for the plot :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Previously

"I know, Adora. I just don't know what to do with Glimmer anymore," Bow's crestfallen tone causes the soldier to worry for him. Her and Glimmer seem to be on better footing these days, but Bow is still having a hard time forgiving her. Of course, it doesn't help when the purple princess makes more problems for them than she solves.

Adora is truly worried about the future of the Best Friend Squad - she watches the archer's shoulders slump even further as his sadness seems to weigh on him more than ever. She reaches out and wraps an arm around her friend and rests her head on his shoulder, hoping to lend him her strength to get through this.

Chapter 11

The exhausted soldier retires to her room early that night, skipping out on dinner. She didn't want to face Glimmer just yet, afraid she might snap at her, and she can't face the rest of the rebellion and their questions. It was a long, emotional day for the princess, and she doesn't think she can handle anyone else's problems right now.

While she did go back to her room early to rest, sleep eludes her. After everything that happened that day, all she can do is sit on her bed and stare off at nothing while her brain shuts down, not even trying to process everything that's happened. She keeps telling herself to get up and get dressed for bed, or, if she can't manage that, to just lay down and try to sleep, but her brain is even too fried for that.

When a timid knock rings on her door a few moments later, she feels almost shocked out of her reverie, but then it's immediately replaced by irritation. Adora has no idea who could be at her door right now, but she legitimately has no room in her head for any more news today. As she pushes herself up and trudges over to the door to tell whoever it is to politely 'fuck off', the door opens and a small brunette with a bandage pokes her head in to look at the blonde.

Adora freezes and watches Catra step in and quietly close the door behind her. "Shouldn't you be in the med bay?" The worn soldier can't stop the worry in her voice, no matter how tired she is.

The feline shakes her head while she shuffles over to stand in front of her. "No, I couldn't sleep," here she meets the tired princess with an exhausted expression of her own, "I convinced them to let me go as long as I go straight to bed."

Adora lets out a breath of a laugh - of course, she did - and steps aside to gesture behind her. "Go on then."

Catra's eyes widen for a second before she gently shakes her injured head, "What? No, Adora, I'm not- I'm not gonna kick you out of your own bed."

"You're not kicking me out," the blonde tells her with a soft smile, "It's big enough for the both of us."

The brunette swallows thickly when she processes what the girl means, "And you're… okay with that?"

Here Adora rolls her eyes and takes the cat girl's arm before leading her over to the roomy mattress. "Just don't hog the covers," she jokes and leaves the feline to go get her sleep clothes on.

Catra stands there, dumbfounded for a moment, wondering if her head wound is actually worse than she thought… but she's not gonna say no, hallucination or not. She quickly, but gently disrobes, leaving her in her usual sleeping gear before settling in the warrior's bed. The feline stretches and curls around, trying to find a comfortable position, all the while breathing in the scent of her old friend. *This is nice*, she thinks, already halfway to dreamland.

By the time the princess makes it back over to the bed, Catra is already curled up in her blankets and sleeping peacefully. She's sure in the morning, when she's more lucid, she'll question this decision. But for the time being, she'd rather have the feline close in case she needs something in the night.

Adora goes about getting settled in her bed, being careful not to disturb the other girl, and tries not to think about how much she's missed her sleeping partner before she passes out from exhaustion.

It's nearly midday before the warrior wakes up. Her eyes squint open from the sunlight pouring in her windows and wonders how she slept so heavily that the time passed like it was nothing. Rubbing her eyes to hopefully wipe away the last remnants of sleep, she then drops her arms back on the bed and stares blankly at the ceiling. There were no dreams, no nightmares… no glowing woman haunting her from space. It was just a peaceful night of sleep after battling off the Horde the day before. Adora's still contemplating it, everything that happened, when she feels the warmth next to her shift just slightly.

Wait- what? Her eyes widen and she panics for a second before she glances over and remembers the end of her night last night.

The blonde can’t help the smile tugging at her lips as she witnesses the still very heavily asleep feline curled up into a ball against her side. They must have shifted in the night to seek each other out since they’re now cuddled together right in the center of the bed. Something about waking up with the cat woman so close makes warmth blossom in her chest, feeling nostalgic about mornings passed where she woke up in a very similar fashion. It feels like home, Adora thinks and feels her muscles relax as she sinks back into the bed.

She knows rationally this should be a big red flag in her head and she acknowledges it… but for a few minutes she just wants to pretend - pretend that this is how it’s always been. She didn’t lose her, they didn’t fight, they weren’t enemies… they were always just this- a natural support for each other. Adora would give anything to go back and fix things. She feels a few tears leak out of her eyes when she thinks of how much hurt they’ve caused each other over the years. But the blonde shuts the thought down and gets up to get dressed to distract herself.

She’s shocked no one has come by to wake her yet, but after the impromptu battle they had yesterday, she imagines everyone else was as tired as she was. Once she’s up and walking around the castle, it’s pretty much confirmed when there are very few people up and about. The few that are awake are mostly sitting with themselves, the shell-shocked expressions on their faces probably mirroring her own.

Everything just happened so fast… and there’s so much to be done as a result.

Glimmer started sending villagers out at first light with their rebellion escorts - the ones who were able to walk, that is. The castle is in disarray, but there’s nothing to be done about that at the moment. So, then they had to consider the Horde… Even though they walked away from yesterday victorious, there were a few disturbing things they took away from that battle.

The biggest of which is that Horde Prime's portal capabilities aren't specifically limited to the spires. The rebellion assumed that since there were spires at the Kingdom of Snows, that they would be in danger while Bright Moon would be safe. But the truth is, Horde Prime's troops can teleport to any location on the planet that they want. There were no spires in the vicinity of the castle yesterday, and yet, as soon as the tanks moved within firing range, bots, drones and clones all started teleporting in from everywhere. It was chaos. Fortunately, the villagers under their protection were saved and pulled away from the battle with minor injuries - thanks to Catra - but that still left a lot of questions up in the air about the rest of Bright Moon.

An emergency meeting had been called that afternoon once everyone felt rested enough after their battle to contribute. Adora didn't bother getting Catra for this as she knew the girl needed to rest, so instead she went in and sat with Bow while the rest of the inner council filed into the room.

Once everyone was situated, a few of the princesses looking more haggard than the others, King Micah, along with a very exhausted looking Queen, stepped forward to begin the discussion.

"Good mornin- or I guess I should say good afternoon, everyone," King Micah himself looks like he hasn't slept in days, "There are a few things we need to discuss, a few things that need to be brought to light, and then there needs to be a very serious decision made before we leave here today."

Everyone is quiet, reading into the King's ominous tone, and they start glancing around nervously.

"First and foremost, thanks to the quick efforts of our princesses yesterday, we once again protected the castle of Bright Moon with little damage and no loss of life. And, as I'm sure most of you have heard already, She-Ra has returned to us… just in the knick of time," there's a few scattered claps, everyone glancing over to Adora, smiling, before they fall quiet again, "But while we have

succeeded this time, Horde Prime's technology and combative prowess are far greater than we could have anticipated."

King Micah takes a second to glance around all the fearful faces, "He can send his troops to any point of the planet he wants. And seeing as how he's hitting our kingdoms head on with an iron fist… We believe he means to strike the rebellion down as quickly as possible." There are a few grave nods before he continues. "And seeing as how he seems to have eyes and ears everywhere; we can bet he's figured out where the head of the rebellion usually lies."

Everyone feels the weight of his words hanging heavily over the room.

"We believe that's why he came here yesterday. To take our home from us and leave us scattered to the wind for him to pick off, one by one. And there's nothing to say he won't try again," Adora gulps and hugs herself, worried if, or really *when*, he plans to return. Leaving a moment for everyone to think of the gravity of their situation, King Micah continues, "So we need to decide… are we prepared to handle another strike to our home? … Or do we need to relocate somewhere Horde Prime will never find us?"

"This isn't just a matter of relocation either," Glimmer cuts in, her tone despairing. "Is there even somewhere large enough we can all go? Somewhere Horde Prime wouldn't think to look? And also, how will we get there without him seeing us?"

The situation seems hopeless honestly. No one has any opinions, no one knows what they should do. They could take a chance and stay here only for Horde Prime to attack them again or roll the dice with the unknown. Neither of the answers seem great.

"Are you really considering leaving Bright Moon??"

Everyone seems a little surprised and they start looking around. Adora, for one, immediately stands up when she hears the voice and moves to the center of the room to look for its owner. Once

the group parts, in walks Catra. She's removed her bandage, leaving her healing wound on display. The warrior feels saddened looking at the jagged line running up her eyebrow onto her forehead. It isn't bleeding anymore which is good, but Adora really doesn't like the color of the bruising around it.

"This isn't an open forum, *Catra*," Glimmer states, none too friendly, as she glares at the woman.

"Really?" The brunette crosses her arms and cocks her good eyebrow at the Queen, "Because I'm sure the word *'discussion'* implies that other people have a say in the matter."

The purple princess glowers at her and takes a step forward, intending to put the former Horde commander in her place when Bow appears in the circle and speaks up, "We should hear what she has to say, Glimmer."

The Queen instantly loses her anger and flashes a wounded look in the duo's direction before stepping back.

Bow faces Catra then and gives her a small, encouraging smile which the feline doesn't know what to do with.

"Alright," she begins as she walks up to the war table, "Why do you think the Horde has never been able to overtake Bright Moon before? Even yesterday we were caught completely off guard and we were able to hold our own… why?"

When no one answers, she points to the diagram of the castle, "Because of its excellent strategic location. The castle is literally built into the side of a mountain… That means our enemies can't attack us from the rear, and the front? Is mostly covered in water."

"So???" Glimmer starts.

"*Sooo*," here she meets the Queen's attitude with snarkiness of her own, "Electronics and water don't mix. The tanks could only get so close which is why they could only hit us on the bottom

few levels, and the bots would fry if they even stepped foot into the lakes around here."

The purple princess rolls her eyes, "Okay, so that helps with the bots and the tanks, but what about the clones? And the drones for that matter?"

"Thought you'd never ask," Catra smirks at her, sarcastically. "My idea, for fortifying the castle at least, is to have our resident genius here-" she pauses to gesture to Entrapta who instantly perks up, "draw us up some designs for an electric grid system - sort of an electric fence around the castle - far enough away that their tanks can't reach us, and tall enough that anything with an electric charge fries as soon as it passes *throooough*- I believe you called it a *vector* field?" The commander directs to the scientist-

-Who immediately lets out a maniacal laugh and walks towards the girl on her hair. Once she's in front of the cat woman, she looks up at her with stars in her eyes and tells her, "You remembered," in a dreamy voice while patting her on the head.

"Alright, alright," Catra swats the princess's hair away and continues, "Once we have those designs, Arrow Boy here can lead the charge on setting up the system-"

"-What?" Bow asks, dumbfounded, "Me? Wouldn't Entrapta be a better choice for that?"

"Typically, yes, but you with all your weird gadgets should be able to handle it just fine. Besides, Entrapta will have her hands full with another project," the feline answers.

"*Oooooo*," the purple haired scientist sits on her hair and looks to the former commander completely mesmerized, "Do tell."

Here the brunette pauses to face her, "Well, you tell me… are you able to restrict the limits of Horde Prime's portal capabilities?"

"HAAHHAHAHAA," Entrapta shoots up and pumps her fist in the air. "Yes!" she exclaims before moving back to grab her

trackerpad.

"Wait- you *can?"* Glimmer asks the eccentric genius incredulously.

"She helped Hordak build his portal machine from scratch way back. Needless to say, Entrapta is our foremost expert on portals," Catra says with a smug look painted on her face.

The Queen scowls at the brunette and turns her attention back to Entrapta.

"Yes, figuratively speaking," she says as she punches some buttons on her pad, "I haven't been able to decrypt his sophisticated system yet, BUT I have studied it enough that if I were to upload an encryption of my *owwwn* I could make it passable enough that he wouldn't know what hit him!"

"So, what would that do, exactly?" Adora pipes in.

"Well, I'm hoping we'll at least limit his reach for teleporting which would mean he'd have to rely on his spires to teleport his troops from now on," the feline tells her.

"So, he wouldn't be able to just teleport them anywhere anymore?" Bow asks with a surprised look on his face.

"Exactly," Catra flashes him a small grin, "And I know it's not much, but the more we restrict Horde Prime's movements, the less control he'll have on Etheria. I'm hoping if we restrict him *enough*-"

"-He'll have to come down to Etheria to face us," Adora finishes, her face alight with excitement.

Catra has to pause for a second to admire it, before she throws the blonde a soft grin and a nod. The two maybe stare at each other for a moment too long, because the room goes completely quiet and, when she looks around, everyone is staring at her with various expressions. She doesn't know what to think of it.

"So, is that… a *good* plan?" She asks hesitantly.

The room erupts with voices. The general consensus, she believes she understands from all the chaos, is the rebellion like the idea. Everyone's chattering excitedly. Some still look unsure but appear to be willing to give it a try. However, Catra's interrupted by a giant claw coming to mess up her hair.

"Hey-" she tries to protest but doesn't get far before Scorpia crushes her in a hug.

"There's my wild cat," the red-shelled woman says fondly before setting her back down to face Perfuma.

The flower girl looks at her with pride in her eyes before stepping up to embrace her as well. *These princesses really enjoy their hugs, don't they?* Catra endures it but can't stop the color filling her cheeks from all the attention.

She looks back across the room then and is happy to see the hopefulness coming back to the rebellion in full force. Everyone starts volunteering for projects or throwing out ideas of their own. They can make this work.

There are only three that aren't participating in the chaos. One, of course, is Glimmer who stands off to the side with her arms crossed, silently fuming. The second is Adora who's not able to contain the pride and adoration shining through her eyes as she watches her old friend get accepted into the rebellion with open arms.

And lastly there's Shadow Weaver - she stands in the corner of the room, observing all of their behavior at this ridiculous plan. She narrows her eyes and turns her back on the crowd as she slides out the way she came.

Something would need to be done about this.

Chapter End Notes

I promise next chapter will be longer and have some good Catradora moments :)

What was that?!

Chapter Notes

> Bum bum bummm - So two important notes. I'm posting this one early because I've hit a bit of a snag in my writing. I'm working on the last 6 chapters now and they're all sort of connected, so I think a rewatch is in order for me to get back into the swing of things.
>
> Which brings me to the second note - starting with this chapter, the story starts to lead naturally to its conclusion. If you recall, in the beginning, I did say this is an alternate ending, but just the journey is different - the ending will be very similar to the way the tv series ended but with a few changes; I'll be adding some scenes and taking out others to fit along with the story I've started here. So yeah, starting with this chapter, you will start to see some scenes that come from season 5 of the show... just from a different perspective maybe :) Hope you like it!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Previously

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Chapter 12

Over the course of the next week, the castle is a flutter of activity.

Entrapta was able to draw up plans for the electric fence in one night, leaving Bow and his helpers to start gathering the materials they needed the very next morning. More than half the rebels were assisting the archer with getting the working parts in place, so they made quick work of it.

In the meantime, the rest of the rebels were busy protecting towns as well as the castle in case Horde Prime decided to attack again while they were still vulnerable. As it stands though, they've been seeing less and less of Horde Prime's bots after having destroyed most of them defending Bright Moon. He most likely has his hands full rebuilding more.

On this particular sunny afternoon, Adora finds herself patrolling the grounds of Bright Moon, finally getting a break from being a part of the rescue squad. The other princesses sat with her after their last war council meeting and coached her, trying to get She-Ra to reappear. With a little practice, she was able to conjure She-Ra's sword (along with She-Ra) once again, and she's been fighting ever since. Her handling most of the rescue missions gave the other princesses a much-needed rest, and now they're all ready to take on their next challenge. Every day Adora feels

stronger and more ready than ever to take down the Horde… Though having a little break is nice, too.

When the warrior has been around the castle, she's pushed her feline companion to rest which she says she'll do, but she doubts it ever happens. Still, her head wound is looking better and better every day. And if resting throughout the day isn't helping her, maybe her sleeping in most mornings is contributing to her recovery.

Every night since the battle, Catra has come through her bedroom door instead of the window, which is progress. And every night she stands awkwardly by the couch until the princess rolls her eyes and tells her to get in the bed - which always brings out the biggest smile from the cat girl.

They don't talk about it. They never do… just like they never did in the Horde. The two were always inseparable when they were kids, and it didn't get much better as they grew. Always sleeping together, sharing food… even in training they both stood close by, sometimes even touching in some way. Though they're both tough, battle worn soldiers now, nothing made them happier than sharing a bed again, of all things. They didn't cuddle, but every night while they dreamed, they'd always drift closer to each other to relish in the other's warmth and familiarity.

As much as she loved it and didn't want it to go away, Adora knew it was a problem and a big one.

She just convinced herself if she didn't think about it, then it wasn't a problem anymore. That way she could enjoy her old friend's closeness once again without worrying about what her new friends - who still don't entirely trust her, just as *she* shouldn't - will think about it.

Things were still precarious for the best friend squad. There's been some definite tension between Bow and Glimmer whenever they're all in the same room together. Adora never confronted her about blaming Catra for the attack, seeing as how Bow ripping

into her must've been enough to shut that line of thinking down. But with Bow slowly slipping away, him being the one holding them together all this time, Adora and Glimmer are now awkward around each other, too.

She knows they need to fix things, and she has no doubt that once this war is over that will be at the forefront of all their minds… But until then, they would just have to work together and somehow not do any further harm to each other.

That seemed unlikely.

Unfortunately they all had their hands full and didn't have the time to sit and talk through their problems like they should.

"Adora!" Someone calling her name brings her back to the moment to see a group dispersing up the corridor. She's actually confused to see so many people, plus Swift Wind, standing around seeing as how they all usually have jobs to do.

"What's going on?" she asks once she makes it to the group.

Netossa skips past the greeting and gets right to business, "We just had a distress call come through from Elberon. Apparently, they've spotted some Horde troops heading their way."

"Oh yeah, I am *definitely* there," Swift Wind prances up. "Elberon throws the *best* victory parties." After seeing the two women giving him chastising looks, he ducks his head and tries to recover, "But also, yeah, we should uhh- go save some farmers first."

"So whaddya say?" Netossa tosses her a grin, "Feel like kicking some Horde butt?"

Looking around she sees they already have a decent group assembled - along with Netossa and Swift Wind, it looks like Spinnerella, King Micah, and Frosta are going as well. They probably don't *need* her, but also, they're starting to finish up working on the electric grid, so more and more people are around

to defend the castle if need be. The blonde supposes it couldn't hurt when her eye catches movement down the hall.

"Yeah, that sounds good- I'll be right back!" she calls as she trots down the hallway, chasing after a certain former Horde commander.

She rounds the corner and heads into the garden where she finds Catra delivering some soil to Perfuma. The flower princess thanks her with a hug which the feline quickly escapes from and turns to leave again only to stop when she finds Adora watching her with a teasing grin.

Catra rolls her eyes at the warrior and continues on her wait out. "Not a word," the lithe woman grumbles as she passes her.

Adora laughs and turns to follow, "I wasn't going to say anything." Reaching out to touch the woman on the shoulder, she gets her to stop and face her, "I was, however, going to ask how you feel about easing back into battle?"

She crosses her arms and looks at the taller girl, intrigued, "I'm listening."

"Well, your wound is mostly healed now, no reason to continue to lay around the castle," she tosses the brunette a grin. "We just got word that one of our farming villages is being targeted by a troop of Horde bots - It should be an easy win with everyone we're taking. Plus," remembering what Swift Wind brought up, "they *do* throw awesome parties… Interested?"

Catra mulls it over for a second, but Adora can already tell by the girl's expression she's ready to stretch her legs a bit, "Sounds fun. Now get me out of here before flower girl asks to braid my hair again." The princess laughs and the two walk over to join the rest of the group.

It's not long before the rebels find themselves wandering into, what looks like, an abandoned Elberon. Swift Wind dances up first, expecting a warm welcome only to find the street deserted.

“Where are they?” Netossa asks.

“I have no idea,” King Micah replies, suspiciously.

As they walk through town, suddenly they see the villagers marching, single file out of their homes and the great hall - what’s even more eerie is the fact that no one is talking. The rebels stand there and watch as the leader of Elberon approaches.

Catra, never having actually mingled with the villagers before leans over to whisper to Adora, ”Umm… this is weird, right?”

The blonde woman watches on with furrowed brows and shrugs her shoulders.

“Welcome Rebels,” the leader says with a cheshire grin.

“Um, hello,” King Micah looks around unsure, “We’re here to fight off the Horde.”

“The Horde?” the robotic woman responds, “My, no one has seen the Horde here since you liberated us. I’m sorry if we made you worry. You should stay… we will have a celebration in your honor.”

The more the monotone lady talks, the more Catra is creeped out.

“Oh yeah, party time,” Swift Wind prances up.

“We really should go…” King Micah sounds unsure of himself again, “There could be others that need our help.”

“I mean, it wouldn’t hurt if we just stayed for a little bit, right?” Netossa asks. “We could all use a break.”

“Yes!” the magical horse agrees.

King Micah isn’t sure he likes this plan but reluctantly agrees. The villagers come to shower them with flowers and gifts, others escorting the rebels into the main hall for the party. Adora stands off to the side, still curious about how odd the farmers are

behaving, but chuckles once she sees Swift Wind gobbling down apples. When she glances over to say something to her companion, she finds that she's not there -

Catra had vacated the premises, probably wisely considering how off this party is, so Adora decides to follow.

She finds the cat woman a little ways off from their main hall, leaning on a fence and looking out onto their fields far away from the rest of the crowd. The warrior sidles up beside her and rests her arms on the fence, taking a stance similar to her brunette comrade. She doesn't know what's out there that the feline finds so fascinating, but she tries to make a game out of it to see if she can guess what it is.

It's a short, peaceful moment between the two- whatever they are to each other now- before Adora decides to break the silence.

"You don't like parties?" the blonde asks softly as to not disturb the atmosphere.

"I don't mind parties," Catra starts off before glancing behind the soldier to look at… whatever it is that's happening back there. "But I'm starting to think the rebellion's idea of parties is a little skewed."

Adora chuckles at that, knowing exactly what she's talking about, "They're usually not like that." She says by way of explanation, "They were a lot more fun the last time we were here. I think the invasion just has everyone on edge."

The feline takes one more look at the robotic people trying to engage the other rebels in conversation before shuddering and turning back to face the fields, "If you say so."

They sit in silence again before the cat woman changes the topic, "It's not that bad, y'know?"

The soldier turns to glance at her, both eyebrows scaling up in mock surprise. “The party?” she jokes.

“No, not the party,” Catra says around a laugh, nudging the girl with her shoulder. “I meant *this* … Being the good guys, or whatever.” The cat woman feels a little embarrassed towards the end as her face heats up. She can see her companion smiling at her from the corner of her eye.

Adora appreciates her profile for a moment, still smiling softly, before nudging her back, “I knew you’d fit right in.”

The brunette lets out an incredulous chuckle, “Hardly, though the princesses aren’t as bad as I thought they’d be. They’re definitely too teary and huggy for my tastes, but they’re not the worst.”

“Oh whatever,” Adora calls bullshit, “I’ve seen you with them - you love your new friends.”

Catra rolls her eyes but goes quiet, still staring out at the fields. The soldier joins her, just enjoying the moment of no battles, no arguing friends, no stress, just this…

“You were always good at that, you know,” the cat girl starts softly causing Adora to look over at her, “Making friends. That’s not something I’ve ever mastered, though I also have little reason to want to.”

The warrior rolls her eyes but continues to look at the girl’s profile, “That’s ridiculous. You’ve made friends - you made a lot of them since I left the Horde.”

“We weren’t always friends,” the former commander chuckles ruefully, “I… pushed them away most of the time.”

Adora shakes her head, “I’ve seen how Scorpia and Entrapta are with you. Maybe you used to push them away, but you’re here now,” She watches as the girl tucks her chin in to look at the ground. The blonde adds in for good measure: “You can be charming when you want to be.”

Catra perks up at that, suddenly turning her face to finally meet Adora's eyes, reading her closely while she smirks, "Charming, huh?"

The warrior laughs, "Of course you'd focus on that." But she doesn't move away, and it becomes abundantly clear to her how close they are.

The cat girl studies Adora's face when given the rare opportunity to stand so close to her. Every detail, every curve, every angle… Perfection. She can't help but to fall into those endlessly blue eyes, like trying to see through to the bottom of the ocean. From her eyes to her nose- Catra's gaze finally lands on the girl's lips, and she lets out a small, defeated sigh. The former commander doesn't know when, if ever, she'll be able to taste those lips again, so she turns her head away to resist the temptation.

The blonde's face turned red during the close inspection, and she felt her heart rate speed up when the brunette looked at her lips… But she didn't try anything, much to Adora's disappointment, even though she knows she shouldn't be thinking about that. She turns her face back to the fields, too, hoping to distract herself.

Catra had been a lot more brazen with her than usual lately, ever since her slip up in the Whispering Woods that day. And while she doesn't know what to make of it, it definitely has a physical effect on her. Racing heart, sweaty palms, sometimes combined with a stirring feeling down in her core she can't quite place. She can't be thinking like that, though- she gently scolds herself. The two girls are just starting to trust each other again; she can't let things get out of control… can't leave her heart vulnerable again.

After Adora spends a minute reprimanding herself, Catra turns her head to inspect her again. The feline hears the music swell from the main dining hall where it looks like everyone is heading. Without thinking too much about it, her mouth carries on without her, "You know… we never got to finish our dance."

"W-what?" The soldier's head shoots up and she looks at the brunette, speechless.

Catra chuckles at the girl's wide-eyed expression, "Come on, I don't bite." She removes herself from the fence and straightens up, holding her hand out to the taller girl.

Adora continues to look at her like she's grown a second head, but when the feline continues to watch her expectantly, the warrior finally relents and takes her hand. Catra tosses her a grin and then turns to pull her to the side of the town hall under an awning covered with stringed lights. She didn't want to go inside with the rest of the party, enjoying the rare moment alone with the popular princess. When they're hidden away from the view of the others, she turns around and once again admires the comically unsure look on the soldier's face.

"Relax," Catra tells her with a laugh. "It's just a dance," she uses the opportunity to pull the girl's arm around her. When Adora's hand lands unsurely on the small of her back, she then drapes her arm over the rebel's shoulder and uses her free hand to grasp the girl's other hand in her own. Once they're in position, the brunette starts to sway in place, pulling the taller girl into the motion even though she looks more and more unsure of herself by the second.

Adora immediately drops her head and starts watching the petite woman's steps, trying to emulate them so she gets the movement right. Catra watches her stumbling around with an amused smile, "You always were so awkward with learning a new skill."

The blonde's head shoots up at that and tries to excuse herself, "I'm trying here!" She laughs to disguise her embarrassment and tries to continue the dance without looking at her feet too much, "And I know how to dance, I just never learned the steps to *this* dance."

"There are no steps, dummy," the cat woman tells her

affectionately, not able to contain the adoration pouring from her eyes. “It’s just this - swaying to the music.”

Adora nods and offers a small smile of understanding… but continues to take small, discreet glances down at her feet every so often, much to the feline’s ceaseless amusement. She can’t help but tease her again, “So awkward - every time. You were the slowest *climber,* the clumsiest *runner*…”

“Hey,” the princess tries to cut her off, but can’t stop the smile taking over her face.

“The messiest *eater,*” she concludes.

“Okay- *well*… that one hasn’t really changed,” she admits with a chuckle while her cheeks burn, “What is this, ‘Shit on Adora’ day?”

“*Always* such an awkward learner,” Catra continues with an adoring smile, “But you never gave up, did you?”

Adora ducks her head suddenly, not to check her feet, but to hide her pleased smile and the blush on her cheeks.

“With everything, even people, you never gave up,” the feline tells her seriously and waits until the blonde feels brave enough to meet her eyes again before saying quietly, “Not even on me.”

The warrior’s heart feels very full at the moment, and she wants to say something, but words fail her. It doesn’t help that Catra takes the opportunity to drop her hand and then slide her other arm over her shoulder as well, bringing them that much closer. Adora takes a steadying breath while her now free hand finds its way to her back with the other. Her entire field of vision is mostly taken up by the cat girl’s face now, and she apparently has to keep reminding herself to breathe. *This is dangerous… should I stop this?*

But as much as her mind is flashing warning signs, the warrior can’t take her eyes away.

"I knew you weren't evil," Adora finally jokes with a forced chuckle to break the tension.

Catra tilts her head back to laugh and the warrior can finally breathe for a second. "Glad to hear it," the former commander returns, still chuckling and shaking her head. "So awkward, but always great with people," she concludes her assessment.

They sway quietly for a moment - Adora looking pensive while the brunette watches her. This whole line of conversation brings her back to earlier when the cat woman complimented her friend making skills. "You- never really liked me making friends before though," the rebel finally says, recalling several instances where Catra ended up attacking anyone who tried to get close to Adora. It never stopped her from making new friends, she just always had to reel Catra in before things got too nasty.

"I… guess I just wanted you all to myself," the cat girl jokes, not really sure how to excuse her past behavior.

"You *had* me all to yourself," Adora blurts out and immediately grimaces.

They slow to a stop while Catra regards her taller friend. When the embarrassed girl finally looks back at her, the brunette gives her a questioning tilt of the head to which she responds, "It's just- I mean, yeah, I liked meeting new people and making new friends, but…" Her cheeks flush red again before she concludes, "I always came back to you… didn't I?" She tries desperately to look anywhere but at the feline's face as their dance resumes, but it's not so easy. "Even the one time I didn't, I still tried to get you to come with me."

When the blonde finally feels brave enough to look back at the girl, she finds Catra smiling at her softly with tears forming at the corners of her eyes. Predictably once she's caught, the fearsome commander quickly clears her throat and shakes her head, trying to get control of her emotions again, but instead of pulling away… she pulls closer. Using her leverage on the taller girl's shoulders,

she holds the princess in place while she steps into her, their bodies pressing together.

Instantly those warning signals from before come back in full force as Adora stands there and gets lost in those heterochromatic eyes regarding her so tenderly. She gulps, *Very… very dangerous.* But she's once again distracted when she feels one of her old friend's arms releasing her and pulling back - she then uses her hand to slide over the rebel's shoulder and down to her chest before grasping at her collar and gently pulling her forward until their foreheads connect.

"Thank you," the cat woman tells her - her voice still raspy with emotion. She pauses while her eyes shift back and forth to look between the deep blue orbs staring into her soul. "Thank you for not giving up on me," she finishes softly.

Adora feels tears pricking at the corners of her eyes now. Her heart is fluttering, and she feels like her oxygen is cutting off when her mouth carries on without her, "Thank you for coming back to me."

She watches as tears fill the cat woman's eyes again before they drop down. Adora's not a hundred percent sure, but she's fairly certain the brunette is looking at her lips. *Uh oh… bad, bad, very bad*. Her muscles start to tense, and she feels torn between celebrating and crying when Catra closes her eyes and starts to erase the distance between them.

This is it - it's happening. The feline can feel the girl's breath against her lips and can't help but reach out to taste…

Only for her lips to press against the girl's cheek.

Adora, starting to panic, turned her head at the last second, letting the cat woman press a kiss to her cheek instead of her lips… She's not sure who's more disappointed - her or the former Horde commander.

Catra pulls away slowly, back to a respectable distance - she knows better than to try and push again. When Adora finally meets her gaze, she looks timid, like a caged animal. The brunette smiles gently at her to ease her fears.

"Can't blame a girl for trying, right?" she jokes with Adora who lets out a breath of a laugh while the tension visibly starts to leave her. *We'll get there… someday*, the brunette tells herself. She smiles tenderly at her old friend and can't help but fall for her even more. *When she's ready*.

Adora is still feeling the tension leaving her body while simultaneously feeling elated that the cat woman seems to be understanding. She really wants to hit herself for pulling away, but at the same time she's still terrified at the thought…

Her heart still hadn't fully healed from the first time her friend had hurt her.

While her head and her heart disagree and she tries to rationalize her thoughts with her feelings, Adora is vaguely aware of the sound of music suddenly becoming muffled as someone closes the doors to the main hall. It's almost jarring, because as soon as the doors close, all the sounds of conversation and enjoyment are shut off as well, leaving just the two women… left alone outside. They both stop and turn their heads to look towards the front of the hall at the sudden, eerie quiet. *That's odd…*

After a moment of silence, Adora pulls away from Catra while throwing her a confused glance. They both start walking towards the front of the hall, looking for people on the way.

"What's going on?" the petite girl asks suspiciously, "Where the hell is everyone?"

"I don't know," Adora replies as she reaches the closed doors to the building - she's sure they all have to be inside, but there's hardly any sound coming from within. The warrior reaches out to grasp the door handle to pull it open… only it's stuck.

“Wait, it’s locked?” The former commander is feeling more and more on edge with every turn.

The taller girl turns her head to pass her a worried glance, “Yeah…” that’s when they hear it… The unmistakable sounds of a battle going on inside.

“Adora,” Catra starts to panic-

The rebel pounds on the door and tries jerking it open again, before stepping back to get into position. “Stand back,” she tells the brunette and reaches for her sword.

“For the honor of Grayskull!” She shouts and feels the power of She-Ra burst through her veins.

Once the transformation is complete, she doesn’t hesitate to swing her sword at the doors, causing them to break and fall off their hinges. When they step inside, they’re not entirely sure what they’re looking at…

There’s an ice dome in the center of the room and all of the villagers, groaning like zombies, are tearing away at the structure - most likely trying to get at the rebels hidden inside.

“What the fuck?!”

Adora honestly doesn’t know how to answer the question, so she raises her sword and lets out a stream of light that knocks all the villagers out at once. “We have to hurry!” The duo has no idea what has gotten into the peaceful farmers, but they immediately tear into the dome and start helping the other rebels out.

“No time to explain,” Netossa grunts, “Let’s get the hell outta here!”

The rebel troops flee the scene, leaving Elberon in the dust as they rush back to the castle. Once they feel they’re a safe enough distance away, they finally slow to a brisk walk.

“What the hell was that?” Catra asks immediately.

The ones that got trapped inside all look at each other worriedly. “We have no idea,” Spinnerella starts off.

“One minute they were fine, and the next they turned into zombies,” Frosta continues.

King Micah sighs and glances over to the two women who saved them, “We need to get back and warn the others. Whatever happened back there was definitely the work of Horde Prime.”

Catra feels her eyes widen as she slows to a stop along with Adora - the rest continue barreling ahead. The duo looks at each other worriedly before sprinting to catch up.

If Horde Prime is responsible for taking over their once peaceful farmers and turning them into *this?*…They have big problems.

Chapter End Notes

What do you think?

It was nice while it lasted

Chapter Notes

Whoof. Okay, two notes before I post this:

One - I'm thinking I might've jumped the gun when guessing how many more chapters are left. I definitely underestimated how much I wanted to add to the ending, and the ending consists of the last 3 to 4 chapters on it's own. Since I haven't even started on it yet - and I'm currently working on Chapter 21 - I'm guessing it's going to be more like 24 or 25 chapters in total? But I won't update the number until I've actually completed it and know for certain.

And two - This chapter doesn't have much Catradora in it, so I do apologize for that, but I am building up to some great Catradora moments coming soon!

Hope you enjoy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Previously

"What the hell was that?" Catra asks immediately.

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other worriedly before sprinting to catch up.

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Chapter 13

The troop of rebels get back to Bright Moon as quickly as they can. They don't even bother with calling a war council meeting - they barge straight into the dining hall, where everyone's just sitting down to dinner, to announce this latest strategy Horde Prime has come up with.

"So wait, they weren't… farmers anymore?" Scorpia asks.

"I think you're missing the point," King Micah sighs before trying again, "The villagers of Elberon were still there, they just- weren't themselves."

"Yeah, their eyes turned green and they tried to eat us," Swift Wind follows, "Definitely not the people we knew, let me just say."

Frosta rolls her eyes, "They didn't try to *eat* us, but they were definitely trying to capture us."

"And you think they were being controlled by Horde Prime?" Glimmer is just as confused as the rest of the rebellion.

"It's just the things that they were saying," Netossa shakes her head and casts a glance at her concerned wife before continuing, "It didn't sound like the villagers of Elberon."

“And what were they saying?” Bow is as concerned as the rest of them. *What could this possibly mean?*

King Micah takes the question, “They were saying things like, ‘Join us in the Light of Horde Prime’ and ‘I only wish to bring peace to your world’. It’s very confusing - at times it seemed as if Horde Prime was talking directly to us *through* them.”

“Like puppets?” Catra asks for clarification. The rest of the troubled group nod.

“Weren’t you there?” Glimmer asks, squinting at the former commander suspiciously.

“Um..” she glances over to Adora who suddenly finds the floor very fascinating, “We were locked out of the hall. We didn’t see the villagers turn evil, we… came in after the fact.”

More than a few of them find that news interesting and glance back and forth between the princess and the former Horde commander curiously, but they have bigger problems to deal with.

“The important thing to note here is- We don’t know who we can trust anymore,” King Micah lets that linger before continuing, “We have no idea how Horde Prime was able to take control of the villagers at Elberon, so at the moment we don’t know how to stop it or… how to detect it.”

“Yeah, they were perfectly normal at first,” Swift Wind pauses to think for a second, “Well, normal’s the wrong word, but they weren’t attacking us!”

“Yes, they did look perfectly normal initially, but it wasn’t until we tried to leave that their eyes turned green and they started to attack,” King Micah agrees, “As a matter of fact, their eyes reminded me of the clones.”

“That’s what I was thinking,” Netossa adds with a visible shiver.

"Okay," Queen Glimmer nods and takes over, "That means for the time being we have to be careful about where we go. I don't think we can answer random calls for help anymore unless the danger has been verified by our scouts." No one likes to hear the news, but they can't help Etheria if they're taken over by the Horde as well. "Also Bow?" the archer looks to her warily, and she loses some of her air of authority, "How close are we to finishing the electric grid?"

"It should be ready to go up in a couple of days," he tells her.

"Good… we need to enact these plans as soon as possible before Horde Prime takes over the rest of Etheria. Princesses-" she calls out and waits to get their attention, "You should reach out to your respective kingdoms and alert them of the news. Tell them if the situation seems off, they need to run and protect themselves. Adora, maybe you can reach out to Huntara in the Crimson Waste? And any of our other allies must be warned about the dangers." The princesses all nod in agreement. "For the rest of us, we'll continue to do what we can as safely as we can… We need to get those defenses up, and Entrapta-" here the purple haired scientist looks up and awaits instructions, "We'll need you to start working double time on that virus. Everyone, please - finish your meals and then get back to work."

It's a tense realization that things could turn hairy at a moment's notice. Only earlier that day were the rebels starting to feel safe in their home again after the attack, but now they're right back to where they started. Dinner is finished in mostly silence and then they carry on from there.

Warnings go out all across Etheria - everyone's using the trackerpads to contact their homes as well as their other allied camps. After that, it's a lot of restless movements. The news coming from Elberon puts everyone on high alert, and they immediately get to work - or try to find something to keep them busy - so they feel like something is being done.

Glimmer is just finishing up a conversation with her Aunt when she spots Bow heading back outside, arms full of parts. The Queen excuses herself and then runs to catch up, "Bow!"

The archer slows and half turns, meeting Glimmer's eyes with a guarded expression that makes the shorter princess feel like they're strangers. She immediately feels rebuffed and grasps at straws to engage her old friend. "How's it going?" she almost grimaces at her own stupidity and follows it up quickly, "Do you have everything you need?"

"Yeah, I think we're good for now," he states and immediately turns to continue on his way.

"W-wait, wait," Glimmer hops a step and cuts him off, hoping to see a flash or some kind of semblance of care from her old friend. "Do you think this system is really going to work?" she asks, still grasping at straws.

"Entrapta's design is solid - it should work just fine," Bow looks as if he's going to turn to leave again, but pauses, "Was there anything else?"

The way her oldest friend regards her is painful - it feels like a stab in the heart every time. Her and Adora were able to find some kind of common ground again; why couldn't she do the same with Bow?

"Y-yeah," she can't help the crestfallen expression that comes over her, but then remembers the original reason she stopped the man in the first place, "We're um- having some trouble contacting a couple of our allied camps, Devlan and Colonia. We think they just have their hands full, but um… do you think you could try again later? They love you over there, I'm sure they'll answer if they see it's you." She gives a half-hearted laugh, hoping to at least get a smile from the archer.

Bow only looks concerned though. He takes a second to set down the parts he's carrying on a nearby table before turning back to

the Queen. “They’re not answering?” his brow is creased, and he asks the next important question, “Are you sure the signal is working?”

“Yeah-no, everything is working,” she assures him and tries to keep her tone light despite the implications.

The archer only looks more worried though. “Glimmer, it’s not possible that… I mean, those camps are a far reach from Elberon, there’s no way that-”

“We don’t know anything for certain yet,” the shorter friend tells him quickly and quietly while glancing around the hallway. “So for the time being,” the purple haired princess gives him a significant look, “We should just keep this between ourselves, okay?… To avoid a panic.”

Bow nods and tries to keep his hopes up. “Alright,” he sighs as he turns around to collect his stuff, before glancing back at the Queen. “I’ll let you know if I hear anything,” and with that he turns to leave, not sparing another glance back as Glimmer watches him go. When he’s out of sight, her shoulders drop and she returns to her duty, but she can’t get the distance she feels with her oldest friend out of her head.

The rest of the rebellion is still running around, trying to make themselves useful. The hours pass on quickly and before they know it, the night has fallen over them. Some of the rebels are holding lights for those who are still working outside, while the rest try to find jobs to do inside the castle. Adora had just been shooed away from Entrapta’s lab so she could concentrate, so the warrior decides to regroup with the rebels outside when she runs into Bow coming in from the other direction.

“Hey,” she trots up to him, sounding breathless when really it’s just nerves, “What can I do to help?”

He eyes her for a second before putting his trackerpad away. The blonde isn’t sure if it’s worry or exhaustion she reads on her

friend's face.

"Are you still being careful?" he asks her bluntly. Adora grimaces slightly - she knew what he was referring to; she was just hoping everyone had forgotten about it already. She wants to find an excuse to give him, but his face and his voice are more concerned than anything.

"Yeah," the soldier swallows thickly and tries to sound confident, "You don't need to worry about me."

Bow keeps inspecting her closely, letting the not-quite-a-lie hang heavily in the air between them.

"I promise, Bow," she tells him resolutely with a hardened expression - determined to make this true. "I'm being careful. She hasn't done or said anything that seems suspicious. I- I think she may actually be trying to be a better person."

"Because you and her were *alone* together the entire time at Elberon?" he asks with a raised eyebrow, looking at her accusingly. When the warrior's face turns red, he sighs and rolls his eyes in amusement. "When this war is over, you're going to tell me *everything*," Bow says with a half hearted grin.

He really is very interested to hear the whole story, because he just can't wrap his mind around it, at *all.* The sweet woman he's come to call one of his closest, most trusted friends and *Catra?* The woman who *literally* pushed him off a cliff that one time? He just doesn't get it - how can these two polar opposites have that strong of a connection?

Unfortunately his smile doesn't last very long as the news that's been haunting him from before comes back to the forefront of his mind.

"Bow?" Adora takes a step forward, suddenly concerned when she sees the archer's face fall.

Her friend looks around the hallway - seeing that it's mostly empty, he leads her to one of the alcoves so they're hidden from view. His expression is very grave when he looks back at her, "You know when we were reaching out to our allies earlier?" at Adora's nod, he continues, "There were at least two camps we couldn't get a hold of. We thought they must've just been busy, but I've tried them two more times since, and nothing…"

"Do you think that…" the blonde lets her sentence trail off, too afraid to even think it.

"Glimmer asked me to keep it quiet," though he's sharing the news with her, the soldier can see that he's clearly stressed and needs to get it off his chest, "And I'm going to keep trying, but… Adora, I'm worried."

Adora gulps. Suddenly the seriousness of the situation comes back to hit her ten fold.

"I am, too."

It's well into the early hours of the morning and Adora is still pacing - going from one end of the castle to the other - desperately trying to find something she can do. Anything that'll keep her mind off the news her friend passed on to her earlier. It really sucked being the first one to know sometimes.

As time goes on, Adora is seeing less and less people around. Most of them wisely decide to go to bed to get some rest, but the warrior is still too antsy. Though her feet and eyelids are getting heavier, she can't even begin to think of sleep.

Unfortunately walking on fumes does little to improve her peripheral vision, and so she doesn't see the attack happening until she's tackled on the ground.

The blonde shakes her head and blinks her eyes to catch her bearings when she looks up to see a wild feline leaned over her while straddling her stomach.

“What are you doing?” Catra asks the dazed warrior laying under her. Her tone isn’t jovial however - more accusatory - as she narrows her eyes at the girl.

Adora lifts her head to confirm she is in fact pinned before dropping it back to the floor in exhaustion. She’s really going to have to get used to the cat girl greeting her in this way again, isn’t she? “I don’t even know any more,” the worn soldier tells her honestly. Between whatever’s going on between the two frenemies, between Glimmer and Bow, and between the Horde and Rebellion, she’s completely at a loss.

The brunette’s expression softens and she decides to take it easy on the girl. She gracefully gets back on her feet and then pulls the princess up with her. “C’mon,” she says, leading her away, “Let’s get you to bed.”

Adora plants herself and refuses to be pulled a step farther, “I can’t, Catra.” She brings her weary eyes up to her friend’s worried expression. “I can’t sleep,” she looks away, defeated.

The feline steps back up to her, “You haven’t even tried-”

“I don’t *have* to try,” Adora angrily pulls her hand back and steps away from the girl. She can’t deal with this right now; she can’t deal with everythi- “You have *no idea* what’s going on,” the blonde finally spits out. She takes a breath then and rubs her face - she knows the cat woman doesn’t deserve her ire.

“Then tell me,” Catra stands there with her brow furrowed and regards the taller girl carefully.

“People are *missing*, Catra,” she finally looks back at her with tears stinging her eyes, “They’re dropping off like flies. Villages we *just* spoke to yesterday are suddenly not answering our calls - they’re just.. *gone*. What if they were taken just like the people at Elberon?”

Catra nods her head solemnly and looks back up into blue watery eyes, “Okay.” Taking a measured step towards the flighty princess,

she continues, “That *is* troubling news.” When she sees the warrior is standing her ground, the cat girl takes a chance to reach up and cup her cheek. “But you’re not helping anyone by walking yourself to exhaustion, alright?” Adora’s shoulders slump and she closes her eyes, letting a lone tear escape which Catra gently wipes away with her thumb. “You tried that before, and it didn’t work out too well for you, did it? …You need to get some sleep - you can’t help them if you can barely stand.”

Adora keeps her eyes cast down and nods her head in defeat. With little coaxing, she lets Catra lead her back to her room with a comforting arm around her waist.

Little did the two women know, there were a couple of witnesses to the entire exchange. One was Shadow Weaver who was about to come back inside from the garden when she heard voices and stopped to listen. The other was the Queen who watched the scene from her spot where she was perched at the top of the stairs - sleep eluding her as well.

When the two girls are out of sight, Glimmer takes the opportunity to march back to her room with her fists clenched.

Enough is enough, she thinks*, it’s time for the Horde scum to go.*

The next few days are tense.

Everyone goes about their business, picking up jobs left and right, but with all the news that keeps pouring in, the rebels start to distance themselves more and more. There have been at least three villages, one of which is a village they sent their own refugees to, that have stopped checking in entirely. Teams have been sent out each and every time to inspect the now abandoned homes, but they haven't found a single trace of evidence.

The princesses who are sent on these missions report back to Glimmer and the inner council alone. They try to keep this information away from the rest of the rebellion at Bright Moon to avoid a panic, but they wear the worry clearly on their faces… And with more people disappearing every day, it puts everyone on edge.

How are they supposed to face an enemy they can't defeat?

What if Horde Prime plans on sending these villagers after them to fight in his clones' place knowing the rebellion won't do anything to harm their own people?

The possibilities and limits of this power are unknown to them, which makes everything seem that much more hopeless.

On the third day after they've returned from Elberon, a few members of the inner council decide to meet with Entrapta to see what their options are from there.

"Do you have any idea what could be causing this?"

Bow, Glimmer, Adora, Catra as well as King Micah stand with Entrapta in her makeshift lab while Scorpia finds parts to bring to her.

"You mean the un*natural* phenomenon where people are being controlled by a being out in space? ..No idea," the purple scientist says while walking back over to her computer to read some statistics, "But unless Horde Prime has a mind controlling ability, which he might - we *do* have a princess here who can create nets out of thin air and another who can control the weather - BUT if he doesn't have a magical ability, my guess is he would have to have some kind of device that would allow him to control those people."

"And.. what would this device look like?" King Micah asks skeptically.

"Again… no idea. But he would have to find a way to gain access to a person's central nervous system in order to manipulate their movements as well as their speech. I thought maybe he was doing it remotely, but unless he's found out how to hack directly into someone's brain, unlikely but maybe not impossible with his limitless resources, there would have to be a device on or near their person in order for Horde Prime to control them. It's all fascinating, really," Entrapta sits on her hair, resting her chin in her hand, a mysterious light to her eyes. "I'm curious to see how he's doing it."

"That is one invention we will *not* be replicating," Catra tells her sternly before turning to the others. "As long as we get the grid system up, we should be safe… it'll fry anything mechanical that comes through."

"Alright… Bow?" Adora asks, looking at their friend, "How are we doing on that?"

"I have everyone checking back through the lines to make sure everything is in place before we turn it on this afternoon," it's the first bit of good news they've received since Elberon, so everyone, including Bow, look a little relieved to know their home will at least be protected soon.

"And as soon as that's up," Glimmer continues, "This will be a safe haven. No one who's under Horde Prime's control will be able to breach the perimeter."

"Exactly," Entrapta concludes and returns to her research, deciding her part in the conversation is over.

Everyone stands there and nods absently. Hopefully this will be the first step to ending this nightmare.

When the moment of truth is upon them, the electric grid goes up and everyone breathes a sigh of relief. They run several tests, tossing different pieces of tech and mechanical devices over the line only for their circuits to be fried as soon as they breach the

perimeter. The crowd that gathered around all applauded the Master Builder, Bow, for his efforts as well as Entrapta for designing it. They never really talked about it, but getting this defense up and running has been at the forefront in everyone's mind. And now that it's there, they can all rest easy tonight.

The difference in the rebellion is clear as they gather in the dining hall to eat and drink. Looking around the room, Adora can clearly see that the stress that's been weighing everyone down over the past few days has finally dissipated. Is the war over? No, far from it. But this threat of Horde Prime taking control of their minds isn't as dangerous as it was the day before. It's discussed that they'll continue to exercise caution when going to rescue towns and villages, and every one is in agreement.

But for tonight? They're safe.

Bow looks exhausted but utterly relieved to have it finished. He sits at their table and chuckles along with the rest of them as Seahawk regales them with an exaggerated tale of how he dispensed 200 bots at his last battle in Sealineas.

When he's met with various napkins and leftover food parcels being tossed in his direction, he tries to insist it's all true. "There were *so* many bots, the ground looked white!" he exclaims, which only makes his audience laugh more. "Oh, for the love of- Mermista?" he glances around but doesn't immediately spot his lady love, "Where is Mermista? *She'll* tell you what happened."

The other princesses and rebels glance around without any luck.

"She must've gotten tired of your bullshit, too," Netossa takes another sip of her drink as she brings out another bout of laughter.

Perfuma is giggling demurely with the rest but slowly loses her amusement when she notices Scorpia is missing, too. "Maybe she left with Scorpia?" she asks.

“I think Scorpia went back to help Entrapta,” Catra speaks up while slumping back in her chair to catch the grape she threw in the air with her mouth. The blonde warrior who’s trying to make it subtle that she’s watching the cat woman can’t help but smile at the behavior.

“Nope!” the purple scientist speaks up, her head suddenly popping up from under the next table over, causing the feline and several others to jump, “I just came from there. I haven’t seen Scorpia since we set up the grid!” And with that the scientist retreats back under the table leaving everyone to stare after her curiously.

“What is she-” Netossa starts, but Catra cuts her off.

“-Don’t ask.” the feline snorts before popping another grape in her mouth.

With the other princesses turning up missing, Netossa can’t help but look around suspiciously, “Where did Spinny go? There’s no way she’s been in the bathroom all this time.”

“My dad was going to the communications room to get reports from our scouts... about an hour ago… maybe they’re helping him?” Glimmer offers, but she, like everyone else, suddenly seems unsure of herself.

Everyone starts looking around, noticing more and more of the rebels who were sitting with them earlier have mysteriously disappeared. They didn’t have to sit in there to drink with them, but with all the people that are gone, surely there’d be more noise coming from the hallway where the main staircase sits just outside the dining hall doors, but there’s nothing. With every minute of silence that passes, not counting the storm that sounds like it’s brewing outside, the small group that are left behind become more and more unsettled.

It’s definitely really early to sleep, but -“You think everyone just went to be-”

Adora’s question is cut off when every glass window in the hall shatters instantly - the strong winds suddenly sound five times louder as the broken glass gets blown across the room. Everyone either falls out of their chairs or immediately bends over to cover their heads as the glass starts to rain down over them, and that’s when the real chaos begins.

There are shouts and sounds of battle coming up from the other levels, so as soon as the dining friends snap out of their shock, they immediately get up and run to help. No one has any idea what to expect when they split up in search of the disturbance, but even when they get there, they’re not exactly sure what they’re looking at.

Mermista and Spinnerella are currently targeting several rebels across the room, so the group automatically think the soldiers are the problem and go to target them. But then, as soon as the daring Seahawk leaps into battle to defend his love, he’s swept away by Mermista’s wave. Everyone watches in horror as she swipes him up and then deliberately tosses him out the window into the lakes below.

“Mermista!” Perfuma cries, “What are you doing?!”

That’s when the two princesses turn to them and they see their eyes for the first time - The same glowing green eyes of Horde Prime’s clones.

“Hoooooly fuck,” Catra stands there agape just as Adora steps forward and calls on She-Ra’s sword... which doesn't come. The warrior stands there, flabbergasted, looking down at her empty hand that barely flickers with light. *What happened to She-Ra?* Before either of the groups can attack each other though, a wall of ice builds quickly in between them.

“We have to go,” Frosta pulls on Glimmer’s arm, “We can’t hurt them - they don’t know what they’re doing.”

Everyone is still standing around in shock as a huge gust of wind can be heard blowing against the ice. "Glimmer!" Frosta shakes the girl's arm, trying to get her to snap out of it.

When the ice wall starts to cave to the pressure, the Queen finally comes back into focus. "Everyone- here, now!"

The group that dashed out to save everyone now runs towards their escape. "We should check the other levels!" Adora shouts as she grabs Bow's shoulder, "We don't want to leave anyone behind!"

"They better move fast," Catra replies while grasping Castaspella's shoulder, still staring ahead at the wall of ice crumbling before them. Once everyone has grabbed on, Glimmer starts moving them quickly between the levels. The few that are innocent and trying to survive the onslaught of brainwashed princesses go charging towards the teleporters as soon as they see them.

They're able to save a few people on every level, but the more levels they travel to, the more green eyed zombies who wear the faces of their friends they see. It's unnerving. How did this happen? After making a quick stop to Entrapta's lab to grab a few things, it's time for them to go.

There are still people missing though… so many people they haven't found yet. But they can't stick around. They make one last trip down to the ground level of the entrance to the castle in an effort to find Seahawk. He's easy to spot, looking like a nearly drowned rat who scurries over to them as fast as he can. As they get ready to lift off again, this time to the Whispering Woods to regroup, the flower princess suddenly shouts, "Wait!"

Perfuma breaks from the group when she spots the broad shouldered red woman standing close to the generator hidden amongst the rocks for the electric grid system. "Scorpia!" When her friend doesn't immediately answer, she starts walking forward and tries again, "Scorpia? We need to leave! The castle's been breached!"

Catra is walking just behind Perfuma towards their friend, but the closer they get, the more she feels like something is very wrong. "Scorpia?" the feline tries to get the woman's attention this time - and the red princess finally turns back to look at them.

"Scorpia, no!" Perfuma screams as Catra grabs the flower girl around the waist and starts dragging her back and away from the green eyed red woman who's now aiming her giant claw right for the generator.

"Guys?! A little help?" Catra calls back as she wrestles with Perfuma to get her back in time, but it's already happening.

Scorpia sends red electricity straight into the generator, overloading it and sending sparks and explosions along the lines leading all the way back up to where the dumbfounded group are standing. Seeing the danger, Adora jumps between them and stretches out with the help of Swift Wind - with his long body she's able to make the distance. With one hand holding onto his long tail and the other reaching out to grab Catra's shoulder, she yells, "Glimmer! Now!"

And they're gone.

They all end up either laid out on the grass, sitting or weeping in the aftermath of the attack on Bright Moon… After all these years, the rebel kingdom has finally fallen, taking some of their friends and half of their troops with it. While many were saved and escaped in the nick of time, it doesn't make up for the amount they lost.

The few leaders left look around at the shell-shocked group and wonder what the hell can they do now...

Chapter End Notes

Any thoughts?

Home, Sweet Home

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Previously

"Scorpia, no!" Perfuma screams as Catra grabs the flower girl around the waist and starts dragging her back and away from the green eyed red woman who's now aiming her giant claw right for the generator.

"Guys?! A little help?" Catra calls back as she wrestles with Perfuma to get her back in time, but it's already happening.

Scorpia sends red electricity straight into the generator, overloading it and sending sparks and explosions along the lines leading all the way back up to where the dumbfounded group are standing. Seeing the danger, Adora jumps between them and stretches out with the help of Swift Wind - with his long body she's able to make the distance. With one hand holding onto his long tail and the other reaching out to grab Catra's shoulder, she yells, "Glimmer! Now!"

And they're gone.

They all end up either laid out on the grass, sitting or weeping in the aftermath of the attack on Bright Moon… After all these years, the rebel kingdom has finally fallen, taking some of their friends and half of their troops with it. While many were saved and escaped in the nick of time, it doesn't make up for the amount they lost.

The few leaders left look around at the shell-shocked group and wonder what the hell can they do now...

Chapter 14

The survivors that escaped the siege of the castle at Bright Moon shuffle through the Whispering Woods throughout the night.

They can't stop for rest - they can barely stop for anything. They're without a home now, escaping mostly with just the clothes on their backs. Everyone is tired and hungry, wondering where or if they'll get sleep tonight. Bow is leading them with his trackerpad, but honestly? He doesn't even know where. The woods offer them the most cover as the thick canopy overhead shields them from view, but where could they go? The few villages in the area are some of the ones they've lost contact with, so they can't rely on them.

So they wander, ceaselessly, while they try to figure out what to do.

Once the initial shock wore off, several of the troops who were caught in the attack were able to report that the ones infected had some kind of device that was attached to the backs of their necks… similar to the glowing spots they've all seen on the clones. One of them had actually seen it on Mermista when her braid brushed to the side and went to ask her what it was - that's when the attack began.

After everything is laid out, they realize that Spinnerella must have been the one to infect everyone in the castle. Of those known to be under the control of Horde Prime, Spinnerella was among the few who was engaged by the infected at Elberon. King Micah also hasn't been seen since the siege, so there's a possibility it could have been him. But after some discussion, Netossa admits to everyone that her wife has been a little off since the party. She just assumed that she, like everyone else, was stressed from the situation. They couldn't have known any better. She must have been chipping their friends for the past few days and no one suspected a thing.

Whatever Horde Prime is doing to them is fool proof.

They don't know a way around it.

Hopefully when they get to wherever they're going, Entrapta can go about trying to find a way to hack the chips so they can release their friends. Until then, everyone will be doubly cautious around those who've engaged the Horde, checking to see if they've been chipped before letting them get close.

Before long Bow stops at an unusual entrance. From his trackerpad he can see that there's definitely room for a structure behind the shade of leaves. Once he saw the blank area on his map, he knew they should check it out seeing as how it's a non-organic, human made shape - but now with the shade of trees in the way, he wonders if that's a good idea.

"Why're we stopped?" Netossa asks when she sees the group gathering, looking up at the strange structure.

"Does anyone know what this is?" Bow looks at them curiously.

Surprisingly there are a couple who recognize the place. Catra and Glimmer both glance at each other, scowl and turn away. Adora, witnessing the exchange, decides to press the matter.

"What is this place, Catra?"

The feline sighs and kicks at the ground, "It's a workshop and a storage facility…" when everyone continues to stare at her, she continues, "It's where we kept the exploding drill bots you all had such fun with. We had to keep them hidden so you wouldn't know where to stop them."

"This is an Etherian Horde hideout?" Bow asks curiously.

"Yeah," the former commander shrugs, looking past his shoulder at the structure behind him.

“And there’s no way Horde Prime would have any knowledge of this place?” Adora asks.

“I honestly don’t know, but- I don’t think so.” She shrugs again, still looking up at the hidden-in-plain-sight building. “We even kept the location off our own maps since Hordak was worried about a breach in security,” she grimaces thinking about what she did to Entrapta, but continues. “The only way we knew how to find it was with verbal instructions as well as a few cleverly placed signs.”

“How big is it, Bow?” the blonde warrior turns back to their friend. She’s sure the rest of the group like her is willing to settle down anywhere at this point as long as they can get some rest.

“It’s… big,” he sounds surprised while adjusting the image on his map, “But so were those bots. It looks like there are a few levels here?” The archer asks while looking back up to Catra.

“We had soldiers stationed here,” she tells him, “Needed *someone* to keep an eye on things.”

Netossa steps forward with her own question, “Is there any chance there’s some Horde soldiers in there now?”

Catra’s only response is to shake her head - she returns her eyes to the structure as her heart sinks lower and lower. The last time she was here she was a completely different person. *Sparkles, however* - she takes a second to glare over at the woman - *was just starting to go down her own path of self destruction.* As much as she wants to direct ire at the Queen though, it’s really to just distract from her own feelings about this place.

When the rest of the group trudge ahead, looking forward to finally having a place to settle down for the time being, Catra brings up the rear, hoping they won’t choose to stay here too long.

As the rest of the tired soldiers find somewhere on the ground that’s not littered with debris to sleep, Adora and Bow stay up to

take the first watch. They're both equally as exhausted if not more so, but they're also too amped up to even think about trying to sleep.

Looking around at the rebels who are left… It's not great. Of the princesses they have She-Ra, Glimmer, Frosta, Entrapta, Perfuma and Netossa. Other powerful individuals to note are Castaspella and also, unfortunately, Shadow Weaver as well as a few other conjurers who worked with the former at Mystacor for a time. The rest are soldiers, some who've been with them since the beginning and others they've acquired along the way. While they did lose a good bit of their numbers, they saved a good portion of them as well. And who knows? There may be more out there just looking to find them…

Bow had already tried to reach out to their few scouts left in the area with no luck. They either abandoned ship or were taken by the Horde. So they have no eyes or ears anywhere. While most of the other kingdoms still appear to be standing for the time being, it's probably only a matter of time before they're hit as well. They did at least warn them to start checking people for a device attached to their necks, so hopefully they'll be able to stop the invasion before it starts.

Among the allied camps they've lost touch with, now Salineas as well as the Crimson Waste are added to the list. Huntara along with the other rough riders are no longer answering their calls. And Salineas was probably lost the moment Mermista was chipped. They've thought about sending Glimmer to these places - see if there's anyone left untouched - but it isn't worth the risk.

Adora sighs hopelessly, feeling the weight that's been piling on her shoulders since the siege get heavier and heavier. "What are we gonna do, Bow?" she asks quietly, staring blankly out ahead of her.

"I honestly have no idea," he seems just as hopeless as she is, "After everyone's gotten some rest, we'll start setting up this place to be more liveable. There's still a chance some of our friends are

out there, we just got split up… Who knows. And we'll have Entrapta start working on a solution." While he tries to sound full of confidence, it's getting harder and harder to put on a brave face these days.

The worn princess nods solemnly, hoping it'll be enough.

The next morning everyone sets off to start cleaning up the place and taking inventory of supplies. In the end, Adora and Bow only ended up sleeping a couple hours, way too distracted to rest for long. When they got up, they started to help with the efforts as well.

Glimmer is one of the other leaders who suddenly feels at a loss. While they're all chipping in and working as a team, she keeps looking over to Bow and Adora, wanting to join them, but not being able to bear the thought of Bow disregarding her again. She just lost her home - her heart can't take much more.

They take a break while cleaning and finally decide to have a sit down to discuss their options. For the time being, it didn't seem prudent to go out looking for survivors - they'll keep their coms open in case someone reaches out for help, but they'll have protocols in place before bringing anyone back to their safe house. They can't be too careful.

The rebels that are left behind will take shifts guarding the outside, checking anyone who tries to approach, even if it's one of them. They can't trust anyone… not even themselves.

They also discuss the lost. Adora watches Perfuma turn her crying face into Catra's shoulder… Catra, who sits there resolutely, her stance tense as she keeps her hardened stare looking forward at nothing. Those two took losing Scorpia the hardest… She knows Entrapta is upset in her own way but chooses work to take her mind off things. Meanwhile Seahawk is still crying for his lost love, and Netossa looks more determined than ever to find and fix her wife.

Though their friends are gone for now, the blonde won't rest until she brings them back.

It gets to the point where it's obvious everyone is done talking - most of them still grieving. So they decide to disperse and get back to securing their new location. Entrapta has already carved out her own section of the bunker and has been plugging away all day, trying to look for solutions. Shadow Weaver and the other sorcerers are working together to put up an illusion spell to keep the secret entrance to their safe house hidden from anyone who may stumble across them.

Everything seems to be falling into place.

Adora is surveying the dent they've made in cleaning - almost all the debris that looks to be left over from some massive attack is being taken outside - when she glances around for the sullen feline… *Where is she?*

"Hey Adora! Little help?"

A few of the guards are working on removing a large piece of shrapnel that's too heavy for any of them to lift. The princess calls on She-Ra's sword - this time she's able to pull it up after a couple of tries - and slices the shrapnel in halves and then fourths, making it easier to carry. When that's done, she assists them with carrying it out - this is the last of it, and they're all glad to be rid of it.

"Whoo," the guard removes his helmet to wipe his brow, "Thanks for the assist."

"Yeah, no problem," the princess tells them, trying not to worry about her power being on the fritz. "Tell me though, have any of you seen Catra?"

The guards all look at each other, confused, before shaking their heads.

"You're looking for Catra?" She hears and turns around to find Castaspella drawing an enchantment on the ground.

Adora leaves the guards and joins her, being careful not to step on her work. "Yeah, do you know where she is? Or what she's working on?"

"She left to go out in the woods earlier, after our meeting," she says, still focusing on her drawing.

"What- she's out there? In the woods… Alone?" the blonde asks incredulously leading Castaspella to look up at her. "She's not supposed to be unsupervised - what is she doing?"

The Queen's aunt looks up at her curiously, "I think I heard her say something about taking those signs down? The ones that the Horde used to lead them back here?"

Adora sighs and looks towards the treeline. *Looks like I'm going on a hike.* She thanks Castaspella and heads out. They'll both need to be inspected when they get back which leads the rebel soldier to roll her eyes. *What was she thinking?*

Though trudging out in the woods alone like this does bring back the memories of when they reunited, shortly after destroying the sword. She shakes her head - that definitely feels like forever ago. Catra has grounded herself a lot since then.

After walking a bit in one direction, the warrior stops. She has no idea which way the girl went, so she decides to cross over, heading in another direction closer to the river… But past that point, Catra will be on her own. They can only go so far in these ever shifting woods without getting lost. But that's when she hears it - the sounds of a struggle just a little farther in.

Catra? Suddenly her feet kick into overdrive, taking her in the direction of the yells. *Fuck, Catra, what were you thinking?*

She leaps through the brush and tumbles before landing on her feet, ready for action… What she doesn't expect to find is that she

might be fighting the feline herself. As she watches, Catra takes another swipe at the tree, its bark nearly completely removed from the side now as the cat girl digs her claws in farther and farther with every hit. It also looks like she's taken a few swipes at the bushes around her as well - all of them torn to shreds and scattered in a disarray around the clearing. With every swipe of her claws, the commander yells… Whether that yell is from pain or from anger, she doesn't know. Either way, she needs to stop it and she's not exactly sure how.

She eases up behind the woman - there's no way to get around her unfortunately - so she just tries calling her name at an arm's length away.

"Catra?"

And what Adora worried might happen, happened.

Without missing a beat, the distressed feline crouches, turns and launches herself right at the blonde, unseeing - so lost in her rage that she can't even control herself. She's tackled and the two roll around on the ground before Adora gets the upper hand and pins the cat girl down, holding her in place. Catra hisses at her, but once she takes a good look at Adora, her ire seems to fade just enough that she stops struggling, but the frown etched into her features doesn't disappear. She just turns her head to the side and does her best to ignore the situation… like her oldest friend just didn't witness her having a massive breakdown.

"What the hell was that?" the warrior asks her captured target, a bit out of breath from the scare more than the impromptu rolling in the dirt.

"Can you let me go?" Catra's voice is gruff and she still refuses to look at the girl.

"Not until you tell me what the hell's going on," Adora softens a tad. "Haven't seen that look on your face since we last fought," she adds on quietly.

The feline squeezes her eyes shut, feeling the guilt gnawing at her insides again. She doesn't need this - She's half tempted to dislodge the woman sitting on top of her so she can flee, but even in her darkest moments she knows rationally she shouldn't hurt the woman. With all of her might she tries to restrain the impulse, all the while trying to ignore the blonde.

"Catra-"

"I *failed*, okay?!" The cat woman finally turns her face to glare at the woman restraining her. "It's exactly like Shadow Weaver said. I tried to help and I failed everyone - I can't even succeed at being good."

"Catra," Adora feels her face fall as well as her defenses, which is why it's easy for the cat woman to topple her over so she can jump back to her feet. The blonde watches her cautiously while she slowly stands - The feline pacing just a few steps away could lash out at her in the blink of an eye. But neither of them want that…

"I don't need your pity," the former commander spits out but tries to keep her glares to herself, knowing the princess doesn't deserve them. "If you wanna be sad, go be sad with the rest of your friends that are hurting - I need to go find Scorpia."

The taller girl feels her heart break for the struggling feline but tries to keep her emotions to herself seeing as how that didn't help last time. "You can't do that-"

"It's my fault!" Catra finally stops and faces her again, her chest heaving from the adrenaline. Adora also notices the unshed tears forming in her eyes and reminds herself to keep her expressions in check. The feline continues, "The minute the rebellion finally starts to trust me and I let them down."

"Catra-"

"Look around, Adora!" she yells at her desperately, "Half of the

rebellion is gone, okay? It's just - *gone*. I knew there was something wrong with those villagers, but we stayed anyway. We stayed, and our friends got infected. Horde Prime bested me." Her shoulders drop then and for the first time in her tirade Catra looks defeated - her eyes fall to the ground, unseeing. "He probably saw us building the electric grid system and decided to take us out from within… How the fuck are we supposed to fight this?" her tone is despondent.

Seizing the opportunity, the princess steps forward and grasps onto the lithe woman's shoulders firmly, holding her in place. Catra's brow furrows again as she looks back up to meet her eyes. "This is *not* your fault," Adora tells her adamantly, but the feline only scowls and turns her face away. "We were all fooled, okay? You had no way of knowing what Horde Prime was planning." She gives the girl a gentle shake when she still won't meet her gaze. Heterochromatic eyes that are more filled with self-doubt than anger now finally look back up at her. "Prime will pay for this, I *promise* you," the blonde's voice is practically a growl, "But we need to stick together to make that happen."

When the ex-commander's shoulders drop in defeat, Adora uses the time to pull her in before wrapping her arms around the girl's slender frame. Catra doesn't seem opposed to the hug like she is with most people but she doesn't reciprocate right away either. When her clawed hands finally find their way to dig into the back of the blonde's jacket, the princess sighs in relief and buries her face in the commander's messy hair. She uses her hand on the opposite side to dig into the crazy locks before speaking again, "We'll get them back- we'll get them all back."

Catra tries to swallow down her emotions and nods before burying her face in the warrior's neck and settling into the embrace. Adora, like before, holds her with ease and uses the fingers buried in the feline's wild locks to start scratching gently at the back of her scalp - it's always been a favored spot for the feline, not that anyone outside of Adora would know. Pretty soon she's completely relaxed and purring lightly in her spot, hidden away in the blonde warrior's embrace.

Adora breathes her in, missing the intimacy she had with the woman. She wonders if they'll ever be able to get back to that - those days when they trusted each other implicitly and only had each other to rely on. The thought brings tears to her eyes and she holds the former force captain tighter. After a few moments of peace, she decides to break the silence.

"You remember that day… when you scratched Octavia and called her a dumb face?"

The frame of the lithe woman in her arms shakes slightly as she chuckles. "Oh yeah," is the amused response she gets.

Adora smiles and continues, "And so we had to run from her. It was funny at first, but then she started tearing through the hallway and our locker room trying to find us, so we got scared and hid - in the top of that supply closet, remember? You climbed up the shelves in the back and I followed?"

Catra nods gently, a smile still dawning her face from the memory, "Yeah, I remember."

The warrior relishes in the warmth for a moment while she pets the girl's hair. "We stayed up there for hours," her voice is softer now, barely above a whisper, "We missed dinner and the unit's evening report." She shrugs gently, "But I didn't want to leave for anything." The feline is curious about that but waits for the princess to continue. "That night in the closet was probably the safest I ever felt in the Fright Zone - just you and me, as we shut out the rest of the world."

"... didn't I fall asleep on you?" the cat woman chuckles.

"You did," Adora laughs with her, "You had your head in my lap and I held you until hunger got the best of us." She waits a second for the laughter to die down before she adjusts her head to press her forehead to the feline's temple to look at her profile. "I knew then that I would always do everything in my power to

protect you," she whispers, barely loud enough for the cat woman's overly sensitive ears to even pick up.

Catra feels her heart jump to her throat and her eyes water. She starts to turn her head to get a good look at her blonde counterpart when she feels warm lips press to the corner of her mouth. It only lasts a second and then Adora pulls away from the embrace, trying to act nonchalant even with the red tint coloring her cheeks. The feline watches her embarrassed friend with an amused grin while her racing heart settles - she's trying to decide if she should tease her or put her out of her misery… But it took courage for Adora to do that - to tell her that hidden truth and to kiss her; it's probably for the best that she doesn't push her luck.

Even if she's dying to follow up on that kiss with one of her own. She stares at the taller girl's mouth for a moment, trying to restrain her impulses but it definitely isn't easy - for most of her teenage years and even now as an adult, she's wanted nothing more than to taste the girl, and only getting a swift drive by kiss isn't nearly enough to slate her thirst. But she can't… She doesn't want to scare the princess away, especially when it seems like she's finally coming around. "Thank you," is what she says instead, finally pulling her gaze away from the girl's lips to meet her eyes again.

Adora manages to give her a small smile though she's still probably panicking. Catra steps to her side, then bumps her shoulder playfully with her own. "You wanna know what I remember from that day?" The blonde raises her eyebrows at the question. "I remember that you really are the slowest runner in the world."

The warrior barks out a laugh unexpectedly, the tension between the two finally breaking, as she turns to face her lifelong competitor, "That's only because you always cheated."

"Oh yeah?" is her catty response before she pushes the girl and starts running back in the direction of the storage facility.

“Hey!” Adora yells around a laugh and is quick on her heels, “No fair!” The two girls laugh all the way back to the shelter, taking turns bumping into each other along the way.

They’re still at a loss for what the future looks like from here… But pretty soon they’ll have a plan, and they’ll be right back to fighting off Horde Prime with everything they’ve got. The rebellion won’t stay down for long.

“Yeah, let’s uh- put those in the containers over there?” Glimmer recommends when Perfuma shows her the weapons she found lying around. The obviously concerned flower princess takes a calming breath and then goes to find a volunteer to move the dangerous life threatening devices somewhere safer. The Queen takes a breath, too, and continues on her way only to be stopped again.

“Your highness, what should we do with these?” one of the guards asks her, holding up what looks like old clothes left behind by the Horde.

“Ah, yes- umm, we’ve been laying those out over in the residential section we’ve cornered off-” and by ‘residential’ she literally means a clear corner of the storage area where they’ve laid out a bunch of sleeping bags, “-right over there.” She points past Entrapta’s make shift lab where a few people are already resting.

It’s been a long day for the rebellion. Have they made any steps to figure out where to go from here? … Not exactly, but! They have spent a good amount of energy securing a new homefront for themselves until the war is over. Glimmer isn’t necessarily happy that it’s a former Horde structure, or that it’s where she and Catra met at a stalemate just a few short weeks ago, but beggars can’t be choosers. And speaking of the Horde scum…

A few sets of eyes are drawn to the entrance of the facility where the commander's distinctive laugh could be heard as Adora literally tackles the brunette while running inside. They tumble around a bit, jump back up and continue to rough house even inside the structure. That is until Bow appears right in front of them.

The Queen watches as the pair immediately halt in their antics and stand up straight while passing each other curious glances. The trio are too far away for Glimmer to hear what's being said, but it looks serious… at first, at least. Next thing she sees is Adora flashing Bow a grin as the archer steps past Catra and pats the suspicious feline on the shoulder. The girl then turns back to Adora with a question in her eyes, which the blonde answers by putting her in a headlock so they can continue to play-fight each other.

Throughout the entire exchange, Glimmer can feel her blood pressure rising. She clenches her fists and she watches her best friend goof around with their sworn enemy. It's been bad enough to feel like Adora is slipping away from her, but now Bow? *BOW?!* Her oldest friend - After everything the feline has done, he's suddenly showing more warmth towards the Horde scum than he has his own best friend for weeks now. *Why - Why is this happening? Why are they suddenly so eager to listen to Catra instead of her?*

"It's curious, isn't it?"

The voice comes from right over her shoulder, causing her to gasp and jump away. *What the fuck*- "Shadow Weaver?"

The dark conjurer lurks in the shadows behind her, her eyes - if they even are eyes - are regarding the two former Horde cadets playing with each other across the way before turning to look at the Queen. "I said it's curious, isn't it."

Glimmer rubs her forehead, already tired of this conversation; whatever Shadow Weaver had to say, she would only take with a

grain of salt. “What’s curious?” she asks in exasperation.

“That you predicted exactly what would happen if we let that manipulative sociopath enter the rebellion,” Shadow Weaver turns back to watch the two women again, and so does Glimmer, “We followed *her* plan… and look where we are now.”

The Queen grinds her teeth and clenches her fists so hard she can feel the strain up her arms. Seeing this, the conjurer concludes her observation, “We are *far* worse off now than we were before. Don’t you agree?”

Glimmer doesn’t dignify the question with an answer, choosing instead to skulk off to go pace somewhere angrily. Shadow Weaver has taken enough from her and she won’t let her take anymore. *But yes… I do agree*, she thinks, hotly.

When she gets far enough away, she turns back to glare one more time at the traitor sitting on a crate with *her* best friend while they share some food. As she turns to go find someplace quiet so she won’t be disturbed, the Queen has one final thought:

She can't hide her true colors forever.

Chapter End Notes

What'd ya think? :)

What Happens in the Dark

Chapter Notes

> I won't say much here because I don't want to give anything away, but I will say that this chapter as well as the next two have been my favorite to write thus far. I hope you like it!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Previously

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Chapter 15

It took some effort, but the storage facility was finally starting to feel a bit livable. Not homey, necessarily, but it'll do for the time being. A few of the rebels are going to stay behind to finish organizing and sorting supplies they've uncovered, while the rest split up into groups to do some reconnaissance. They need to reestablish some scout locations, check out the Horde positions, and look for any more survivors that escaped the siege at Bright Moon.

Glimmer feels a little excited and a little nervous at the prospect. It's been a while since she's been included in these side missions - everyone always deeming her too important to risk - but now that they're short on foot soldiers, the Queen finally gets to be a part of the gang again.

Not necessarily with her best friends, but she'll see if she can fix that.

"Hey!" Adora jumps at the sudden greeting and spins around to find the shorter princess suddenly standing at her shoulder. Glimmer chuckles to cover her embarrassment, "I was gonna see if you were going to be a part of the rescue squad? I'm going… I mean, I have to- I'm- the fastest way around to look for survivors. But um- are you coming?" She tries to keep the hopefulness out of her voice, but what fun will this be without the best friend squad back in action at last?

“Oh,” the tall warrior’s face suddenly falls, the awkward tension growing between them as the Queen already feels the rejection coming. “I kinda told Perfuma that I’d help her sort these,” evidently the flower princess had found yet another crate of weapons - *“Why does the Horde need so many weapons?!”* her irritation was palpable. But regardless - “She doesn’t like them, so I offered,” the blonde shrugs. She sees the look of disappointment color her friend’s face, so she quickly adds, “I’m sorry, but hey! Maybe next time?” Adora offers the Queen a smile, hoping that rectifies the situation for now. Glimmer returns it, though her smile doesn’t quite meet her eyes.

“That’s fine,” the sparkly princess says to save face, “I’ll see who else is available.” And by ‘who else’ she means Bow, but she keeps that information to herself as she turns around to go search for the archer.

It doesn’t take long to spot him among the masses with his broad shoulders and cut off shirt she’s always loved on him. “Bow!” Glimmer yells and quickly trots up behind him. The man is engrossed in his tablet and barely glances up to acknowledge the princess. “Um, I was gonna see-”

“Can you get me those insulators?” he directs the question to one of the harried guards walking by with his arms full of parts. The guard nods and continues on his way, neither of them even breaking in their stride.

The Queen brushes off the interruption and tries again, “Anyway, I’m leading the group who’s going out to look for survivors-”

“Bow!” Entrapta yells across the way, “Where did you leave my blowtorch?”

“I told you, no welding without my supervision!” He yells back and then turns to Glimmer impatiently, “So, what is it you need from me?”

The sparkly princess is thrown off by his exasperated tone, though she should be used to it by now, shouldn't she? "I was… just gonna see if you were coming with us?"

"I'm a little busy here, Glimmer," he dismisses her and turns to continue on his way.

"Bow-"

"You have plenty of people to choose from," the archer is borderline yelling as he turns back to face her. Once he sees the wounded look on her face, he takes a breath and tries again. "I'm sorry- just… I'm needed here. You can find someone else." With that, he leaves her.

Glimmer is left standing there with unshed tears in her eyes as she watches her friend turn his back on her once again. She sniffs and shakes her head, willing her vision to clear as she marches on with her head held high.

She'll win her friends back over someday.

Adora smiles at the passing guard before heading back into the dark storage area. She has an armful of weapons that they've decided to lock up as they're not needed. When she begins to stow the weapons away, she feels a passing seed of guilt planted in her stomach from her interaction with Glimmer before. It's not that she didn't want to go with her friend, she did. But as the other two members of the best friends squad grow apart, they both start leaning more heavily on the warrior, and let's face it… Adora is the last person you want to go to with emotional problems. She could offer advice, but that's not to say anyone should necessarily take it.

She lets out a sad sigh, before turning to go collect more weapons. She's sure her friends will work out their problems eventually, she just doesn't know how to help them. As the soldier leaves the dusty storage unit, a voice - seemingly out of nowhere - calls out to her, making her jump for the second time today.

"You look troubled, dear," the voice calls from the shadows.

Narrowing her eyes, Adora spots the luminescent ones staring back at her before Shadow Weaver emerges from the darkness. She has a cup of what the warrior can only assume is wine in her hand, but it doesn't stop the woman from appraising her. The princess rolls her eyes as she turns to continue on her way - she's really not in the mood to deal with her former mentor today.

"I see you and Catra are becoming close again," the rebel soldier stops in her tracks, feeling her shoulders tense as she balls up her fists - she definitely hasn't forgotten Shadow Weaver's attack on the feline only a week prior. "Do you really think that's wise?"

Okay, Adora nearly chuckles maliciously, hoping the sorceress will give her a reason to smack her, before she turns around to glare at the woman. "What Catra and I do is *none* of your business. You don't have any authority over us anymore." With that, the princess turns on her heel and starts marching back to the main floor.

Once she's nearly out of sight, the shadow woman calls out to her again - though the words are spoken at her normal volume, Adora hears them like they were spoken just over her shoulder:

"Haven't you two hurt each other enough?"

The tall soldier pauses in her stride, almost turning to look back but decides against it. She returns to her work station and continues sorting the weapons mindlessly - her thoughts still circling around the last thing Shadow Weaver said to her as her stomach fills with dread. *Yes, we have hurt each other in the past*, she thinks, trying to reason with herself, *but that's in the past. We've both moved on and forgiven each other… right?*

While logically she knows she’s right, she can’t help but feel nervous about seeing the cat woman again.

Adora stays at the front, sorting through what’s left of the assortment of weapons the Horde left behind, while the rest of the groups leave. There’s only a small number - a skeleton crew, really - of people left behind. Most of them will be guarding the front, checking anyone who comes back while the few others finish up organizing their supplies.

Entrapta is one of the few left behind just because she’s still hard at work trying to figure out how the chips work - she’s asked the groups going out, if the opportunity presents itself, to try and find a chip to bring back to her to study. Seeing as how the only chips they know about are currently attached to *people* though, it probably won’t work out.

The warrior has seen a few other people moving around, doing what she is by putting things in their rightful place, but for the most part, she’s left alone. She’s pretty sure she’s heard Catra somewhere off in the distance - so the commander apparently stayed behind as well - but Adora does her best not to go looking for the girl.

“Haven’t you two hurt each other enough?”

Shadow Weaver’s words still resonate, hammering into her head whenever she lets her thoughts get too quiet. As much as she doesn’t want to, she tries to force herself to get some distance from her old friend. She doesn't want to hurt the cat girl again… just like she doesn't want to be the one hurting.

Catra doesn’t have the same reservations, however.

"*Uggghh*, if the flower child hands me *one* more thing to put away," she leaves the threat open ended as she hops up to sit on the table the princess has designated as her work station. The brunette glances over to her while she continues to work diligently on her task. "We need to bring Scorpia home so she can go back to distracting her Weeping Willow over there." Adora lets out a breath of a laugh at the joke, but keeps her eyes focused on her sorting. Catra observes her for a moment longer and furrows her brow in confusion.

They were doing good yesterday, weren't they? The blonde witnessed her having a breakdown in the woods, came to console her, gave her a kiss on the cheek… The cat woman feels the corner of her mouth creeping up at the thought. And then they returned here after some much needed playful competition.

But Adora definitely seems closed off now, doesn't she?

Trying to distract the girl from her work, seeing as how that's what the feline does best, she reaches over to pick up one of the Horde shock batons and ignites it a few times. "Hmm," she says thoughtfully, "Hey- you remember when you knocked me out with one of these to kidnap me?" She throws a smile over to the blonde, hoping it does the trick.

The warrior doesn't look up from her work though. "I was only doing that because you pulled the lever that tore the fabric of space and time," Adora gives her a passing side glance, "Remember?"

Catra bites down on her lip as she grimaces. "Oh yeah…" she mumbles before dropping the baton back in its place. The feline looks down and pulls at her fingers punishingly. *How could you forget that, dumbass??? Now you've gone and reminded her of how terrible you can be.*

While she's in the middle of reprimanding herself, though, a pale hand reaches over to grab onto hers, stopping the brunette from pulling back too far on her fingers. Catra looks over to the rebel

hesitantly only to find a small smile waiting for her. "It was a long time ago," Adora tells her quietly. She squeezes her hand and then lets go, turning her attention back to her work.

Well, that's a step in the right direction…

Catra's just wondering where she should take the conversation from here, when something catches her eye. "Well hello," she says and hops off the table. The lithe brunette walks around Adora to reach the staffs on the other side of the table, "What do we have here?" She picks up one to twirl around herself a few times before turning to face the taller girl again - Adora is watching her curiously when Catra smiles and takes the opportunity to toss the staff to her, which she stumbles trying to catch. While the blonde rights herself, the lithe woman steps up to take another staff.

Adora quickly catches on and then immediately starts to shake her head.

"Oh, come *on*," the cat girl whines, "You did say we'd get back into sparring, didn't you?"

Adora inspects her staff, torn about the idea. On the one hand, she has work to do… not to mention she was trying to distance herself from a certain dangerous feline, but on the other hand… The princess looks up to her brunette counterpart to find a cheshire grin waiting on her friend's face. Feeling her heart warm, and realizing too late that she's powerless to resist the girl when she smiles like that, the princess rolls her eyes and acquiesces.

Seeing as the two women are mostly alone on the main floor, they're able to spar for a few minutes undisturbed. It doesn't take long for the rebel to realize she's very much out of practice when she winds up on the floor… again. Catra had already made her trip over her own feet a few times now.

"Oh man," the feline laughs as she watches the soldier pick herself up again, "This is almost too easy."

Adora shakes her head, though she can't even begin to know how to wipe the smile off her face. She starts to wonder how much of her epic failure is from being out of practice, and how much of it is being unable to tear her eyes away from the lithe brunette's curves, perfectly accentuated in her form fitting Horde outfit. The warrior shakes her head again, this time to try and lose the inappropriate thoughts that just flooded her mind. But it's hard - it's really not fair how well the feline filled out. With her curves and her toned arms on display, Adora really has to concentrate to move her eyes back to safer ground.

She's so distracted with trying to *not* be distracted that she doesn't see Catra using her staff to push off the ground to launch herself at the princess.

"Oof" the air leaves the rebel soldier in one fell swoop as the cat girl topples her over on the ground again, her staff being knocked out of her hand in the process.

Catra 'tsk's above her, and the fallen girl squints her eyes open to see the amused cat woman sat on her haunches over her. "It's not even fun anymore," she tells Adora light heartedly before pulling her back to her feet.

"Heh," Adora chuckles to cover up her embarrassment, "I guess my head's just not in it today."

"Shh-yeah, no kidding," Catra does her best to try to tone down her shit-eating grin but can't. She does try to be nice though. When she steps up to the girl, Adora instantly raises her fists to prepare for another strike which makes the cat girl laugh again. "Relax, dummy," the former commander tells her affectionately, then pushes the woman's fists down so she can step right into her space.

Adora feels her heart leap into her throat when the cat woman suddenly invades her personal bubble, but then she reaches around to start straightening the collar on her jacket. *Breathe,* she tells herself, *She's just fixing your clothes*, *dummy… Great,*

now I'm insulting myself. The princess tries to keep her breathing even with the amused commander so near, but she can't stop the red tint that colors her cheeks. When Catra's finished straightening the back, she then runs her hands down her shoulders and her arms to straighten out her sleeves. Adora can't help but feel her heart race at all the extra attention. When the cat woman finishes by tugging the hem of her jacket, the taller girl finally breathes a sigh of relief.

"Who dressed you this morning?" Catra asks her seriously, though there's still amusement in her voice as a corner of her mouth drifts up into a smirk.

"I-I did," the warrior suddenly looks down at her outfit, confused. "What's wrong with it?"

"Your belt is twisted," the brunette tells her plainly and the princess feels her face heat up again. Before she can respond though, clawed fingers are already reaching up to undo the belt.

Adora's not quite sure what it is about the sensation of her old friend suddenly undressing her, but it sends a delightful pulse all the way down to her core while her mouth suddenly becomes very dry. "Umm-" she starts only for Catra to interrupt her.

"I'll be quick," she rolls her eyes and then steps into the taller woman, wrapping her arms entirely around her waist so she can fix the belt in the back. While she's there, both the girl's inspect each other closely while simultaneously acting like they're not looking at each other. Catra has to bite her lip when she looks down and sees just how close her friend's mouth is - she tries to calm her pounding heart and restrain her impulses… But it's getting harder and harder to do so.

When she's done straightening the rebel's belt, she quickly takes a step back to remove the temptation. "There you go; good as new," Catra tells her, though her voice has suddenly taken on a raspy quality. Her heart is still racing, and she can't help but to glance at the princess's mouth longingly.

Adora is still staring at the smaller girl - her scent still lingering in the air as she tries to swallow down the desire to pull the lithe brunette back into her. *What is wrong with me?* She clears her throat and looks away, hoping to shove away her raging hormones.

This is fucking torture, the cat woman thinks to herself. She shifts on her feet and tries desperately to cut the thick tension that's fallen over them. "You, uh-" she looks away and clears her throat before trying again, "I guess you should add 'clumsiest dresser' to your list of accomplishments, huh?" When she looks back at Adora, she flashes her a teasing grin, which causes the blonde to narrow her eyes comically.

Though she's trying to look intimidating, the warrior feels the corners of her mouth twitching as she tries not to smile.

"Oh *really?"* she says.

"Well, yea-" Catra's sentence is cut off by Adora immediately lunging forward to capture the shorter girl in a headlock. "Hey!" The feline screeches and laughs as the rebel rubs her knuckles across the brunette's scalp, messing up her hair. "Stop it!"

"Oh, look who forgot to brush their hair this morning!"

"Get *off*, you *ass hat!*"

The two tussle back and forth. With Adora refusing to let go of her head and Catra refusing to be captured, they almost knock each other over while laughing the entire time. It's not until they hear a very distinctive "a- *hem"* that the two come back to reality and jump apart. They both have red coloring their cheeks as they stand away from each other and at attention (out of habit from all the times Shadow Weaver has caught them goofing off), as they face the flower princess who seems to be regarding them with an amused grin.

Perfuma shakes her head and walks towards them, giving Catra a knowing look that has the cat girl swallowing down her nerves.

"Ladies," the flower princess starts, "I'm done downstairs for the most part." She sighs wistfully, "Outside of the Horde's absurdly limitless stock of weapons, there was something else I thought you could take care of, Adora?"

"Oh- oh yeah?" The taller princess forces a smile, just glad Perfuma skipped over their childish behavior.

"Yes," the peaceful blonde looks baffled here as she tries to find the words to describe it. "There's another container down there that appears to be… sustenance?" she hesitates to even use the word for it, "They're these little bars that are wrapped up. I opened one and it smelled… edible? But it was definitely *gray* in color. Perhaps they're past their expiration?" She hopes that's enough to describe it.

The duo turn their heads to look at each other - they're both thinking the same thing, but the cat woman has better reflexes. She immediately darts around Perfuma… only to fall on her face.

Ouch - what the fuck?

When she hears Adora's raucous laughter a little ways ahead, she quickly deduces her friend tripped her. Catra curses the taller girl, "*Fuck you!* That is *so* cheating!" The feline laughs as she gets up to bound after her.

"Those ration bars are *mine!"* the princess yells as she starts tearing down the stairwell.

Catra runs up to the rail and looks over, not hurried because this is one race Adora won't win, "You don't get to just *claim* all the ration bars for yourself!"

"I do if I get there first," she calls back after jumping down the remaining few steps on that level. The feline jumps over the rail then and lands on the level just below her. "Now *that's* cheating!," She yells and immediately tries to jump over the rail herself.

The friends take turns jumping in front of the other, laughing all the way until they're almost out of breath. Catra can't remember the last time she's had this much fun. When she sees Adora has made it to the ground level, the cat woman jumps over the railing again, this time landing directly on top of the princess, taking her down instantly. They immediately start to tussle, both of them trying to pin down the other without success.

The two are breathless after they've finished rolling around, still laughing at each other. Adora wound up on top of Catra at some point, and when she lifts up to look down at her brunette counterpart, their eyes lock and the laughter slowly fades. They examine each other carefully - both feeling very full in the moment and one feeling very excited when blue eyes stay locked with her own. It feels like forever- how long Adora stares into her eyes; both of their chests still rising and falling rapidly from the exertion of the run but also something else. Catra feels like all the air has been sucked out of the room, like the two are trapped inside a vacuum and it's only them tangled in each other - no other outside forces to interrupt them.

Why does she have to be so beautiful? She questions sadly, not able to break her eyes away. Her chest feels so full that she might explode. *I want her so much.* Can something just go right for her? Can she just have this one little thing? It's been so long since they last kissed, the cat woman has forgotten what she tasted like… How she felt under her.

She wants *so* much to revisit that moment, that when the blonde's eyes drift down to her mouth… Catra loses all control.

The brunette reaches up to grab the back of Adora's neck and follows swiftly, shifting up to plant her lips against her old friends while keeping her in place to taste her. "Mmmmm," *Finally.* She sighs happily against a soft mouth while going to reconnect their lips again. When the taller girl doesn't immediately pull away and actually starts responding by capturing Catra's lips with her own,

the cat woman slowly lowers herself back to the ground, bringing Adora with her.

Her back eventually reconnects with the floor and the energy of the kiss suddenly shifts.

This time *Adora* kisses *her*.

The taller girl reaches up to dig her fingers into brunette hair and takes control - She tilts her head and deepens their connection by licking the cat woman's bottom lip, causing the latter to gasp and allow her entrance. Catra moans at the unexpected turn of events and gladly relinquishes control to the woman laying on top of her. *As long as she keeps doing that,* the cat girl thinks deliriously as her tongue swipes smoothly against her own.

When Adora starts to pull back to switch angles, the feline nips her on her bottom lip, causing the taller of the two to moan - but it also shoots fire right through her, causing her to shift her hips ever so slightly right where she's laying, pressed firmly between Catra's thighs.

The former commander moans loudly and raises her hips to meet her before pulling the girl into another searing kiss. *Fuck*, *what was that?* The cat woman wonders dazedly. She is running out of air and it's clouding her mind and her judgment. She doesn't know what it was but she needs it to happen again. The electricity that shoots through her all the way down to her core makes her squirm under the blonde - she feels like she's been ignited and she needs Adora to stoke the flame until they both combust. So, while the rebel is focused on her lips, Catra slips her hands down to her waist, gripping at her hips - being careful not to scratch the girl though her claws dig in just a bit. She uses her thighs to squeeze her between her legs, attempting to pull her closer - and then with one gentle tug at her hips, she tries to encourage the woman to push into her again, like she did before…

And with that one gentle tug, Adora freezes… and then removes herself completely.

Catra is dazed and curious why the blonde is suddenly gone. She shakes her head, trying to clear the lust-filled haze as she looks around and props herself up on her elbows. She finds Adora just a couple feet away, still in a crouched position - her cheeks are flushed, her pupils are blown and her chest rises and falls rapidly as she tries to catch her breath.

"Adora?" Catra calls, confused if not a little worried.

Without saying anything, the warrior turns and runs from the room. The cat woman stalls, willing her brain to catch up as she jumps to her feet. "Adora!" She calls again but doesn't give chase. She watches, dumbfounded, as the woman she loves runs away - her ears suddenly falling with her stomach.

"Fuck!" she yells as she turns to punch one of the nearby containers. "Fuck, fuck *fuck!"*

What did I just do? Why do I always push?! The pain in her hand isn't enough to feed her destructive fit so she turns and kicks a small table over, leaving its contents to scatter across the floor.

"*Ooooo*, Kitten's *mad*."

Catra whirls around with her claws out and is surprised to see them there, emerging from the darkness behind one of the containers.

"Double Trouble?" She shakes her head, thinking she's imagining things, but the longer she looks, the more sure she is. The feline retracts her claws and walks towards the shapeshifter, confusion written across her face, "What the hell are *you* doing here?" She glances around the room looking for other hidden trespassers, "And how long were you standing there?"

"Oh, I only caught the end of your *rousing* performance," they chuckle as a blush colors Catra's cheeks. "And I could ask you the same thing, darling," the shapeshifter continues as they strut over

to her. “Last I saw of you, you were neck deep in self-loathing after you lost everything you worked so hard for.” Here they bend over to pick up one of the discarded ration bars before tossing it with the rest of the mess. “So *destructive*,” they comment before righting the table and sitting on top of it. “So tell me - what’s the master plan now?" they ask before giving the feline a teasing grin, "…*Seduce* She-Ra and bring her back to the dark side?”

Catra shakes her head, not sure where this is going. “I don’t know what you’re talking about,” she tells them. But speaking of- she turns to look mournfully at the staircase Adora just used to escape.

“Oh, don’t be coy, dear - it doesn’t suit you,” the shapeshifter flicks their hair over their shoulder. When Catra turns back to them with a confused look, they continue, “You don’t honestly believe anyone buys this *reforming* act you’re putting on, do you? You’re the same person you were in that broken down lab - desperate for *any* way to crush the rebellion. So be honest… What’s the plan?” Here they flash their sharp teeth at her with a wicked gleam in their eye, “You know I’d be happy to offer my services… for a price, of course.”

The feline rolls her eyes and turns back to look at the staircase, wanting nothing more than to chase after the girl but knowing deep down she shouldn’t. *Why can’t things just ever be easy?* “Yeah, because that worked out for me so well last time,” she grumbles while crossing her arms.

“You *knew* what the deal was, kitten,” they hop back off the table and slither around to stand in her field of view. “You have to pick the winning side if you want to survive, and as it stands-” here they pause to look at their nails, “-the Horde obviously has all the means to demolish the rebellion until they’re lost to history. So, what will it be?” Their reptilian eyes turn back to pin her with their unnerving stare.

“There’s nothing to tell, Double Trouble,” the cat girl drops her arms and moves around them, her feet dragging as her shoulders

slump. "I'm with the rebellion now."

"Do you *honestly* expect me to believe that?" They turn with her movement, following her with their eyes as they laugh. "I *know* you, dear girl. Giving up just simply *isn't* in your vocabulary."

"Well, I guess you didn't know me that well," she turns to glare at them. "We weren't friends, Double Trouble. You were only there because I *paid* you to be, and the few things you learned about me were your attempt to 'figure out my character'."

"*Ooo,* touché," the reptilian smirks at her.

The cat girl turns back to the staircase sullenly. "Everything I was before was a lie. I was hurt, but I did it mostly to myself. You were right about one thing, if that makes you feel any better." Here she grinds her teeth as tears form in the corner of her eyes, "I chased everyone away."

The shapeshifter moves a couple steps back to get a good look at the broken feline, and they're shocked by what they find. "You really *are* trying to be good, then?" They blink at her in confusion.

Catra shifts her eyes to look back at them before responding, "I've hurt a lot of people. I'm trying to make it right, but I've only been somewhat successful." The feline crouches down on her haunches and sighs sadly to herself. "I'm no rebel hero by any means, but I've resigned myself to seeing this war through with them… regardless of the outcome."

"I see," Double Trouble tells her, still observing her carefully, but they found everything they needed. "Well then, I will leave you to it."

They walk away then, leaving the cat girl alone with her thoughts. Before returning to the shadows though, they turn back to call out to her, "Don't worry, kitten." When Catra turns her head to meet their eyes, they finish the thought, "Little Miss Brawn-For-Brains wouldn't have let you get close enough to maul her like that if she didn't *want* you to."

The brunette blushes again but offers them a small, somewhat defeated smile, so they make their exit.

End scene.

Double Trouble waits until nightfall, hiding in plain sight, until it's time for them to report in.

When they enter the somewhat private room, they return to their true form and immediately start taking bows, "*Thank you*, thank you."

"I'm guessing you learned what you needed to, then?" Their impatient employer pushes.

"Tsk tsk tsk," Double Trouble stands back up straight and holds out their hand, "Payment first, darling."

There's a sigh followed by a coin bag being dropped into their waiting palm. "Now tell me, what's the plan?"

"Oh, there *is* no plan, princess," here the shapeshifter goes to sit by the makeshift war table.

"What do you *mean* there's 'no plan'?" Queen Glimmer places her hands on her hips and scrutinizes them..

"It's like I said - that broken girl out there isn't *planning* anything," they take a moment to knock over a few of the rebel figurines standing on the map.

"You're wrong," the shorter princess rolls her eyes and goes back to her chair, "You'll just have to try again."

Now it's the reptilian's turn to observe the sparkly princess, "You really *are* that blind, aren't you? Don't even see what's happening

beyond your own nose."

"What's *that* supposed to mean?" She frowns at them as her frustrations grow, "What exactly am I missing?"

"I'm sure you'll figure it out eventually," the shapeshifter stands, preparing their exit, "The important thing to note is-" they pause for dramatic effect, "-Horde Prime is your enemy here… Not Catra. So, you'd be better off focusing your efforts on him."

Double Trouble gives a little wave before Glimmer can offer a rebuttal, "*Do* let me know if you have any more acting gigs for me - it's been fun infiltrating the rebellion again." They chuckle wickedly before changing back into the shape of one of her guards and exiting.

Glimmer sits there, dumbfounded, for a beat before she yells and shoves everything off the table in front of her. *They have to be wrong*, she thinks while pacing. *I'll just have to figure it out myself*.

Once she's made her resolution to get to the bottom of this, she turns to exit the room towards the rear only to stop dead in her tracks… The princess feels her heart sink as her stomach drops. *Oh no…*

"Bow?" she asks the man, timidly. He's standing just around the corner, looking at her with an unreadable expression. "H-How long were you standing there?"

"Long enough," he drops the layout of the woods he was bringing her on the floor, then turns on his heel and leaves.

"Bow!" She runs to the back exit and watches him walk away from her, again. When he doesn't turn back, the Queen sinks down to her knees, drops her face in her hands and begins to cry.

There will be no coming back from this, she thinks and feels herself sink even lower to the ground. *He'll never forgive me*.

Chapter End Notes

Teeheehee. I actually wrote the kiss scene in this chapter pretty early on. I wanna say around the time I was working on chapter 4 or 5 I got the idea for the scene and wrote it down, wanting to fit it in somewhere - although, at the time, I planned for it to take place in Bright Moon. So really, I've been writing the story to lead up to this moment for a while now and plan to build on it after. I hope y'all liked it!

Return to Alwyn Pt. I

Chapter Summary

> So, a couple things to start before I post this - I ended up leaving an important part of the season 5 storyline out by changing the story the way I did, and I've been trying to think of a good way to include it ever since. But then it dawned on me XD I'll send the group back to Alwyn; the "haunted" village from season 2 episode 3 "Signals", which is by far one of my favorite episodes. So these next two chapters were really fun for me to write. I hope y'all enjoy them :)
>
> And secondly - as we get closer to the end, I started getting overzealous and writing a lot more in these chapters than I originally intended. So, some of the chapters got so long, I had to break them up into parts. And to avoid y'all just sitting with only one half of the mission for days, I'm going to be posting the multiple parts together, so... you get Ch. 16 and 17 today :D

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Previously

Glimmer sits there, dumbfounded, for a beat before she yells and shoves everything off the table in front of her. They have to be wrong, she thinks while pacing. I'll just have to figure it out myself.

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Chapter 16

Glimmer barely sleeps that night. She spent a good portion of the evening trying to find the archer to talk to him, to plead her case, but he was nowhere to be found. When she stopped to speak briefly with Adora, she didn't appear to be mad at her, so the Queen can at least be grateful that he hasn't told her yet. That's not to say he won't get around to it though…

It is exactly as he said - she's on the brink of losing all her friends, and for what? For *Catra?*

She's still determined she's right about the Horde commander, and it's only an amount of time before she shows her true colors. Glimmer will do everything in her power to prove her to be the traitor she is, but for the time being… She needs to play it cool. The Queen refuses to lose her closest friends over this. Perhaps she could find someone with a like mind to try and trip the feline up to reveal her plan? That way at least she won't be directly involved. But she can't risk it getting back to Adora or Bow… she's already in enough trouble as it is.

As she's contemplating who would be a good choice for espionage, the princess is interrupted.

"Glimmer!" Entrapta waves over to her from her workshop, "Over here!"

The Queen makes her way over, her thoughts from yesterday still replaying in her head. Aside from the best friend squad drama, they were fortunate to find a few more survivors who escaped the city, but only a few - they can assume anyone else still left out there has been compromised by the Horde, which is hard to think about - her own father being among the several still missing. But they were able to set up some new scouting locations and got a vague idea of where the Horde is heading next. They've completely taken over Bright Moon and appear to be going after the Fright Zone… that one won't be much of a fight since it's been abandoned.

When Glimmer reaches the foot of the mad woman's work station, a purple tendril of hair immediately wraps around her wrist and pulls her toward her screens. "So, I have good news and I have bad news," the Queen rubs her arm when she's released and looks at the information the scientist has gathered. "The bad news is - try as I might, I can't do anything to fight against the chips until I get one to examine. And seeing as how no one brought me anything yesterday, we're stuck there for the time being. I considered the possibility of using the shock batons to fry the chips off, but since we don't know how they're connected, that could do more harm to the host than anything. But the good news is-" here she stops to scroll through the feed of gibberish that's rolling across her screen, "I've finished coding my virus. I believe I can upload this to Horde Prime servers to not only limit his teleporting capabilities but also to secure a back door so we can gather information on his movements."

"That's great!" The Queen smiles, trying to translate the gibberish on the screen. For the first time since the siege, she feels like there may be hope for them yet.

“Oh, well-” the scientist takes the opportunity to scratch her head, “Guess I should’ve clarified - there’s bad news regarding that, too.”

Glimmer groans and face palms, *Of course*. “And what’s the bad news there?”

“Wellllll,” Entrapta looks away and fiddles with some of her tools, “You remember how we made plans for this while we were still operating out of Bright Moon?”

“Yeah,” Glimmer narrows her eyes, wondering where this is going.

“And you remember how our friends were being chipped under our noses?” Entrapta continues, still not looking at her.

“*Yeeeah*,” the Queen has to restrain herself from shaking the scientist so she’ll hurry up and get to the point.

The shorter princess pulls down her welding helmet before turning to face her again, “Well, we’ve always said it seems like Horde Prime has eyes and ears everywhere… My guess is he uses those chips, not only to control the hosts, but also to gather information…”

The sparkly princess sighs and closes her eyes briefly, “So he most likely knows what we’re planning.”

“Yes, and seeing as how this will take a few, if not several, minutes to upload, we’re going to need to gain full access to his mainframe - which would mean I would have to have complete control over one of his spires to tinker with as I see fit…” she pauses for a second, but knows this needs to be said, too, “Which I’m sure are now guarded with hundreds of bots.”

Glimmer drags her hand down her face to try and wipe away the stress she’s feeling, “So what are our options here? Can we take over one of the spires?”

“Unlikely,” Entrapta turns back to her monitors and starts tapping

away, “Even if we had the numbers to take on all those bots, there’s a good chance Horde Prime will just send the rest. Buuuut I have another solution.” She clicks enter on her keyboard and swivels back around to face the taller princess, “Do you know what this is?” she asks while gesturing to the screen.

The Queen takes a moment to study the structure, “It looks… oddly familiar.” She turns her head to glance back over to the scientist, “What is it?”

“It’s a first-one's intergalactic telecommunications device!!!” The purple haired genius raises her helmet and gets more exuberant as the sentence goes on - at the end she’s staring at the taller girl with stars in her eyes. “It would be so *fun* - I mean, a *great* idea to use it for our purposes.”

“Alwyn,” Glimmer says as she stares at the structure - all those memories suddenly flooding back to her. *That seems like forever ago…*

“Oh, so you *have* heard of it?” Entrapta turns to start tapping away at her keyboard again.

“Heard of it?” the Queen lets out a faint laugh, “I’ve *seen* it.”

Suddenly the scientist is standing a few inches from Glimmer’s face. “What was it like?” she asks dreamily.

“Okay,” Glimmer takes a step back and holds her hand up when the other purple haired princess tries to follow. “It just looked like your standard, first-ones structure.”

“And did you try out its telecommunications function? It's got far more range than anything I’ve ever seen,” Entrapta’s eyes get super round again as she hangs on every word.

“Uhh no, we didn’t,” the Queen laughs uneasily, still getting used to her quirky friend again, “We were still lost to despondos at the time and… I don’t know, something was blocking it?”

“Well, that *does* make sense,” the scientist moves back to her research. “Despondos is set apart from the wider universe so it figures you wouldn’t be able to communicate from one to the other.”

“Yeah, I guess,” Glimmer watches the girl for a few moments and, when she realizes the scientist is already engrossed back in her work again, she interrupts. “Entrapta? Do we need to get a group together to go to Alwyn?”

“Yes,” the eccentric genius glances back to her, confused, “I thought that much was obvious?”

The rebel leader rolls her eyes but then her spirits pick up. Quickly glancing around she spots one of the people she's looking for. "Adora!" She yells to get the girl's attention. When the blonde glances over to her from her conversation with Netossa, Glimmer waves her over.

"What's up?" The tall warrior asks once she makes her way to the work station.

"Time for the Best Friends Squad to get back in action!" The Queen throws a punch in the air which results in a few sparkles flying from her fist.

"Oh yeah?" Adora smiles at her friend while glancing over to Entrapta, "What's the job?"

Before she can begin, though, the archer, who she's been looking out for, suddenly makes a reappearance - the man slows to a stop when he sees Glimmer and Adora standing right where he was heading, and the taller princess suddenly feels the need to bolt. The three of them stand there looking at each other awkwardly - Glimmer is looking at Bow with saddened eyes, Bow is ignoring her but keeps glancing at her every so often as he looks between them, and Adora is looking obviously ‘nonchalantly’ at the floor.

“Did you tell him the news?” Entrapta suddenly appears at the Queen’s elbow, causing her to jump.

The rebel leader laughs to cover her nerves, "I was just getting to that-"

"-I need a group to escort me to Alwyn so I can use their telecommunications tower to hack into Horde Prime's system without him noticing," the scientist gives her lab assistant a grin that nearly splits her face in half. She then walks around the group of friends on her hair before returning to her original position by the monitors, "It's going to be *amazing!"* She then immediately gets back to typing.

"I see," the archer looks at Glimmer with unease, "And I'm guessing you're going?"

"Yes," the Queen grins and immediately hooks her elbow with Adora to pin her to her side, "We all are - Best Friend's Squad style."

Bow has his arms crossed at this point; his fingers tapping against his bicep as he considers the idea. While he contemplates, he glances back and forth between the Queen and their friend.

"Please, Bow?" Glimmer face falls somewhat.

Adora, seeing this, immediately jumps in, "Y-yeah, Bow - heh. It'll be fun… just like old times." She doesn't really sound convinced, but she gives him a significant look.

To the girls' surprise, the archer actually starts to grin at the idea, which causes the Queen's spirits to lift again.

"You'll go?" she asks, hopefully.

His smile seems more pressed when he looks at Glimmer, but he concedes. "Yeah… I'll go," he waits a moment before turning his head, "Hey Catra?"

Both Glimmer and Adora immediately tense up, *Wait… what the hell is he doing?*

"Uhh- yeah?" Catra saunters over from where she was stealing a ration bar. She takes a second to look at her captive audience, her eyes maybe lingering on the tall blonde for a second longer - this being the first time she's seen the girl up close since their heated encounter the day before - then she turns back to face the man, "What's up, boss?"

"Glimmer, Adora, and I are going on a mission," he tells the feline - his tone is full of faux excitement as he glances pointedly at the Queen with a raised eyebrow before turning back, "We need to escort Entrapta to a first one's structure in Alwyn… Interested in tagging along?"

Catra was already invested as soon as he said 'Adora'. She gives him a small grin, "Count me in."

"Uhhh," Glimmer lets out a forced, uncomfortable laugh, "We don't really need that many people… Besides, they'll probably need her help on the Fright Zone reconnaissance mission."

"Nooope," the former commander gives her royal highness a taunting look, "They already have plenty of people going, and they're not ready to leave yet. So, even if they *did* need me, which they don't, I'm sure we'll be back before they go."

She turns her eyes back to Adora who immediately blushes and looks down at her feet, memories from yesterday suddenly flooding her mind. The warrior has been avoiding the cat woman, not sure how to process everything that went on in the lower levels just the day before. She swallows thickly and shifts nervously on her feet, trying not to think about how nice it felt to have the lithe brunette pliant underneath her hands and mouth- *What is wrong with me?*

Glimmer doesn't want Catra to go for other, still obvious, reasons.

"That's settled then," Bow has a satisfied smile on his face as he looks to the Queen expectantly.

“Hurray,” Glimmer says sarcastically as she crosses her arms and tries not to sulk.

The four friends go silent then, each one looking at another with conflicting expressions on their faces: Catra stares at Adora longingly, Adora does her best to avoid looking at Catra at all costs while simultaneously looking between her two tense best friends, Glimmer is looking at Bow like a kicked puppy, and Bow has pulled his trackerpad back out so he can avoid her gaze.

This should be fun… right?

After they stand there in awkward silence for several moments, they suddenly hear the click of Entrapta’s recorder. In her hushed voice, she starts annotating her notes just behind them, “Social experiment number 438 - the group of close friends seem to be *uncomfortable* around each other even though they all have significant ties dating back-”

“- *O*- kay,” Catra cuts her off. She goes up to the scientist and physically turns her around before escorting her to the main entrance, “Let’s go, genius.”

“But I didn’t finish my notes!” The scientist complains to the brunette while the rest of the group falls in behind them.

“You can finish them later,” Catra drapes an arm over the shorter girl’s shoulders after flicking the long tendril of hair behind her. She then taps her on the nose with a claw, “Preferably somewhere we can’t hear them.”

Adora can’t help but smile as she watches the once fearsome Horde commander be so good with the shorter girl. Her and Catra have a lot of tension between them right now, but she can still adore the cat woman from afar… right?

As the group heads out on their mission, everyone left behind can hear Entrapta argue all the way out the door.

"If I wait to finish them, it'll jeopardize the accuracy of the experiment, because my memory won't be as precise as present observation!"

"Okay, okay," Catra chuckles, shaking her head as she knows she'll never win an argument with this one.

Glimmer ends up teleporting the group a little ways outside of Alwyn. The spooky farming village is one of the few locations they've recently lost touch with, so they'll have to be careful as they approach. So far there doesn't seem to be any Horde spires in the general vicinity, but something must have happened to the village, otherwise they would've heard from them by now.

As the woods start to thin, they know they're getting close. Thankfully this time they're visiting the orchard in the daylight hours, but even so… The sky is covered with thick, overcast clouds. The little sunlight that's burning through, coupled with the iridescence of the magical forest, gives the town an eerie blue tint. And what's worse? The entire ground is covered in a thick fog that's drifted over from the nearby lake. So while it is daytime, the village looks just as creepy as it did the last time they were here.

When they stop just outside the treeline to examine the town for life, Glimmer has a flashback of their prior visit and she visibly shudders, wondering if this is such a good idea after all.

"You alright there, Sparkles?" Catra asks with a hint of amusement.

"Shut up," Glimmer throws over her shoulder.

"Does anyone see anything?" Adora feels her own shoulders tensing up. Though they are very aware of what made this town

‘haunted’ before, it doesn’t help the general creepiness of the place.

“It’s hard to see with the fog,” Bow has his bow and arrow at the ready, but so far he doesn’t see any bots… or people for that matter.

Adora almost jumps out of her skin when she feels something brush against her hand. “Easy,” Catra whispers as she captures the blonde’s fingers with her own. When she looks over to see the concern written across the shorter girl’s features, she relaxes a little bit. The cat woman glances forward to make sure the others are preoccupied before turning back to the flighty girl, “Are you okay?”

The warrior swallows down her nerves, and offers the former commander a forced smile and a nod. She then squeezes the hand in her own before letting go and stepping up behind the others. It’s not that she doesn’t want to hold Catra’s hand - in fact, she’d very much like that - but right now, she needs to focus… And being so close to the woman who she was very heatedly lip locked with the day before- She shakes her head before thoughts of yesterday come flooding back. *No- focus*, the soldier scolds herself.

The brunette tries to hold her crestfallen expression at bay as she watches the princess flee her presence once again. She knows she pushed the girl too fast in the basement the day prior, but she was hoping maybe it didn't completely obliterate all the progress they made - now she's not so sure.

When Adora feels a bit more settled, she glances back to make sure the cat girl is following and gives her a more authentic grin. “It’s just the last time we were here… it was- interesting.”

Catra raises an eyebrow at her, “Interesting, how?” She takes a second to look at the others, “Why’re you all so tense? …There’s nothing out there.”

"*I'm* not tense," the group immediately shushes the scientist who spoke at full volume, making them all jump. She recalibrates and speaks a bit softer, "I concur with Catra - I don't see any movement out there. Let's go!"

"Not just yet," Bow swallows uncomfortably and turns to answer Catra's question. "This town is said to be haunted."

"*Buuut* -" Adora cuts in, looking to alleviate any worry, "It's not actually."

"Right… it isn't," the archer lets out a breath and feels his shoulders relax a bit. "The telecommunications device Entrapta is looking to use was turned on the last time we were here, and- I don't know. It was just spooky, is all."

"Spooky *how?"* Catra doesn't think she's ever had this much trouble getting the three best friend's to spit words out.

"We were seeing things and hearing things, okay?" Glimmer finally tells her, impatiently. "Now, let's go - the sooner we get this over with, the sooner we can leave this creepy place."

Catra rolls her eyes but falls in line as the group starts to move. "Sounds like the story of the Invisible Princess, if you ask me."

Adora gasps comically and claps a hand over her mouth as she looks at the girl with wide eyes, "I forgot about the Invisible Princess!" She whisper-yells.

"For fucks sake," Glimmer grumbles as they edge around the first house, still looking out for any signs of life, "Not this shit again." She doesn't need any assistance with feeling uneasy here.

Bow knows he'll regret asking but does anyway once he's stopped at the first corner, "What's the story of the Invisible Princess?"

Catra takes the opportunity to creep up to him in the fog - she gets down on all fours and scurries over to him smoothly, giving her the appearance of someone floating over the ground. Now

that she stands at the front of the group she faces them with her shoulders bunched up and her arms sticking out and bent at the elbows so she can bare her claws at them. "They say that she haunts you before she strikes," she wiggles her fingers at them with a devilish grin, "Moving chairs and whispering over your shoulder until you think you're going mad." She starts stalking towards the group as they gulp and huddle closer together, "You'll run as fast as you can, and hide in the most unreachable spots, but she'll always find you… And *then* -"

The feline stops, mid-story and straightens up as she looks back the way they came. Her ears are perked up and she loses some of her color, suddenly folding into herself, "D-D-Did you guys hear that?"

"Knock it off, Catra," Glimmer bites off and removes herself from the group to go stand off with her.

"I'm not kidding," the brunette swallows thickly, her eyes still fixed on the Whispering Woods. Everyone slowly turns to look, and while they don't see any movement, it definitely suddenly feels like the trees are closing in on them.

Bow gulps and the Queen suddenly looks unsure of herself, but continues to argue with the Horde commander nevertheless, "Well, *I* didn't hear anything."

"Catra has better hearing than us," Adora's eyes are still fixed on the woods as she stands there hugging herself. Everyone's on edge now… everyone except-

"What are we all standing around for?" Entrapta inspects them curiously. She points with her hair and starts marching further into the village with her trackerpad, "The first one's ruin is *this* way!"

Everyone tries to shake off their fear and continue forward with the scientist - though several of them keep making glances back behind them.

“Should we, um- maybe check the houses?” Bow asks after a moment of peering at darkened windows, waiting to see eyes staring back at him. “Make sure there’s no one home?”

“I am *not* going into one of these creepy ass houses,” Catra adamantly refuses, but relaxes a bit when Adora grasps her shoulder and squeezes gently.

“That won’t be necessary,” Entrapta continues to move forward without watching where she’s going - never taking her eyes off her trackerpad. “I’m not seeing any heat signatures where we are.”

The other four collectively let out a sigh of relief and continue in silence. Once they know there really is nothing out there, the creepy town is a little easier to walk through - a *little*.

As they cross between rows of houses, a slight breeze picks up, carrying with it dust from the grounds and the abandoned homes - Catra has never been good with dust.

“Ah…Ah- *pew!”*

“Awww,” Bow’s eyes suddenly widen as he looks at the feline adoringly, “That’s your sneeze?”

“What about it?” She continues walking while rubbing her nose.

“It’s just- so- *cute!”* he gushes to Adora’s never ending amusement. *It is a cute sneeze,* she thinks, but she’s never actually been dumb enough to tell the cat girl that.

The woman immediately glares at the archer and lands a solid punch to his arm, “It’s a normal sneeze!” She then continues forward with the rest of the group, trying to avoid snapping at the taller girl’s friend.

“I can’t believe the *entire* time you’ve been trying to kill us, you’ve had the *cutest* sneeze of all time!” The archer has his fists balled

up on either side of his face while he coos at the cat girl - Adora can't help but giggle at them this time.

Catra immediately turns to face the asshole, stopping him in his tracks - her glare set with her hair and tail puffed up, "I- am not-*CUTE!"*

Adora is still giggling, but Glimmer rolls her eyes and reaches out to pull Entrapta to a stop.

Bow doesn't back down, though, adoration scrunching up his face even more, "The angrier you get, the cuter you *are!"*

Catra growls and pounces at the audacious man, who easily steps out of the way. She slides across the ground and turns, ready to strike again, but then her ears flick as she picks up a noise-

She shoots back up into a standing position and this time looks down one of the rows of empty houses, "Guys?" She can't stop the trepidation from leaking out into her voice.

"What is it?" The blonde warrior suddenly loses her amusement and steps over to the girl's side.

Catra swallows and points with one of her claws, "I d-definitely heard voices coming from down there." She feels her frame slightly shaking, "But now there's nothing," she turns to look at Adora worriedly, "Am I going crazy?"

The taller girl's eyes widen as she grasps the feline's shoulders - she's starting to feel tense again herself, "Like in the story of the Invisible Princess!?" Bow, shuddering, immediately pulls out his weapon and starts looking for enemies.

"Oh, for crying out loud," Glimmer steps towards the girls, getting more and more tired of their familiarity, and pushes them apart. "*Enough* with the ghost stories," she glares at both of them, "Entrapta *just said* there's nothing out there."

"Well, maybe I-"

"-AHH!" the Queen screams and spins around just to find the scientist there - she had walked quietly up behind her and spoke at a normal volume just over her shoulder. She pauses for a second and rests her hand over her heart while she tries to calm her breathing, as well as her anger at the two idiots chortling behind her. "Entrapta," Glimmer says warningly, "Please - *don't do that*." Once her breathing has returned to normal, she tries again in a calmer tone, "Now, what were you saying?"

Entrapta looks confused, but finishes the thought, "I was just saying I spoke too soon… about there not being anyone out there, I mean."

Adora immediately loses her amusement again and slaps both hands on either side of her face, trying to contain her terror. "... *What?*" the other three begin to look around, nervously.

"Yeah, see-," Entrapta holds up her trackerpad, acting very nonchalant given the subject, and points to a glowing dot on her map, "Right there - That's definitely a heat signature, but it's all the way on the other side of the village so…" She puts her trackpad back down, "Can we go now? I have things to do."

Everyone nods and takes a breath, trying to relax again-

"WHAT WAS THAT?!"

And everyone is suddenly back on edge - Glimmer pulled up some sparkle blasts, ready to fire, Catra jumped on Adora's back, and the taller girl appeared to be trying to karate chop something with her eyes closed. Bow, the one who had exclaimed, is pointing in the direction they were going with a look of terror on his face. But when Entrapta inspects the area, she comes up empty. She turns back to the other four, scratching her head, curiously, "What did you see?"

They all start to relax again, seeing nothing to worry about. "I just- I saw something walking in front of those homes up there,"

Bow's still pointing in that direction, but he seems more confused now than scared.

"Well, I don't know what to tell you," the scientist takes a second to point at her pad again while Glimmer releases the power in her hands and Adora eases Catra back to the ground. "Data never lies."

"Bow," Glimmer sighs and takes a second to pinch the bridge of her nose, "I think the device has been turned back on."

The archer drops his head in his hands and does his best to calm down, "I think you're right."

"What does this device *do* exactly?" Catra shudders, trying to fight off the last of her jitters.

"It was used for communication across long distances," Bow starts to explain as the group moves forward again, "But a lot more powerful than anything you and I have ever used."

"Yes, something this size would allow you to communicate across *galaxies*," Entrapta lifts herself off the ground with her hair and gestures out towards space.

"Seriously?" The brunette looks skeptical.

"Yeah," Adora sighs, finally starting to feel relaxed again as she glances over to the shorter girl, "The reason we're all seeing and hearing things is because the device is malfunctioning - it was doing that last time, too."

"Anyone who used it to send a message to someone far away- those messages were lost. And seeing how the messages are in the forms of holograms, they're just… trapped here, walking and talking and dancing. Reeeeally creepy," Bow concludes.

As the group gets closer and closer to the point of origin, Entrapta and Catra start to see what they're talking about. Although, unlike before, there is no interference, so the images and voices

are crystal clear… It almost feels like these holograms are the people who usually live here, walking around and talking to the air. It's strange.

"So maybe nothing happened to the villagers that lived here-" the lithe feline stops to watch a holographic woman walking past her, "-they were just creeped out by the living dead."

"Let's hope so," Bow comments and then points up ahead, "I believe that's the tower you're looking for."

Entrapta looks up from her trackerpad and laughs maniacally as she takes off towards it. The group watches her go and then take off after her. The scientist wastes no time getting settled in front of the communications relay and immediately hooks up her pad to the system.

As she plugs away, Glimmer turns to Bow with concern on her face, "I think… I think we should go make sure that person is safe."

Adora's head snaps in her direction so fast she doesn't know how it's still attached, *"What?"*

Catra groans and drops her head in her hands, "*Please* tell me we are not traipsing through this creepy ass farmland looking for someone who probably doesn't want to be found?"

"I didn't say it was a person," Entrapta remarks off-handedly, and the rest of the group gape at her back.

"Yeeep, *no* way," the feline shakes her head vehemently.

Adora shudders and looks between the other two.

Bow sighs and rubs his face, "She's right." Glimmer perks up at that, and he offers her a small smile before turning to the others, "We at least need to check and see if they need help. You don't have to come if you don't want to - I'm sure Entrapta wouldn't mind someone watching her back-"

“No, I’m perfectly safe here, besides,” the mad genius takes a second to stroke the tower lovingly, “I’m going to be a while… And also, I have ear pieces!” She takes a second to toss each of them their own coms, so they can stay in touch with her, and each other, should they get split up. “I’ll monitor you from here and let you know if I see anything dangerous!”

The rest of the group put on their coms and shrug at each other. “Okay Entrapta… we’ll be close in case you need us,” Bow tells her before the group makes their way to the other side of the tower.

Catra watches them suspiciously, looking back every so often. “So, you guys really just march towards uncertain death without a plan… ever?”

The other three glance back at her and then at each other before continuing on their way, “Yeah, that about sums it up.”

The brunette rolls her eyes and grumbles after them, “Honestly, what did I expect?”

The group march ahead in search of this mysterious life form. They have no idea who or what they’re looking for, but once they find them, they can get the hell out of here.

And not a moment too soon, Catra complains internally as she catches up to the others.

She is *beyond* ready for this nightmare to be over.

Chapter End Notes

What'd ya think?

Return to Alwyn Pt. II

Previously

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Chapter 17

The four friends continue on their journey through the abandoned village.

The holograms don't necessarily become less creepy because they know what they are, but at least now they can try to ignore them. As they get closer to the edge of the village, the less and less of them they see… only catching a glimpse of someone walking out of the corner of their eye every so often.

“How are we supposed to find anyone like this? It’s not like we can shout and announce our presence to whoever it is in case they’re chipped,” Catra complains while peeking in one of the darkened windows.

“That’s a good point,” Bow stops to glance around, “We can cover more ground if we split up.”

The feline’s hair and tail immediately puff up and she ducks her head down, “Please tell me you’re joking?”

“No, that’s a good idea, Bow,” Glimmer steps up to grasp his arm before looking at the other two, “You two story tellers can handle this row - we’ll take the next one over.” Before anyone can even say boo about it, the Queen is dragging the archer away to their section; Adora and Catra both watch them go, feeling trepidation wash over them.

Adora swallows, not prepared to be left alone with the cat girl so spontaneously seeing how she's still not ready to address her evident weakness when the brunette is around. But she squares her shoulders and steels her reserve before turning to face Catra, “We got this. You take this house.” She gestures to the house standing behind the girl then points down a little farther, “And I’ll take that one.”

The blonde immediately turns and marches off, leaving Catra to gape after her. “How have you people survived this long… seriously?” she calls after her before she shakes her head and then turns to look at her house.

Wonderful, the brunette gulps.

As soon as Adora enters the home she’s to inspect, she instantly loses all her bravado from before. *Why did I suggest this?* Unlike last time, it’s apparent these houses have been vacated for a while - the food left out on the tables is molded and rotting. The only sound she can really hear is from the flies buzzing about,

looking for sustenance. Adora tries not to gag while she moves into the next room.

When she spots a family photo collecting dust on one of their side tables, she feels saddened. It looks like they left without even packing. The lone warrior takes a moment to pick up and examine the frame - it was a family of four in the picture: two dads and two kids. She feels her heart squeeze painfully before she sets it back down, hoping they'll be able to return for it someday. She also hopes the family is somewhere safe and not under the control of Horde Prime.

The princess continues through the house at a snail's pace - outside of the moldy food and the dust, the place looked fairly homey. It was well lived in and well cared for. Having a house and kids was never something she could think about before, and now she can't help but wonder what it would be like. Her thoughts, as always, drift back to the former commander, and she tries to scold herself, but can't help but think about that intoxicating kiss again…

What was she thinking?

Yes, the two women were finally starting to mend their friendship again - things were even starting to feel back to normal, like they never were apart. But goofing around on the job is a far cry from making out with the cat woman as if her life depended on it. Adora licks her lips subconsciously. It was so easy for her to fall into it, too… too easy. She was just laying there, thinking about what it felt like to kiss this woman she's probably wanted most of her life, when Catra latched onto her in the span of a heartbeat - and Adora had absolutely no qualms about it. She instantly gave herself over to her more primal instincts and was far too willing to let her heart and mind melt at the girl's touch. That's not being safe - that's actually the opposite of playing it safe.

It was a nice kiss though… Adora can't help but daydream about just how nice it was.

"Hey"

"AHHH!" Adora immediately spins around, swinging - fortunately Catra is quick enough to capture the wrist before the girl's fist connects with her face.

"Whoa, whoa," the feline holds onto her until she can calm down, "Sorry, I thought you heard me come in."

The princess gulps down air like her life depends on it. When she's feeling a little more put together, she pulls her arm out of her grasp, "Yeah, I was just… deep in thought, I guess."

"I don't know how you're calm enough to do that right now," Catra shudders looking around the abandoned home, "I practically ran through mine. But uh- we need to go."

"What- Why?" Adora is suddenly alarmed again.

"Look, I don't know if I'm just freaking out enough that I'm hearing things, but uh-" the cat woman looks towards the window behind her nervously. "I thought I heard someone screaming… and I doubt it's one of those holograms."

The warrior feels her muscles tense up as she thinks of their friends. She immediately grabs ahold of the lithe brunette's hand and starts dragging her out of the house behind her while she uses her com, "Glimmer? Bow?... Entrapta- Are you there?"

She doesn't get a response from the first two, but after a moment, the earpiece comes to life as Entrapta answers her, *"I'm still here. …Should I not be?"*

Adora shakes her head at the question and keeps pushing forward, pulling the reluctant cat girl in the direction the other two drifted off in. "We're not getting a response from Glimmer or Bow, can you see where they are??" She can't keep the worry from her voice.

"I saw the four of you split up earlier-," she pauses to check something, *"Yes, I see them. They're approximately 2 kilometers southwest of you… Wait, they're moving really fast - Why are they running?"*

The warrior feels her stomach drop and instantly starts charging in that direction. "Come on!" She yells back to Catra who's quick on her heels. It doesn't take long for the screams and shouts to reach their ears, and they go tearing through the rows of houses to get to them. Once they make it to the row where their friends seem to be, the screams have died down to simple sounds of distress. Adora glances around harriedly until she finds her two friends hugging each other on the ground not too far away.

"Glimmer! Bow!" the taller girl immediately rushes over to them. When they see her, they jump up and grasp her in an embrace. "I'm so glad you're okay! You weren't answering my calls," she says as she pulls back. Catra stands back, watching them with a small frown pulling at her lips.

Bow immediately reaches up for his earpiece only to find it isn't there, then he looks for Glimmer's, "They must've fallen out during the struggle. Boy, are we glad to see you."

"It was awful," Glimmer says, still teary eyed.

"What struggle?" Catra asks as she looks around and finds no one there.

Glimmer and Bow both look at each other with horror on their faces, before Bow answers her, "We need to get out of here. I have no idea what that was, but it *definitely* wasn't friendly."

"We were just walking in between houses a couple of rows over when these spikes started coming out of nowhere!" The Queen gasps out.

"Yeah, they shot out of the walls of the homes, nearly impaling us but we got away," Bow wipes his brow but his wide eyes are still

scanning the area for enemies, “Then when we stopped here to catch our breath, Glimmer went to lean on this wall for support-”

“-and I fell in!” the purple hair princess cries, “It’s like the wall was trying to eat me!”

"*Eat* you, princess? *Really?*" The cat woman teases, but can't help but glance around her nervously.

"*You* weren't there!" Glimmer shouts at her.

“Okay okay, easy guys - we don't need to be fighting each other when we have something else stalking us. But yes - she fell into the wall and then I pulled her out and that’s where you found us,” Bow tells them before adding, “I’m starting to think this place really is haunted.”

Catra shudders and hugs herself while glancing warily at the human eating wall, “Yeah, no kidding.”

"Hello.”

“AHHHHHH!!” All four of them scream and turn around, back to back, looking for a ghost, only to realize it was Entrapta trying to reach them through the speaker function on Adora’s com.

The tall rebel places a hand over her heart and takes a deep breath to calm herself before answering. “What is it, Entrapta?”

“Energy signal just ahead of you. Go through the barn doors.”

“What-” Adora looks to the others in confusion, “What are you-” Catra tugs on her sleeve and points to the creepy, broken down barn not too far off.

“That wasn’t there a second ago,” the cat girl mutters fearfully. “We’re not seriously going in there, are we?”

The rest of the group shudders as they look at the unsound structure - the fog surrounding the broken windows and loose

boards make the place appear that much more ominous. The warrior swallows down her nerves before telling them, "Entrapta says it's this way… we should at least check it out."

Bow and Glimmer concur with Adora and fall in behind her, leaving Catra to look at them incredulously. "Seriously? *Uggghh,* come *on* ." She begrudgingly tags along, definitely not wanting to be left outside alone.

The group approach the barn and pause just outside the doors, glancing at each other with apprehension written all over their faces before proceeding onwards. Once they step inside, they're immediately glued to each other. The barn is full of debris, and what's worse? The fog from outside has seeped in through the loose boards and cracks in the walls. That coupled with no indoor lighting, made it nearly impossible to see.

Catra is full on shuddering at this point but keeps herself pressed into Adora's side as the four try to look around. Glimmer pulls up a light and casts it to the roof to help illuminate the area, but it doesn't help much with the dense fog.

"Hello?" Bow sounds very timid with his shoulders tense and back straight as he calls out into the fog. When he doesn't get an answer, he puts on an air of confidence, "Okay guys, lets just try moving up a little and see if we can see anything further in."

The four move together, walking slowly forward into the fog. Obviously once they're inside it, it gets even harder to see, but they keep moving forward hoping they'll hit something or hear something eventually. They get more nervous with every step and keep darting their eyes everywhere waiting for something to pop out at them.

After several moments, Catra can't help but speak up, "Guys, what is this? There's no way this barn is that big… we should've reached the other side by now, right?"

Glimmer shudders but keeps them moving, "Maybe we're almost there?" She doesn't sound convinced.

"Hi-ya."

Everyone jumps about a foot in the air when Entrapta's voice comes out of Adora's earpiece again.

"I swear I'm going to smash that thing into a thousand pieces," Catra grumbles while petting down her fur from where it was standing on end. Bow and Glimmer both shake off the scare and turn to hear what the scientist has to say.

"What is it now, Entrapta?" Adora asks, slightly out of breath.

"Well, I just wanted to let you know that the virus has been uploaded! I'm ready to go whenever you are… I'll just keep doing research on this old thing until you come back for me."

Everyone breathes a sigh of relief. Finally, they can get out of here.

"Good to hear, Entrapta - We'll head back now… and get out of this creepy barn," she adds on the last part, speaking for all of them.

"I'm sorry, what barn?"

Catra eyes furrow and she immediately turns her com on to speak, "What do you *mean*, 'what barn'? The one *you* told us to walk into."

"That wasn't me… This is the first time I've spoken since you guys were still split up."

A pit of terror slowly starts to grow in their stomach's. If that wasn't Entrapta they heard, then what-

"-By the way, who's your new friend?"

"W-w-what do you mean?" Glimmer asks, nervously, "It's just the four of us."

"I hate to disagree - but there's a definite heat signature… right in front of you."

The four friends slowly turn or lift their heads to look ahead of them again only to find a 6 foot tall alien being with luminescent hair that seems to move on its own, like a liquid or a flame, covering the creature's entire head.

"AHHHHHHHHHH!!!"

The other three immediately rear back as if to flee the creature's presence, but Catra breaks through them and immediately tackles the thing… only when they hit the ground? They completely disappear.

"Catra?" Adora calls worriedly and quickly falls to the ground where she should have landed, searching through the fog desperately. "Catra?!"

"Adora? I'm here *… I-I'm back in the woods."*

"WHAT? Okay, hold on, I'm coming!" The warrior immediately charges back the way they came and gets back to the front barn doors in no time. When she hears a timid, "Hurry," come through the com, she tears the doors open and runs out - Glimmer and Bow struggle to keep up.

Catra sits on the ground, trembling, as the alien creature suddenly shape-shifts into a cat-like figure, only much bigger than she is, and roars at her. The feline gulps and watches the big cat stalk around her, never looking away from her… but then suddenly it vanishes into thin air.

What?

The brunette looks around her frantically, trying to figure out where it went, only for it to materialize again, inches from her

face… its once blue mane is now red to match its menacing stare.

The trio of friends are running blindly back in the direction of the woods when they hear a scream. Adora instantly feels her heart stop and tears spring to her eyes as she alters course and goes sprinting in the direction she heard it. "Catra?! Hang on!"

Catra vaguely hears the shout off in the distance, but she's too focused on the alien creature getting closer and closer to her. She can't stop her trembling and she's too frightened to move. When a gust of wind blows past them, she's almost shocked out of her frozen state, but still can't flee as a sneeze suddenly comes over her.

"Ahh-ahhh- *PEW!* "

For some reason the sneeze distracts the creature and it rears back, suddenly shifting into a much smaller cat - its mane back to its original blue color.

"Ahh-ahhh- *PEW!* "

The Horde commander is surprised to hear her sneeze mimicked right back at her in the same fashion. Suddenly this fearsome creature seems a lot less intimidating. When it sits back and meows at her casually, Catra even feels her mouth twitching up into a small smile. *Okay, let's just roll with this.*

Adora, Bow, and Glimmer have finally broken through the treeline and are searching frantically until they find the feline a little ways inland. When she spots her, the blonde soldier immediately calls out to her, "Catra! Catra! Hang.. on?"

When they enter the clearing, they all stop and stare curiously at the former force captain as she sits on the ground, gently stroking the alien that now appears to be… a cat??

"Are you- Are you *petting* the thing that's been trying to kill us?" Adora asks her, genuinely curious.

Catra's face hardens as she speaks through clenched teeth, "I'm *trying* something here, if you didn't notice."

Adora has to cover her mouth to stifle the giggles while Glimmer rolls her eyes. Bow's the only one that has any comment on it, "That's just- so- *cute* ."

The cat girl growls again; she's getting sick and tired of this asshole. "It's *not* cute!"

As soon as the words are out, she realizes it was the wrong move to make. The alien pet's mane suddenly turns fiery red again as it growls at the newcomers. The warrior quickly loses her giggles and steps forward towards the brunette. "Get away from her!" She yells at the alien cat.

"Whoa, whoa, hang on," Catra's up now, standing between her and the alien, attempting to speak in a calmer tone, "Look, I'm sorry I got angry - it's something I'm working on."

"Awww, you are?" Adora can't help the pleased smile that comes over her face.

"*Yes*, so would you *please*-" the former commander feels herself becoming angry again and has to stop to take a moment to breathe before she starts over, "Yes, I am. I think this thing responds to emotions, so can you *please* not give me a hard time right now?"

"Oh, sorry, yeah - Go ahead," the taller girl smiles at her fondly, earning her an eye roll from the cat woman.

Catra turns to go coax the alien back over to her with soothing tones and calming words, "It's okay. We're not gonna hurt you."

The cat slowly walks up to her again and directly into her awaiting palm. When the two connect again, there's a blinding light that encompasses everyone in the clearing before it fades again. When it's over, Bow can't help but ask, "What was that?"

The alien pet starts meowing at Catra then, who immediately backs up away from it. "Uhh, what the *fuck?"*

"What's happening?" Adora takes a step forward but tries not to get too close.

"It's talking. *Please*, tell me you can hear it talking?" When the other three shake their heads at her, she can't help but ask, "Why is everything with you guys so weird?"

"I think it imprinted on you…" Bow says with surprise coloring his features. "It trusts you."

"Yeah? Well, it shouldn't," Catra concludes before the alien pet starts meowing at her again. She listens for a moment and then starts to translate. "It says it's name is Melog. He comes from a planet called Krytis where he and his family lived for centuries… before the One who Destroys came." Melog transforms then, into the shape of Horde Prime.

The friends have never laid eyes on him before, but they recognize him right away. The image holds the same eerie quality of the clones.

"He came to their planet to destroy everything they'd built. They fought him off for a long time, and finally scared him away. Horde Prime couldn't defeat their magic - he couldn't fight it, couldn't stand against it. So he left, taking Melog with him as a trophy… the last of his kind." Adora places her hand over her heart at the news before Catra continues, "He's been a prisoner for some time now, and only recently managed to escape when Horde Prime's armies got distracted with our planet. Now, he's all alone… but at least he's free."

The blonde princess steps forward then and slowly lowers herself down besides Catra to face their new alien friend. "I'm sorry that happened to you… But Etheria has magic, too? This could be your new home, if you want it. You're welcome to stay as long as you need."

Melog steps up to Adora then and sniffs curiously at her face before he licks her cheek. The princess laughs and pets his head before calling on Entrapta.

"Hey, Entrapta? We're on our way back… and we're bringing a friend."

"Oh good - and when you get back I should have some interesting news for you."

"Thank fuck this nightmare is over," Glimmer is exasperated, "Let's get out of here."

The four friends, along with their new pet, trudge along back to the center of the village. Now that Melog is no longer haunting them, the scariest thing about the place now is the holograms. Speaking of which - "Adora, if Entrapta is done with the tower, can you *please* turn those off?" Glimmer groans.

The taller girl laughs and walks over to place her hand on the tower, effectively shutting it down along with all the creepy holographic people. Now that the place seems a little more normal, they all turn to the scientist. "So what did you find?" Adora asks.

"Interestingly- or maybe not so interesting and maybe more bad? Whatever the case, I found out why the tower was turned back on." Entrapta starts off as she's still putting away her tools.

"Really?" Bow inquires, though the fact that this is bad news probably means it's not something he wants to know.

"Yes. As it turns out, Horde Prime is looking for something, and he was looking through this communications system to find it," the scientist continues.

"Why would Horde Prime be interested in old first one's tech?" the Queen chimes in.

“Well, do you remember what Melog said? About him not being able to fight magic? Maybe he’s trying to find a way to defeat us,” the warrior wonders out loud.

“Well, if you let me finish I could tell you,” Entrapta cuts in, shutting them up, “But yes, I think he is looking for something to defeat the rebellion. He did find an answer, but from what I can tell, he doesn’t know where to locate it.” She holds up her trackerpad to show them. “There’s a first one’s ruin that’s sending out some kind of message, and while it can’t be accessed from here, I suspect it has something to do with the Heart of Etheria. In which case, we could be in very big trouble.”

“If Horde Prime gets his hands on the Heart of Etheria, we’re all doomed,” Bow states gravely.

“Yes, but like I said, he doesn’t know where to find it,” she swipes over to the next screen that has floating symbols flowing in the circle. “You see this? I discovered long ago that each of the first one’s temples has a different marking on it. A locator, if you will. You see this one?” She stops the feed on a marking that looks very familiar to all of them.

"Light Hope… that's the temple where I did my training,” Adora is a little speechless. How has she never realized this?

“Exactly! This is the symbol for the first one’s ruin that’s close to the Fright Zone… You know the one you demolished?” The scientist directs the question at the blonde princess, but doesn’t wait for an answer, “So this-” She stops to point to another symbol, “Is the one we’re looking for and it just so happens that it’s not too far from here.”

“So, we need to get to this temple and secure whatever information is there so that Horde Prime can’t get his hands on it,” Bow states to the group, a determined look on his face.

“I see no reason why we can’t make a detour on the way home,” Glimmer tosses him a smile.

Catra rolls her eyes at the two before turning to leave, “Let’s get this over with then.” She reaches over to pet Melog on the head. “As long as it’s away from here, I’m good with that.”

Adora chuckles and catches up with her, walking on the other side of Melog while the others bring up the rear.

The Best Friends Squad is officially back in action.

With Enemies Like These

Chapter Notes

> This is another two-parter, so I'm posting 18 and 19 today :) hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Previously

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Chapter 18

The Best Friend's Squad are trudging through the forest after Entrapta who's leading them with her trackerpad. The plan is to get to the ruin, get the information, and then bolt before Horde Prime even knows they're there. It should be easy enough.

Glimmer is keeping a close eye on the three up ahead. They narrowly escaped their haunting experience at Alwyn, but now that they have, she's back to scrutinizing the former Horde commander. The Queen narrows her eyes at her back - the feline had just said something to cause her blonde friend to throw her head back and laugh. *I sincerely doubt she's that funny*, Glimmer fumes, but she rolls her eyes and falls back. She waits for Bow to catch up and falls into step with him while he continues to futz around with his trackerpad.

"Were you able to reach them?" Glimmer asks him quietly.

"Yeah," Bow sighs heavily before stowing the trackerpad away. "I let them know we'll be a little longer before we get back."

"I hope everything's going okay with the other group," the Queen reaches for his hand and holds onto it.

Bow looks over to her and offers a small smile before he squeezes her hand and let's go.

That's progress at least, she tries to swallow down her disappointment.

She is drawn out of her reverie by the cat woman's obnoxious laugh, and she looks forward again to see the two women chortling about something. Glimmer sighs, knowing she has to do this, but also knowing it won't end well. "Bow, I have to ask…" she waits for him to look over to her, "Should we send Catra back to the safe house for the time being? I'm not saying we should kick her out-" She immediately puts her hands up when she sees his annoyed expression, "Just that we're about to learn some secrets - probably secrets Horde Prime doesn't want us to know - and maybe she shouldn't be privy to that information just yet?"

The Queen gulps when Bow turns to face forward again, shaking his head before slowing to a stop. *Here we go…*

"You need to give her a chance, Glimmer - Like Double Trouble told you, she's *not* our enemy." With that final word, he gives her

one of his patented looks of disappointment before he turns back to catch up to their friends.

One step forward, two steps back… The Queen feels her shoulders droop and continues after him. Regardless of if her friends are behind her, she will not let Catra get the best of them. *She'll show her true colors eventually*, she thinks, silently seething, *and if I need to give her a push, so be it.*

When the duo join the rest of the group, the former Horde commander glances back at them. And when she meets the icy princess's glare, she immediately loses her smile and rolls her eyes before facing forward again. "Are we almost there?" She asks Entrapta with exasperation.

"Just a little while longer," the scientist answers without looking back.

Glimmer tries her best to sound pleasant, but she's pretty sure everyone can hear the sarcasm behind her words, "Why, you have somewhere more pressing to be?" The barely disguised contempt causes Bow to drop his face into his waiting palm.

"Of *course* not, your royal sparkliness," Catra bites back - without missing a beat, she turns around and starts walking backwards so she can throw Glimmer a saccharine smile. "Where else would I rather be than out here with *you?* " When Adora elbows the cat woman and gives her a chastising look, she rolls her eyes again and turns back around. "But I'm sure *you* have more pressing matters to tend to - why don't you head on back and we'll let you know if we find anything."

"Oh, I'm *right* where I want to be," Glimmer has quickly lost her sarcasm and takes on a more aggressive tactic, "*Someone* here needs to keep you in check."

"Glimmer-" Bow tries to corral her.

"-And what's *that* supposed to mean?" Catra immediately spins around and stops in her tracks to face the Queen - Melog stops

with her as his mane turns red.

"Catra-" Adora also stops and puts her hand on the brunette's shoulder at the same time Entrapta interrupts her by saying, "Uh oh," while looking down at her trackerpad.

"You know *exactly* what I mean," Glimmer takes a step forward, not backing down from the challenge.

"Guys," Bow warns, moving forward to get between them if need be. Catra takes a step forward, too, invading the Queen's space now, "Why don't you explain it to me?"

"GUYS!"

Everyone pauses to look over at Entrapta furiously tapping on her trackerpad, "Something's *wrong!"* The fact that the sometimes obtuse scientist sounds really worried sets the rest of them on high alert.

"What's going on?" Bow turns to her and asks, trying not to freak out.

"Look!" She holds up the trackerpad for them all to see the dozens and dozens and dozens of heat signatures heading right for them on every side. Realizing the danger they're in, they drop their quarrel and immediately start to panic.

"I thought they couldn't teleport just anywhere anymore?!" Glimmer starts.

"They caaan't, but they must've been tracking us from Alwyn since they're also looking for the ruin!"

"Uhhh- guys?" Catra interrupts them, causing them to look up and witness the dozens of clones suddenly breaking the tree line to surround them.

Adora gulps, "That's a lot of clones."

The group of friends suddenly turn back to back to protect themselves as they try to come up with a plan to get out of this.

"Pssst, Sparkles," Catra whisper-yells over to her, "Get us out of here."

"Oh, *now* you want me here," Glimmer grumbles as the rest of the group discreetly start reaching around to grab each other's hands -

Except for Entrapta.

The scientist jumps away from the rest of them before they can take off, squealing, "No, we can't just leave! We're too close! If they beat us there, it'll be too late!"
The feline groans then corrects herself, "Okay, well then, teleport us to the fucking ruin."

"I *can't*," Glimmer spits out through clenched teeth, still keeping a close eye on the clones that appear to only be blocking them in for the moment.

"Why *not?!* " Catra is starting to panic now, her voice ending in a squeak.

"Be*cause* my power only works when I know *exactly* where I'm going, and a glowing dot on an obscure map doesn't tell me much!" The Queen finally turns to snap at the former commander.

"Well, that's a useless power, isn't it?" The feline rolls her eyes.

Adora elbows Catra for the second time and the bickering girls shut up as they turn to watch one of the clones step forward to address them.

"Hello, Adora. At last, we meet," the clone holds his arms out in a welcoming gesture causing the blonde to narrow her eyes suspiciously. His tone almost sounds… joyful? That's when she notices the whites in his eyes that are different from the rest of the clones - but that's the only difference.

Remembering something King Micah said after the attack at Elberon, the tall princess makes a guess, "... Horde Prime?"

The rest of the group glance at her in shock before slowly turning their eyes back to the clone before them.

"Yes, child, you'll have to forgive me for not meeting you for the first time in person. I'd love to shake your hand, but I can't risk any harm to myself, you see." Here the clone, controlled by Horde Prime, smiles creepily at her, "So I decided it would be best for our visit to be brief, with my physical body far, far away from here."

"Really?" Her brows are furrowed and she can't keep the tinge of anger from her voice, "Because I'd *love* to meet you face-to-face."

"Oh, Adora," Horde Prime chuckles, "Enough with these little games. There is nothing you can do to me from here, but I can do something to *you*…" he lets his gaze wander to the rest of the group, "Or perhaps your friends?"

"You leave them out of this!" She yells at him - she'll let Horde Prime touch them over her dead body.

"No need to be fearful, child," he smiles again, "No harm will come to you or your friends… as long as you give me what I want."

The warrior stares at him intensely, deciding the best course of action in case she can't agree to his terms. "And what do you want?"

The smile that still adorns his face grows to twice its size. He steps forward again and this time leans forward, invading the princess's space. "You… will give me… *She-Ra*."

Adora clenches her jaw and narrows her eyes at him. "Never."

The clone chuckles darkly and turns to walk back to the circle, "If that is your choice, then so be it. You rebels have been nothing but an insufferable pain in my side." His joyful tone is lost and

when he turns back around, his face is contorted in anger. "I seek only to bring peace to your world, but you… you wouldn't have that, would you? Well, my days of trying to help you are over. This ends now - And with She-Ra lost? *So* is the rebellion."

The group of friends are back to back again, tensed up and ready to fight.

"De*stroy* them."

With the order, the clones immediately begin to swarm the friends. Adora doesn't hesitate to call on She-Ra and she immediately starts knocking over clones as fast as she can. Entrapta stays in the middle as the others fight around her, but she has her electric taser at the ready if any of them get too close.

Catra gets lost in the crowd - her fighting style being that she leaps from one clone to the next while Melog covers her rear, knocking over any clones that target her. She stabs at the glowing spots at the back of their necks with her claws and that seems to drop them.

"Go for the back of the neck!"

The group hear her instruction, but outside of She'ra, the others are quickly getting overwhelmed.

Fuck. The brunette leaps over to the clone that has Arrow Boy trapped by the neck with his own bow and takes him out. Then she jumps back to the middle to pull Entrapta just behind She-Ra for protection. With She-Ra taking out as many as she can from the front, Entrapta just has to guard her back. And with that, Catra helps the blonde princess take out a few more clones on her side - her side which is thinning out a lot quicker than the rest where more clones are running in out of nowhere.

Catra growls. She jumps back behind Adora and grabs Arrow Boy who's standing in front of Entrapta now, defending them both. "You need to go," she yells at him and pushes him towards

Entrapta who backs up and bumps into Adora. When they turn to watch the feline take out a few more clones swiftly, she yells again, "There's too many of them! We can't keep up. Take Entrapta to the ruin… *Now!"*

She-Ra steps forward, concern written on her face, but Bow stops her.

"Adora, go!" She yells again and glances back to the purple Queen and Melog fighting behind her. "We got this, okay?" She tries to reassure her but doesn't have long before she has to knock a few more clones out. "We'll buy you some time, now go!"

Adora is torn, so is Bow. But when Glimmer also looks at him to give them a reassuring smile before knocking another clone out, he nods and makes a decision. He pulls on She-Ra's arm telling her, "They've got this, Adora. We need you for the ruin, remember? We have to go."

When the blonde takes too long to decide, a few of the clones spot them off to the side and come charging for them. She-Ra knocks them down with her sword, and then gives Bow a nod. He and Entrapta scurry off to the woods with Adora behind them. She takes one more look back and Catra gives her one of her infamous shit eating grins as she and Glimmer make fools of the clones by leaping and teleporting from one place to the next.

Adora smiles then, knowing her friends are going to be okay, and turns to follow the others.

The trio run through the woods as fast as they can, trailing after the glowing dot on Entrapta's trackerpad. "We're getting close!" the scientist calls back to them. *And not a moment too soon*, Adora thinks, picturing her friends back there still fighting to keep the Horde at bay. She glances back for a moment, hoping her friends are okay, when she blindly runs into Bow.

"Oof," the air gets knocked out of her, but she manages to catch the man before they completely topple over. "Bow?" She only ran

into him because he came to a stop while Entrapta walks ahead of them. "What's going on?"

"I- I recognize this place," he glances back at her before moving forward again. "Entrapta," he calls to get her attention, "The entrance is on this side."

The trio move around the suspicious rock formation, and there it stands - the first ones ruin that looks to be built inside of a hill.

"Bow, how did you know this was here?" Adora asks curiously while she looks for the door.

"My dads used to bring me here when I was a kid," the princess can hear the worry in his tone and turns to look back at her friend. Bow continues, "They were excavating this place, looking for first ones artifacts… they live not too far from here."

When the archer stops to look back in the direction of his old home, Adora approaches him and places a hand on his shoulder. "You're worried about them, aren't you?"

Bow pulls out his trackerpad and looks down at it hopelessly. "I've- been trying to reach them," he casts his worried eyes up to the warrior, "They haven't been responding."

"Hey," Adora offers him a small, encouraging smile. "If we make it out of here alive, I don't see why we can't swing by there on our way back to check in???" The archer offers her a brave face and nods his head.

"Hey guys?" Entrapta calls over to them, distracting them, "I think this is the door."

Adora walks over to the structure Entrapta has found, and sure enough, there are the markings. She reaches forward to place her hand on the door and calls out, "Eternia." The trio stand there idly while the structure opens, allowing them all entrance. The place is dark, the only light coming from the luminescent stones lining the hallway as they walk deeper in.

“Do you know where we’re headed?” Adora asks the man since he’s been here before.

“If I remember correctly, this ruin isn’t that large… let’s try a little farther up,” he tells them. As they move forward slowly, Bow shoots out a quick message to the rest of the rebellion to aim for the chips should they encounter any of their corrupted friends - he hopes it finds them okay. Adora sees the worry on his face and asks him softly, “Any word from the others?”

Bow looks grim as he answers, “Not yet… they’re probably just now arriving at the Fright Zone.” Once they exit the hallway, they’re led into a large open room where they slow to a stop. The room is a lot larger which makes it a lot darker than the hallway.

They’re just peering around, trying to figure out which way to go when Bow hears the telltale sound of an arrow being released. “Get down!” He shouts and pulls both Adora and Entrapta to the floor as the arrow flies past them and gets buried in the wall behind them.

“Bow?” They hear a man’s voice up ahead and they all look up to see Bow’s dads emerging from the shadows.

“Lance?? … George?!” the archer exclaims and shoots over to them to embrace them in a hug.

“Bow! Oh, Bow,” his fathers exclaim excitedly, so relieved to see their son. “Oh, and friends?” Lance asks, “I’m so sorry, I hope we didn’t hit you?”

“Hi dads,” Adora waves at them sheepishly before pulling Entrapta back to their feet.

“I’m still teaching him how to use this thing,” George tells them while taking the bow back from Lance, “And I don’t know how to use it either, so uh… it’s good you’re here!”

"I've been so worried!" Bow tells them, "Why haven't you answered my calls?"

"Our trackerpad has been on the fritz lately, and you know we're useless at that sort of thing," Lance continues as Adora and Entrapta walk up behind Bow, "We left a note!" George steps up then to elbow playfully at his son with a wink, "A 'pun'ny note."

"You will not distract me with puns right now," the archer argues with them, "You can't just work on ancient history like nothing's happening!"

"*You* were the one who inspired us to fight for what we believe in," George steps forward to grasp his shoulder, "I promise you, we're not hiding. In fact, we've *found* something."

That piques the trio's interest when Lance continues on, "Yes - something we think might help everyone!"

Adora steps up beside Bow, "What did you find?"

"It's easier if we show you," Lance tells them then gestures to them to follow, "Come on!"

The trio all glance at each other curiously, then quickly follow after the two men before they disappear in the shadows once more.

While the others are looking for answers, Catra, Melog, and Glimmer continue to distract and attack the clones as safely as they can - Glimmer teleports back and forth, confusing them, while Catra uses Melog's invisibility cloaking to sneak up and hit them from behind. The two women operate separate of each other, doing their own thing, just trying their best to keep the clones distracted while their friends escape. But there are too

many of them, and they can only hold on for so long. Pretty soon, Glimmer uses up her magical reserves.

The next time she tries to use her powers, they go out, and she receives a solid punch from one of the clones. *It's definitely time to leave*, she thinks, only she's on the ground now and is quickly surrounded on all sides.

Catra, seeing the problem, uses Melog to run over to her. Glimmer almost smacks the girl when she sees her suddenly so close, but Catra tells her to *"hold on"* and Melog cloaks them both. Once they're both invisible, the girls make a break for it. They do well until they keep running into more clones at every turn, and eventually have to back track the way they came. As soon as they're in the clear, Melog's legs give out and they all stumble on the ground, rolling about in the dirt, becoming visible and vulnerable to attack once more.

"Are we clear?" Catra eventually asks, out of breath.

Glimmer lifts her head to glance around. Not seeing any danger, she responds, "Clear."

The feline nods and closes her eyes while trying to gulp down air as Glimmer inspects her. *She just saved me*… The princess is confused, waiting for the girl to get up and end her herself, but nothing happens. When the former commander *does* eventually get to her feet, Glimmer watches her suspiciously and tenses up when she walks over.

But still, the strike never comes.

Instead, the cat woman holds her hand out to her, which she reluctantly accepts. Catra then pulls the Queen to her feet and walks away, leaving her to gape behind her. *This must be a trick*, Glimmer thinks, but even now she's a little unsure of herself... She follows along behind her, being sure to keep a close eye on her.

The two walk aimlessly for a little while, being on the lookout for the clones, but eventually Glimmer has to ask, "Where are we going?"

"We're looking for the ruin," Catra states, plainly.

"We don't have a trackerpad, Catra," the Queen stops and plants her hands on her hips. "Even if we did, we don't have access to the location Entrapta got from Alwyn. We might as well go back to the safe house and wait for them."

"I'm not going back," the former commander argues, not bothering to turn around or even stop, leaving the princess to catch up to her.

"You *do* know why it's impossible to navigate the Whispering Woods, right? I mean, you've been traveling through them enough to *attack* us that you have to know," she stops and nearly curses at the cat woman when she lets go of a tree limb that bounces back to hit the purple haired girl in the face. *Motherfucker - Why isn't she listening?* Glimmer plants herself and yells, "You're going to get us lost - you don't know where you're going!"

"I don't *care!* " Catra rounds on her in anger, but for the first time ever, the Queen sees worry and fear in those mismatched eyes and she loses some of her ire, "I'll look all night - I'm *not* losing any more of my *friends*, okay?!"

With that the brunette stalks off into the woods again, leaving the rebel leader to gape after her for the second time that afternoon. *She's really worried about them… isn't she?* And no matter how many ways she tries to think around it, she can't… The feline is genuinely worried about them. Something about the thought softens Glimmer's heart and makes her stomach fill with dread. *Oh no… have Adora and Bow been right about her all along?*

Catra honestly doesn't care what the Queen does. *She can go home and rest until the others return, and probably won't lose an*

ounce of sleep when they don't, the cat girl grumbles to herself. *But I'm not going anywhere.* It's not until she stops in a clearing to look around that she realizes the Queen is hot on her tail. She turns to glare at her, "Go home - I'll find them myself."

"Despite your *idiocy* of thinking you might *actually* find them without a map-" Glimmer starts while crossing her arms, "I don't want to lose my friends either, so I guess that makes us travel buddies…" The last part is mumbled and probably doesn't need to be said, "-even though you're the *last* person I'd wanna be stuck with," but Catra catches it all the same.

"Trust me, *Sparkles*," the brunette glares at her again, "The feeling is mutual."

The response, said with the usual snarkiness she's come to expect from the commander, makes the sparkly princess smile softly. So, with that, the two women decide, for the moment, to put their differences aside for the sake of their friends and carry on through the woods, hoping to find any clue for where they are.

They just had to try not to kill each other before then.

Chapter End Notes

Teehee

Mending Hearts

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Previously

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Chapter 19

The trio of friends are following Bow's dads into the darkness of the ruin until they get to a platform type structure, one very similar to the one Adora has seen before.

George starts narrating as they approach, "We unearthed an ancient secret, long forgotten - A rebellion from the time of the

first ones, fighting against a powerful tyrant, just like we are!" The friends are engrossed in the story when the dads come to a full stop. "Watch," George tells them in a hushed voice and then takes another step forward. He holds out his arms and speaks to the platform, "Eternia."

And then the navigator, one who they've all faced before, turns on. "Greetings, administrator," the hologram speaks in her robotic voice, "What is your query?"

"Uh, that's cool, dad," Bow starts, scratching at the back of his neck, "But we met her a while ago. She uh- wasn't that helpful."

"Oh, that's not it!" Lance turns to him excitedly, "We found something *hidden* in her programming!"

"For the honor of-"

"-No no no, let me do it this time."

The three friends glance at each other curiously, wondering where this is leading, as the dads fight over who gets to show them.

"You always get to do it."

"I don't! You did it last time."

"Uh, dads? Not to rush you here, but we're in a bit of a time crunch," Bow states while covering his face in embarrassment.

"Okay, fine," George concedes.

"*Thank* you," Lance turns back to the platform and declares in his most triumphant tone, "For the Honor of *Grayskull!!!"*

Suddenly the navigator disappears and a globe of light expands over their heads. The friends don't really know what they're looking for at first until Entrapta gasps beside them.

“It’s written in the language of the First Ones!” she cries dreamily as she starts walking around to inspect the glowing sphere.

“That it is,” George states proudly before turning back to the other two, “We weren’t sure what to think when we first found this. We thought it must be a glitch-”

“-But then we remembered that message on your trackerpad,” Lance picks it up from there, walking backwards through the sphere of language to explain, “-and how it used coded language based on the star formations of the distant past!”

“Woooow,” Entrapta looks absolutely enthralled as she lifts herself up on her hair to try to touch the floating words. The two other friends watch her with amusement while the dads struggle to put together the message.

“Friends of-”

“No, not that one-”

“I’ve got it,” George says as he puts in the final piece, “‘Mara’ - there.”

Once the message is complete, it fades into a blinding light that flashes them for a moment. They all have to blink and refocus their vision, but then they watch as the navigator resurfaces.

“Greetings… Friends of Mara.”

“Mara?” Adora asks, incredulously.

“Mara wasn’t alone,” Lance tells her with a smile, “She was working with a group of rebels going against their First Ones leaders.”

“There is one recording available,” the navigator interrupts them, “Would you like to review?”

“Play it,” Lance instructs her.

[Serenia] "This is our last transmission. If anyone's hearing this, you need to listen. There is a failsafe for the Heart of Etheria - It will allow you to destroy the Heart and end this for good. It's at the Arxia outpost, but we lost touch with them a week ago. If there's anyone left out there, you need to find it. Mara bought us time, but it's too late for us. This is Rebel Squadron Grayskull, and for the last time, we're signing off."

Everyone stands there in wonder as the navigator shuts off again, taking with it the sphere of First One's language. "Awww," Entrapta says, disappointed.

The dads both look at each other curiously when Bow interrupts them. "A failsafe? There's a failsafe to destroy the Heart of Etheria!" He turns to Adora excitedly, "This could stop Prime from using the Heart! This could save the universe!"

"They said it's at Arxia," Adora steps forward to address the dads, "What is that?"

"Oh, that?" Lance starts, "*That* … we don't know - The First Ones had different names for everything on Etheria. But in all of our studies? We've never heard of a place called Arxia."

"We have to get back to tell the others," the blonde turns to Bow with determination written on her face, "If there's a failsafe out there somewhere, we need to find it."

Bow gives her a devil-may-care grin, "Agreed."

"Horde Prime is going down!" Entrapta adds in.

"That he is," Adora agrees with a grin of her own.

The two ladies plus Melog continue to walk aimlessly for a while longer, still looking for any sign of the first ones ruin. They stumble through the woods until their feet are tired and sore. Catra is just contemplating finding a place to stop and rest when she hears a sniffle behind her. The feline turns sharply and looks at the Queen, flabbergasted, "Are you *crying?"*

"*NO*," Glimmer tells her miserably and pushes her as she walks past. Even though she kept her head down, Catra definitely saw tears on her face.

"For crying out loud," she grumbles after her, "What is wrong with you princesses? Seriously… You're always weepy and huggy and disgusting, like *all* the time."

"Fuck off," Glimmer hiccups between her sobs and stops to cover her face with both hands.

Catra literally smacks her own face and drags her hand down, hoping to erase the entire situation. "Look, let's go take a break over here." She walks forward but checks to make sure the weepy princess is following her before she breaks through the trees. As it stands, she picked a pretty nice spot to rest for a while.

Glimmer hiccups again as she takes in the view, tears still streaming down her face. They've found the ledge of a cliff that oversees a good portion of the Whispering Woods… they should be able to spot signs of trouble from up here. "This okay?" Catra asks her uncomfortably, and the princess offers her a watery smile and a nod. "Okay, just… sit over there and get your shit together."

Catra goes to sit near the edge of the cliff and shouldn't be all that surprised that the crying girl decides to sit just a foot away while Melog curls up on her other side. The former commander tries not to roll her eyes and instead reaches out to stroke the alien pet's head. She knows she'll regret asking, but "You- you wanna talk about it?" she asks with not a very well-hidden grimace.

Glimmer smiles gently over at the girl, clearly surprised by the offer, but ends up shrugging and looking back out at the horizon where the sun is just starting to set.

“Okay then,” Catra tries not to sound too relieved, but she tried, right? No one can say she didn’t try.

“I’m losing them,” Glimmer whispers a moment later, and the brunette barely catches it in the wind. She turns to look at the sullen princess - she’s no longer crying, but the cat woman can tell it won’t take much for her to start again.

“Who? You mean the friends you’ve been chasing away with a stick?” Catra asks sarcastically.

“I haven’t been *chasing* them away,” the purple haired princess tries to argue, tears filling her eyes once more, but the former commander cuts her off.

Catra pins her with an incredulous stare, “You haven’t exactly made it easy for them to be near you though, have you?”

“What would *you* know about it?” The Queen barks at her but turns her head away to quickly dab at her watering eyes again.

“*Please*,” the brunette rolls her eyes before looking back to the horizon, “I don’t have to be a part of your little magical friends group to see that you’re breaking it apart at the seams - Your friends try to instill their faith in you and give you *every chance* in the world to pull your head out of your ass, and that’s rewarded by you questioning their every move." Catra shakes her head disapprovingly, but she's not finished yet, "*You* get all the say and *they* get none - I mean, I know you’re *technically* their ruler and all, but if you want them to stop disobeying you and running around, doing things without you, then you need to be their friend… not their dictator,” the cat girl finishes her rant, but can’t help but add on, “Your new title only changed *your* perspective - they never stopped seeing you as their friend which probably made it difficult when you stopped treating them like they are.”

There's a muffled crying sound and Catra drops her head, trying not to groan out loud. The two sit in silence for a moment while the princess regains her composure - when she calms down a little, she tries again, "I just don't *get* it. *Why* are they so quick to trust you?" Glimmer stares at her as if she actually expects the cat woman to know the answer. "They're *my* friends, but lately they'd rather listen to *you* than me." Catra rolls her eyes but keeps quiet. "Bow I can kind of understand because he's a sweetheart and noble and trusting…" the Queen cuts herself off when she realizes she's not only rambling but making herself sad again, "He'd give anyone a second chance, but *Adora?"*

The cat girl grimaces but keeps her eyes focused on the setting sun while the princess's gaze bores holes into the side of her head.

"I mean," Glimmer sniffles, "I know you two have known each other longer, but we've been through *hell* and *back* over the last few years. And yeah, I know I've messed up, but she forgave me for that… How come she's so willing to mend her friendship with you over me? Cause honestly," she lets out a half-hearted, watery laugh, "You've definitely done a lot worse."

Catra lets out a heavy sigh, but tells the girl softly and honestly, "She's never gonna stop being your friend, Glimmer." She's not sure how else to help the girl - Knowing she's Adora's friend, though, she at least has to try, doesn't she?

"But I *see* you two together, and it's like you were never apart. You obviously hold a special place in her heart that I'll never understand," this brings on a fresh round of tears.

"Glimmer," the ex-horde commander sighs, "Look, I'm gonna tell you something… but if you tell anyone I swear on the Heart of Etheria, I'll bring you back here and *no one* will ever hear from you again… *understood?"* she hardens her glare in the princess's direction to show her she's serious.

Glimmer looks at her with wide, wet eyes, halting her tears for the moment.

Catra takes a calming breath and looks ahead at the valley before she continues, "Adora and I were.. never really friends, I don't think."

"What are you talking about? You two are like peas in a pod," The purple haired girl starts getting teary eyed again.

"Well, I mean, we *were*, maybe, when we were kids, but after that," here she shrugs, "We were competitors; pitted against each other for fame and glory." The cat girl sighs before continuing - knowing the next part probably goes without saying, but she says it anyway, "All by the one who was like a mother figure to us."

"Shadow Weaver," Glimmer guesses.

"Yeah," she stares off into the distance for a moment before continuing, "Things changed between us after that. I don't know quite when it happened for her, but I think I could pin down the exact moment it happened for me." Here her cheeks blossom with color and she looks away embarrassed.

"Catra?" Glimmer prompts and the cat woman curses under her breath.

"Look, Sparkles, I'm *trying* here," she says a little too gruffly, then immediately apologizes when she sees Glimmer's down-trodden expression as well as Melog's red mane, "Sorry. We just- I meant we weren't ever *just* friends, you know? We were… something more?"

Here Glimmer's eyebrows slowly raise in shock… *Surely not?* The princess inspects the cat woman's overly embarrassed expression - *She doesn't mean what I think she means… right?* She *thinks* she knows where the feline is going with this, seeing how much she's struggling to get it out - The princess is more surprised than anything, but she acts confused for appearances sake.

“Ugggh, come on,” Catra says after glancing at her and then drops her head in her hand, “You’re really gonna make me say it, aren’t you?”

“Mhmm,” Glimmer tries to hold in her delighted glee at the cat woman’s obvious discomfort.

Catra rolls her eyes and tries again, “We have… feelings.. for each other.” her face turns bright red before she mumbles, “Like.. romantic type feelings.”

“WHAT?!” Glimmer shrieks, causing her former enemy to jump. It’s immediately followed by hysterical laughter though, and the feline flattens her ears in anger just as Melog growls.

“You know what?” She bites off as she stands up and turns toward the treeline, “I don’t need this.”

“Catra… Catra,” Glimmer is still chuckling but teleports in front of her, blocking her exit. She holds her hands up in surrender while she tries to calm her amusement. “I’m sorry,” she clears her throat when the apology comes out squeaky, “I’m sorry, truly. I just- *honestly* didn’t expect that… and wouldn’t have in a million years." The Queen chuckles again as she examines Catra brazenly, "If it weren't for your obvious embarrassment, I’d swear you were pulling my leg.”

Rolling her eyes, the shorter girl turns back to the cliff’s edge and grumbles, “Yeah, well… Now you know.” After the two sit down, side by side again she continues, “So, you really have no reason to worry about me stealing your best friend.”

Glimmer smiles softly at the girl, looking at her in a completely different light. *How did I not see this?* This must’ve been what Double Trouble was talking about. *Fuck, I really am blind.* All this time she thought the cat woman had an ulterior motive, but even if she did- It was more about winning back Adora’s heart than

winning back over the Horde. When the brunette goes to lay down on the grass, the Queen lays down with her, though she's eager to ask the cat woman a million questions..

"So…"

Catra rolls her eyes again and ignores her.

"Adora feels the same way?"

Sighing as she focuses on the stars that are starting to peek out, she reluctantly answers, "She used to… I think she may be starting to again, but- it's hard to tell."

Glimmer turns her head to look at her profile - not really being a love expert herself, she's not sure what to say, "You two haven't talked about it?"

"That's probably the one thing you'll never understand about me and Adora," here the feline glances over at her for a moment before looking back up to the stars. "In the Horde, we weren't- It was discouraged to fraternize with our squad mates.. With *anyone* really. The average Horde soldier barely makes it past twenty years of age, so… the whole 'getting married', 'having babies' thing was unrealistic for people like us." Catra watches as a shooting star crosses the sky before continuing, "But even *if* it was a possibility… Feelings are considered weakness." She says the last part with a hint of hostility, "Love is considered weakness, sadness is considered weakness, crying.. Even sickness can be seen as weakness."

"I recall Adora saying something similar once," Glimmer adds softly, allowing the cat woman to continue.

After taking a breath, she finishes softly, "We just never learned how to talk about our feelings, is all."

Glimmer feels her chin tremble as she bites back her tears. She turns back to look at the stars - she knew that life in the Horde had to be rough, but not quite the extent of it. Adora never discussed those things in too much detail, and the sparkly princess is starting to see why.

Once she's given the cat woman a chance to recover, she pushes the conversation forward, "You gotta try to find a way to talk to her about this."

"I mean, I feel like I've been pretty obvious," Catra chuckles wryly. "I've fucking kissed her a few times now-

"You've *KISSED?!"* The princess bolts straight up while she shrieks again.

"Damnit, woman," Catra flattens her hands over her ears, folding them against her head, "Some of us have extraordinary hearing."

"Maybe used to," here she thumps the lithe woman's elbow, getting her to lower her hands, "When was this? Tell me- I wanna know everything." Glimmer sits there with literal stars in her eyes, waiting wide-eyed and impatient for the story.

"*No*," Catra laughs and swats at her, "I'm not one to kiss and tell-"

"-You *just* told me-"

"-Any-*more*," the brunette clarifies with a good-natured eyeroll, "That's all the detail you're getting."

Glimmer huffs and crosses her arms, upset she's not getting what she wants, but the two former enemies are still on shaky ground,, so she tries not to push her luck. After a moment of quiet, the Queen can't help but ask one question in particular though, "How did you know?"

"How did I *know?"* Catra turns her head to look at her questioningly.

“Yeah,” the princess shrugs, trying not to look too invested in the answer, “You said you could pin down the exact moment, so… How did you know you were in love with her?”

Catra swallows thickly and looks back up to the stars which are more prominent now that the sun has fallen past the horizon. Her cheeks are flushed again, because she never told the princess she was *in love* with Adora - but maybe it’s pretty obvious now that she’s looking for it. She goes back and forth about whether or not she wants to answer this question, but goes on anyway, “It was… my fourteenth birthday. Granted I’m pretty sure I’ve, you know, wanted her most of my life, I just- didn’t *realize* it until my fourteenth birthday.” The feline glances over to make sure Princess Sparkly-pants is still listening before she continues.

“We don’t know exactly when I was born - Like Adora, I was found when I was just a baby. The story is that Shadow Weaver found me trapped in an apple crate out behind the mess hall one day… just thrown out like the rest of the trash,” she says, spitefully. “Truth is, I was probably abandoned and got stuck in the trash trying to find food.” Here she shrugs - she doesn’t know the truth and perhaps it’s better that way.

“Anyway, Adora celebrated my birthday with me every year, even though we didn't know the exact day, and even though technically we weren’t even supposed to have birthdays. But on this birthday in particular…” the cat woman has to stop and chuckle for a moment, “she stole all the apples from storage and we ran up to the tallest point of the city before they could find us… We stayed up all night talking about whatever came to our minds. We were laying down, just like this, and looking up at the sky.. Of course, this was before there were stars, but-” She passes a grin over to the Queen before finishing the story. “It was still nice… I remember her asking me what I thought our lives would be like if we hadn’t grown up there. Would we still be friends? We spent hours going over all the possible scenarios, but in every one, Adora was always by my side,” Catra feels tears creeping up on her, and she clears her throat, trying to keep the emotions at bay.

"She always used to say nothing bad could ever happen to us as long as we were together, and she really believed that…"

Glimmer hangs on every word of her story… so surprised yet so enthralled about how close the two were. She honestly shouldn't be shocked they drifted back towards each other as quickly as they did. It's just such a whirlwind - trying to piece together this woman laying here, opening up to her about intimate details of her life with the angry Horde commander who made her life a living hell.

"I just had to be the asshole that didn't go with her when she left, though," the cat woman continues, breaking the Queen out of her thoughts. "I've fucked up a lot in my life, but that was probably the biggest fuck up of all."

Glimmer looks down at her hands and can't help but feel tears of her own welling back up again. *We've both fucked up quite a bit, haven't we?* She clears her throat quickly and looks up to the stars willing her tears not to fall, before she asks her next question.

"So, what was it about that night that made you realize you were in love with her?"

Catra thinks on it for a moment before a small smile starts pulling at the corner of her lips. She shrugs and answers simply, "In all those make-believe scenarios we came up with, about what our lives would look like had things been different…" she turns to meet the princess's gaze earnestly, "The only thing I really wanted was her."

This time Glimmer can't stop the tears from welling up or from falling out.

"Oh fuck," Catra complains, but it only makes her cry more. Knowing Adora would most likely kick her ass for making her friend cry, she sits up and gestures the girl over. It only takes a

second for Glimmer to accept the invitation to hold the cat woman and cry into her shoulder.

The feline was really, *very* much against this - she only allowed it with Perfuma because of Scorpia, but this? She awkwardly pats the girl's purple hair, hoping it'll calm her down - she doesn't even know what she said to upset her. It takes a few minutes for the tears to finally subside, but even then, the princess doesn't pull her face away. Catra is about to ask her if she can let go now when the sad girl speaks again.

"I think I really fucked things up with Bow."

And that's when it dawns on her. The cat girl's brow furrows and she sighs, feeling her heart go out to the miserable girl - she's all too familiar with the feeling. She takes a moment to rest her head on top of the princess's before she responds, "You just gotta be honest with him. The next time you see him, sit him down and apologize… But it has to be more than that." Catra shakes her head gently, "You gotta actually show him that you're trying to be better, y'know?"

Glimmer pulls back then to regard the usually cold cat girl. The brunette raises her eyebrows at her, but before she can ask her what the fuck she wants, the princess presses a big kiss to her cheek.

"BLECH!" Catra immediately jumps away onto the boulder behind her. "No! Okay? *NO* - *Never* again!"

The Queen is rolling around in hysterics, though, laughing at the cat girl's absurdly exaggerated reaction, so much so that they almost miss it - a light in the distance.

"Uh, Glimmer?" The girl is still chuckling when she sits up to see what it is that's caught the lithe brunette's attention.

Just up ahead, in the middle of the valley, a bright light that shoots miles into the air beckons them. That's definitely got to be

them, right? Glimmer hops up and immediately offers her hand to the cat girl, who backs away, looking at her distastefully. "Come *on*," the princess rolls her eyes, before smiling at her devilishly, "I'll keep my lips to myself."

"Yeah, you better," Catra grumbles. She starts to reach for her hand, but then pauses to add, "And you better not tell anyone about this… ever!" She growls.

"Okay okay," Glimmer laughs while shaking her head. When the feline eventually takes her hand, she's sure to include, "You big baby," before she teleports them away.

When they land at the foot of the ruin, the two women walk around the hill until they find the entrance which is conveniently left open for them. Glimmer starts to walk in when Catra stops her with a hand on her arm.

"What is it?" she asks when she sees the uncertainty on the cat woman's face.

Catra looks behind them back at the woods - she thought she heard something - before turning back to ask her question, "Do you think those clones are still looking for the ruin? … the ruin that's currently sending out its own personal homing beacon for anyone around to see?"

The Queen feels her stomach drop, "Oh shit."

The two women stand there, shoulder to shoulder, while they wait and listen. It doesn't take long before they see them, walking between the trees in a beeline right towards them. And if it's even possible? There seems to be more of them than the ones they left behind.

"Oh fuck," Glimmer says, and they immediately glance worriedly at each other before turning and darting into the ruin. "Wait," Catra calls before they're too far in. The sparkly princess turns just in time to watch the feline strike her claws at what looks like a manual release mechanism which causes the door to slam shut

behind them. “Nice,” Glimmer grins at her before waving her forward, “Let’s go!”

As Bow and Adora are finishing up with his dads and trying to pull Entrapta away from the crystal that the hologram came from, there’s a commotion at the entrance of the ruin. They all freeze and listen quietly, wondering what to expect and trying not to draw attention to themselves. When they hear the sound of feet running straight towards them, the archer pulls out his bow and arrow as he stands in front of his dads while Adora pushes Entrapta behind her - ready to call on She-Ra if need be.

But when their two friends plus Melog slide into the room, the group looks at them flabbergasted.

“Glimmer?!” Bow calls out at the same time Adora lets out an exasperated breath from the scare, “*Catra*, what the hell?”

“No time to explain,” Catra bounds over to them and grabs Entrapta by the hand, “The clones are headed straight for us - we need to go, *now*.”

“What, no!” the scientist cries, pulling against the brunette’s hold on her while the rest of the group grab onto each other, “We can’t just leave the information here - what if Prime finds out about the failsafe?!”

Glimmer and Catra have no idea what she’s talking about, but there’s no time to argue. The Queen immediately calls on her father’s scepter and walks over to break the crystal with it. Everyone watches as sparks fly out and the power that once lit up the pillars now fades. “There,” Glimmer dust her hands off before returning to the group, “That should do it.” When she’s close enough, she grabs onto Lance’s shoulder and teleports the group back to Bow’s family home.

Adora, Bow, and his dads are still trying to catch up from the quick escape, looking to their rescuers for answers, when they see Catra turn to Glimmer with a scowl.

"So… you *couldn't* teleport us to the ruin before when we *really needed* you to, but had *no* trouble getting us to some weird, obscure library in the middle of nowhere?" The cat woman asks sarcastically. Adora groans while Bow face-palms, waiting for the two women to go at it again. But only a moment later, they snap their heads up, surprised when they hear Glimmer's laughter.

"I can only teleport when I know or can *see* exactly where I'm going," the Queen rolls her eyes good-naturedly with a smile, "If I teleport somewhere blind, I'd risk us getting trapped inside a wall or something."

Catra rolls her eyes, too, but sighs fondly, "I guess that's okay then… Quick thinking with the crystal smashing, by the way. That was smart."

"Right back at ya," Glimmer replies, reaching out to high five the cat girl, "If you hadn't broken the lock, those clones would've been right on our heels."

"-I'm *sorry*," Bow interrupts their little love fest, leading the two women to look back at him while he shakes his head in utter bewilderment and Adora stares on with wide eyes, "Are you two… getting *along?"*

The women glance back at each other and shrug. Glimmer takes a step closer and throws her arm casually over the feline's shoulders, "Yeah… turns out she's not too bad."

Catra crosses her arms and sneers at the sentiment, but can't help but agree, "Yeah… and Glimmer isn't the *worst* princess anymore - Now that title goes to the water one," she says, causing the Queen to laugh.

The warrior and the archer both stare at them with their mouths agape - What *is* happening?! *What the actual* fuck???

But when the initial shock wears off, Bow's dads grab ahold of Adora and drag her away to translate something for them, and

Catra goes over to check in on Entrapta… leaving the two best friends to stare at each other awkwardly.

Glimmer just stands there, twisting her fingers together nervously behind her back and wondering if she should approach him. When she hears an "a-hem" directed at her from the other side of the room, the anxious princess glances over to find Catra's mismatched eyes looking at her expectantly - the feline then nods her head in Bow's direction, and Glimmer takes the hint. Taking a deep breath to center herself, the purple haired Queen walks up to her friend who's still looking at her curiously like she's grown a second head.

When the archer is within arm's reach, Glimmer quickly leans forward to embrace him, which he hesitantly returns after a moment. The princess smiles and uses the opportunity to whisper up to him, "Thank you for pushing me to give her a chance." She then pulls back to look up at her old friend with watery eyes, "You were right."

Bow's eyebrows scrunch together as he regards her closely, but there's no turning back now. She has to get this all out there, so she continues.

"I'm sorry for not trusting you - that's a mistake I'll never make again. You have every right to be mad at me, and you get to stay mad at me for as long as you need - but I'm not going anywhere," she tells him sincerely, "I'll never stop trying to make things better. And even if-" Glimmer pauses to gather up her courage before pressing on, "-even if we can never go back to the way things used to be, I'll *never* stop being your friend, so… whenever, or *if* you ever need me… I'll be here." Glimmer does her best to offer him a brave smile, but she knows it must come out wobbly as she's barely controlling her tears.

She turns away then, prepared to give him the space he needs, but he stops her with a hand on her shoulder. When she turns to glance back at him, Bow is smiling at her gently with the warm eyes that she's always known and loved.

"Okay," he tells her softly, his smile growing. Glimmer feels her tears start to leak out in full force and can't stop herself from falling into his arms and letting him hold her. She's needed this for too long.

"Awwwwww," they both look up with teary eyes to find Adora back in the room and staring at them with watery eyes herself. "Best Friend Squad hug?!" She cries as she runs at them. They both laugh and break apart to receive her in their group hug. "Best Friend Squad hug!" The other friends call after her as they grip onto each other.

Catra watches the interaction from the side as Entrapta inspects a nearby vase behind her. She can't help but feel her heart sink a bit when she sees the open and loving expression on the blonde's face - it comes so naturally to her when it involves her other friends. It's just a sore reminder that Catra still has so much farther to go with the girl before she trusts her like that again. The feline subconsciously reaches out to pet Melog on the head after he nudges at her leg and meows sadly at her. She looks down at him and puts on a brave smile, *We'll get there someday, buddy.*

She's broken from her reverie when she hears the idiots scream, "Best Friend's Squad hug," again, but they sound a lot closer this time. Catra looks up just in time to puff up her fur and squeak before Glimmer and Bow sandwich her in a hug. She immediately starts to protest and tries to push them off, "No! *What?!* Get *off!"*

Entrapta as well as the dads laugh while Adora observes the interaction from the side. She smiles softly and feels tears stinging her eyes again as she watches her oldest friend get accepted by her newer friends. *Everything seems to be falling into place*, she thinks before her gut twists miserably. She crosses her arms and hugs herself tightly as she continues to observe the new friends interact with each other. Catra's won over the rebellion, made up with her Horde friends, fought hard for them, helped steer them from danger on multiple occasions, and now?

Adora watches her leap over the biggest hurdle she had to face - winning over Bow and Glimmer.

So, why am I still so afraid of her?

When Catra's proven she's trying to change for the better time and time again… Why is the warrior so terrified to get close to her again? She thinks back to last night - last night that's been looping through her thoughts all throughout their struggles today. Adora was so out of control - so willing to just let herself fall, and give herself to the feline all over again, without a single hesitation.

This is where her head and her heart have a difference of opinion.

Because while her heart is more than willing to take the girl back- her head can't forget all the awful ways they've hurt each other over the years. Can she really get that back? Can she really look past all the times Catra's attacked her - personally, as well as attacking the rebellion - to reclaim that friendship they had all those years ago? The princess really can't say for certain one way or the other. But she knows she needs to figure it out.

Bow takes a minute to say goodbye to his fathers and has them swear to keep in better touch this time - also to call if they're ever in danger. But after they've had their hugs and their tears of sorrow and happiness, the rebels get their game faces back on before traveling back to the safe house.

They've learned a lot over the course of the day, so they need to regroup with the rest of the rebels to decide where they can go from here. The answer to defeating Horde Prime is finally within their reach, and they don't have a minute to lose.

Chapter End Notes

Fiiiinally lol how'd ya like it?

I am currently working on the last two chapters now - I hope to have them done in the next week. As is stands right now, it looks like it's going to be 25 chapters instead of 23, but I'll fix that when I know for sure.

Failsafe Pt. 1

Chapter Notes

Alright - 2 notes to start off with. I did just recently finish writing the story - there are still some revisions to be made, but it is mostly done and ready to post. That being said, I've been trying to decide whether I should be mean and continue with my regular posting schedule or be nice and post the rest of the story all at once so y'all can binge read it. Let me know what you think :)

And secondly, I do want to apologize for several of these last chapters. As I've said before, I did write this fic with the intention of it finishing the same way the show does, so in chapters 20, 21, 23, and 24, you will start to see a lot of repeats of scenes that you already know from the show. I did try to paraphrase or recount the scenes from memory as well as rewording things where I could afford to - I also embellished on and added some scenes while completely glazing over others in an effort to keep the fic from looking like you're just reading a transcript of the show. I also added a lot of inner monologues, so hopefully that'll help it from feeling too familiar, too. And I added a bonus chapter at the end - maybe that'll make up for it lol

But regardless - here's the episode Failsafe :) hope you like my version.

Previously

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Because while her heart is more than willing to take the girl back- her head can't forget all the awful ways they've hurt each other over the years. Can she really get that back? Can she really look past all the times Catra's attacked her - personally, as well as attacking the rebellion - to reclaim that friendship they had all those years ago? The princess really can't say for certain one way or the other. But she knows she needs to figure it out.

Bow takes a minute to say goodbye to his fathers and has them swear to keep in better touch this time - also to call if they're ever in danger. But after they've had their hugs and their tears of sorrow and happiness, the rebels get their game faces back on before traveling back to the safe house.

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Chapter 20

When the group return from their adventure, they're immediately overwhelmed by the news coming from the Fright Zone.

Apparently the reconnaissance team that went to investigate to see what the Horde were up to were lured into a trap. Scorpia, Spinnerella, and Mermista were all waiting for them, along with Horde Prime, and attacked as soon as their backs were turned. They barely managed to escape, and Netossa fortunately was able to take the knowledge of aiming for the chip to subdue Spinnerella and bring her back - All of the rebellion were anxiously waiting to see if Entrapta could save her. Too anxious to focus on

what's to come next, everyone loitered in the main hall discussing the events of the past few hours.

Catra, eager to hear about Scorpia, seeks out the flower princess and finds her not too far away, sitting on the ground and "meditating" as she calls it.

"Hey," she calls out when she's close. Perfuma gives a small smile in response but doesn't stop her meditation. The feline is a little creeped out from how calm she's being. "So, I hear Scorpia dropped a beam on you," she says as she drops down on a crate nearby.

The flower princess, still in her serene state, finally opens her eyes to meet Catra's gaze. "She missed," she tells her plainly.

"On purpose?" Catra looks at her suspiciously. At the peaceful blonde's nod, she asks a follow up question, "But she was still chipped, right?"

"She was," Perfuma's peaceful smile stays in place as she closes her eyes again and resumes her previous stance.

"How can you be so sure she let you go on purpose then?" The cat woman asks skeptically, not really sure if the flower princess maybe took a knock to the head while she was out.

At this Perfuma raises her hands in a prayer pose before she answers, "Because I believe in Scorpia." She opens her eyes to regard the brunette once more. When she spots the look of disbelief still adorning her face, the princess stands and walks over to the former commander before crushing her in a hug. "If Entrapta is able to pull this chip off Spinerella then all of our friends can be saved," Perfuma tells her hopefully and then releases the girl, so she can breathe again, "Scorpia will be home soon enough."

"I hope so," Catra offers her a small grin. She needs Scorpia back - not having the red woman around has left her feeling more

antsy than usual. When the flower child makes her exit, the former commander is left there to her thoughts. The pressure of the impending war hangs heavily over her. She knows there's a lot of things to do, a lot of things that have been left unsaid, that she's not sure what to do with - but the feeling leaves her heart in a vice, constricting her. She reaches out to pet Melog's head, hoping it'll bring her comfort.

Glimmer is on the other side of the hall, chatting with Bow and feeling, for the first time, that things may actually be okay with them again. They're smiling and laughing together - she's never been happier than at this moment. Everything seems to be going in their favor. When she stops to glance around at the nervous energy around the room, though, her eyes land on a sullen and pensive looking cat girl, and her heart breaks just a tad. She looks back up to Bow, not believing she's about to do this. I mean, it was only this morning she had her mind set on destroying the girl, but a lot has changed since then.

"Sorry," she grimaces at him and holds up a finger as she backs away from the confused looking archer, "Hold that thought. I'll be right back!" Bow watches the princess, intrigued, as she trots over to the lone cat woman. He can't help the smile that graces his features when she grabs the woman's hand and starts leading her away.

"Hey," Catra complains at the purple princess after she swoops in out of nowhere and starts pulling on her. "I don't know what the hell I did or said to make you think this is okay-" she plants herself when they're a little ways away from the rest of the group and pulls her hand back, "-because it's not." The former commander glowers at her.

Glimmer rolls her eyes and crosses her arms - she won't be scared away by the brunette's intimidation tactics any longer. "What's wrong with your face?"

"What?" Catra's frown deepens and she faces the Queen with her hands on her hips.

The sparkly princess chuckles and rolls her eyes while shaking her head. "Why are you sulking? We just had three successful missions in a row! Pretty soon we're gonna be knocking down Horde Prime's door and kicking his *ass* -" she pauses to scrutinize her former enemy for another moment, "Why aren't you more excited?"

The brunette's face drops again, and she unintentionally looks out across the main hall where Adora is now chatting with Bow before Melog comes up to tackle the tall princess from behind.

Glimmer catches the look and softens a bit - she reaches out to tap the girl on the elbow. "Hey," she says quietly to get her attention. When Catra looks back to her, her guard is already back up in place. "Talk to me," and in case she needs further incentive, "You helped me out with Bow, now let me return the favor."

Catra sighs in defeat and feels her shoulders drop before taking another glance at her blonde counterpart. "I dunno," if she had to put what was bothering her into words: "She still doesn't trust me."

"How can you say that?" Glimmer frowns at her, "You two have come so far-"

"-I *know*, I know," Catra shakes her head and looks away, "I just- it still feels like there's this wall between us and with everything that's going on it feels like I'm running out of time to figure out how to get over it." She shrugs, trying to act nonchalant about it, but honestly, she feels like she's drowning.

The princess is able to see through the facade pretty easily seeing as how she's been putting on a brave front herself for a while now. She doesn't call her out on it, but instead decides to help her.

"Look, I don't know if this will help at all… And I honestly can't even tell you *what* exactly it was that hurt her because she never

talked about it…" Glimmer starts and Catra watches her intensely, hanging on every word, "But I *do* know that whatever transpired between you two in that first ones ruin all those years ago?" Here the feline's face along with her ears fall, piquing the Queen's interest, "That really changed things for her… Like I said, she would never tell us what happened, no matter how much I pestered her about it, but after that? She was different." Glimmer shrugs before she continues, "It's like her drive became less about defeating the Horde and more about how to defeat *you*… Before then, she seemed genuinely upset that you were enemies, but not after."

Catra nods, her eyes still looking at the floor, but they're unfocused, "I see."

Watching the cat girl's expression, Glimmer really wants to press. That question has been on her mind for years, but seeing how downtrodden the girl is over it, it's probably for the best that she doesn't push. She can't leave her like this though.

"Hey," she ducks down a tad to catch the girl's eyes again, "Everything's going to be okay. You two have come *so far* since you've joined us… Just give it some time, okay?" She offers the feline a smile and hopes it'll do the trick. Catra offers her a small smile in return, but before the Queen can question if it's authentic, there's a disturbance on the other side of the room.

"Spinny?!" There are a few gasps and then sounds of excitement as Netossa goes charging up to grasp her wife in an embrace. There she is - good as new. The onlookers collectively let out a sigh of relief now that they know the trapped people of Etheria can be saved. Now they just need to leave Entrapta to do what she does best - tear things apart to figure out how they work.

Members of the rebellion all take turns crowding the two love birds, either giving Spinnerella hugs or clapping Netossa on the shoulder. Once the excitement settles, though, it's time to dive back into business. Glimmer calls on the war council to meet to

discuss the things they learned at the first ones ruin. Once the core group is seated around in a circle they begin.

“There’s a failsafe?” Perfuma asks once everything has been laid out in the open.

“Yes - for the Heart of Etheria,” Glimmer goes on cautiously.

“And what does that mean exactly?” Netossa asks.

Frosta jumps in immediately after, “Yeah, explain it for the other people who *don’t* maybe know what that means,” she says while looking unsure herself. Swift Wind jumps in, too, “*Yeah!* … What are we talking about again?”

Bow sighs before picking up where Glimmer left off, “It means that the Heart of Etheria, the weapon that the first ones created, would be disabled. And all the magic trapped inside would be released.”

“Kind of like what I attempted to do by *triggering* the Heart,” Glimmer mumbles through it, “It’ll release the magic and make us all super charged.”

“With the Heart disabled, Prime won't be able to use it against us. And with all the extra magic, we should be able to take him out, once and for all,” Adora concludes.

Catra can’t help but look at the flaw in this plan, so she cuts in, “Though we *do* need to consider that by doing that we’ll make the princesses still under his control that much stronger, too.”

“Well, that’s where Entrapta comes in!” Adora says with false bravado, suddenly looking around for the scientist only to find that she’s left to go back to work.

“Entrapta is currently looking into the data she's collected on Horde Prime's system thus far as well as inspecting the chips..." Here he glances nervously over to Glimmer, "We should have a fix for that soon."

The Queen nods at him with a small smile, trying to instill confidence in their team before continuing, "And while Entrapta works on that, our first objective would be to actually *find* the failsafe… As of right now, all we know is that it's in a place called Arxia - Does that name mean anything to anyone?"

"*We* know where it is," the war council turns around suddenly to face the voice that just joined the group. They all watch in various states of confusion as Shadow Weaver along with Castaspella suddenly emerge from the shadows. Several of the group, particularly Adora, Catra, and Glimmer, all frown at the unexpected intrusion. "We have to go to Mystacor."

Bow, seeing the tension building, quickly cuts in, "Hold on, where have you two been this whole time again?"

"While the lot of you were running around looking for First One's artifacts or running away from Prime, *some of us* have been working to stop the Heart of Etheria," Shadow Weaver explains as the two sorceresses join the group. "And on our journey, we discovered the same thing you did - Rumors of a failsafe that will break the restraints the first ones built and set the stolen magic free."

"After everything's that's happened, you're still looking for ways to take the power for yourself," Glimmer stands, accusing Shadow Weaver, before her eyes fall on her Aunt, "And *you're* helping her?!"

"We're trying to free the magic for *all* of Etheria," Castaspella approaches her niece, explaining to her gently, "I know it's not easy to accept, but this is for the best. We need to do this in order to defeat Prime-" and though it goes without saying, she adds, "Shadow Weaver is the lesser of two evils."

"At least you *admit* she's evil," Catra grumbles just loud enough for the others to hear.

Without missing a beat, Shadow Weaver turns her steely gaze to the feline, "*You're* one to talk."

Catra doesn't hesitate to stand up to growl at her but is cut off when Adora grasps her shoulder and sends her a pleading look. The feline, sufficiently rebuffed, sits back down and turns her face away, trying not to get too upset about it. *Why is she listening to her?*

"Tell us what you know about the Failsafe," Adora demands of her former mentor, "What makes you think it's in Mystacor?"

"Mystacor, like much of Etheria, was built on the ruins of an ancient First Ones citadel," Shadow Weaver begins, narrowing her eyes at the warrior, "And *beneath* Mystacor there are chambers and tunnels that have been sealed off for centuries. No one knows what's down there, but there are whispers… It's believed that an artifact known as the Crystal of Arxia, hidden there by a group of traitorous first ones, resides somewhere within those ruins."

"Arxia," Bow looks to Adora in wonder, "That must be the outpost that Mara's rebels were talking about. The failsafe might be under Mystacor!"

"Reaching it won't be easy," Shadow Weaver continues, "But I have spent my whole life studying the secrets of Mystacor - *I* can get us in."

The blonde warrior, not trusting the woman for a second, furrows her brow and questions her, "If you figured it out on your own, why come back here? Why do you need us at all?"

"Because Mystacor is controlled by *Micah*," the sorceress's voice keeps rising as she goes on, "Who, as you may recall, is controlled by Horde Prime." When the shadow woman starts advancing on Adora, the blonde takes a step in front of Catra, blocking her from reach, but she's not the one the dark sorceress is after. "*You* have allowed Horde Prime to gain too much ground," she raises her volume with her superior inflection as she stops in front of the

princess and places her hands on her shoulders. It’s at that point Catra can’t stand to watch anymore and turns away to leave. “If he seizes the Heart, it will all be over - There is no more time for half measures, Adora; you *must* act *now*.”

The rebel warrior frowns at her former mentor and knocks her hands off her shoulders. “It’s the best plan we’ve got for now, but it’ll have to be a stealth mission. Catra, do you think you and Melog can-” she stops when she turns around to see the feline isn’t there.

“Leave her to sulk,” Shadow Weaver grasps her shoulder again, “We can’t let her slow us down-”

“-You guys get ready,” Adora commands, ignoring the sorceress, “I’ll go find her.”

The warrior turns and sprints back to the sleeping area, wondering if the brunette left to go gather her belongings. Once she enters the tented off space, she spots her right away, sitting against the far wall and shuffling cards while Melog rests next to her. When she hears the princess walk in, her mismatched eyes shoot up to regard her cooly, and Adora suddenly feels very unsure of herself. She shuffles on her feet awkwardly when she realizes this is the first time the two women have been alone together since... well, *things* happened the day before. But more than that, Catra seems to be very closed off and stand offish compared to how she's been lately. *So, she's not very happy*, Adora thinks worriedly.

When Catra drops her eyes back to the cards she's shuffling, the warrior walks forward and crouches in front of her. "Hey," she says and grimaces at herself.

"Hey," the feline reponds flippantly, not looking up.

Adora sighs, knowing this isn't going to be easy. "Are you coming with us to Mystacor?"

“Why?” Catra spits out spitefully, still not looking at her, “It seems you and Shadow Weaver have a handle on things.”

“Catra-” the blonde starts, saddened, but cuts herself off as the cat woman stands up and paces away from her. Adora returns to her feet and turns to follow her with her eyes, "That's not fair..."

“*Why* are you listening to her?” Catra spins around, finally letting her anger shine through, “After everything she’s done to us... everything she’s put us through?”

"This has nothing to do with her," she argues as she turns to face her fully, "I don't trust her, okay? I wouldn't trust her as far as I could throw her, because I *know* what she is... what she's done." The feline crosses her arms and turns her face away with a scowl. Adora continues with a softer tone, "I haven't forgotten any of it, Catra. She's hurt us, she's hurt *you*..." she gestures to the girl and starts approaching her slowly, "So, I definitely *won't* forget it... But this is about *Prime*."

Catra still has a frown on her face, but looks back at Adora with a little less hostility.

"He's out there right now, and he's hurting *so* many more people," the princess softens even more as she stops right in the front of the cat girl, "This is the best plan we have to overthrow him... despite where it came from." Catra feels her shoulders sag in defeat as she looks down at the floor. Adora frowns and reaches up to gently lift her chin so those brilliant eyes are looking up at her again. Her hand starts to shake under the scrutiny, however - still feeling nervous around the woman who makes her feel too many things - and she releases her before she notices the tremble. "Please, Catra? We-" the blonde pauses before she starts again. She needs to be intentional with her words; the feline at least deserves that much. So, she reaches out and pulls the woman's arm away from where it was crossed over her chest and then cradles her hand with both of hers. "*I* could really use your help."

And she's rewarded with the biggest eyeroll in history. "Now *that's* not fair," Catra tells her in a chastising manner, but she can see the beginnings of a smile pulling at the corners of the cat woman's lips. So, Adora takes it one step further and pokes out her bottom lip and widens her eyes in the world's most ridiculous looking pout. "Oh, come *on*," the feline can't help but laugh. "*Okay*, fine," she tells the warrior once she's able to meet her eyes again without chuckling. But she's sure to include, "But I'm only doing this to make sure Shadow Weaver doesn't *try* anything - *not* because I like you." The princess smiles at her like she knows better, but Melog contradicts her further by tackling the rebel and licking her face, eliciting a laugh. Catra rolls her eyes but can't help smiling down at the two rolling on the ground.

Across the room, Bow is collecting his arrows for the mission when something nabs him from behind. "Bow!" Entrapta yells as her hair collects him and drags him over to her work station. "I need to show you something."

"What is it, Entrapta?" Bow tries to calm his racing heart after the scare and looks down at her work.

"While I was able to remove Spinnerella's chip, it wasn't easy," the scientist pulls up a diagram and then turns to face the man to explain, "The chip had almost completely fused with her nervous system… had I waited much longer to remove it, I'm not sure I would've been able to get it off at all."

Bow hears the worry in her voice and becomes concerned himself, "That means we're running out of time to save everyone else."

"Yes," Entrapta tells him seriously, but perks up, "Luckily, I have an idea." The mad scientist reaches over to change the screen back to the one she's been staring at for hours, "This is the backdoor I placed in Prime's system - it gives me access to tinker with his programming. As you can see, the system is very sophisticated. I've learned a little of how to read his coding, but if I could just find a way to crack his signal pattern, I could disrupt

it, severing his connection to the chips and taking them all offline at once!"

"That's amazing!" The archer exclaims, placing a hand on Entrapta's shoulder, "This could save everyone on Etheria. You're a genius, Entrapta! Just keep working on it until you get it - We'll be back later tonight."

"You *got* it!" The scientist tells him with determination in her eyes as the archer returns to the others before they take off for Mystacor.

Glimmer teleports the group to the grounds, and using Melog's shroud of invisibility, they're able to sneak their way inside the building.

They move quietly, only communicating in gestures, as they maneuver around all the sorcerers that have been chipped by Prime. It sends a chill down their spine whenever they see a green pair of eyes, knowing they're deep behind enemy lines now, but there's no going back - this has to be done.

Shadow Weaver leads them through for the most part, stopping them from moving further whenever there's danger up ahead. When they encounter Micah himself at the end of the hallway, both Glimmer and Castaspella worry but also have tears in their eyes as they watch their trapped loved one move on. They succeed in getting through the castle unnoticed until the last room before they enter the underground tunnels.

Catra peers around the frame, looking for danger - when she doesn't spot anything, she turns back to the others, "This room is clear-" she starts to tell them, but is cut off by Shadow Weaver grabbing her and pulling her away with her hand over the feline's mouth.

"Keep your voice down!" Shadow Weaver whisper-yells at her as the corrupted sorcerer Catra didn't see steps out into the open.

Shadow Weaver's attempt at controlling the situation, however, backfires.

The brunette immediately tenses up when she's grabbed, and as soon as she realizes who it is, she responds violently - She shoves back against the woman to free herself, "Don't touch me!" she yells, and backs away from her as Melog growls, releasing his power so they're visible to the patrons of Mystacor once more. The corrupted sorcerer, seeing the group of spies out in the hallway, immediately rears back and starts casting a spell. And Adora, knowing that Catra is immediately in the line of fire, doesn't hesitate to jump into the situation.

"For the honor of Grayskull!" she shouts, but when her power fizzles and she looks down at her empty hand, a pit of dread fills her stomach. She's too late to react to the spell that's thrown in their direction, but Catra isn't - she immediately grabs the taller girl and pulls them out of the way so they can hide behind a pillar. The spell flies past them and is deflected by Glimmer - her Aunt Castaspella then steps forward to cast a spell of her own that knocks the young sorcerer out.

"Quickly," Shadow Weaver commands, "We need to move."

The group doesn't hesitate to run through the room, out into the halls of triumph where the past leaders of Mystacor have been immortalized; their images carved into the stones of the walls. Once Shadow Weaver finds the correct image, she and Castaspella stop to put a spell on the entryway that gives them access to the underground tunnels below. The doors close behind them and the group breathes a sigh of relief. Hopefully any sorcerers that heard the disruption won't know how to follow or at least will be held up for a while.

Everyone moves together cautiously, looking out for whatever dangers may lie in wait for them in the bowels of this ancient ruin… And pray they have the strength to face it.

To be continued

Failsafe Pt. 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Previously

"Quickly," Shadow Weaver commands, "We need to move."

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Chapter 21

As the group moves through the ancient ruins, Glimmer brings up a light and casts it to the ceiling, so they can see where they're going - but it also brings to light the many paintings of history covering the walls. The rest of the group examine the paintings as they walk past, and Glimmer uses the opportunity to hold onto Bow's arm. But Adora's attention is drawn more to the feline walking just a few steps ahead of her - with her ears downturned

and her arms hugging herself. After what went on upstairs, the warrior feels like she should check in.

The princess lets the rest of the rebels get a little farther ahead before she approaches the lithe brunette from behind. “Hey, are you-”

Catra winces away from the blonde’s touch and looks the other way while she holds herself tighter. “I’m fine,” she lies.

The rebel is all too familiar with the situation and reaches out to pull her to a stop by her shoulders. “Hey,” Adora says softly and examines her face carefully when she’s finally facing her. “Everything’s gonna be okay,” when Catra’s eyes find hers, the princess offers her a soft smile and pulls one hand off her shoulder to cup her cheek, “Trust me?” She asks while she caresses the warm cheek with her thumb.

The feline feels her heart jump into her throat as she looks into the warm eyes shining down at her. Even if there's no way to know it for sure, she'll always feel okay if she has those eyes to look forward to.

Adora watches as the cat girl’s shoulders relax a bit when she takes a deep breath, and then the former commander returns her smile with a brave one of her own, making the blonde’s smile grow wider. It’s a nice moment… before it’s ruined.

“There’s *no* time to waste.”

At the sound of Shadow Weaver’s voice directed towards them, Catra flinches away from Adora again, making the taller girl’s heart sink before she turns to frown at the interruption.

The two women watch as the shadow woman marches right up to them. “The corrupted sorcerers will be looking for us after that-” she pauses to lean towards the smaller girl with narrowed eyes, “-*disturbance*.”

She doesn't have long to try and intimidate the brunette, though, as the blonde warrior immediately steps in between them and barks at their former mentor aggressively, "*Back* off."

Shadow Weaver's eyes narrow even further, but she does at least straighten back up and move back a step. The last thing any of them want is to get into a pissing contest right now.

Once they're clear, Adora reaches back to grab the feline's hand to walk along with her, "Come on, we have to keep moving," she glares at the woman one last time before moving around her, bringing Catra with her.

The lagging women catch up to the rest of the group before walking in silence once more.

The group continues to move through the narrow passageways, occasionally stopping to talk about the paintings from events long ago. Shadow Weaver finds herself back up at the front of the group, looking for traps, and the two tense girls feel relaxed enough that they can let go of each other and join back up with their friends. Glimmer keeps elbowing Bow to point out certain figures from history, and the archer listens, observing his friend with a soft smile on his face.

Once they hit the bottom of a flight of stairs, with many of them stopping to wonder how far down these tunnels go, Shadow Weaver also stops and crouches to examine a spell left on the ground. Before she can figure out what it is or how to disarm it, however, the oblivious blonde princess goes walking right towards it.

"Wait!" Shadow Weaver calls with her hand out, trying to warn the unsuspecting girl.

But it's too late - Adora steps on the seal and is immediately encased in a ring of fire that stretches several yards off the ground.

“Adora!” the friends yell as Catra reacts, immediately leaping into the flames.

Everyone waits with bated breath before the duo tumble back out onto the ground, seemingly unharmed. Adora raises her hands, showing everyone she’s fine. “I’m okay! I’m okay” outside of her racing heart from the scare, there were no burns or anything. But that’s when she notices her savior, still laying atop her and looking down at her with relief in her eyes. The warrior can't help her heart melting at the gesture and takes a moment to relish in the girl's closeness, resting her hands down on the brunette's hips.

“Nice save," she murmurs up to her and Catra's smiles broadens. But both of the women become very aware and nervous of the fact that they have a room full of witnesses to their simping. The cat woman clears her throat abruptly to cut the tension and moves off the girl.

Once she knows her friends are safe, Glimmer walks forward to stick her hand in the flames, realizing it’s cool to the touch. “It’s an illusion,” she realizes.

“Some of the fire is illusory, but some of it is real,” Shadow Weaver informs the group while watching Adora help the cat girl back up to her feet- their eyes lingering on each other maybe a moment too long, “We’ll have to be careful.”

One by one the rebel soldiers walk through the illusion into the next passageway that’s shrouded by fire. A few of them gulp at the sight, but as long as they stay on the walkway and avoid the walls, they should be fine. They thin out into a single file line to avoid the flames as they move through this quite literal trial by fire.

Adora ends up at the back of the line, fortunately. While no one is watching she looks down at her hands and tries again to quietly call on She-Ra’s sword, only to be ignored the second time that day. *Why is this happening? And why now?!* The blonde squeezes her eyes shut for a moment and lets her hands drop in defeat.

When she reopens her eyes to resume her walk, she's surprised to find Shadow Weaver there, regarding her closely.

Whatever this is, it can't be good. The warrior furrows her brow at the woman, before walking forward again, but instead of falling back, her former mentor walks alongside her.

"You and Catra seem very… *friendly* towards each other these days," Adora feels her shoulders tense up at the accusation. Shadow Weaver doesn't say it explicitly, but her tone suggests she knows something. She doesn't know *what* the woman has gleaned about their relationship, but really, she shouldn't care. The rebel tries to shrug it off and continues forward, tossing over her shoulder, "That's none of your business."

"But it is," Shadow Weaver insists.

Adora shakes her head, knowing she should just keep going, but she's already ruffled enough from this day - she's not just going to stand by and let the sorceress get into her head again. So, she twists back around, her glare set before she goes off, "Whether or not we're 'friendly' with each other frankly doesn't concern you... We're adults now - we can make our own decisions because it's *our* business, *not* yours."

Shadow Weaver narrows her eyes at that before she continues, "If your emotions are blocking you from becoming She-Ra, it's all of Etheria's business." The warrior gulps and tries to keep a straight face, but she feels her heart drop and her eyes start to water. *How did she know?* Her former mentor steps forward and stops just in front of the girl so she can lower her voice. "How long has it been since you were able to transform?"

Adora clenches her jaw but lowers her head in shame with a defeated sigh. She looks down at her hands again. "It's been happening since the siege on Bright Moon," the saddened warrior feels tears stinging at the corner of her eyes as she clenches her fists together, "What if- what if I'm losing her?"

Shadow Weaver reaches forward and grasps onto the blonde's hands lovingly before answering, "Do you remember when I taught you how to use her powers to heal?" At the girl's nod, she continues, "In order to wield She-Ra's *full* strength, you have to be focused, *clear* headed… But you're letting your emotions pull you in too many directions." Adora feels the dread pooling in her stomach, praying she's wrong, but she can't help but try to glance back in the direction the feline is.

Before she can though, Shadow Weaver cups her cheek and keeps the princess facing towards her, "*Catra*, she- she dis*tracts* you, my child- con*fuses* you. She's spent her whole life getting inside your head, manipulating your emotions, *using* your own fierce loyalty against you." The soldier squeezes her eyes shut, preparing to pull away - *No,* she doesn't want to hear this, but Shadow Weaver changes course, taking on a more motherly tone she's always used with the girl. "*But* - if you *truly* care about her - focus on *protecting* her."

Little did the two women know, their conversation is caught by the subject's long ranged hearing as she stands just around the corner, struggling to listen.

Adora opens her tear-filled eyes again as Shadow Weaver continues, "The world needs you as She-Ra right now, not Adora," the warrior feels a stab in her chest at the words, so similar yet so different to the ones Catra had spoken to her before. *Is she right?* "If She-Ra can't stop Prime… we are all doomed."

That's the point when the princess finally finds the strength to jerk her hands away from the woman, taking on a defiant stance as she meets her gaze again, this time with determination. "I *will* stop Prime," she growls out, "No matter *what*."

Catra feels her heart sink at the words. She really hopes Adora doesn't mean what she thinks she means - doesn't mean that she's actually going to follow the mad woman's advice… right? When she hears the women on the move again, she quickly darts forward to rejoin the others before she's caught. A few of them

glance at her curiously when she catches up, but she can't even bring herself to acknowledge them… The brunette glances back to see the two women finally coming around the corner, Adora looking a little worse for wear. She needs to do something about this… sooner rather than later. She can't let the princess believe that anything Shadow Weaver just said is true.

"There you are," Castaspella lets out an exasperated sigh once the shadow woman has rejoined them, "I can't get this door open - I think it needs the Cast of Learning to open, but it's not working for me."

"Have you tried the Cast of *Un*learning?" Shadow Weaver asks her warily before joining her at the door.

"Of course, you would think *dark* magic would be at play here," Castaspella throws out the accusation before the sorceresses stand together to try out different spells.

While the others try to figure out how to open the door, Catra takes the opportunity to grab Adora by the hand to lead her aside and out of hearing range from the rest of the group.

"Catra, what-"

The cat woman holds up her hand, halting the warrior's question. She takes a second to peer over the taller girl's shoulder, making sure the others are distracted, before going down this road. When she meets blue eyes again, she lets it out, "Look, I- I never apologized to you properly."

Adora's brow instantly furrows, and she starts to shake her head, "Catra-"

"-I said a lot of things and did a lot of things I wish I could take back," the brunette swallows thickly, trying to hold her tears at bay, "I was angry at you for leaving and I blamed you for wanting this other life away from me. I convinced myself that I must not have been that important to you to begin with, but that was just an excuse for my piss-poor behavior-"

The princess reaches forward, placing a firm grip on her shoulder before trying again, "*Catra* -"

"-And then, when Shadow Weaver left me to go be with you in Bright Moon, I absolutely lost it." She can't stop the tears that fill her eyes at this point, but she can't stop now until it's all out there. "I blamed you for that, too, and I was so angry I tried to destroy the world. I wanted to make you pay."

"Catra," Adora's eyes are sad now, filling with tears like the cat girls.

"*Please*, just-" Catra shakes her head and tries to get a grip on herself before continuing. "Please listen," her eyes meet the warrior's again, this time with determination. "Adora, I'm so sorry. I'm sorry I didn't come with you, I'm sorry I blamed you for everything and that I was so angry. I'm sorry I hurt you…" she sighs, "I'm sorry for everything."

The princess releases her shoulder to reach up and cup the shorter girl's cheek, holding her gaze, "I *know*," she tells her resolutely.

There's no falseness to her words - Adora meets her gaze unwaveringly - she knows the blonde means it. Catra feels tears forming in the corners of her eyes again, her heart never feeling more full or fragile than in that moment. *Does this mean she's forgiven me?*

"A-Adora.. I-"

"-*Ladies*," Shadow Weaver's words float down the hall towards them, halting their conversation in its tracks, "Anytime now… preferably *before* the world ends."

Adora continues looking at her questioningly, but Catra shakes her head, having lost her nerve. *That'll have to wait.*

When the duo returns to the group, they all head inside the chamber the spell unveiled. Once they see it, they all stop and stare in wonder.

"*That's* the failsafe?" Bow asks incredulously, referring to the giant blue stone structure lying ahead of them, "It's definitely bigger than I thought it'd be… How are we supposed to get that to the Heart?"

"The failsafe is a code," Shadow Weaver tells them as she retrieves Adora and guides her up to the structure. "It's stored inside the crystal, but it needs a password to be released," the sorceress takes the princess's hand and presses it to the crystal, "I believe you already know what it is."

The blonde frowns at her, but then looks to the crystal, "We're Friends of Mara."

They all watch in stunned silence as the stone structure comes to life. When the light travels upwards, lighting the structure along the way, Adora takes a few steps back before the pillars open to reveal the code.

"What does it say?" Glimmer asks.

"Someone needs to go inside to-" the warrior stops to make sure she's reading it correctly, "'accept the failsafe'. What does *that* mean?"

"It means the failsafe must be bonded to a willing soul," Shadow Weaver explains, "And carried to the Heart of Etheria in their body in order to be deployed." Right at that moment, the structure lets out a burst of lightning that travels all the way down the pillars where the two women stand.

Bow suddenly looks very uncomfortable with this plan, "And are we sure that's safe?"

“We can’t turn back now,” the sorceress answers him, then moves to stand behind Adora to prompt her by grasping at her shoulders, “The failsafe is the final weapon we need to defeat the Horde. Once we *have* it, once we *disable the Heart*… this will all be over.”

The princess takes her cue and walks up the steps to approach the structure again. She pauses only briefly to calm her nerves before taking that leap of faith-

“*Adora-*” Catra’s voice stops her in her tracks, and then she feels a hand taking hers, “Don’t go in there.” The warrior looks back at her, concerned, but before she can ask what’s wrong, Shadow Weaver cuts in.

“*Catra-* this is not the time,” the shadow woman says in a chastising tone, but Adora is more drawn to the fact that Melog now stands at the feline’s back, with his red mane running wild, while he turns to growl at the sorceress. Shadow Weaver ignores the alien pet and goes on, “Someone must go inside to accept the failsafe.”

The former commander meets the woman’s glare with one of her own, “So, *you* do it then.”

As the others watch on, they see the sorceress physically retract, her eyes narrowing at the shorter girl dangerously.

Catra uses her hold on the princess to pull her back down off the steps as she approaches the shadow woman, “I’ve been watching you the whole way in.” Her tone is cold and calculating, “You’ve been here before, *haven’t you?* You could’ve taken the failsafe yourself and gotten all the power you’ve ever wanted - But you didn’t… *Why?”*

“You’re being paranoid, as usual,” her former mentor attempts to gaslight her, “We're on the cusp of having the tools we need to finally stop this war, and you're making a nuisance of yourself.” The brunette's frown deepens, but she doesn't take the bait. So, Shadow Weaver redirects, "This is the only way to stop Prime,"

she takes a step forward, her arm reaching out to the rebel soldier, "Adora understands that well enough."

Catra steps in front of the girl, blocking Shadow Weaver's access, before getting to the heart of the matter, "Why does it have to be Adora? *What* is going to happen to her? *What aren't you telling us?"*

At this point the others in the group, Castaspella, Bow and Glimmer, are all fully aware that Shadow Weaver has been pulling the wool over their eyes, and they form a circle around the sorceress, ready to attack if need be.

"*Answer* the question," Castaspella tells her in a threatening tone while Melog growls at her again.

Shadow Weaver takes a breath and resigns herself to revealing the truth, "Whoever uses the Failsafe must absorb the full magic of the Heart when it is destroyed." Adora turns around to look at the structure again, realizing the predicament they're in when her former mentor continues, "That much raw magical power would burn any mere mortal apart - None of us are strong enough."

"But She-Ra is," the blonde is mostly speaking to herself as she gazes at the structure, her heart sinking with every breath. Catra lets go of her and glances back to watch her, not sure what's going on in the warrior's head.

"Only She-Ra can hope to survive the process," the sorceress continues as she floats forward behind the girl, "No one else can do it."

Adora watches the structure light up with lightning again and clenches her fists. "And if I don't survive?" she has to ask.

Shadow Weaver reaches up to grasp the girl's face to turn her head away to look back at her. She tells her as gently as she can, "Then the magic will be restored to Etheria through your sacrifice… You will give us the power to bring us to victory. Prime

will be defeated.” Here the woman stops to caress her cheek, “Your friends will be safe.”

When Shadow Weaver releases her, Adora stares ahead unseeing. The realization of what she has to do is crawling through her mind, and she tries to process it while the others start to yell over each other.

“You were planning this all along!”

“Why are you surprised by this?!”

“It’s not going to work!”

“There is *no* way we’re risking Adora like that!”

Their voices get louder and louder while the princess turns to look at the structure one more time. All this time- this road she's been traveling since she first came across She-Ra's sword in the Whispering Woods... it was always meant to lead to this. She wouldn't be comfortable with anyone else taking the failsafe knowing it would only lead to their deaths, but her? She could survive. When she’s made her decision, she puts an end to the fighting.

“Stop it!” Adora yells and all of their voices slowly drown out as they turn to look at her. The warrior glances back and tells them plainly, “I’ll do it,” before marching back towards the structure.

“No, *what?”* Catra exclaims, immediately darting around Shadow Weaver to get to the girl before she steps on the platform, “W-what’s wrong with you?!” The feline feels tears growing in her eyes as she forcibly turns the woman around and grasps onto the collar of her jacket, trying not to shake some sense into her. “Shadow Weaver is *sacrificing* you, why can’t you *see* that?!”

“Because *even if she is*, it’s better than Prime getting the Heart and destroying the universe!” Adora argues back with the girl who she just realizes is trembling while holding onto her. She takes a second to lower her voice and grab onto the cat girl’s hands to try

and comfort her. “We’re out of options,” she tells her friend solemnly, resigned to her fate, “This is the only way.”

“Ahh!”

The girls are suddenly distracted by the sounds of fighting and look back to see the sorcerers that are under Prime’s control have finally found them. The rebels engage them, deflecting their magic, but one spell gets through heading right for them. Adora quickly pushes Catra out of the way to take the hit herself.

“Adora!” Catra cries and immediately jumps on Melog’s back to go distract Micah before he can strike her again. The warrior is able to get an arm free and immediately tries to call on She-Ra’s sword, only to once again be left without an answer.

“No,” she looks down at her hands despairingly before looking up at the fight scene again. The rebels are quickly tiring out, having used up a lot of their magic just to get here. They’ll need to make a break for it soon.

“Uh guys?!” Bow cries out from his hiding spot behind a pillar, “We should get out of here - I’m almost out of arrows!”

“The failsafe!” Shadow Weaver cries as she picks herself up from her last hit, “We can’t!”

Adora grits her teeth and uses her strength to break free of the ties from the spell and immediately charges for the stone structure.

“Adora, don’t!” the warrior pauses to look back at the tired feline crying out to her, “*Please*- It doesn’t always have to be *you!”*

The princess feels tears flood her eyes but immediately turns to finish her mission, ignoring the girl crying out to her again.

The rebels are quickly being overrun when Adora steps inside the structure. The power of the stones suddenly comes to life and starts flooding into her veins while she’s lifted up into the air.

Horde Prime, seeing this through the lens of King Micah's eyes, quickly lets out a shadow of dark magic that starts to engulf the room as well as the people in it. He laughs wickedly at their cries for help - their cries which are enough to distract Adora from the immense pain she's in. When she looks out across the room and sees the closest thing she has to a family being swept up in this never-ending darkness, a stillness comes over her that calms her pounding heart and mutes the sounds of suffering until all she can hear is her own breathing.

And in that stillness, she calls out one more time, "For the Honor of Grayskull!"

Much to her relief, this time She-Ra arrives, flooding her veins, making her surge with power. Once she's back on the ground, She-Ra strikes out with her sword, lassoing the corrupted sorcerers with strings of light, effectively cutting off King Micah's power. When her friends are freed, She-Ra glances down at her chest to find the glowing failsafe hovering just over where her heart is. *That was a close one*.

The 8-foot-tall princess immediately trots over to the fallen feline while the others start helping each other up. "I got it - I got the failsafe. Let's get out of here," she calls out to the others while stopping to offer her hand to the cat girl. But Catra only glares angrily at the glowing heart on her chest, tears flooding her eyes to the point they're overflowing. Then the brunette turns and flees the room, Melog trailing close after her. Adora feels a stabbing pain in her chest as she retracts her hand and watches the girl run away from her. She wants to call out, to chase after her, but somehow knows her old friend wants nothing to do with her right now.

When the others are up and moving, they quickly escape the chamber. She-Ra turns around to face the immobilized sorcerers once more and decides to seal the entrance. Even when they manage to escape their binds, they'll still have to find a way out of the room - that should offer them plenty of time to escape.

And time for Adora to figure out what the hell is wrong with Catra…

Chapter End Notes

Y'all let me know in the comments if you want me to go ahead and post the rest of the story when it's ready :)

In the Still of the Night

Chapter Summary

Alright guys - you can't blame me for this, but I am a bit of a musical theater nerd- musicals are just my thing. So, of course, I found a way to fit a song into the fic lol. The song is actually what the story is named for - It's called All I've Ever Needed and it was recorded by AJ Michalka (voice of Catra) for some religious movie I have no interest in ever watching lol. But if you've heard the song before or read the lyrics, you know that it could be easily used for Season 5 Catra. Like it really could've been Catra singing that song, and the fact it's sung by the same voice actress just makes it all the better.

If you haven't listened to it, you should definitely go check it out.

All I've Ever Needed
Singer: AJ Michalka
Songwriters: Benjamin Glover, Sarah Ruth Hart

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Previously

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Chapter 22

The group of rebels mostly limp or hobble back to the safe house to rest and regroup. Though it was a short journey back, Adora still struggled to get the cat woman to even look in her direction. The longer the feline goes about ignoring her, the more her heart hurts… Her heart which is already carrying the weight of the universe - the glowing first one's symbol being a constant reminder of that.

When they sit down with the rest of the war council to go over where they go from here, everyone is on edge. Their scouts have reported in that there has been a lot of unusual movements from Prime's army, so even though they've just returned from one mission, they need to prepare for the next.

"Alright everyone," Glimmer sighs but tries to rally the troops, "We have a few hours to rest before we launch our final attack on Horde Prime. We'll need to leave at first light, so before we disperse, we need to sort out who is going where."

"Glimmer and I plan to escort Adora down to the Heart of Etheria, but we could always use some extra hands," Bow stands besides the Queen and continues from there, "We have no idea what security measures the First Ones set up to protect the Heart, so we don't really know what we're up against. But aside from that,

we have our strike team and our back ups who will jump in in case things for the strike team get too messy."

Glimmer nods along before explaining, "Our strike team will hit Prime's army head on - dealing as much damage as possible while Entrapta sneaks around behind them to use the spire to upload her virus. Once she's done that, our friends will be set free, and we'll have even more fire power to take on Prime."

"That's right," Bow grins over at his friend, his eyes sparkling, before he addresses the troops again, "Once that's done, we'll have She-Ra activate the failsafe to release the magic - and then Horde Prime doesn't stand a chance." There's a few scattered excited hollars and applause while the best friends high five each other.

"Now," Bow claps his hands to get everyone's attention again, "Who's going where?"

"I'll be on the strike team."

Everyone is taken aback for a second when the former Horde commander answers immediately. Bow and Glimmer both glance at each other and then over to the crestfallen expression on their blonde friend's face. They all just assumed Catra would be going with them, but- Bow grimaces and clears his throat, trying to break the tension, "Okay- then, Catra will be helping to lead the strike team." The words haven't even fully left his mouth yet before the cat woman turns around and dismisses herself. "Umm-" he glances back over to Adora nervously before addressing the group again, "Who else?"

Bow and Glimmer both try to corral the situation and try not to draw anymore unnecessary attention to whatever is going on between the two frenemies, but that doesn't help Adora. The warrior swallows thickly with her arms crossed and her fists clenched. She grinds her teeth to try to keep the tears at bay - *I did what I had to do for the sake of the entire fucking universe. Why is she acting like this?* The princess decides she can't wait to

find out and turns to walk away from the group, too, quickly following the angry cat girl as she ignores the rest of the troop's stares.

Catra and Melog duck into the tented sleeping area, and the agitated blonde isn't far behind them. Once she breaches the tent flap, she immediately hones in on the cat woman who has her back to her.

"What the hell was that?" Adora asks, unable to keep the tears from stinging her eyes, even though her tone is more outraged.

The brunette chuckles darkly before throwing the tape in her hands across the room angrily and facing her old friend, "Well, I'm a distraction, right?" Catra's words slice through the blonde, "Now you don't have to worry about me *confusing* you." Adora feels her tears leak out as her stomach falls through the floor. She realizes too late that the cat girl must've heard her conversation with Shadow Weaver.

The warrior quickly steps forward to grasp the woman's shoulder, urgently trying to fix the situation, "Catra, no, that's *not* true. Please don't listen to her-"

She's cut off, however, when the cat girl uses her weight to push back against the soldier fiercely - so much so that she almost falls backwards. Almost. Adora catches her balance just as Catra lashes out at her, "*Why* are you like this?!" Now the former commander has tears in her eyes as she cries out angrily, "*Why* do you always have to sacrifice *everything* for *everyone else?!"*

The question hits her hard in the gut, leaving the princess speechless. She watches the woman unravel in front of her, tears streaming down both their faces now.

"When do *you* get to choose?" Catra asks her quietly, more broken than she's ever seen the girl, "... What do *you* want, Adora?"

More tears fall as the warrior regards her old friend with a trembling jaw. *I want you* … the words are there, on the tip of her

tongue, but she bites them back. That won't help them now, not when the future is so uncertain. "I have to do this, Catra," she argues, angrily - trying to push fury into her words to distract from her sadness. "I'm the only one who stands a chance to survive the process… I *can't* lose anyone else."

And with that, Catra's heart shatters for the second time in her life. If she thought she was broken before, it doesn't even compare to this. She's about to lose her best friend, the woman she loves, over her own stupid stubbornness.

"Okay," more tears fall before she brushes them away angrily, staring at the wall for a moment to control herself. "If that's what you want, if that's what you'll always choose…" once she's gotten a better handle on herself, she turns back to glare at the girl coldly, "I don't have to stick around and watch it happen."

"Catra, please…" Adora can't stop the tears as she watches her friend close herself off again.

"What? Do you *really* need another sidekick to leave behind?" The words are out before she can stop them. The brunette grimaces and closes her eyes for a second, knowing this isn't going to end well, but she can't stop herself now; her pain is fueling her anger. "If so, I'd recommend Shadow Weaver - though if the Heart doesn't kill you, *she* most likely will."

Adora falls a step back, immediately looking like she's been slapped as more tears spill over. Seeing this, Catra feels her heart constrict painfully in her chest, so she whirls around and punches the nearest wall next to her. Melog doesn't hesitate to step in between the two quarreling women, but this time he's growling at *Catra* while he stands protectively in front of Adora. The feline hears the growl and turns back around to point a finger at him disapprovingly, "Stop it!" she yells, not fully comprehending the complexities of why her alien pet is reacting that way, before she turns her glare back on the warrior, who glares right back through her tears.

“So, that’s it?” Adora spits out angrily, her heart breaking all over again, “I *need* you - Are you *really* just going to abandon me again?”

“You don’t *need* me, Adora,” Catra’s tears have finally run out - her heart is stone as she scowls at her friend coolly, “You never have.”

“Umm, guys?”

The two women immediately look away from the tent opening, trying to hide their anguish, as Perfuma pokes her head in. “Umm,” the peaceful princess can clearly see the tension in the room, but she was sent to break them up. “The rest of us have decided we’re too geared up to sleep, so…” she glances back over her shoulder for a second, “We’ve decided to just sit with each other and enjoy these last few moments of tranquility until we have to engage in war.” She glances at both of the girls awkwardly, “But um, well, your argument is disrupting the harmony - perhaps you’d like to join us? We could do some breathing exercises or-”

The princess is cut off when Catra turns and storms out of the tent. “Whatever,” she grumbles as she pushes past. Adora’s not much better, still reeling from the argument and seething at her supposed ‘friend’s last words to her - she storms out, too, heading in the opposite direction, far away from the cat girl. Perfuma is left there staring after them. “Okay then,” she says to herself before taking a calming breath. She doesn’t need to bring this negativity back to the rest of the group.

The rebels that have decided to stay up watch as the two girls storm away from each other to opposite ends of the room - Adora going over to the weapons table to make sure they have everything ready for their last battle, while Catra sits off to the side of Entrapta’s makeshift lab with Melog gazing at her. Everyone awkwardly looks at each other while glancing between the two, wondering what, if anything, they should do. Glimmer starts to get up from where she’s sitting, tucked into Bow’s side,

but he stops her with a gentle hand on her arm. She throws him a questioning look, but he just shakes his head. Whatever is going on between those two, they'll need to figure it out for themselves. The archer is fairly certain this isn't a problem the other two friends of the Best Friend Squad can get involved with.

After a few moments, the group resumes with their previous activities. Many of them are sitting around in a circle, chatting quietly amongst themselves while others are laid out, dozing lightly. The atmosphere is cozy - all of them knowing that the culmination of their efforts will be coming to a head in just a short time, so they want to enjoy these peaceful few moments while they last. Spinnerella laughs at something her wife says, while Bow continues plucking at the lute style instrument he found lying around. Him and Glimmer are both cuddling together, leaning back against Swift Wind's warm torso while the archer attempts to get a song out. It doesn't take long before Swift Wind loses his patience and lifts his head up.

"Bow, will you stop playing that thing?" he groans, speaking for more than a few of the people gathered around them, "It's terrible."

Glimmer immediately interrupts him, hoping to save her oldest friend's dignity, "Well, *I* like it." Bow smiles fondly over at the princess.

Perfuma chuckles demurely along with several others at the magical horse's outburst, before speaking up, "Bow, maybe you could have Catra show you a few chords first?"

Everyone stills, completely thrown off by that - not only because of the seemingly absurd suggestion, but also because Adora laughs loudly and mockingly at it.

The peaceful blonde is confused by the reaction, and, suspecting the other princess is being cruel with her laughter, decides to ask, "What's so funny, Adora?"

The warrior turns around and crosses her arms before glancing over in the cat girl's direction - everyone looks over to the other side of the room then, seeing the blush covering the brunette's face as she tries desperately not to make eye contact with any of them. "*Catra? ..*Playing a musical instrument?" the soldier looks back to Perfuma, tartly, "*That's* hilarious."

"I can, actually," it's spoken so softly the rest of the group barely hears her, but they snap their heads back over in Catra's direction - she's now glaring openly at the blonde laughing at her across the way. Her response just leads the princess to snort loudly, though.

Glimmer - trying to alleviate the tension by quickly cutting in to distract from her friend's blatant rudeness - asks excitedly, albeit nervously, "Really?" She really has no idea what's gotten into the soldier, but she pulls the instrument from Bow's hands and directs to the former commander, "Will you play something for us?"

Adora laughs obnoxiously while looking at her friend, "*Really*, Glimmer? C'mon."

Catra is red faced when she stands up to march over to the purple princess. She really doesn't want to do this, but at this point she'll do anything to shove it back in her old friend's face. "I *maybe* taught myself how to play while I was a gang leader in the Crimson Waste for a while," she grumbles at the laughing princess, but at the response, the rest of the group comes to life - everyone cheering her on, offering her words of encouragement, while Glimmer stands up to hand the instrument off to her.

Adora rolls her eyes at the display. *Oh please… this is ridiculous.*

Once Catra has the lute, she sits down on a crate, facing the core group while the warrior continues to scoff on the side. The feline ducks her head and puts her fingers in position - she's really starting to second guess this as she only knows one song, but it's too late to back out now.

Everyone stares in wonder as the cat woman gingerly starts to pluck out a slow but pleasing melody - even Adora loses her amusement and stares on unabashedly. It's beautiful. But what's even more surprising than the hardened Horde commander knowing how to play an instrument, is when she starts to sing:

Honestly, it's time for honesty
My heart is on my sleeve
Oh, will you hear me out?

The group falls completely silent - everyone is shocked to hear the pleasant raspiness of the feline's alto singing voice.

I've got nothing left
to give of me - I gave up
everything, so, there
is nothing left to lose for me now…

Catra is mostly keeping her eyes trained on the floor - her cheeks burning red - but she finally summons the courage to glance around the room at her newfound friends.

Will you forgive me somehow?

Glimmer is having to fight off tears while Bow tries to console her. No one pays attention to the lone soldier in the back slowly walking forward, so she can get a better view of the singing cat woman.

I've chased a million things
Bright lights and empty dreams
Now, here I am

Right where I thought I wanted to be
I'll trade it all right now
Leave it all and lay it down
To get back to where I belong…

Catra gulps and looks back down at the lute, but forces the next line out anyway.

Oh, all I've ever needed was your love.

It's pretty obvious to most of the group listening that the cat girl must've written this before she ever joined the rebellion, which makes the song all that much more heartbreaking.

Truth be told I made the
Horde my home - I let it
steal my soul…
But now I want it back

Catra swallows and raises her eyes again, glancing, unfocused, around the room.

`*Cause all I need is waiting*
in your arms, a place to
hang my heart
where I am known at last…

Summoning what little courage she has left, the cat woman manages to drag her eyes up to connect with Adora's across the way.

You're the one true thing I had...

After the line, her eyes fall back to the floor while the blonde starts to tear up again - her heart is in her throat while she tries to come to terms with what the woman is singing.

I've chased a million things
Bright lights and empty dreams
Now here I am
Right where I thought I wanted to be
I'll trade it all right now
Leave it all and lay it down
To get back to where I belong

Oh, all I've ever needed was your love.

Several of the rebels are tearing up now, and more than a few of them are glancing back and forth between the woman singing to the woman she was arguing with just before, knowing that the song holds more depth for them than the rest of the group.

And I know that I was meant to be
More than just an enemy

I know that you had hopes for me
I hope you still believe in… me

Catra's eyes are starting to tear up now as the lute drops off, just playing a few light strings while she sings the chorus again, quietly. Never in a million years would she ever have played this song for anyone, but now that she has… she's letting it all out there.

I've chased a million things
Bright lights and empty dreams
Now, here I am
Right where I thought I wanted to be

The cat woman takes a breath and starts singing out again, loudly from the depths of her broken heart. But Adora can't watch anymore - her tears are overflowing now so she quickly makes her exit to go hide. She doesn't know what to make of Catra's song, but she knows it's left her wounded heart open; all the pain it's suffered throughout the years bubbling just under the surface and spilling out of her eyes. She can't handle it...

I'll trade it all right now
Leave it all and lay it down
To get back to where I belong
Oh, all I've ever needed was your love

Oh, all I've needed was your love.

When the song tapers off and the cat woman looks down to pluck the last few notes, the rebels erupt in applause - all shocked but similarly elated to see something so beautiful from the woman who's hard as iron most of the time. Catra takes a shaky breath and looks around the room once she has her emotions back under control. Everyone seemed to enjoy it. Everyone, that is, except the warrior who she just realized is missing...

The feline stands up to look around and barely catches a glimpse of blonde hair as the girl ducks back into the tented sleeping area. Something about the princess dismissing her after she just poured her heart out everywhere for everyone to see- when the blonde basically forced her to step up in her own defense -brings her anger from before right back to the surface. The cat girl frowns and tenses up - their argument from earlier still weighing heavily on her. Shoving the lute back at the archer, she dashes off,

narrowly escaping all the rebels coming up to congratulate her. She doesn't have the patience for that - all she has left is her anger, so she stomps after the princess, realizing she still has a few more things to get off her chest.

As soon as Catra breaches the flap, she goes off, "Did you *ever* stop to consider that we don't want to lose you either?" When Adora turns to her with tears streaming down her face, Catra's heart stutters and it gives her pause. She has to slam her eyes shut and force herself to look away - she can't get this out if she sees the girl crying. So, she starts to pace the short distance across the makeshift room, "Did you ever consider that *any* of us would *gladly* take a cannon blas-"

The cat girl doesn't hear Adora's approach - she only stops when the blonde yanks her around and crashes their lips together.. Catra stumbles a bit from the momentum of being spun around like that, but Adora grips onto her hips and holds her steady against her. "Mmm," Catra can't help but lean into her strong frame and sink into the kiss for a moment, tasting her as her heart tries not to break out of her chest. It takes her a moment to realize what's happening, too distracted by the soldier's passionate, knee-weakening pace, and by the strong hands holding her in place.

But when the feline does finally catch up and accepts that this is really happening… this time *she's* the one who pulls away.

She grips onto blonde hair but only moves back far enough to break the kiss, so she can get a good look at Adora's face. The warrior holds her eyes closed for a moment longer, but then ocean blue open to meet the feline's mismatched aqua and amber. Catra tries her hardest to read whatever is going through the taller girl's mind, but all she can see is vulnerability and fear…

However, those are both overshadowed by the *hope* she finds there…

Hope for Catra.

Tears prick at her eyes once the cat girl comes to her conclusion - she nods as she states softly, “Okay… okay,” and then presses her mouth to Adora’s once more. The taller girl hums in contentment while her shorter companion wraps her arms over her shoulders and pulls her closer. The princess wraps her arms fully around Catra’s waist and pulls the girl flush up against while their lips fight for dominance.

Adora's heart is pounding, so much it's almost all she can hear. That song broke her- *Catra* broke her. She has the woman in her arms, their bodies pressed together, while she tries to get in as many kisses as they can in the short amount of time they have- the warrior is in heaven. She's holding her and kissing her like she's wanted to do since the brunette found her that fateful day, lost and broken out in the Whispering Woods. The princess has wanted this for so long, and she's not going to hold back anymore.

It isn’t long before Catra feels those strong arms lifting her off the floor. She doesn’t even realize they’ve moved that much until she feels her back connect to a wall. “Mmmm” the feline moans again and breaks away just a second to climb up and wrap her legs securely around Adora’s waist. The soldier grunts and reaches up to reconnect their lips while her hands slide down under her thighs, holding the lithe brunette up by her legs and by holding her captive against the wall. Catra doesn’t seem to mind though - she wraps her arms completely around the warrior’s neck and finally understands what it feels like to be tall as she makes Adora tilt her chin up to kiss her again. The rebel doesn’t seem pleased with the arrangement at first until she realizes she can press further into the cat woman, practically pinning her against the wall, to reach her easier - Catra seems to enjoy that as well.

They kiss each other with a frenzied passion. After years of wanting each other combined with the fear of what’s to come next, they keep up their erratic pace until their lips are sore and bruised. Once their lips feel tender to the touch, they finally slow down, pressing their mouths together sensually and gently, just enjoying the feeling of being able to do this freely… finally. Catra’s

wanted this for so long, she feels a few tears slip out and can't help but start to purr at the comfortable weight of the woman she loves against her, as they continue to kiss each other gently.



*** see end notes ***

The purring, however, sends vibrations right into the warrior's mouth and the sensation makes her lips… tickle.

Adora's frame starts shaking gently as she tries to contain her amusement, but it's enough for Catra to feel it - she, herself,

starts to smile and has to break away laughing. “Stooop,” she whines in between laughs before pressing their lips together again. Adora gladly receives her, but then the purring starts back up again followed by the rest of the cycle.

“'Dooora,” she whines, the childhood nickname slipping out as her tears continue to fall even though she’s laughing, “Stop it.” She tells her with a wobbly grin.

“Okay, okay,” the princess chuckles one more time before leaning up again, her tears finally starting to dry, “I’ll be good.” When their lips reconnect, they hold… trying to put all the pent-up feelings they have for each other through the connection, hoping that the other feels it. It’s wonderful. This time, when the feline starts purring, Adora can feel her heart almost explode from joy. She never wants this feeling to end. She's decided this is what she wants - all she's ever wanted. All of her fears and worries have flown out the window as she gives her heart completely to the woman who's held it for so long, feeling so relieved and so loved as she sinks into another kiss. *Finally*... She doesn't think she'd have the strength to fight whatever comes next without the lithe woman in her arms - or if the brunette was still mad at her. But now? She smiles as she kisses her again-

Everything is gonna be just fine.

“Hey guys?”

Adora and Catra’s eyes both shoot open at the same time, and they jump apart as soon as they hear the tent flap rustling. Glimmer, accompanied by Bow, who was the one who called out to them, look around before they spot the odd pair. The women both look clearly ruffled, their clothes and hair askew with matching blushes covering their faces. The Queen has to bite her lip to keep from grinning, realizing they must’ve interrupted the ladies ‘making up’. Bow must have had the same thought, because he elbows her when he sees her starting to smile - though he’s not doing much better. The two friends have to keep from looking at each other, otherwise they’ll definitely end up

laughing.

Glimmer clears her throat once she’s gotten ahold of herself and looks over to find Adora’s eyes still looking anywhere but at her. “It’s about that time,” she tells them, “The strike team needs to be leaving soon - we thought you might wanna rally the troops before they head out?”

The blonde, trying to be subtle as she sighs in relief, nods her head and passes them a genuine smile. *We've got this*, she thinks confidently. Bow opens the flap for them and she moves forward, casting a glance over her shoulder and holding out her hand for the feline. But the brunette’s eyes are still cast to the ground... and she walks past the warrior without a glance. Adora swallows gently and watches the girl walk out of the sleeping area ahead of her, but she tries not to worry about it. Looking up, she spots both Bow and Glimmer giving her foolishly wide grins, while the archer gives her a thumbs up. The sight makes her grin stretch all the way across her face and she roll her eyes before going with them, trying to act like it's no big deal. She doesn't think she's fooling anyone, though... especially when she can't even begin to wipe the smile off her face.

Sure enough, when they exit the tented area, they see the troops milling about - some grabbing weapons, other’s suiting up with whatever armor they have. Though the majority of them stayed up throughout the night, the tension is palpable… Everyone is ready to get out there and make Prime rue the day he ever set foot on Etheria. Adora is still grinning broadly - she, like everyone else, is ready to get on with it. She gets up to the front of the room and a hush falls over the waiting soldiers.

When she has all of their attention, she gets serious and begins, “Horde Prime gets closer to the Heart of Etheria every day. If he gets his hands on it, he could destroy worlds- galaxies… Maybe even the entire universe. The failsafe is our only chance at stopping him,” she pauses to look around at their expectant faces, “But Prime still has our friends. His hold over them grows stronger every day they’re chipped. If we don’t free them now, we

may lose them forever." Adora sees the worry in their eyes, and decides to alter course, "Prime holds every advantage in this fight - but we have a plan. Entrapta, being able to hack into the Horde's signal pattern, can upload a virus that will disrupt his connection to our friends and disable the chips all at once. So, we need to keep Prime's armies distracted while she gets to the spire to disrupt this signal." Everyone in the room nods, getting geared up to protect the princess at all cost. "I'm going to take the failsafe to the Heart and destroy it once and for all… We're going to make sure that Prime can never hurt anyone *ever* again!"

There's some scattered yells and claps as the group agree with her. She looks out across the room and finishes with a determined grin, "We're ending this today, for good."

There are several shouts of agreement as the strike team falls away from the rest of the crowd, heading towards the door, though several of them stop to say farewell to their friends. Adora walks over to where Glimmer and Bow are waiting for her with smiles that match her own. They may have been broken down time and time again, but if there's anything they can say about the rebellion, is that they won't stay down for long. Once she's close, she grasps her friends in an embrace before releasing them and getting down to business. "Okay, so after the strike team clears out, we'll head on over to the ruin…"

Adora still feels pumped as she lays out their plan, but slowly loses her smile and lets her sentence trail off as she watches Bow and Glimmer's faces take on a worried expression. She's about to ask them what's wrong when she notices they're no longer looking at her, but over her shoulder.

"Guys?" she asks before turning back to look for whatever has them so bothered. It doesn't take her long to spot the problem... and her heart stops.

There, at the back of the crowd currently exiting the building, is Catra. But she's not saying farewells... she's leaving.

Adora suddenly feels like her stomach is trying to fall out as her heart clenches painfully in her chest to the point it's nearly choking her. *No* … is the only thought she can get out before she sprints over to try to catch the girl before she leaves. Why did she just assume that since they made up, that meant the cat girl was coming with them? She has to stop this.

When she's close enough, she reaches out to grasp the cat woman's shoulder, "Catra, *wait* -"

When the feline turns around, her face is a mix of emotions- mostly masked with determination as she tries to shovel all her other feelings aside. Adora feels her heart clench again painfully when faced with the girl's walls... *This isn't good.* She wants to ask her something and opens her mouth to do so, but no words come out. Catra sees this - the expectant hope on her face underlying her worry - and somehow knows exactly what she wants. The heterochromatic eyes fall down to the glowing heart on the princess's chest... and her answer is to turn her head away while she clenches her jaw, trying to keep a grip on herself.

She can't go.

Despite the saddened warrior wanting the cat woman by her side all the way to the end to face.. whatever may come… Catra won't go - she can't.

The princess feels her energy boost from before leave her in a single breath - her shoulders sagging as her heart struggles to keep going. She feels tears creeping up on her, forming in the corner of her eyes as she watches the feline turn back to face her.

Catra's gotten a better control over her emotions now and looks at the broken soldier's face with her shoulders back and her walls firmly in place - the only thing really giving her away is the unshed tears in her eyes. She knows people are watching, she knows they're starting to hold people up, but there's this thing in her chest that wants to explode out… and she doesn't know how

to handle it. Neither of them do. This may very well be the last time they see each other, but they have no idea how to get the words out, how to express their grief.

The brunette takes a steadying breath and meets Adora's gaze with determination. She furrows her brow and tells her emphatically, "You stay safe… okay?" She says it fiercely but softly, trying not to draw any more attention to them.

Adora grinds her teeth, trying to keep her tears at bay and gives a single nod, knowing that's all she'll get from the former commander- she's made up her mind and there's no way for the princess to stop her.. She feels her heart break a little as she takes a step back, prepared to turn away so she doesn't have to watch her go, but Catra quickly grabs at the collar of her jacket and pulls her in so the shorter girl can crush her in an embrace. When she pulls back a moment later, both girls have red tinting their faces as they try their best to mask whatever it is they're feeling. Once her heart settles, she meets Adora's eyes again to say one more thing, "I'll see you on the other side."

The warrior swallows thickly and nods, trying to hold it together while the brunette turns her back on her.

"What are *you* looking at?" Catra barks at some of the voyeurs with her infamous glare, "Let's go, *move!* I'm not getting any younger."

Once the strike team has exited, Adora still stands there, watching the open doorway… watching it with tears in her eyes, hoping she'll change her mind. Bow and Glimmer, who watched the farewell unfold, look at each other sadly before approaching the lone princess.

"You're not trying to leave without us, now, are ya?" Bow elbows her in the side as he walks up, hoping to lighten the mood.

The rebel stands there and tries to swallow down the feeling of heartbreak so she can focus on the goal ahead. She turns to face

her friends with a forced smile and tries not to grimace at the obviously worried looks on their faces, “Are we sure it’s even safe for you to come? We don’t know what’s waiting for us down there… it could be dangerous.”

“Oh, come on, we’re not gonna let you have all the fun yourself,” Glimmer grins at her.

“Exactly,” Bow agrees, “Whatever we find, we’ll face it together.”

Adora lets out a sigh of relief and pulls her two friends into a fierce hug. They don’t mention Catra, and it’s for the best that they didn’t, but at least she can count on her best friends being there… for whatever comes next.

Chapter End Notes

*** this is my first attempt at a catradora illustration lol be gentle ***

The Heart Pt. 1

Chapter Notes

Welcome to the end :)

Previously

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Chapter 23

There’s something about the humidity of the early morning air, before the sun’s even completely risen over the horizon, that reminds the feline so much of preparing for battle with the Horde. But, unlike working for the Horde, this time she has much more at stake...

The strike team moves into their positions by sticking to the cover of the trees all the way to their destination - the giant spire located just outside the Whispering Woods where Prime’s battalions have been gathering. And there they lay in wait, everyone quietly monitoring the situation as they keep an eye out for Entrapta’s signal that she’s in position.

Catra stands outside of the group crouched behind a tree as she surveys the movements down below. She tries to mentally prepare herself for whatever’s to come while trying not to worry too much about the group they left behind... *Or how hurt she looked when I walked away...* The brunette shakes her head at the thought - she can't think about that now. She narrows her eyes at the enemy and tells herself quietly to focus.

It doesn’t help her concentration, though, when she hears someone walking up behind her.

Her ears twitch and she sighs, bracing herself for whatever the flower princess came to speak to her about. When she’s close, the brunette gives up her position in order to turn around and face the girl.

Perfuma regards her quietly. Unlike the rest of the rebels, the princess seems to be at peace for what they’re about to do, which Catra takes some comfort in. Her *expression*, however… The peaceful blonde’s eyes seem saddened, and the lithe cat girl doesn’t know if she wants to hear this.

“Why are you here?” Perfuma asks her softly and the shorter girl grimaces, feeling her stomach bottom out. *Yeah, I really don't wanna hear this.* The princess gently shakes her head at her, and

the cat girl feels the weight of her disappointment hit her in full force. "Why didn't you go with her?"

Catra crosses her arms over her chest and looks away from the princess, not able to handle this right now. "Because I'm a coward."

The demure girl inspects her curiously before following up with another observation, "You didn't tell her… did you?"

The brunette lets out a tired laugh, willing the tears not to spring to her eyes. *Of course, the know-it-all sees right through everything*. She doesn't even have to specify… Catra knows exactly what she's asking.

Perfuma sighs as she takes the girl in - the brunette has turned her face away from her, probably hoping to save face, but the peaceful girl is all too familiar with the action by now. She moves to stand at the feline's side and reaches out to stroke her back comfortingly while they both watch the Horde down below.

"You've suffered a lot of heart break throughout your life," the sentence is said softly - it isn't a question, it's a fact. Catra starts collapsing inwards as she wraps her arms around to hug herself - trying to contain her sadness. But she knows she needs to get this off her chest.

"I can't-" the lithe woman cuts herself off by shaking her head before trying again, "I can't just stand by and watch-" She stops again and tries to meet the blonde's eyes but can't quite manage it - she looks down at her feet instead. "I can't watch her leave me again while I stand by and do nothing… I'm not strong enough."

Perfuma feels her heart go out to the girl, knowing this can't be easy for her. She wraps her arm around the shorter woman in a side hug before releasing her to step forward and face her. Catra has trouble looking at her, so the taller girl reaches out to grasp her shoulder, calling for her attention. When the cat girl hesitantly

meets her eyes, she smiles softly at her. “Love isn’t easy - it never is. But it makes you better,” Perfuma smiles again before continuing, “You and Adora make each other better… You challenge each other and support each other when the other falls short. You're *good* for each other - the more you trust in that, the less fear you'll have.” Catra feels her throat tighten with emotion as she fights to hold her tears at bay. The princess can see she's struggling, so she continues, “It’s hard… keeping your heart open,” she tells her sympathetically, having seen her friends suffer time and time again, “It makes you vulnerable, but it doesn’t make you weak.” The former commander looks away here, but Perfuma waits patiently for the cat woman to meet her eyeline again, “And I have to believe it’s worth it.”

The words linger - softening some of the restraints the cat girl’s built around her heart. After a moment, she lets out a watery laugh before she asks, “You sure about that?” It’s pretty obvious that the two of them, along with Glimmer, have had a lot of trouble getting close to their significant others lately.

Perfuma smiles at her and goes to respond, but then something she spots farther into the woods brings her pause. The former commander loses her amusement when she sees the look of worry cross over the princess’s face and turns back to look and see what’s captured her attention.

Somewhere, deep in the woods behind them, is a green light illuminating all the trees in its path. Seeing as how the troops just traveled right through that area and didn’t see anything means it wasn’t there before. *What the fuck?*

“I don’t like the look of that,” Catra tells her.

“I don’t either,” Perfuma sounds worried. When the feline turns back to face her, she can see the worry clearly etched out on the woman’s face.

“Okay - you keep a look out up here. If I’m not back before Entrapta gives the signal, you continue without me. Can you do

that?" The brunette says decisively while walking over to Melog.

The flower princess forces out a brave smile, not exactly used to leading, but the commander can see the determination in her eyes. There's no way Perfuma is walking away from this day without Scorpia at her side. "I know you can," Catra tells her confidently, easing the princess's fears, before hopping on Melog's back and taking off.

She buckles down and urges the giant cat to run as fast as he can - she needs to find out what Horde Prime is up to before it's too late.

Once Entrapta is in position with Swift Wind, the scientist signals the troops across the way. The princesses strike first- hitting the Horde hard right out of the gate while the rest of the rebel troops come flying in after them, all of them yelling as they charge into battle. Meanwhile, Glimmer, Bow, and Adora have accessed the entrance to the tunnels that lead to the Heart of Etheria…

The final battle has finally begun. The war ends today, and, depending on if they play their cards just right, they could come out of this at the other end victorious…

But everything must go according to plan, and right now?

Catra feels the sweat building at her temple when Melog cloaks them with his invisibility, so they creep forward to spot the giant structure Prime has somehow built right under their noses. As they watch, they hear him:

"My brothers, the time has come at last," One of the clones, puppeted by Horde Prime, is standing at what looks like a control center as he continues to speak, "These rebels have chosen their fates - the Heart of Etheria will soon be laid bare, its power *mine* for the taking. And soon this planet will understand the *gravity* of their mistakes."

There's a chorus of chants from his numbers, "Cast out the shadows, cast out the shadows." The cat girl trembles as she

watches. When the chanting finally dies down, Prime then turns and tells his acolytes, “Begin the acquisition process.”

And then, right before her eyes, she watches the structure, which she now recognizes as a drill, start to move towards the ground. Dread fills her stomach and her eyes water from not blinking - as soon as the drill connects with the ground, it stops. She thinks that’s it and starts to breathe a sigh of relief when she sees it - suddenly the ground lights up, and these green veins, somehow built into the planet, spread out from the drill. They continue to grow and travel through the ground, all the way past where the brunette is hiding.

She looks at Melog worriedly and tells him, “We have to warn Adora.” The alien pet turns and she hops on his back before they take off back towards the shelter - hoping they’re not already too late.

Meanwhile, down in the bowels of Etheria, the trio of friends walk silently. Bow and Glimmer have already tried a few times to raise Adora’s spirits, but the woman has hardly smiled since Catra left. Glimmer trusts that everything will be okay. She doesn’t know what happened between the two, but they have a world to save. The Queen casts a worried glance over to the archer who sends it right back to her, before she speaks up. “Are you scared?” Glimmer asks She-Ra quietly, looking up at the giant princess gingerly.

The blonde shakes her head though, and the friends can tell it’s authentic - she really isn’t afraid. “No,” she tells them in case they need to hear it. “I really just hope this works,” she says light heartedly, not wanting them to worry.

“It will,” Bow says confidently - trying to instill his confidence into their tall friend. “We’ll be with you the whole way, and when this is over? It will be a new world.”

She-Ra offers him a forced smile, but then looks away before they see her grimace - even if they do succeed today and make a new world, there's no way to know for certain that she'll actually live to see it. She starts to move forward again when an echo captures her attention - the giant princess stops and looks around excitedly, "Did you hear that?"

Bow and Glimmer pass each other worried glances again, "Hear… what?" the shorter girl asks.

Adora starts to answer, but then she hears it again - a very distinctive laugh that she would recognize anywhere. "Catra?" she asks quietly, then immediately darts around her friends to backtrack the way they came.

"Adora? …Adora!"

The princess ignores her friends and tears through the hallway until she finds her. Tucked just around the corner, she finds the warm and welcoming sight for sore eyes. "Catra," she breathes out in relief, tears filling her eyes.

The feline offers her one of her rare and genuine smiles. "Hey Adora," she says affectionately, her eyes squinting as she takes in the woman in front of her, leading the taller of the two to blush.

"I'm so glad you came bac-"

"Adora!" Bow's voice interrupts her from down the hall where the friends are still running to catch up.

The warrior takes her eyes off the girl for a second to glance down the hallway, but when she looks back, the hallway has shifted… Suddenly she's looking at one of the Etherian Horde training rooms, and Catra- well, Catra suddenly resembles her 14-year-old self. Adora watches, confused, as the scene in front of her changes second after second while the former commander approaches her. First, she was a teenager, then a cadet, then her enemy, then the world's destroyer, before finally stopping in front of her as the woman she's fallen in love with all over again.

While the princess knows logically that whatever is happening right now isn't real, when the fake Catra reaches out to hold her face and pulls her in, Adora doesn't hesitate to lean in to meet the brunette's lips with her own. As soon as they touch, however, the hologram disappears, and the princess realizes she was one step away from falling into a depthless hole, probably to her death.

It's at that point that the two friends finally catch up - their legs being much shorter than the 8-foot-tall warrior's. Bow calls out to her to ask if she's alright, but Adora keeps facing forward, swallowing down her emotions and willing the tears to go away.

I really wanted it to be her, she thinks miserably. With every step she takes farther into the tunnels, the weaker she feels - and all she wants is her oldest friend by her side once again.

Once the tall blonde swallows down her emotions, she finally turns back to face her friends. "This place still has access to my memories," she says as she moves past them, "We'll have to be careful." While she keeps her head up and acts tough, it doesn't stop She-Ra from flickering out of focus a couple of times.

Bow and Glimmer both watch the princess fizzle, revealing Adora for a brief second, before she reverts back, and their worry returns ten-fold. They look at each other with exasperation before running to catch up.

What is going on?

Back on the surface, Catra pushes Melog as fast as she can. She can hear the sounds of battle happening behind her, and it worries her even more. Whatever this is, she has to stop it, or at least stop Adora before it's too late.

Once she gets to the shelter, she runs inside screaming for the blonde, looking around hurriedly. She doesn't see anyone initially

until-

“You’re too late,” Catra hears behind her, and she tenses up before turning around to face the shadow woman. “They’ve already left.”

Subconsciously the cat girl sees that the woman has been drinking, and, from her own personal history, she knows an inebriated Shadow Weaver is even more dangerous than when she’s sober, but she doesn’t have time. She marches forward and stops before the woman, “Where did they go?”

Shadow Weaver narrows her eyes at the girl, “To the first one’s ruin so she can access the Heart of Etheria and finally become the hero she was always meant to be.” She’ll always be proud of the girl, even if she wants nothing to do with her, but then there’s this one to deal with. When she speaks again, she’s chastising, “And if you’re honestly selfish enough to try and stop her-”

“ENOUGH!” Catra yells, shocking the woman by grabbing the collar of her cloak and yelling in her face. “This isn’t about you or me or our fucked up power struggle - Prime is up to something. He’s-he’s infecting the planet! We need to do something before it’s too late.”

Shadow Weaver has half a mind to throw the tiny girl across the room for her insolence, but then she stops when they both hear a voice coming from outside.

“Rejoice Etheria,” Horde prime’s voice echoes loudly for all to hear, *“For your day of reckoning has come.”*

The two adversaries relax their ire at each other momentarily and immediately run to get outside. There they find a hologram of Prime reaching as tall as the castle of Bright Moon, standing far above the trees for everyone in the immediate vicinity to see.

“I offered you mercy,” the hologram continues, “But you have

spurned my good graces… So be it!" The hologram reaches out of view and pulls back with the long hair connected to Entrapta.

Catra feels her heart squeeze as her fists clench - her claws biting into her palms; her eyes fill with fury and tears as she watches the helpless girl. The troops left at the scene of the battle all feel the dread coming over them as they realize the scientist has been taken… and there's no one to release the chipped friends who are currently there, surrounding them. *What are we gonna do?*

"All of your struggle has been for naught," Prime gloats, "Your She-Ra has abandoned you. Now all that is left for your world is a terrible and eternal night."

It's abundantly clear to all the rebels left on the surface - They're losing.

But they won't give up without a fight.

Catra immediately turns back to Shadow Weaver - "Take us to Adora… now!" She demands.

But the woman shakes her head, "She's probably already at the Heart - we have no way of catching her now."

"No," the feline argues - she doesn't believe her for a second. "*Use* your magic - I *know* you have more power than you're letting on." She *knows* she does, "You used it- w-when you left me in the Fright Zone. And you've *always* been able to track us our whole lives." Shadow Weaver narrows her eyes at the girl, but the cat girl will not be intimidated. "So, do something good for once in your miserable life and help me save Adora."

The shadow woman regards her coldly - Catra has talked back to her for the majority of her troublesome life, but never for the sake of another. She sighs and holds out her hand, "Come here."

The brunette hesitates - looking at the hand as if it's poison. But she doesn't have another choice - she needs to find Adora, and if she has to work with a snake to get to her, so be it.

As soon as their hands connect, they're off.

Back down in the tunnels of Etheria, Bow and Glimmer both struggle to keep up with She-Ra who still appears to be glitching, in and out of focus while she walks full steam ahead. The friends are starting to think they should be concerned, but they've been worried about the girl since they came down here. Anytime they try to slow her down or ask her about it though, she's unresponsive.

Adora has to focus. She can hear her friends calling for her, but it only pushes her faster and faster. The warrior can feel She-Ra slipping away from her at every moment, but it's too much. She can't focus on her friends, she can't think about Catra, she can't worry about what's happening on the surface - her heart is being spread too thin and pulled in too many directions. She just… can't.

Suddenly the scenery around her glitches again and she finds herself in the Whispering Woods, facing She-Ra's sword sticking out of the ground, and her heart nearly stops. Tears spring to her eyes and she walks forward, remembering too clearly what that day felt like so long ago… the day she discovered her fate. It held importance to her before - it made her special. But now as she approaches the sword, hearing her friends just now entering the clearing behind her, she finds herself resenting it. She reaches up to touch the phantom heart glowing on her chest as her friends speak up.

"Adora?" Bow can't keep the worry out of his voice. Why are they here? What's wrong with She-Ra? But he focuses on the most important question, "Are you okay?"

"What's going on?" Glimmer asks, memories from the day they met flooding her mind.

Adora drops her hand despondently, still staring ahead at the sword as she answers, "This place… it's responding to my memories. I think I'm doing this."

"Okay, umm.. So how do we get out?" Bow asks, looking around.

She-ra can't look at them, and she can't give them any more answers. She's already withheld too much today and lost as a result of it… She won't make that mistake again. But this has to be the end of it.

"When I broke the sword, I thought…" her voice trails off as she walks towards the sword, tears filling her eyes. The vines of the woods start piling up behind her, blocking her in or rather- blocking the others out. "I thought I could make my own destiny," she says humorlessly - how naive she was. "But I can't… it was always going to end like this," the blonde stops just in front of the sword.

The words ring alarm bells in both the friends' heads - they move to step forward, but the growing vines block their path. Glimmer feels herself start to panic as she looks for a way around, "What do you mean *'end'?"*

"I'm losing her," the friends stop when they hear the familiar sound of Adora crying and watch on- with She-Ra's back turned to them, she continues, "I'm distracted and confused, and I'm scared… I can't be any of those things if this is going to work." The tall woman clenches her fists as she looks at the sword. "I need to go the rest of the way by myself," she tells them resolutely.

"Adora, no," Bow exclaims, tears filling his eyes, "You don't have to do this."

"I love you guys so much," the words halt the friends in their tracks, and they watch the woman turn around, all of them openly crying now. "I never could have done any of this without you," she tells them honestly, her voice cracking. "Thank you for being

the best friends anyone could ever ask for," and with that, she turns back around and reaches for the sword.

"Adora, *no!"* Glimmer yells, running forward despite the vines blocking her path… but she never makes it. A blinding light falls over them and once their vision clears, they're back in the tunnels below Etheria. The princess looks around in a panic, her heart wrenching, but Adora is nowhere to be found. She falls to her knees then, her tears falling freely. Bow doesn't hesitate to kneel down and hug the Queen while they cry for their friend.

They're only broken away from their sadness when they hear a shift in the ground, like a collision happened, somewhere far off. When they look back the way they came, they see that the floors and the walls are suddenly being taken over by this green, sickly light - the veins of the ruin leading down to the Heart are being taken over by something.

They don't know what it is, but it can't be good.

They meet each other's eyes with determination - despite their friend leaving, they refuse to leave her. Once the two are back on their feet, they go charging ahead, calling for the girl.

"Adora?"

"Adora!!"

They receive no answer - for all they know, Adora's already made it to the Heart. But they continue ahead, only stopping when a magical seal appears on the floor in front of them. They skid right over it but turn around just in time to watch Shadow Weaver along with Catra and Melog materialize in front of them.

Catra doesn't hesitate. She immediately leaps towards them and grabs the Queen by the shoulders, "Where's Adora?" She asks in a panic.

"She-" Glimmer slams her eyes shut before looking back at the cat girl with tears in her eyes, "She left us… She's going to the Heart

on her own."

The brunette feels tears of anger creeping up on her. "Of *course,* she's gone," she curses the girl, "That's what she *does*, isn't it!?"

Their conversation is interrupted by the ground shifting around them, flecks of debris falling from the ceiling. Bow cuts in, narrowing in on the girl, "Catra, what the hell is going on up there?"

"It's Prime," she tells him, panicked, "He-he found some way to hack into the planet." She gestures to the green coding on the walls, "All of this - it's from him."

"He's going for the Heart?!" the archer asks.

She nods, but- "That's not all," she tells him sadly, "He's got Entrapta."

Bow feels his heart stop - *No.* He turns to Glimmer, "If Prime's got Entrapta, that means the other princesses are still chipped." He holds out his hand, "We have to get back up there."

But the princess refuses, tears still in her eyes, "We can't just *leave* Adora-"

"-*I'll* stay… I'll find her," Catra cuts her off, and both the friends look to her to see she's trembling.

"Catra-" Glimmer starts, unsure of herself.

"-I can't lose her again, okay?!" The feline yells with tears in her eyes. She takes a breath and tries again in a calmer tone, "Look, I… I made Adora a promise long ago that I'd look out for her." This time when she looks at the friends, it's with sad eyes, "It's time I made good on that."

Bow and Glimmer both nod, having complete faith in her. The princess, by far, is the most shocked to realize how much she

cares for the cat girl as she moves forward to embrace the woman in a hug. “Go get her, Horde scum,” she tells her affectionately.

Catra lets out an emotionally exhausted laugh, “That’s the plan, Sparkles,” she says as the archer joins them in the hug.

When they break apart, the two friends' group together, prepared to take off back for the surface. Catra decides to say goodbye to Melog, instructing the alien cat to look after them. She then straightens back up to smile at her new friends, and they return the smile in kind before they disappear.

As soon as they’re out of sight, the former commander gets serious again as she looks back to the shadow woman. “Let’s go,” she tells her, and starts running down the hallway as fast as she can.

But Adora is nowhere to be found…

When She-Ra grasped the sword handle, she was teleported. And when she finally opens her eyes, she sees herself on the ledge of a cliff, overlooking the kingdom of Bright Moon at sunset - it’s beautiful. She starts to wonder why the ruin is showing her this, when she suddenly spots Mara’s She-Ra standing right next her - their long, blonde hair blowing gently in the wind simultaneously. Adora takes peace in the moment, figuring it’s another glitch in the system, but she takes a minute to clear her conscience - If she can’t have what she wants, she can at least honestly tell her predecessor she has no reason to worry.

“I’m going to save Etheria, no matter what it takes,” Adora tells the image of Mara with determination, “Your sacrifice won't be in vain, I promise.” She then looks back to the sunset, but is shaken to her core when she hears her voice-

“But at what cost?” the warrior’s eyes shoot back over to Mara who still faces the sunset. *Did the hologram just-* “I never wanted to die,” Mara continues, “I sacrificed myself so you would never have to.” It’s then that Mara turns to face her, shocking the young She-Ra even more when their eyes meet. “Why are you doing this, Adora?” Mara asks her sadly.

How does she- Adora is flabbergasted. *How is this happening?* Whatever the reason, the warrior answers her, “It’s better this way.” She tells her sadly, her eyes dropping to the ground, “My friends will be safe-” Her mind flashes over images of Bow, Glimmer… Catra- she grimaces and continues, not sure who she’s trying to convince, “they’ll be happy-”

“-And you?” Mara cuts her off, reaching up to cup her cheek and bring her eyes back up to meet her own. “What do *you* want when this is all over?” the hologram woman asks her.

Though Adora knows this just has to be a simulation, her heart breaks all the same- a lump forms in her throat and she tears up as she suddenly pictures mismatched eyes looking up at her lovingly… And then the image shifts- the cat woman’s eyes are sad now as she asks her, disheartened, “*What do* you *want, Adora?”* The warrior slams her eyes shut at the memory and tries to will it away. “I-” Adora tries to answer but shakes her head roughly before meeting Mara’s eyes again, “It doesn’t matter. I’m She-Ra. This is what I’m supposed to do.”

Mara starts to answer, but they freeze as the hologram suddenly glitches- their world shaking for a moment. When it stops, Mara charges forward, knowing she needs to get this out before it’s too late. She reaches out to grasp both of Adora’s hands and looks at her earnestly. “You are worth more than what you can give to other people… You deserve love, too,” she tells her firmly, and Adora feels her eyes tearing up again. “You’re so close, Adora, don’t give up-” but the woman is cut off as the scene glitches again, freezing Mara in her place.

Adora steps away worriedly, watching the frozen hologram as the scenery suddenly takes on a sickly green hue. "Mara?" she asks worriedly, "What's-"

"Ahh… there you are, Adora." The princess spins around to find Horde Prime standing in front of her.

No… this isn't possible.

"You're not here - you can't stop-" she's cut off as the man literally walks right through her on his way to Mara.

"So strange," he remarks, pensively, ignoring her outrage, "I must've fought her… must've known her face. But hers, like so many others, have been lost to history… their brief light snuffed out by my hand."

Adora watches him with growing trepidation, when she's pulled from their conversation by a loud scream - something so loud and grating, there's no way it could be human. She conjures her sword and quickly looks back in the direction she came… but all she sees is the hologram they're standing in - the trees frozen in time behind her.

Prime continues talking as if it didn't happen - he turns around to tell her menacingly, "Just as *yours* will be."

She-Ra glances back for only a second, but it's enough.

She doesn't see the vine-like tendril whip out of the frozen forest to lash at her right across the ribs. The wound is painful, so painful, and it only grows. She-Ra screams out, holding her side. Though merely a flesh wound, it casts her in a green light until she's lost. When she falls to her knees, she's just Adora.

"A parting gift from the first ones," Prime tells her casually as he walks past her. Once he's stood in front of her, he looks back as the hologram finally disappears, revealing the monster on the other side. The blonde looks on in shock and horror. "Their old

security system… strong enough to take out one even as strong as She-Ra.”

As she watches, the monster stands back up to its full height, standing even taller than a house - it's many eyes, it's height, and vine-like tendrils make it a lot more terrifying than the spiders she's faced before. How is she supposed to face that?

“Goodbye, my oldest enemy,” Prime smirks at her before he disappears into thin air.

Adora feels the tears flood her eyes. She has no weapon, no armor, and now? She’s lost She-Ra. The broken warrior slumps back against the wall, crying out in pain once more. She keeps her hand over the wound like that will help, but it’s evident this is no ordinary injury.

The monster screeches again, piercing her ears as she turns her face away, hoping to hide away from it, but she can’t. She watches the creature loom over her as it slowly draws nearer, stalking its prey…

Adora closes her eyes and bows her head. *It’s over…*

I failed.

To be continued…

The Heart Pt. II

Chapter Notes

Whoof. Part II is the longest chapter yet. Hope you like it!

Previously

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I failed.

Chapter 24

Bow and Glimmer land just in front of the spire that Entrapta was taken from, which fortunately is lightly guarded now that most of Prime's forces have their hands full with the rebellion.

As soon as they materialize, the archer doesn't hesitate. "I'll go work on uploading Entrapta's virus - you go help the others," he tells her hastily as he turns to run towards the spire. But

Glimmer's firm grip on his arm spins him back around until she's crushing him in a hug, her face buried in his chest.

"Bow? …I love you," the girl admits with her eyes squeezed shut. She knows this isn't the best time, but they have no idea how this day will end, and she wouldn't be able to live with herself if she lost her only chance to tell him. She almost doesn't even want him to respond, but she at least needs him to know the truth. "I love you," she says again, feeling the weight finally lifted off her chest.

"Hey," Bow's gentle voice calls to her, and she hesitantly pulls back to look at him with her teary eyes. But there's nothing but warmth there. His expression is soft and open as he looks at his oldest friend adoringly. "I love you, too."

Glimmer doesn't believe what she's hearing, but then the man leans down to kiss her sweetly on her forehead. When he stands back up, he tells her gently, "Be careful for me, okay?"

"Me?" She laughs while brushing her tears away, "I'm always careful." Bow tosses her another smile before he turns and runs towards the spire. Feeling validated and empowered, Glimmer then turns and teleports into the battle - It's time for her to show Prime what the rebellion is made of.

And not a moment too soon. Their soldiers and princesses are weakened - they've been fighting this whole time, and once the corrupted Mermista and Scorpia showed up, they lost even more of their energy fighting them off. But as soon as the sparkly princess arrives on the battlefield, she glitter bombs the clones and sends them flying. With the reinforcements charging in after her, the troops renew their effort and are able to take out Mermista's chip as well as the other clones that are teleporting in.

Somewhere among all the fighting though, they've lost track of Scorpia and Glimmer suddenly worries about Bow. Now that the

rebels have gained the upper hand again, she decides she needs to go check on him.

"Aunt Castaspella, can you-" she turns and is shocked to see the frozen, horrified face of her Aunt, and behind her? All of their troops similarly stuck, held in place by the giant, magical seal suddenly covering the battlefield. Glimmer looks down at her own feet just in time to teleport out of the way before the dark magic sucks her in, too. Once she's safely outside of the seal, she tries to think fast - how can she fix it? How did this even happen? They were all fine just a moment ago. But before she can figure it out, a figure materializes behind her. When she looks back, she feels a tremor of fear run down her spine when she looks into the corrupted green eyes of her father.

"Hello, baby girl..."

There's sweat starting to pool at her temple. Whatever was transferred from the monster through her wound is making her sick.

Adora looks up at the creature wearily - some part of her begging for it to just get it over with… end her already. When the beast finally rears back, preparing to deliver the final blow, the warrior closes her eyes again, accepting her defeat.

What she doesn't expect is to hear a very familiar yell.

Her eyes shoot open, and, as she watches, Catra appears out of nowhere, leaping right for the creature's face to break one of its many eyes before landing gracefully back on the ground.

"Catra?" she asks in disbelief, her heart soaring. *Is this another illusion?*

The lithe woman glances back, relief flooding over her that she's found the blonde warrior alive - she responds, "Hey Adora," with a tired smile and then charges forward to attack the monster again.

No no no no, the broken soldier can't let her do this. She tries to stand, only to falter, her strength sucked right out of her due to the glowing wound at her side. But somehow, arms catch her to hold her up. It can't be Catra, so it must be-

Adora looks back and her eyes widen to twice their size, "Shadow Weaver?!"

Of all the alliances that could have come from this war, Catra and Shadow Weaver would be the last she would've expected. If it weren't for the feline actively destroying the very real monster, she definitely would think this is an illusion.

"Yes, my dear. We're running out of time," the sorceress pulls her back up to her feet and supports her weight. "We need to get you to the Heart." The woman starts escorting her towards their escape, but Adora still has a little strength left.

"No," she tells her adamantly and falls away from her to lean against the nearest wall. Her eyes seek out her friend again, "Catra?!" She calls, worriedly.

The beast screams out in pain as he loses more of his sight - Catra lands back in front of it again and turns to look back with fear in her eyes - Not for herself, but for the injured woman. "Adora, you need to go - I'll take care of this thing," she tells her sternly before glaring at Shadow Weaver, *"Get her out of here!"*

The shadow woman approaches her again and reaches out her arms to grab ahold of her, but Adora slinks away, further down the wall, "No. *No!* I'm not going anywhere."

Catra nearly drops her head in disbelief - of all the times for this woman to be stubborn - but she shoots back up, barely dodging an attack from the monster. It's getting more sluggish now. The

cat woman is definitely getting the upper hand over it, but they don't have time for this.

"Adora, *please*," she asks desperately, dodging another swipe, "I'm okay, but you need to go." The cat girl tumbles out of the way of another swinging tentacle before she adds, "I'll catch up with you, okay?" Then she runs full speed at the monster and launches herself at his face again.

Adora is crying now and reluctantly lets her former mentor grab ahold of her to lead her away. She's still on the fence; the warrior doesn't want to go. And as soon as they reach the doorway, she loses her willpower to walk away. She can't… not again. The princess grabs ahold of the frame and escapes her grasp, glaring at the conjurer when she tries to reach for her again, "I'm *not* going." She tells her fiercely.

Shadow Weaver has lost her patience, "Adora, *please*, we do not have time fo-"

She's cut off by the feline's scream.

Adora's heart stops and she looks out across the room to spot the girl. *"Catraaa!!"* she cries for her.

In the midst of their argument, the monster finally captured the agile brunette, wrapping one of its tentacles around her foot. Both the women watch on, helplessly, as the beast lifts up the crying woman, most likely to devour her.

The sorceress can't take her eyes away - she's frozen, watching the eternal pain in her side finally get defeated in battle… She doesn't know how to feel about that, but she definitely doesn't expect her heart to constrict painfully at the sight.

"Shadow Weaver, *please*," the tall woman looks back at her injured, pseudo daughter - she has tears streaming down her face as she pleads for the conjurer's help; this is the first time Adora has needed anything from her in years. Her mind flashes back to

the two girls running through the hallways of the Frightzone, starting food fights, sneaking around areas that were off-limits, stealing sweets from the pantry, terrorizing the members of their unit…

She never could separate them from each other… not for long.

And there's no way she'll be able to start now.

Catra's tears are streaming upwards, falling into her hairline as the creature holds her upside down - she's nearly over his mouth now. It's nearly over… But then she's thrown back on the ground.

The feline looks around frantically, hearing the sounds of a struggle, and that's when she sees her - her former mentor, hitting the beast with every spell she's got.

"Shadow Weaver, what are you doing?!" She yells - the woman is strong, but not nearly strong enough to take on something a hundred times her size.

The sorceress barely glances at her, but yells back, "Take Adora and run!"

"What?!" The injured brunette tries to stand, only to fall back down - her leg is pulsing from whatever poison was transferred to her by the monster. *Fuck*. "Get away from it!" She screams again.

"I told you to run, now *RUN!!"* Shadow Weaver throws her hand back, pushing the girl with her magic until she's in the hallway with Adora.

The brunette manages to stand up this time and runs back towards the room only to have Shadow Weaver block the exit. "Shadow Weaver, no!" She cries and bangs her fists against the magical barrier.

The sorcerer uses her magic to lock the beast in chains, but it'll only hold for so long. While she has a moment, she turns back to

look at the girl sympathetically. "Catra, please… you *must* get Adora to the Heart before it's too late."

The monster roars as it breaks free of the chains and immediately lashes down with a power strike against the conjurer who's able to use a ward to keep it at bay.

"Stop it!" Catra hits the barrier again, crying now for an entirely different reason. "It's going to kill you!"

"It's too late for me," the sorceress says sadly when she looks back at them again, "But you - this is only the beginning for you." Shadow Weaver tells her sincerely, "I am so *proud* of you, Catra."

The cat girl rears back, tears streaming down her face - the sorceress has never said that to her before. "No!" She cries, going to hit the barrier again, but Adora captures her fist and pulls the cat woman back against her. Catra glances back at her, relaxing against her frame and then the two women watch their old mentor remove her mask in front of them, intentionally, for the first time ever.

"You're welcome," Shadow Weaver tells them with her broken smile. Then she's engulfed in flames as she casts one final spell - a spell that takes all that's in her to disintegrate the beast and save her daughters.

Adora's hand flies up to her mouth, and she cries for the woman silently before Catra turns around and pulls her into an embrace. They cry for their mother, but don't have long to dwell there.. There's a war still happening on the surface, and it'll all be for naught if they don't get the failsafe to the Heart.

They pull back to look at each other sadly, before marching on towards their fate.

Glimmer is broken and bruised. She's tossed to the side again where she rolls across the hard ground. Taking a breath, she struggles to push herself up again - not sure that this is a fight she can win. Her father is the most powerful sorcerer in the world… Can her magic really compare?

"Dad, please," she stands and looks at him with tears in his eyes, "I just got you back… I don't want to lose you again. You have to remember me."

Micah lashes out, encasing his only daughter in dark magic, slowly choking the life from her when he answers. "Oh, I'm very familiar with who you are. My daughter… the failure- To think the kingdom was left to *you,* as if you could ever hope to fill your mother's shoes." With that, he lifts her up and slams her on the ground.

If the bruises and the scrapes weren't enough, now Glimmer has to deal with the lashes to her heart as well. The tears continue to leak from her eyes as she accepts defeat - she can't do this. That last hit at least cracked a few ribs - she won't be able to sustain another hit like that.

"And so it ends," Micah concludes, "My daughter… the weakling."

The words are spat out in disgust, making her cringe. She wants the ground to swallow her up and eat her whole, but that word… No, she's not a failure- definitely not *weak.* When she blinks her eyes, her mind flashes to a brilliant image of her mother - the strongest woman she knew. Angela wouldn't stand for this… and neither will she.

"No," she grunts out between clenched teeth as she pushes herself back up, "I'm not."

Glimmer then takes the offense, teleporting around him so quickly he can't keep up - hitting him with sparkle blasts at every turn. Micah tries to find her, to get a lock on her, but it's no use. He

does the only thing he can do. With a terrifying yell, he lets loose a storm of dark magic, encircling them - Glimmer is sure to get sucked up in it, no matter where she teleports next. But much to his surprise, he sees his daughter there, approaching him in a ward of light - a very difficult spell to master, even more difficult to hold against such an onslaught of power.

"How are you doing this?!" He yells, but he can't lose his focus - all he has to do is keep up the storm long enough to outlast her ward.

"My mother taught me to be brave… my friends taught me to be kind," Glimmer tells him ferociously as she approaches - the look in her eyes chills him to his core. He's never seen a sorcerer so steady in the midst of battle. "And I'm stubborn - I get that from you," her moment of weakness is over, now standing before him, she shouts at him, "I will *never* stop fighting!! And I *won't* lose another parent!"

She takes a breath and casts the spell of cleansing, just like her aunt taught her, with all the stillness and assurance her father has shown her, and pushes it into him. "I love you, dad," she says tearfully, before she unleashes its full power, knocking him clean off his feet while the darkness inside him evaporates into the air.

Bow feels the sweat pooling at his temple, trying desperately not to breathe too loudly.

Scorpia interrupted him before he could finish uploading the virus, and it's only thanks to Melog that he's been able to keep hidden from her. But she's not leaving, which means he'll have to do this now… as quietly as possible.

The duo creep back over to the monitors where the archer starts typing as quickly and as silently as possible. He's almost finished - he just needs a few more…

"I got it!" Bow exclaims while pounding the launch key - but the monitor suddenly explodes in front of him. He only has time to gasp before Scorpia shoots another stream of electricity right for him, zapping both him and Melog back into the visible world. Bow starts to panic, immediately backing up so he's pressed against a wall - Melog lays dazed at his side while Scorpia approaches them, preparing for another strike.

No, no no… He knows he did it right and completed the sequence, so why isn't it working? Bow glances nervously over to the remaining monitors, watching as the virus continues uploading… it'll take a few more moments, which means he's officially out of time.

"Scorpia, wait! Please-" Bow holds up his hands in surrender when he sees her claw start to light up, "I know- I know you don't want to do this, any of it… And I know that Prime maybe made you do a lot of bad things, but it's okay. Because you know as well as I do that he can't turn you into something you're not." The corrupted princess pauses and watches him with her green eyes, completely void of emotion. "You're Scorpia - you're brave, strong, loyal… and you give great hugs," he tells her with a teary laugh, "And your friends? The people who care about you? They're waiting for you - they *need* you, Scorpia… All you have to do? Is just trust me, *please*." Bow pleads.

And somehow, that works.

With a great yell, Scorpia manages to defy Prime's control just long enough for the virus to complete, and once it does, her chip fizzles and dies before falling off her neck.

Similarly, all around the world, the ones who are infected suddenly regain their consciousness, regain their selves. And far away, on Prime's mothership, he watches on as he loses all of his puppets at once.

"Ha *ha!"* the captured scientist exclaims, "I *knew* my virus would work."

Prime growls with barely contained rage, "Deploy all battalions! Get this under control!" But if he wasn't angry before, he becomes incensed when his screen starts to project holograms to his spires all over the globe. The man, the sidekick, to the princesses, suddenly appears, and Prime's hand tightens on his controls.

"Hey everyone, I'm Bow," is the message he projects for everyone to see, *"I don't have much time - I'm airing this message on Prime's private channel, so I'll have to make this quick."*

"Prime has been controlling the universe for too long, and now? We're the only things standing in his way for total control. I know the situation seems hopeless - I know with his numbers it feels like we don't stand a chance… And maybe we don't. Prime is too strong, his army is too powerful - but that won't stop us. It can't. We need to show Prime that he can't defeat us that easily, because we have each other."

Together the rebel troops start to pick each other up as they watch Prime's back up battalions start to land everywhere around them. But they won't back down. The princesses start to power up - getting their second wind to finish what they started.

"We can't give up - and if we go down, we go down together. We need you, all of you. It's time to take back our world. We need to fight - fight for She-Ra, for our homes, and for each other!"

Prime breathes in haggardly - these rebels are proving to be more of a pain than they're worth. "Put an *end* to this mockery," he growls at his acolytes before turning to glare at them

"Destroy them all!"

The two women are haggard and limping, barely able to hold themselves up. But Catra is determined - she pulls the warrior's arm over her shoulders and holds her up as they walk the final

part of their trek. Adora is too busy trying to memorize the beautiful woman's profile - she knows the fate of the world hangs in the balance, but all she can feel is grateful for her old friend coming back to see this through with her. She didn't realize just how much she needed to see her until then, and now she feels like she has the strength to see this through. The warrior prepares to speak - not exactly sure what she wants to say to her, but knows she needs to say something - when a simmering light casts over them..

They're here…

The princess moves to stand on her own, and the duo walk into the chamber where the Heart of Etheria resides. The entire room is cast in iridescent lights shining through the crystalline structure as it rotates seemingly on its own in midair. The women are star struck for a moment as they study it, but they don't have a moment to lose. Adora steps forward underneath the crystal and reaches out for She-Ra's sword.

As she concentrates, she sees the light of the sword shining, trying to break through the air just above her hand- but she can't hold it. She screams out in pain as the virus, now infecting the rest of her body, has travelled all the way down her arm…

Catra immediately bolts forward at the girl's scream and catches her before she falls backwards. "What the fuck just happened? What's wrong?" the feline asks her worriedly.

The princess looks down at her infected appendage with tears in her eyes. *I can't do this*, she thinks - the realization of what that means turns her stomach. "I can't- I can't transform," she tells the woman holding her up quietly.

"Okay, so.. What does that mean? It won't work?"

Adora lifts her eyes, staring blankly ahead - her heart quietly breaking for what has to come next. "No… it'll work," she tells her solemnly as she turns around, but then tries to sound confident so

as to not worry the woman. "You need to go- get as far away from here as possible. I have to do this next part on my own," she tells her resolutely, hoping she'll just accept it and go.

"Adora," Catra has her face set, determined, as she asks her bluntly, "What is going to happen to you?"

The blonde swallows with some difficulty, but can't keep the tears at bay, "Without She-Ra, the power of the Heart will destroy me… I'm so sorry, Catra," she weeps for the girl - this is exactly why she didn't want to come with her. *I did this*, she thinks, miserably, "But we don't have any more time." Adora steps back towards her, hoping she can bring the girl some comfort, "I can still fix everything… I can do this."

When she's standing in front of the girl, she cups the brunette's face in both hands and brings their foreheads together, relishing in the closeness of her friend one last time. "I'm ready," Adora sighs, and drops her hands, prepared to turn away- But Catra grabs onto her.

"No," is all the feline says in response.

Adora starts crying again, "Catra, please-"

"-No, I'm not leaving!" She tells the warrior adamantly, "Whatever happens, I am *staying* with you."

There's no talking her out of this. The princess has seen this look on her face enough times to know. She nods, solemnly, and turns to face her fate with Catra falling in behind her.

Here goes nothing.

As soon as Adora stands under the Heart, she immediately falls back in pain.

"Adora?" Catra yells, worriedly, as she catches her. The woman is screaming and dropping her entire weight back on the smaller girl. "Adora!" the cat woman yells again, while assisting her to the

ground. As she inspects the warrior's prone form, she sees the failsafe glowing over her chest, but it's flickering with the same green hue as the rest of Horde Prime's virus. "No, no no," Catra gasps and then winces when there's a terrible explosion overhead - she looks up to see that Prime's virus has finally infiltrated the chamber and now is taking over the Heart.

The cat girl feels the overbearing weight of dread settle over her as she watches the Heart suffer.

No…

Back up in space, Prime surges with energy. He laughs maniacally as he feels the power of the Heart coursing through his veins.

"Hahaha! I *feel* it," he shouts, "The Heart is mine!"

"You can't do this!" Entrapta yells, "The Heart is too powerful - it's unstable! It will take you and the whole universe with it!"

Prime starts unhooking himself from the controls, "I have had enough of this chatty little rebel - it's time to end this." He marches towards the scientist then, a wicked gleam in his eye. "You've forced my hand with your tricks and your schemes," he reaches out with one hand and grabs the princess by her hair roughly. "But now I will unleash the Heart and we shall die in cleansing flame together!" Horde Prime exclaims before using his new power to teleport them to the battlefield.

The princesses, now completely out from under Prime's control, unleash their magic against the battalions and finally start to see the victory within their grasp. They're all there, fighting before the spire, as the last of Prime's minions start to fall.

But they're all disrupted.

Suddenly there's a cloud of darkness whirling around overhead, and Prime's mothership travels directly over them. *This can't be good*. That's when they hear him.

"REJOICE ETHERIA! FOR YOUR END HAS FINALLY COME!"

Glimmer and Bow see Horde Prime for the first time, standing up on the crumbling ledge, looking down at them. But then the ground beneath their very feet starts to crumble. The two grasp onto each other and struggle to keep their balance.

"YOU HAVE CHOSEN DARKNESS, AND SO INTO DARKNESS YOU SHALL BE PLUNGED!"

The large crevices splitting into the ground causes them to shake, but what's more terrifying is the green fire that spews from its core.

"THE WORLD WILL END IN FIRE!"

Bow keeps Glimmer close - holding her to try and protect her from the world erupting all around them. Screams of panic fill their ears as the princess looks up to him. "Adora?!"

"The failsafe," he's in shock as he meets her teary eyes with his own, "It didn't work."

Prime continues to shout to the heavens for all the rebels to hear. They watch him in terror as the flames reach up to scorch the sky.

"And once the ashes have scattered- *THEN* … THERE WILL BE… *PEACE!!!"*

"No," the feline feels the dread overwhelm her as she watches Prime's virus continue to ravage the Heart. *We're too late…* She

turns back to the woman crying out in pain only to see her lose consciousness. "Adora?!"

"Adora!!!"

The yell barely breaks through her subconscious mind, but then it all fades to black.

When Adora opens her eyes again, she's faced with her reflection in the waterfall fountain back in her chambers at Bright Moon. She inspects herself closely, but something is very, very off. For one, she's wearing her hair down - she never wears her hair down… and the dress?? What the hell is going on? Not only that, but the woman somehow appears to have aged 10 years overnight.

She reaches out as if to touch the image, but stops… What is this?

Before she can figure it out, she hears a high-pitched giggle that sounds oddly familiar. When she turns around, she sees a tiny magicat running into the room on all fours. Something about the sight reminds her of a young Catra running in the halls of the Frightzone long, long ago. The child starts running circles around her legs as the women chasing him come hurdling in.

Catra, with her hair pulled back and a loose button down top, begins to chase the child around her, saying, "C'mere you brat." Glimmer, who's hot on her heels, stops and watches the scene breathlessly. "I told you we should've closed the door."

The taller cat girl eventually catches the child and wrangles him in. Once he's settled, Glimmer hands the woman a brush and then passes off a tiny suit to Adora. Before the blonde has a chance to ask any questions, Bow enters the room.

"Come on, guys," the man says as he walks up to put an arm around Glimmer, "Scorpia will kill us if we're late to her first ball."

"They're almost ready," Glimmer tells him before she pats him on the chest and pulls him back out of the room.

"Wow," Catra breathes, and Adora's eyes are drawn back over to her. The cat woman stands in front of her after having brushed the blonde boy's wild mane and examines the princess from head to toe. "You look-" she stops and clears her throat, seeming to just remember there's a child in the room. She leans down to not-whisper in the boy's ear, "Finn, you wanna tell her how beautiful she looks?" She then grins mischievously up at the woman causing her to blush - she doesn't think 'beautiful' is the word she was wanting to use.

The boy looks up to the warrior for the first time, and she has to stop herself from gasping at his beautiful blue eyes, so similar to her own.

Is that…?

Before she can finish the question, the two-year-old responds, "You look boootiful, mommy."

Adora watches him with tears in her eyes, trying to control herself. Catra kisses him on the head when he goes back to fiddling with the buttons on her shirt. She then shifts him out of the way so she can step up to plant a small kiss on the stunned princess's lips before gesturing to the door. "You almost ready?"

Adora eagerly nods and smiles, trying to contain her joy. "Well, come on then," Catra reaches her free hand out for her to take, which she readily reaches for-

But her hand falls right through. With growing dread, she looks back up to see the frozen, glitching image in front of her… It wasn't real.

As her heart sinks, she hears his voice before she sees him…

"Ah, what a beautiful wish," Prime's face appears, destroying the family image. Adora can only look at him with angry tears in her eyes, "But there will be no happy endings - not for you!"

Adora feels herself screaming again - the pain of the virus completely taking over her as she's locked in this virtual dimension with no hope of escape.

Catra rocks the woman gingerly - she's glad that she's finally stopped screaming, but somehow her unconsciousness is so much worse. How can she fix this?

When she holds a hand in front of her face, she can tell that the taller woman is barely breathing, and Catra starts to choke on her sobs. *No, this can't be it… This can't be real.*

"Adora," she calls helplessly before she shakes the girl.

"Adora!"

This time when the yell breaks into her mind, she actually latches onto it. When she opens her eyes, she sees her there, leaning into the doorway of the Prime's prison while she reaches out desperately to her. Is this real? Adora wonders, or is this another trick?

"Adora, please!" she cries, "You have to wake up!"

Catra goes back to rocking the girl gingerly, crying over her as she watches her closely for any signs of life. She tells her desperately, "You can't give up." Her tears start to fall on the girl's face, "You've never given up on anything in your life…"

"-not even on me."

The words ring in her head - they're familiar - and when she closes her eyes again, she sees it… The two of them… dancing under the stars.

No, not the stars.

She looks around the memory and sees it more clearly. Her and Catra at Elberon, dancing outside under the stringed lights. The

cat girl is looking up at her with tears and love in her eyes and the blonde can't help but reciprocate it.

"So, don't you dare start now!" the words break her out of her reverie. She opens her eyes to face her again and instantly reaches forward, trying desperately to grab her outstretched hand… but she's too far away.

"I can't," Adora tells her miserably. "I failed."

"No, no…"

Catra buries her face into the woman's chest as she hugs her lifeless body, trying to control her sobs, "I'm not letting you go."

Adora watches the woman cry over her helplessly - what else can she do?

She's resigned herself to her fate, slowly closing her eyes when the feline screams out again-

"Don't you get it?!" Catra cries, her tears falling down over the girl, "I love you, I always have… So please, just this once… stay!"

"Stay," Catra cries into her chest, fully sobbing now as it's no longer rising and falling with breath. *No… please, no…*

She doesn't see the crystalline structure start to fight back in protest against the virus. All she sees is the electricity striking the floor next to her, so she covers Adora's body with her own, trying to protect her, only for a bright light to suddenly shield them away from it.

When Catra feels brave enough to look back, she releases her hold on Adora and looks over her shoulder to see… She-Ra's shield? Before she can even comprehend what's happening, the shield disappears and Adora's hand falls back on her shoulder to pull herself up.

The feline's eyes grow to twice their size when she feels the blonde moving, and quickly jerks her head around to watch the girl struggle to sit up… The cat woman is utterly speechless when she watches those ocean blue eyes finally open to meet her own.

Adora looks at her full of hope, trying to memorize every detail of the woman's face as she asks candidly, "You love me?"

Catra chokes out a laugh at the ridiculousness of it… *Did this woman really just come back from the dead to ask me if I love her?*

There are tears streaming down her cheeks as she confirms it, "Of course I do, dummy," but her face turns serious when she sees the woman hanging on her every word like her life depends on it. The weary warrior smiles at her, her own tears spilling over now.

"I love you, too."

Catra can't even begin to control the smile that nearly splits her face in half. She lets out another tearful chuckle before she grabs the woman's face and kisses her for all she's worth.

The two women sit there like that, under the spinning Heart that grows brighter with every turn, as they stay liplocked - tasting each other and trying desperately to express their feelings with every kiss. They're so engrossed in each other, they don't understand the warmth that floods their veins, making them feel lighter and lighter. It's not until Catra opens her eyes to see the glowing princess attached to her that she realizes what's happening.

She-Ra, she smiles softly before closing her eyes and kissing the princess again.

Welcome back.

“Cry, Etheria!” Prime laughs maniacally as he watches the ground crack and fill with his destructive power, “You will all be consumed… in undying flames!”

Everyone on the ground stumbles, trying to keep their balance while also trying to avoid the large, gaping crevices opening up all around them. Bow pulls Glimmer into his chest again once he regains his balance. *This is it… isn’t it?* They gave it their all, but it’s finally over. The archer presses a kiss to the shorter woman’s hair as tears stream down his face. He wishes they had more time…

But as quickly as the crevices opened, they stop…

The green hellfire that was shooting up from the ground now turns into golden, harmless specks of magic floating through the sky. Everyone looks around, confused. Why did he stop? But even Prime doesn’t know what’s happening. It’s not until a light burns through the entrance to the Heart that they finally see why it stopped. She-Ra walks out of the ruin, glowing as bright as the sun. The rebels start to hope again as the princess surveys the damage done to their planet…

That won’t do.

She-Ra lifts up her sword and drives it into the ground - the power that bursts forth heals the damage and replenishes their beautiful climate, bringing back the flowers, the grass, and the trees. When she’s finished, it looks as if Prime never visited their planet.

The giant princess goes to visit him next. He can’t comprehend how he was defeated… he had everything within his grasp and then…

The glowing princess kneels before him where he's fallen on the ground. He will have the final word - he always does. “Prime will rise again, as it’s always been, so it always shall be.”

"No," Adora tells him plainly, then grasps his head in her hands, holding him still. "It's time for you to go." As he sits there, the princess uses her power to enter his mind and cleanse all traces of him, so he can no longer hurt anyone else. And then he falls, lifeless on the ground before her. She-Ra stands up then and looks into the confused red eyes of one of Prime's minions standing a few feet away. He looks at the girl's blonde hair and shining blue eyes - she looks so familiar.

"I remember you," Hordak tells her. Adora smiles.

"Welcome back, Hordak," she tells him.

"Hordak?!?!" They both look over just in time for Entrapta to nearly tackle the man and cling onto him with her hair. Adora can't help but chuckle at the sight before looking on at the rest of the rebels. Everyone is laughing, clapping each other on the back, finding their lost loved ones…

It's over… she sighs in relief as she shifts back to her true form, *he's finally gone.*

"Adora!" She hears her friends before she sees them. She turns around just in time for Glimmer and Bow to embrace her in a hug.

When they pull back a moment later, Glimmer looks up to her with tears in her eyes, "You did it."

Adora matches her watery smile with one of her own.

"No… *we* did it."

Scorpia is surrounded by people, looking around dazedly. Everyone, all of her friends, welcoming her back to the land of the living, and she can barely contain herself. *But where is* …

She's thrown off balance by someone wrapping around her middle. When she lifts her arm up to investigate, she finds the flower princess there and almost swallows her tongue.

“Oh wow- hey,” Scorpia says with a blush coloring her cheeks. When the princess lets her go and comes around to face her, “You look great,” the words are out before she can stop them. But Perfuma doesn’t seem to mind. She giggles at the woman’s bashfulness and uses her claw for balance as she steps up on her tiptoes to deliver a kiss to the red princess’s cheek. “Oh-” if it were possible for her to blush more, she doesn’t think that’s ever happened before. “That’s-that’s nice.” She rubs at her cheek before she can make an even bigger fool of herself. But she’s saved from having to string an actual sentence together when someone else latches onto her back.

Now, this one is a little more difficult because she has no way of turning her head around that far to see who’s back there but is distracted temporarily by the blonde princess giggling again. She can’t even begin to imagine who would’ve elicited that response from Perfuma, but then she hears the faint purring behind her.

“KITTY!” She shouts as her face lights up. She reaches over her shoulder and grasps onto the brunette’s uniform before dragging her forward and cradling her like a babe in her arms.

“No, hey! Let me go!” Catra laughs and half-heartedly tries to escape.

“No way,” Scorpia tells her joyfully but at least lets the cat woman stand on her own two feet while she reaches out to hug them both.

Glimmer has just finished hugging, laughing and crying with the other princesses when she sees the brunette swept up in Scorpia’s arms. She laughs and shakes her head at the sight before she’s unsuspectingly pulled into another hug. But these arms she’s familiar with.

The Queen leans into the man and buries her face in his chest, taking comfort in his presence. “We did it,” she sighs in relief before pulling back to look up at the archer, “It’s over.”

"Yeah, it is," Bow's eyes shine down at her and she feels her heart rate kick up a bit.

"Glimmer?"

The purple princess's eyes widen, and she turns sharply to find King Micah finally awake and looking at her worriedly.

"Dad?!" She rushes over to him and throws herself into his arms… Which might've been a bad call seeing how he's still weak from their battle.

"Whoa," he laughs as he stumbles a bit but manages to hold her up. Once they've embraced each other for a few solid, loving moments, King Micah eventually pulls away to look down at her with sad eyes. "I hope I didn't hurt you."

Glimmer has tears running down her cheeks for the dozenth time that day as she shakes her head. "Nuh uh," she gives him a watery smile, "It wasn't you - I know that."

King Micah returns her watery smile with one of her own and cups her face so he can place a gentle kiss on her forehead. Bow watches the whole exchange with a tired smile. Everything is back to the way it should be.

Catra, Perfuma and Scorpia stand there at a loss for words as Entrapta reintroduces Hordak to their group - the brunette and the red woman both watch on with barely concealed amusement as the eccentric scientist has Hordak shake Perfuma's hand. And Catra can't help but laugh out loud when the scientist drags the other three away to go talk to the rest of the princesses to see if they'll mind if Hordak stays. *That's gonna be such a fun conversation*, she thinks. Though she's technically not a princess, she considers catching up to them to watch just for the entertainment value when a gentle hand on her shoulder stops her.

When she turns around- she wasn't sure what she was expecting, but it definitely wasn't Adora's tired but relieved smile. Catra relaxes instantly when she sees she's not about to be hugged or slobbered on by someone else but can't help but wonder why the princess is here with her instead of off celebrating with her friends. She's about to ask her why when the blonde reaches forward to cup her face and bring their foreheads together.

Oh… the brunette's eyes widen at first as a blush colors her cheeks, but she smiles when she realizes she really doesn't give a fuck who's watching. *Finally,* she thinks as she reaches forward to grab onto the warrior's hips. This is what she's always wanted… and now it's finally hers. Catra sighs happily and can't help it when her eyes start to water. Adora watches her like she's the most intriguing thing on the planet, which just makes the cat woman smile even wider.

"It's over," Adora whispers to her and strokes her cheek with her thumb. "He's gone," she can't believe they actually won.

"Good riddance," Catra chuckles and watches the woman who holds her heart pull her closer. Their eyes fall closed as their lips connect softly. There's a few whistles and shouts at the display, but the women can't be bothered. Catra tilts her chin up to reconnect with her lips and counts herself the luckiest woman alive that she gets to do this whenever she wants.

Everything is perfect.

The two women only break apart when they're nearly knocked over by Bow and Glimmer running to grasp them in another "Best Friend's Squad" hug. The feline wants to roll her eyes but ends up laughing instead. She's never known what it means to have a family before but, looking out across all the friends she's made recently, she imagines it has to feel a little like this.

"So, what's next?" Bow asks when they finally pull apart. The brunette leans into Adora's side just as Glimmer leans into his. Catra takes comfort in the arm that's casually wrapped around

her, gripping at her waist, and she does the same - wrapping an arm around the woman as they face their friends.

Glimmer sighs, but answers him, "Well… first thing's first - we need to rebuild."

"That's gonna be a lot of work," Adora states, but she doesn't seem to be upset by the prospect. In all honesty, none of them are. They'd gladly take weeks or months of rebuilding their world over fighting the Horde.

Catra's actually looking forward to it. "Yeah," she says, gazing up at the warrior whose eyes shine down on her, "It'll take some time."

"I'm not worried about it," Bow rests his head on top of Glimmer's, and the pair watch the two women make lovey eyes at each other. When they finally look back over to him, he smiles at the group. "As long as we're together, I think we can handle just about anything."

"Agreed," Glimmer smiles up at him with tears in her eyes.

"Yuck," Catra can't help it sometimes, but the rest of the group laugh while Glimmer chases after her, trying to tag her with a kiss.

Adora laughs until her side hurts as she looks around at the relieved and happy faces of the battle worn rebellion.

Yeah, she thinks, blissfully-

We're gonna be just fine.

To be continued…

The End

Chapter Notes

And here's the finale :) hope you enjoy

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 25

The Horde is defeated.

Across the universe, people are celebrating their evil reign coming to an end. The rebellion arose victorious, and there are reports coming in from all over, courtesy of their fully functioning intergalactic telecommunications system, about how the Horde is falling back from all of their own strongholds.

A new day is dawning.

"Catra?"

"Mm-mm," the feline immediately declines, and the blonde has to try not to chuckle.

For the last several days, the rebellion and all of their allies worked towards ridding their planet of the Horde for good. Though Prime was lost, some of his clones remained loyal to him and weren't going down without a fight. It was a collective effort, but with everyone working together they were able to finish them off, once and for all.

Adora clears her throat and tries again, "Catra."

This time, the cat woman yowls at her softly from the back of her throat to let her displeasure be known. The princess has the

thought to chastise the girl but quickly gets distracted again.

Not only was Etheria officially free and clear from the Horde, but they were being chased off other planets as well. And fortunately for Entrapta and Hordak, in the wake of the Horde's defeat, they're swimming in new technology and ideas for inventions - and not a moment too soon. After the war, it became abundantly clear that it would take some time to rebuild - not just repairing Bright Moon's castle, but countless villages and cities across Etheria had suffered damages as well. So, on top of ridding the world of the Horde, they also had volunteers going out every day to help the victims rebuild their homes and communities.

It was going to be a long road, but they were prepared to handle it.

And as for her and Catra…

The princess tries another tactic, slowly reaching up to dig her fingers into messy brunette strands, so she can gingerly scratch at the back of the cat woman's scalp. The only response she gets, though, is a soft purr rumbling in the cat girl's chest… She still refuses to move.

The two are closer than ever. They'd spent the last week since the war ended working with their friends to help rebuild Etheria and wipe any trace of the clones away… that is with the exception of Hordak, of course. But they'd start their days and end their days with work, so much so that they had very little energy for anything else by the time the exhausted women made it back to their room every night.

That is, until the feline gets the princess in bed, and then, suddenly, her backup reserves kick in to lead to such lecherous activities such as these...

Adora gulps softly and prepares to pull off the new stunt she learned by trial and error - it's honestly the best way to handle this kind of situation. Trying not to draw too much attention to

herself, she slowly closes her fingers around the hair at the back of the girl's scalp and prepares to pull her away-

But Catra is onto her.

As soon as her fingers close, the cat woman brandishes her fangs and presses them to the tender flesh at her throat. She yowls again at the girl lying prone underneath her, refusing to let go from where she's buried her face in the princess's neck - a place she was very happily lavishing with kisses and kittenish laps until the blonde so rudely tried to interrupt her. When Catra uses her advantage to bite down on the skin there threateningly, the warrior immediately releases her hold on her hair and squirms underneath her, squeezing her thighs together for probably the dozenth time that evening to try and alleviate the pressure that's been building there.

Oh yeah - that's another new thing Adora's learned on these nights alone together. Apparently, the warrior has a thing for being scratched or bitten, so long as the brunette doesn't push down too hard. Once Catra figured this out, she's used it to her advantage ever since, much to the soldier's dismay.

"Is this okay?" Catra asks a moment later, her voice rumbling from where she's resumed kissing and sucking on the taller girl's neck.

Adora can't help the moan that's pulled from her at the action, but she really needs to get control of the situation and fast. She unconsciously bares her throat more to the girl before she tries to sound firm and authoritative. "Catra," the blonde warns, her voice comes out raspy, though, as she places her hand over the girl's to halt her ministrations.

"Whaaat?" The cat girl whines, finally giving up her spot on the princess's neck and moves up to press kisses to her jaw and cheek so she can get a better look at her. Adora meets her eyes and tries not to smile at the brunette's genuinely disappointed face. "I'll be more careful this time," Catra says sadly while she

delicately squeezes the recently captured breast to prove her point.

The blonde's breath hitches in her throat for a second, and she has to bite back another moan as the cat girl starts gingerly pawing at her breast, being careful not to scratch her like she did the night before. *Fuck, what is she doing to me?* The gradual pulse intensifies in her core, building the pressure there with every passing moment, making it harder and harder to resist the girl… Especially when she's looking at her with those big, pleading eyes with her dilated pupils.

Really… how can she say no to that face?

Uuggghhh, but she has to.

The warrior reaches up to pet the cat girl tenderly before telling her again, "We're going to be late." When Catra groans and drops her face to the woman's shoulder, Adora chuckles but continues, "We're *already* late, actually, and you putting this off isn't going to change anything."

"But why," Catra argues, lifting up her head to face her again, "*Whyyy* are we having a party *now?* On the *first* night we get home at a reasonable hour. What is *wrong* with that girl?" She grumbles.

Adora can't help the smile that blossoms on her face. *Some things never change*. Even though the feline and the Queen get along better *now*, they still seem to get on each other's nerves occasionally. "Because we never got a chance to properly celebrate after the war, and this is the first night we're all here at the same time," the taller one tells her patiently before gently prying the girl's hand off her breast. Catra grunts at the action and doesn't seem at all happy about the circumstances. "You promised you'd go with me," the princess reminds her with a raised brow.

But the cat girl still refuses to remove herself from on top of the girl.

The warrior sighs and tries another tactic. "How about this… You come with me to the party…" she starts even though the annoyed girl actively acts like she's ignoring her. "... And I'll let you help me get changed for bed after."

At that, Catra's eyes shoot back over to the amused ones beneath her, wide and hungry. She blinks a couple of times like she's trying to make sure she heard that right, and the next thing Adora knows, she's being literally dragged out of the bed and towards the door. The blonde can't help but laugh at the brunette's eagerness but has to plant herself because *no way* are they dressed up enough for the Queen's celebration party yet.

Most of the guests have already arrived by the time the late couple actually show their faces. Adora is wearing a red dress similar to the style she wore to princess prom while Catra puts on her old suit - it worked for her before, so it'll work for her now. Everyone is dressed up to the nines, wearing their fanciest clothes and their finest jewelry (if they have any). Adora and her girlfriend, however, were lucky enough to find a somewhat passable outfit for the evening.

The duo split up after a lingering gaze as they go to meet up with their friends. Catra reaches out to snatch a glass of champagne from a tray while she comes up with a plan to see as many people as quickly as possible so she and Adora can retire back to their room early. She's finally decided - she's really not much for parties, especially when she has much more interesting business to tend to. But she sighs and resigns herself to have a good time - many of the princesses will be returning to their kingdoms after tonight to focus on helping their own people, so it may be a while before she sees many of them again.

Scorpia, she learned, plans to go with Perfuma back to Plumeria. Seeing as how the red woman doesn't really have much of a kingdom to return to, she figures she can spend some time with her crush while helping them rebuild their villages. As far as the cat woman knows, things hadn't progressed much farther between the two. I mean, it's obvious that the flower girl has eyes for the broad shouldered red woman, but Scorpia still tends to be a little clueless about the whole situation. Perfuma doesn't mind, however - finding her obliviousness very charming. It doesn't stop her from flirting with the woman whenever she gets the chance though.

Speaking of…

Catra spots the two love birds conversing on the other side of the hall. Perfuma is wearing her usual color, pink, but this dress has accents of red mixed in to match with her much taller companion. Scorpia, it seems, chose to wear a dress as well, but this one is a mix of black with red trim - it looks good on her, though. That, coupled with her black lipstick, makes for a stunning look. It's almost kind of humorous how the flower princess can't seem to take her eyes off her. Scorpia locks eyes with the cat woman across the way and stops in the middle of their conversation with Bow to smile and wave at her. Seeing this, Perfuma and the archer glance back, too, and both offer her pleased smiles.

It is weird being greeted by princesses with smiles instead of punches these days.

The cat woman chuckles as she thinks back to when *Scorpia* was about *ready* to throw punches when she finally cornered Catra earlier this week. The red woman, like many others, was extremely thrown when she witnessed the feline and the blonde warrior lip locked after their victory over the Horde that day. Perfuma, giggling, even said the armor-shelled woman was shocked into silence for several minutes.

"How could you not tell me?" Scorpia had asked her, wide eyed with her mouth agape. Though later, once the shock wore off,

she did admit that it made a whole lotta sense considering how the two frenemies used to have it out for each other whenever they fought. It's honestly a shock she didn't realize it before. *"I knew something was bothering you,"* Scorpia recalled the day she seemed to be avoiding Adora when they were back in Bright Moon. It all makes sense now.

Of course, everyone was extremely happy for the two. Especially Glimmer and Bow who coo over them whenever they engage in PDA, which they try not to do. Yes, they are together now, but they are still hardened soldiers who prefer to at least have the appearance of strength and independence… even though they do usually end up holding hands, because they can't *not* touch each other.

And speaking of the cheerleading squad - Catra watches as Bow brings Glimmer a drink. The Queen smiles graciously at him and holds his gaze maybe a moment too long. Though they don't have any concrete evidence yet, many of the rebels believe the two to be an item or at least well on their way to becoming one. If they'd spent more downtime chatting with the couple, Catra probably could've gotten to the bottom of it. But as it stands, most nights everyone barely has enough energy to make it to their rooms, let alone socialize. Which is how they ended up here - taking one night to celebrate before everyone gets back to their ordinary lives.

But maybe not *too* ordinary.

Catra smiles as she observes her blonde counterpart across the way. She's speaking with Hordak and Entrapta and appears to be trying to corral them into staying. Hordak definitely doesn't seem the type to go to parties, and she bets Entrapta is just really eager to get back to her lab to tear apart some more Horde tech.

The feline sighs wistfully, *Some things never change…*

Clink clink clink

Everyone in the ballroom quiets down and turns their eyes towards the center stage where Queen Glimmer taps on her glass in front of a microphone. Catra narrows her eyes in confusion, wondering why she's talking instead of letting the band play, but just waits with everyone else while she sips on her drink.

"Evening everyone," she smiles out at the crowd, "I just wanted to say a few things really quick - We are all here tonight to celebrate our hard efforts in the war that finally paid off." When she pauses, there are a few claps and hollers from the crowd. "It took each and every one of us to succeed, but those efforts were not in vain. I know it took a lot from us… Some lives were lost," Catra tries to swallow down her emotion when she thinks about Shadow Weaver, but the purple princess continues, "But if it weren't for them, we wouldn't be here today."

There are a few more claps even though the mood has turned somber, but Glimmer turns it around. "We will continue with the gift they have given us - a new chance at a new life in a whole new world… A world that's finally free from the Horde where we can live, and where we can thrive." Catra joins in on the more lighthearted applause, cheering for all of them. Bow distracts Glimmer by letting out a loud, celebratory yell that makes the crowd laugh. The Queen's eyes are shining as she looks down at the archer before she continues, "Now while we all contributed to the battle, and it took all of us to see it through to the end, there is one individual who I think deserves some recognition tonight…"

The cat girl grins broadly and looks over to the woman she loves with unshed tears in her eyes. *Go get 'em, She-Ra*, she thinks, proudly. Adora meets her gaze just as lovingly, though, when she confuses the cat woman by shaking her head with a blinding smile on her face.

Catra loses her smile a tad and raises an eyebrow at the woman questioningly.

"Catra?" The brunette turns back to face the stage and sees the entire crowd looking back at her proudly. When her eyes make

their way to Glimmer's expectant gaze, she continues, "Could you join me on stage for a minute?"

Umm… what?

Catra looks at everyone watching her and feels panicked for a minute - *Is this some kind of joke?*

"Come on," Glimmer tells her with a smile and the crowd parts, creating a direct path for her to the stage. The cat girl gulps and slowly makes her way forward. She looks at everyone questioningly as she passes, hoping they'll fill her in on what's about to happen, but they all just hold the same look of fondness until she steps up on the platform besides the Queen.

The princess smiles at her softly before continuing with her speech. "Now, I'm sure all of you remember just how upset I was about Catra joining us," she starts, leading several members of the crowd to chuckle- the commander relaxes just a bit but still shifts uncomfortably on her feet at all the extra attention. "But, as with many choices I've made recently, I was wrong," here the Queen smiles at the brunette again, "It turns out she was just the hero we needed."

Many of the crowd applaud, whistle, or call out in agreement leading the cat woman to blush profusely.

"Now without further ado," Glimmer turns to Bow then who quickly hops up on the stage to pass her something. Everyone waits with bated breath as the Queen turns back to the cat girl with a shining medal in her hand. "The Kingdom of Bright Moon doesn't hand out medals very often, but I felt it was only right for this occasion," she tells the crowd before she steps up to pin the medal on the surprised feline's lapel. "I gift you the Medal of Valor - for acts of bravery and for your measured steps of wisdom - You helped save the innocent at the first attack on Bright Moon and then charged forth to secure our victory over the Horde… Not to mention, the many, *many* times you steered us in the right direction despite my opposition," everyone watches on with bright

smiles on their faces when Glimmer reaches out to grasp the cat girl's shoulder firmly. "We couldn't have done it without you," she tells the woman sincerely and the room erupts in applause.

Catra swallows thickly, trying to hide all the emotions she's feeling at this moment - her eyes glaze over the crowd at all the smiling faces until she finds the blue eyes she needs to see. Adora is cheering probably louder than most with tears in her eyes. They've both suffered a lot to get to this place, but here they are… And the blonde couldn't be more proud of her.

The lithe woman nods at her, a small, nervous smile gracing her lips as she tries once again to reign in her emotions - but Glimmer's not done. Once the crowd quiets down again, she continues, "Thank you for everything you've done for us… Commander Catra." The brunette's eyes widen and there's a few whistles thrown at her, but the Queen only looks at her softly. When Catra has no response, the princess just grins at her fondly before adding, "The position is yours if you want it."

Catra chokes on her laugh and isn't able to stop the tears springing to her eyes. She shakes her head with her smile nearly splitting her face in two, as she holds out her hand for the Queen to shake on it. Glimmer has no trouble with that - she grasps her hand tightly, giving her a firm shake, before pulling the unsuspecting cat woman in for a crushing hug. The crowd applaud her again and once the two women are able to pull themselves apart, Glimmer goes back to the microphone. "Let the party commence!"

There's a few more shouts of excitement as Catra steps down from the platform only to move through the onslaught of hugs, high fives, and congratulations. It takes her forever to break free of the crowd, but once she does, she finds Adora standing there, waiting for her with eyes full of love and adoration.

"Did you know that was gonna happen?" Catra blurts out the first question that comes to mind, but Bow steps in to the blonde's defense.

"Now, before you get upset," the archer holds his hands up in surrender, "Glimmer made us promise not to say anything." Here he glances back to their taller friend for confirmation, "She said she wanted it to be a surprise."

"Mhmm," Catra rolls her eyes good-naturedly and waves the man off, "I'll deal with you later - right now-" The feline reaches forward to grasp the tall princess's hand in her own. "I need a dance."

The cat girl tosses a smile over her shoulder at Bow before pulling her lady away. Adora doesn't really seem to mind that she's pulling her outside, but at the same time, the warrior hasn't stopped staring at her like the sun shines out of her ass. It's not until they're outside and ducked around a corner that the tall woman seems to snap out of it… And that's only because, as soon as they stop, the cat girl turns and pulls her unexpectedly into a heated, toe-curling kiss.

"Mmmm," Adora hums in contentment and lets her eyes fall closed - Catra digs her fingers into her ponytail to hold the woman close while she kisses her for all she's worth. The women stand like that for a moment - lost in the darkness while the commander does everything in her power to get as many kisses as possible in the short time they have. When the brunette grasps at her waist with her free hand and squeezes just a bit when she pulls the blonde against her, Adora feels her knees almost buckle. What started as a kiss turned into something else very fast. So, the princess takes the opportunity to nip the girl on the lip and break away - though Catra doesn't let her pull back too far. The cat woman pushes their foreheads together so she can look up at the other woman wantonly.

Adora can see the hunger in her eyes, and it makes her feel weak again, but they're not going to be doing this outside where anyone can walk out to find them in such a compromising position. So, the taller girl leans in to press a slow, lingering kiss to the brunette's waiting lips before stepping back with her into

the open area of the balcony. She said she wanted to dance - so she gets a dance.

Catra feels a smile break out across her face as Adora puts them in position - she pulls Catra's other hand up to go over her shoulder and then places both of her hands on the lithe woman's back, pulling them in close. And once there, the princess starts to hesitantly sway to the music, only dropping her eyes down a couple times to look at her feet. Catra shakes her head and gazes at the woman adoringly. *Is this really my life now?*


MH
2022

She doesn’t know how she was able to get this lucky.

The two women sway under the stars, only breaking their gaze when the commander moves in to nuzzle the taller woman softly. Adora smiles, tears springing to her eyes, while the cat woman purrs. This is everything they’ve both ever wanted.

They get to dance, uninterrupted, for a few songs before Bow and Glimmer seek them out. The women are so lost in each other that they don’t even know they’re being watched until Bow starts in with an “Awwwww.”

Catra rolls her eyes and breaks away from the princess - the man has since learned to stop calling her cute, but it doesn’t stop the idiot from smiling at her with his big, rounded eyes and his face scrunched up like she’s the cutest thing in the world.

“Fix your face,” the cat girl tells him and Adora laughs beside her.

“But you two are *so* -”

“-*Don’t* you dare,” Glimmer cuts the archer off, causing both the women to laugh.

Bow takes the hint and reigns it in while he wraps an arm around the Queen’s waist. Adora does the same with Catra, pulling the small brunette into her side as the other princess addresses them.

“So, I know you were just promoted,” Glimmer starts speaking to Catra, “But with the war over, there’s not much for our commander to do, so we’re gonna need to find some work for you.”

Catra nods, mulling it over, “Well, what’s going to happen when we finish rebuilding Etheria? Everyone just settles into a quiet life of peace?” Here she glances over to Adora questioningly, but she wants answers, too… They’ve never known peace before, have they?

“Well, not that this would interest any of you, but Entrapta and Hordak think they can get Mara’s old ship working…” The other three glance at the archer, surprised. “Maybe we can travel?”

“Not just travel,” Catra thinks out loud, “But maybe make sure the rest of the universe has been able to set themselves free from Prime’s clones, too.”

“There’s an idea,” Glimmer says with a wide grin before looking over to the other princess, “What do you think?”

Adora smiles and takes a moment to take in the excited expressions of her friends and her girlfriend… Her family.

The warrior shrugs, “As long as we’re together, I’m happy.”

The Best Friend Squad agree and all press in together for a group hug with only mild protests from the cat woman. She’s still not much for hugging, but as she settles into her friends' arms, she realizes there could be worse things.

The friends all separate and look to the stars then, thinking of all the adventures and trouble they could get into out there. Of all the planets they’ll visit and friends they’ll meet - of all the enemies they’ll face and trials they’ll overcome... Of all the tears they'll shed and of all the love they’ll share

And honestly?

It sounds like it’s gonna be a blast.

The End.

Chapter End Notes

I just wanna thank you guys for coming on this adventure with me. Like I've said before, I'm not much of a writer - I really don't have the discipline to sit down and write every day, so this may be the last time you hear from me for a while. If y'all wanna send me requests or prompts for a ficlet, maybe one or two chapters tops, I could always give it a shot. But regardless, this has been fun.

I wanna give a special shout out to Liseo who's be following the story and commenting on every chapter since the very beginning - I really appreciate your dedication. And thank all of you for your love and support - y'all have definitely had me cracking up a few times with the Glimmer hate lol. But also thank you for sticking it through till the end. I hope the fic turned out as well as you hoped.

Stay hydrated!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!